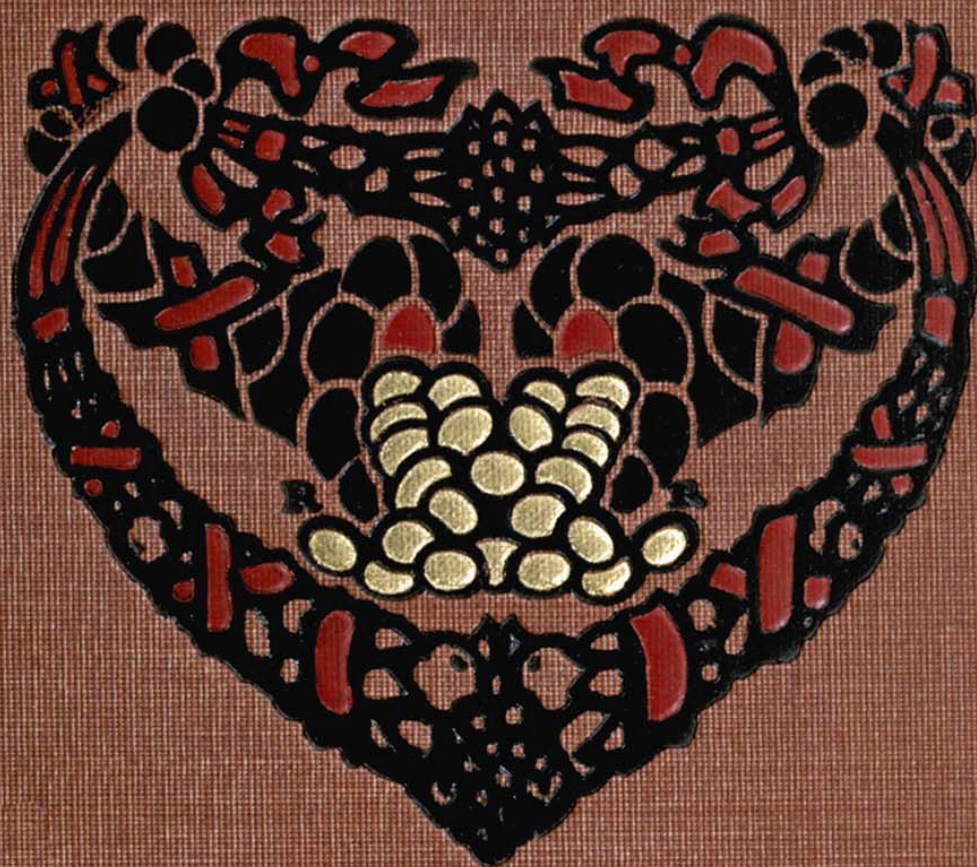


RICH MEN'S CHILDREN



GERALDINE
BONNER

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CHILDREN ***

RICH MEN'S CHILDREN



**“Oh, Rose, if I could see you now and then—only
for a moment like this”**

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RICH MEN'S CHILDREN

By

GERALDINE BONNER

Author of

The Pioneer, Tomorrow's Tangle, etc.

WITH ILLUSTRATIONS BY

C. M. RELYEA

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CHAPTER I

THE BONANZA KING

The cold of foot-hill California in the month of January held the night. The occupants of the surrey were too cramped and stiffened by it, and too uncomfortably enwrapped against it, to speak. Silence as complete as that which lay like a spell on the landscape brooded over them. At the last stopping place, Chinese Gulch, a scattering of houses six miles behind them on the mountain road, they had halted at the main saloon, and whisky and water had been passed to the driver and to the burlier figure on the back seat. The watchers that thronged to the saloon door had eyed the third occupant of the carriage with the intent, sheepish curiosity of the isolated man in presence of the stranger female. Afterward, each one was voluble in his impressions of her face, pale in the smoky lamplight, and the hand that slid, small and white, out of its loose glove when the warming glass was offered her.

Since then both she and her companion had leaned back in their several corners and preserved an unbroken silence. Even the driver's tongue had showed the benumbing effects of the darkness and cold, and the flow of conversation with which, earlier in the day, he had entertained his fares, gradually languished and died.

The surrey sped swiftly along the road which wound in spectral pallor over the shoulder of the foot-hill, now dipping into the blackness of a ravine, then creeping up a bare slope, where the horses' hoofs dug in laboriously amid loosened stones. The solemn loneliness of the landscape, faintly revealed by the light of large, clear stars, seemed to find appropriate expression in this frosty, smoke-breathing stillness. There was not a sign of human life. The gray patches of fields melted into the clouded darkness of trees. The domes of the live-oaks were like cairns of funereal rock in the open spaces. Steep, woody slopes swept upward, in the daytime shivering coppices of wintry leafage pierced by spires of fir and pine, now densely black and mysterious under the transforming magic of the night. Over all an expanse of sky arched, the vast, calm sky of mountain regions and Nature's undesecrated places, crystal-clear and velvet-dark, the light of its stars

seeming to come, tapping messages in an unknown telegraphy, from illimitable distances.

The larger figure on the back seat moved, and turned a face, all of which was hidden save the eyes, toward its companion.

“Hungry?” queried a deep bass voice; the inquiring polysyllable shot out suddenly over an upturned bulwark of collars.

“Fearfully,” came the answer in a muffled feminine treble, that suited the more diminutive bulk.

“Get a move on, Jake,” to the driver. “This girl’s most famished.”

“Hold your horses,” growled the other man; “we’re just about there.”

At these words the woman pricked up her ears, and, leaning forward, peered ahead. As they rounded a protruding angle of hill, a huddle of roofs and walls spotted with lights came into view, and the sight drew her hand forward with an eagerly-pointing finger.

“So that’s Rocky Bar!” she cried. “Have we really got there at last?”

The driver chuckled.

“That’s Rocky Bar all right. Now get your appetite good and ready.”

“No need,” she responded gaily; “it’s been ready and waiting for hours. I was beginning to think that you’d lost your way.”

“Me!” with an accent of incredulous scorn. “Ah, get out! How does it come, Governor, that Bill Cannon’s girl don’t know no more about these parts than a young lady from New York?”

“She’s never been up here before,” said the man on the back seat, beginning to untangle himself from his enfolding rugs. “I’ve brought her up with me this time to show her some of the places where her pa used to work round with the boys, long before *she* was ever thought of.”

A loud barking of dogs broke out as they approached the first detached houses of the settlement. Shapes appeared at the lighted doorways, and as the surrey drew up at the hotel balcony a crowding of heads was seen in the windows. The entire population of Rocky Bar spent its evenings at this hospitable resort, in summer on the balcony under the shade of the locust

trees, in winter round the office stove, spitting and smoking in cheery sociability. But at this hour the great event of Rocky Bar's day was over. The eight stages, the passengers of which dined at the hotel, had long passed onward on their various routes up and down the "mother lode" and into the camps of the Sierra. That the nightly excitement of the "victualing up" was to be supplemented by a late arrival in a surrey, driven by Jake McVeigh, the proprietor of the San Jacinto stables, and accompanied by a woman, was a sensational event not often awarded to Rocky Bar, even in the heyday of summer-time.

The occupants of the office crowded into the doorway and pressed themselves against the windows. They saw that the man who alighted was a thick-set, portly figure, with a short, gray beard and a suggestion of gray hair below the brim of a black wide-awake. Of the lady, shown but dimly by the light of the open door, only a slim, cloaked outline and a glint of fair hair were discernible. But, anyway, it was a woman, and of a kind unusual in Rocky Bar, and the men stared, sunk in bashful appreciation of a beauty that they felt must exist, if it were only to be in keeping with the hour, the circumstances, and their own hopeful admiration.

The hotel proprietor, an ancient man with a loosened vest, and trousers tucked into long boots, dispersed them as he ushered the strangers into the office. That they were travelers of distinction was obvious, as much from their own appearance as from the fact that Jake McVeigh was driving them himself, in his best surrey and with his finest team. But just how important they were no one guessed till McVeigh followed them in, and into ears stretched for the information dropped the sentence, half-heard, like a stage aside:

"It's Bill Cannon and his daughter Rose."

Upon the proprietor it had an electric effect. He sped from the room with the alertness of youth, promising "a cold lunch" in a minute. To the others it came as a piece of intelligence that added awe to the lighter emotions of the occasion. By common consent their eyes focused on the great man who stood warming his hands at the stove. Even the rare, unusual woman, revealed now as sufficiently pretty to be an object of future dreams, was interesting only to the younger and more impressionable members of the

throng. All but these gazed absorbed, unblinking, at Bill Cannon, the Bonanza King.

He was used to it. It had been a part of his life for years. Eying his admirers with a genial good humor, he entered into conversation with them, his manner marked by an easy familiarity, which swept away all shades of embarrassment, and drew the men around the stove, eager to respond to his questions as to the condition and prospects of the locality. The talk was becoming general and animated, when the ancient man returned and announced that the "cold lunch" was ready and to please "step after him into the dining-room."

This gaunt apartment, grimly unadorned and faintly illumined, an occasional lantern backed by a tin reflector projecting a feeble light into its echoing emptiness, was swept of all intruders, and showed a barn-like bareness of wall and loftiness of roof. Lines of tables, uncovered between flanking wooden benches, were arranged down its length. Across the end of one of these a white cloth was spread and three places set. Jake McVeigh, less innocently democratic than the hotel proprietor, was about to withdraw from the society of his distinguished patron and seat himself in seemly loneliness at an adjacent table, when Bill Cannon's voice arrested him.

"What are you going off there for, sonny, as if you were a leper? Come over here and sit side of us."

The driver, greatly pleased, not only to enjoy the companionship of the richest man in California but to let the peeping heads in the doorway see him in this moment of proud apotheosis, took the third seat with modest complacency. Like most of his kind, the sense of social inferiority was unknown to him. He was simply and naturally himself as he would be anywhere in any company. Even the proximity of Miss Cannon did not abash him, and he dexterously propelled the potatoes into his mouth with his knife and cut fiercely at his meat with a sawing motion, talking the while with all the freedom and more than the pleasure with which he talked to his wife in the kitchen at San Jacinto.

Cannon, his overcoat removed, was seen to be a powerful, thick-set man, with a bulkiness that was more a matter of broad build and muscular development than fat. His coat set ill upon him and strained at the buttons. It had the effect of having worked up toward the shoulders, noticeable in the

clothes of men who are deep-chested and sit bunchily. He had a short neck which he accommodated with a turn-down collar, a gray beard, clipped close to his cheeks and square on the chin, and gray hair, worn rather long and combed sleekly and without parting back from his forehead. In age he was close to seventy, but the alertness and intelligence of a conquering energy and vitality were in his glance, and showed in his movements, deliberate, but sure and full of precision. He spoke little as he ate his dinner, leaning over his plate and responding to the remarks of his daughter with an occasional monosyllable that might have sounded curt, had it not been accompanied with a lazy cast of his eye upon her that was as full of affection as a caress.

The young lady, who had also put off her outer wraps, still wore her hat, which was wide-brimmed and cast a shadow over the upper part of her face. Below it her hair showed a fine, bright blonde, giving forth silky gleams in the lamplight. To the peeping heads in the doorway she seemed a creature instinct with romantic charm, which was expressed in such delicacies of appearance as a pearl-white throat, a rounded chin, and lips that smiled readily. These graces, eagerly deciphered through dimness and distance, had the attraction of the semi-seen, and imagination, thus given an encouraging fillip, invested Bill Cannon's girl with a haunting beauty. It was remarked that she bore no resemblance to her father in coloring, features, or build. In talking it over later, Rocky Bar decided that she must favor her mother, who, as all California knew, had been a waitress in the Yuba Hotel at Marysville, when Bill Cannon, then a miner in the Freeze-Out, had wooed and won her.

The conversation between the diners was desultory. They were beyond doubt hungry. Even the young lady was seen to consume the viands set before her with more gusto than a restraining sense of romantic fitness would have dictated. Once or twice, as she bit a semicircle out of a round of buttered bread, her eye, questing sidewise full of sly humor, caught McVeigh's, and a sputter of laughter left her with humped-up shoulders, her lips lightly compressed on the mouthful.

It was toward the end of the meal, that, looking at the opposite wall, her glance was caught by a large clock to which she drew her father's attention:

“Half-past nine! How fashionable we are! And when are you going to get us up to Antelope, Mr. McVeigh?”

McVeigh studied the clock ponderingly as he felt in his breast pocket for his toothpick.

“Well,” he said, “if we leave here at ten and make good time the hull way—it’s up hill pretty much without a break—I’ll get you there about midnight.”

She made a little grimace.

“And it will be much colder, won’t it?”

“Colder ’n’ colder. You’ll be goin’ higher with every step. Antelope’s on the slope of the Sierra, and you can’t expect to be warm up there in the end of January.”

“If you hadn’t wanted to come,” said her father, “you’d have been just about getting ready for Mrs. Ryan’s ball. Isn’t this about the magic hour when you begin to lay on the first layer of war-paint?”

The girl looked at the clock, nodding with a faint, reminiscent smile.

“Just about,” she said. “I’d have been probably looking at my dress laid out on the bed and saying to myself, ‘Now I wonder if it’s worth while getting into that thing and having all the bother of going to this ball.’ On the evenings when I go out, there’s always a stage when that happens.”

McVeigh, with his toothpick in full operation, looked at her, admiring and half comprehending, for the first time feeling himself an outsider. She caught his eye, read its meaning, and with the quick tact of a delicate nature, said:

“It’s Mrs. Cornelius Ryan in San Francisco. She has a ball to-night and I was going, but I came up here with papa instead. I don’t care for balls.”

“Sort of late to be primping up for a ball,” said McVeigh, restoring the toothpick to his pocket and pushing back his chair. “I’ll go and have a look at the horses. And, Governor, if you’ll be ready in fifteen minutes I’ll be round at the porch waiting.”

Cannon nodded, and, as the driver clumped off over the board floor, said to his daughter,

“I wonder if Dominick Ryan’ll be there—at the ball, I mean. His mother’s made up her mind not to recognize the woman he’s married, and to freeze her out, but I wonder if she’ll have the nerve not to ask her to-night.”

“I don’t see how she could do that,” said the girl. “This is one of the largest balls ever given in San Francisco. She can’t leave her son out, and she couldn’t ask him without his wife.”

“Couldn’t she?” said the old man, with a narrowing of his eyes and a knowing wag of his head. “You don’t know Delia Ryan. I do. I’ve known her forty years, ever since she was first married and did washing on the back porch of her shanty in Virginia City. She was a good deal of a woman then, a strong, brainy woman, and she’s the same to-day, but hard as nails. I’ll bet a hat she hasn’t asked Dominick’s wife to that ball.”

“What do you suppose he’ll do?” asked the daughter, somewhat aghast at this glimpse of the Ryan family skeleton.

“Don’t ask me such conundrums. I’m glad I’m not in it, that’s all I know. When two women lock horns I’m ready to step quietly down and out. I never to my knowledge saw Dominick’s wife, but I’ve heard about her, and take it she’s a pretty hard kind of a proposition. They say she married the boy for money and position, and hasn’t got either. Delia, who has the money, hasn’t given them a cent since the marriage; made up her mind, people say, to force Mrs. Dominick out. She doesn’t seem to have done it, and I guess it’s been sort of aggravating to her. Just the same I’d like to know if she’s had the nerve not to send the woman an invitation to the ball. That would be pretty tough.”

“I’ve never seen either Dominick or his wife,” said the girl. “It seems odd when I know Mrs. Ryan and Cornelia so well. But he married the year I came back from Europe, and he’s never been anywhere since. I don’t believe he ever goes to his mother’s. There’s Mr. McVeigh in the doorway; we’d better be going.”

Once again in the carriage they were soon clear of the last straggling shanty, and speeding along the pale, ascending road. The silence that held the trio before their arrival at Rocky Bar again fell on them. Wrapped in overcoats and rugs, Bill Cannon appeared to slumber, every now and then—as the wheels jolted over a piece of rough road-bed—shaken into growling

wakefulness. McVeigh also rolled sleepily in his seat, occasionally leaning sidewise to spit over the wheel. Only the girl seemed alert and wide-awake, her face craning out from the shadowed back seat, her eyes strained to pierce the obscurity and see for the first time the landscape of foot-hill California, of which her father had so often told her.

Now it was all a dark, formless background of broken blacknesses, where the light, open spaces of fields alternated with blotches of woods and trees. At intervals they passed a lone cabin, solitary in its pale clearing, the red eye of a stove sending a gleam through an uncurtained pane. Once they woke the echoes in the single street of a tiny town, sleeping behind its shuttered windows. Dogs barked, the shout of a belated reveler rose from a congeries of gaudily-bright doorways, and over all, imposing its mighty voice on the silence, came the roar of the stamp-mill on the hill above. It rose into the night like a fortress, a black mass looming from the slant of vast dumps, lines of lit windows puncturing its sides. The thunder of its stamps was loud on the night, fierce and insistent, like the roar of a monster round whose feet the little town cowered.

McVeigh looked back over his shoulder, saw the bright eyes under the hat-brim, and said softly,

“The Silver Crescent stamp-mill. The last big mine we’ll see.”

It was the last town they passed; even the groups of buildings that marked embryo mines grew rare. The dimly-seen country became wilder, seemed to shake off the signs of man’s encroachment and to be sweeping up into mountain majesty. The ascending road crept along the edges of ravines whence the sound of running water came in a clear clinking, dived down into black caverns of trees unlighted by the feeblest ray of star-shine, and then climbed in slow, laborious loops the bare bulwarks of the mountain. Had the girl been able to see plainly she would have noticed the change in the foliage, the disappearance of the smaller shrubs and delicate interlacement of naked boughs, and the mightier growth of the pines, soaring shafts devoid of branches to a great height. Boulders appeared among their roots, straight falls of rock edged the road like the walls of a fort.

McVeigh turned again, and again caught the bright eye.

“Seems like your paw must think a lot of what he’s heard about the new strike at Greenhide to come all this way,” he whispered.

“I guess he does,” came the response in the same key.

“It sort of stumps me to know why you came along with him,” he continued, his eyes on the horses, but leaning back to catch her answer.

“Mightn’t I just want to see the country?”

“Well, mebbe you might, but it don’t seem to me that you’re seein’ much of it to-night.”

He heard her smothered laugh, shot his glance back to see her face, and laughed himself, turning to his horses, and then turning back to her.

“You’re a lively girl, ain’t you?” he said.

“I don’t feel very lively just at this minute. I’m a cold girl, the coldest in California, I think.”

That made him laugh, too, but he turned back to his horses, saying with quick consideration:

“I guess you are. Come boys,” to the horses, “we’ve got to get a move on. We can’t let this young lady catch cold.”

The horses quickened their pace and there was no more talk. An hour later the first broken lights of Antelope sparkled along the road. The old mining camp, in a hollow between two buttresses of the Sierra, lay shuttered and dreaming under the starlight. A lamp-lit window, here and there, showed the course of its straggling main street, and where the hotel stood, welcoming rays winked between the boughs of leafless trees.

As the thud of the approaching hoof-beats woke the echoes a sudden violent barking of dogs broke out. Antelope was evidently not as sound asleep as it looked. At the hotel, especially, there was life and movement. The bar disgorged a throng of men, and Perley, the proprietor, had to push his way through them to welcome his midnight guests. Antelope, though remote, was in telegraphic communication with the world, and the operator at Rocky Bar had wired Perley to be ready for the distinguished arrivals,—news that in a half-hour was known throughout the town and had brought most of the unattached male population into the hotel.

Jake McVeigh was pulling the luggage from under the seats and Cannon was interchanging the first greetings with his landlord, when the girl, who had gone to the balcony railing and was looking out into the darkness, cried:

“Why, papa, snow!”

The information seemed to startle every one. The men crowded from the doorway and balcony into the street. McVeigh set down the bags, and, turning his weather-beaten face to the sky, uttered a smothered ejaculation of a profane character. Cannon came forward to where his daughter stood and looked into the blackness beyond. The girl had drawn off her glove and held her bare hand out, then stepping back to the light of the window, she showed it to her father. The white skin was sprinkled with snow crystals.

“Sure enough,” he said in a thoughtful voice. “Well, it won’t be the first time I’ve been snowed up at Antelope.”

CHAPTER II

A YOUNG MAN MARRIED

That same evening, at the hour when Bill Cannon and his daughter were setting out from Rocky Bar, Dominick Ryan was walking up Van Ness Avenue toward his mother's house.

Dominick did not know at what hours balls of the kind Mrs. Ryan was giving that evening were supposed to begin. It was nearly three years since he had been a participant in such festal gatherings. He had not been at a dance, or a dinner, or a theater party since his marriage. He had heard that these "functions," as people now called them, began later than they did in his day. Stopping by a lamp he drew out his watch—ten o'clock. It was later than he expected. In truth, as he had seen the house looming massively from its less imposing neighbors, his foot had lagged, his approach had grown slower and slower. It was his mother's home, once his own, and as he drew nearer to it his reluctance to enter grew stronger, more overpoweringly oppressive.

In the clear, lamp-dotted night it looked much larger and more splendid than by day. When Cornelius Ryan had built it he had wanted to have the finest house in San Francisco, and he certainly had achieved the most spacious and ornate. Its florid ornamentation was now hidden by the beautifying dark, and on its vast façade numerous windows broke the blackness with squares of light. In the lower ones the curtains were drawn, but slivers and cracks of radiance slipped out and penetrated the dusk of a garden, where they encountered the glossy surfaces of leaves and struck into whispering darknesses of shrubbery.

The stimulating unquiet of festival was in the air. Round the mouth of the canvas tunnel that stretched from the door a dingy crowd was assembled, staring in at nothing more inspiring than the blank visage of the closed portal. At every passing footstep each face turned to the street, hopefully expectant of the first guest. The whining of catgut strings, swept by tentative bows, struck on Dominick's ear as he pushed his way through the throng and passed up the tunnel. Before he touched the bell the door swung

back and a man-servant he had never seen before murmured in politely low tones,

“Gentlemen’s dressing-room first floor to the right.”

Dominick stood uncertain. He was only a rare, occasional visitor at his mother’s house, and to-night the hall stripped for revelry looked strangely unfamiliar. The unexpectedness of a great, new mirror, surmounted by gold heraldic devices, confused him. The hall chairs were different. The music, loud now and beginning to develop from broken chords and phrases into the languorous rhythm of a waltz measure, came from behind a grove of palms that stood back under the stairs, where the organ was built into the wall. Both to the right and left, wide, unencumbered rooms opened, brilliantly lighted, with flowers banked in masses on the mantels and in the corners. The scent of these blossoms was rich on the air and seemed to blend naturally—like another expression of the same sensuous delightfulness—with the dreamy sweetness of the music.

“Gentlemen’s dressing-room first floor to the right,” repeated the servant, and Dominick became aware of the man’s eyes, fixed on him with a gleam of uneasy scrutiny shining through cultivated obsequiousness.

“Where is my——” he was going to say “mother,” but checked himself, amending it with, “Where is Mrs. Ryan?”

The servant indicated the open doorway to the right and Dominick passed in. Through the vista of two rooms, their connecting archways uncurtained, he saw the shining spaciousness of the ball-room, the room his mother had added to the house when Cornelia, his sister, had “come out.” It seemed empty and he walked toward it, stepping softly on rugs of tiger skin and polar bear. He noticed the ice-like polish of the oak floor, the lines of gilt chairs, and a thick, fat garland of roses—leaves and blossoms combined—that was festooned along the wall and caught up at each sconce.

As he entered he saw his mother and Cornelia. They had been standing in one corner, Cornelia adjusting the shade of an electric light. One white arm was raised, and her skirt of lace was reflected clearly in the parquet. The light shone along her bare shoulders, having a gloss like old marble. From the nape of her neck her hair, a bright, coarse red, was drawn up. She

seemed all melting shades of cream color and ivory, but for this flaming crest of copper color.

Her mother was standing beside her watching the arranging hand. She was sixty-eight years of age and very stout, but her great wealth made it possible for her to employ dressmakers who were artists and experts, and her Parisian costume made her look almost shapely. It fell about her in dignified black folds, sparkling discreetly with some jetted garnishings. With their shifting gleam the glint of diamonds mingled. She also wore pearls round her neck and some diamond ornaments in her elaborately-dressed gray hair.

The coarseness of her early beginnings could not be hidden by the most proficient artificers in millinery or jewels. Delia Ryan had come from what are vulgarly called “the lower orders,” having, in her ragged childhood, crossed the plains at the tail-board of an ox cart, and in her girlhood been a general servant in a miners’ boarding-house at Sonora. Now, as she stood watching her daughter’s moving hand, her face, set in a frowning rigidity of observation, was strong but unbeautiful. Her small eyes, shrewd and sharp, were set high in her head under brows almost rubbed away. The nose was short, with an undeveloped bridge and keen, open nostrils. Her mouth had grown thinner with years; the lips shut with a significant firmness. They had never been full, but what redness and ripeness they had had in youth were now entirely gone. They were pale, strong lips, the under one a little more prominent than the upper.

“There!” said Cornelia. “Now they’re all even,” and she wheeled slowly, her glance slipping along the veiled lights of the sconces. In its circuit it encountered Dominick’s figure in the doorway.

“Dominick!” she cried, and stood staring, naïvely astonished and dismayed.

Mrs. Ryan turned with a start, her face suffused with color. The one word seemed to have an electrifying effect upon her, joyous, perturbing—unquestionably exciting.

“My boy!” she said, and she rustled across the room with her hands out.

Dominick walked toward her. He was grave, pale, and looked thoroughly miserable. He had his cane in one hand, his hat in the other. As he approached her he moved the hat to his left hand and took hers.

“You’ve come!” she said fondly, “I knew you would. That’s my boy. I knew you’d come when your mother asked you.”

“Yes, I’ve come,” he said slowly, and looking down as if desiring to avoid her eyes. “Yes, I’ve come, but——”

He stopped.

His mother’s glance fell from his face to his figure and saw under the loose fronts of his overcoat that he wore his business suit. Her countenance instantly, with almost electric suddenness, stiffened into antagonism. Her eye lost its love, and hardened into a stony look of defiant indignation. She pulled her hand from his and jerked back the front of his coat with it.

“What’s this mean?” she said sharply. “Why aren’t you dressed? The people will be here in a minute. You can’t come this way.”

“I was going home to dress,” he said. “I am not sure yet that I can come.”

“Why?” she demanded.

His face grew red. The mission on which he had come was more difficult, more detestable, than he had supposed it would be. He looked down at the shining strip of floor between them and said, trying to make his voice sound easy and plausible:

“I came to ask you for an invitation for Berny.”

“Hah!” said his mother, expelling her breath in an angry ejaculation of confirmed suspicion. “That’s it, is it? I thought as much!”

“Mama!” said the girl who had been standing by, uneasily listening. “Mama dear——”

Her voice was soft and sweet, a placating woman’s voice. And as she drew nearer to them, her figure seeming to float over the shining parquet in its pale spread of gauzy draperies, her tone, her face, and her bearing were instinct with a pleading, feminine desire to soothe.

“Keep quiet, Cornie,” said her mother, “you’re not in this”—turning to Dominick. “And so your wife sent you up here to beg for an invitation? She’s got you under her thumb to that extent? Well, go back to her and tell her that she can send you forty times and you’ll not get it. She can make

you crawl here and you'll not get it—not while this is my house. When I'm dead you can do what you like.”

She turned away from him, her face dark with stirred blood, her body quivering. Anger was not the only passion that shook her. Deeper than this went outraged pride, love turned to gall, impotent fury that the woman her son had married had power over him so to reduce his pride and humble his manhood—her only son, the joy and glory of her old age, her Benjamin.

He looked after her, uncertain, frowning, desperate.

“It's not right,” he protested. “It's not fair. You're unjust to her and to me.”

The old woman moved across the room to the corner where she had been standing when he entered. She did not turn, and he continued:

“You're asking people to this ball that you hardly know. Everybody in San Francisco's going. What harm has Berny done that you should leave her out this way?”

“I don't want women with that kind of record in my house. I don't ask decent people here to meet that sort,” said his mother over her shoulder.

He gave a suppressed exclamation, the meaning of which it was difficult to read, then said,

“Are you never going to forget the past, mother?”

She wheeled round toward him almost shouting,

“No—no—no! Never! Never! Make your mind up to that.”

They looked at each other across the open space, the angry defiance in their faces not hiding the love and appeal that spoke in their eyes. The mother longed to take her son in her arms; the son longed to lay his head on her shoulder and forget the wretchedness and humiliations of the last two years. But they were held apart, not only by the specter of the absent woman, but on the one side by a fierce, unbendable pride, and on the other by an unforgettable sense of obligation and duty.

“Oh, mother!” he exclaimed, half-turning away with a movement of despair.

His mother looked at him from under her lowered brows, her under lip thrust out, her face unrelenting.

“Come here whenever you like,” she said, “as often as you want. It’s your home, Dominick, mine and yours. But it’s not your wife’s. Understand that.”

She turned away and again moved slowly toward the corner, her rich skirts trailing fanwise over the parquet. He stood, sick at heart, looking at the tip of his cane as it rested on the floor.

“Dominick,” said his sister’s voice beside him, “go; that’s the only thing to do. You see it’s no use.” She made a backward jerk of her head toward their mother, and then, struck by the misery of the eyes he lifted to her face, said tenderly, “I’m so sorry. You know I’d have sent it if I could. But it’s no use. It’s just the same old fight over again and nothing gained. Tell your wife it’s hopeless. Make her give it up.”

He turned slowly, his head hanging.

“All right,” he said, “I’ll tell her. Good-night, mother.”

“Good-night, Dominick,” came the answer.

“Good-night, Cornie,” he said in a muffled voice and left the room.

He passed through the brilliantly bright, flower-scented parlors and was shown out by the strange man-servant. The crowd at the mouth of the canvas tunnel had increased. Clumps of staring white faces edged the opening and presented themselves to his eye, not like reality, but like a painting of pale visages executed on the background of the night. They drew away as he approached them, making a lane of egress for him, then turned and eyed him—a deserter from the realms of joy—as he stopped by a lamp-post to look at his watch. A quarter past ten. He had been in the house only fifteen minutes. He did not need to go home for a while yet. He could walk about and think and arrange how he would tell Berny.

He was a man in the full vigor of his youth, strong and brave, yet at this moment he feared, feared as a child or a timid woman might fear, the thought of his wife. He dreaded to meet her; he shrank from it, and to put it off he wandered about the familiar streets, up one and down the other,

trying to overcome his sick reluctance, trying to make up his mind to go to her, trying to conquer his fear.

CHAPTER III

THE DAUGHTER OF HETH

He walked for nearly an hour, along quiet, lamp-lit streets where large houses fronted on gardens that exhaled moist earth scents and the breaths of sweet, unseen blossoms, up hills so steep that it seemed as if an earthquake might have heaved up the city's crust and bent it crisply like a piece of cardboard. From these high places he looked down on the expanse of the bay, a stretch of ink surrounded by black hills, here and there spangled with the clustered sparklings of little towns. In the hollows below him he saw the lights of the city swimming on its darkness, winking and trembling on receding depths of blackness, like golden bubbles seething on the surface of thick, dense wine.

He looked down unseeing, thinking of the last three years.

When he had first met Bernice Iverson, she had been a typewriter and stenographer in the office of the Merchants and Mechanics Trust Company. He was twenty-four at the time, the only son of Cornelius Ryan, one of the financial magnates of the far West. The career of Con Ryan, as he was familiarly called, had been as varied as the heart of a public, who loves to dwell on the sensational fortunes of its great men, could have wished. In the early days of Virginia City, Con Ryan had been a miner there, had a claim of his own and lost all he had in it before the first Crown Point excitement, had run a grocery store in Shasta, moved to Sacramento, speculated successfully in mining stock and real estate, and in the bonanza days had had money to play the great game which made millionaires of the few and beggars of the many. He had played it daringly and with profit. When he died he left his widow complete control of a fortune of ten millions.

She had been a sturdy helpmeet—it was generally said that she was the best man of the two—and would keep the fortune safe for the two children, Dominick and Cornelia. Neither she nor Con believed in young men having control of large fortunes. They had seen what came of it in the sons of their bonanza friends. Dominick was sent to the East to college, and on his return, being then twenty-three years of age, was placed in the Oregon and

California Bank, of which his father had been one of the founders. He was soon promoted to a position where he earned a salary of three thousand a year. This was all he had when he met Bernice Iverson.

She was seven years older than he, but told him they were the same age. It was not a wasted lie, as she undoubtedly looked much younger than she was, being a slight, trimly-made woman who had retained a girlish elasticity of figure and sprightliness of manner. She came of respectable, hard-working people, her father, Danny Iverson, having been a contractor in a small way of business, and her two sisters being, one a teacher in the primary school department, the other a saleswoman in a fashionable millinery. She herself was an expert in her work, in office hours quiet, capable and businesslike, afterward lively, easy-going and companionable. The entrapping of young Ryan was a simple matter. He had never loved and knew little of women. He did not love her, but she made him think he did, threw herself at him, led him quickly to the point she wished to reach, and secretly, without a suspicion on the part of her family, became his mistress. Six months later, having driven him to the step by her upbraidings and her apparent sufferings of conscience under the sense of wrong-doing, she persuaded him to marry her.

The marriage was a bombshell to the world in which young Ryan was a planet of magnitude. His previous connection with her—though afterward discovered by his mother—was at the time unknown. Bernice had induced him to keep the marriage secret till its hour of accomplishment, for she knew Mrs. Ryan would try to break it off and feared that she might succeed. Once Dominick's wife she thought that the objections and resentment of the elder woman could be overcome. But she underrated the force and obstinacy of her adversary and the depth of the wound that had been given her. Old Mrs. Ryan had been stricken in her tenderest spot. Her son was her idol, born in her middle-age, the last of four boys, three of whom had died in childhood. In his babyhood she had hoarded money and worked late and early that he might be rich. Now she held the great estate of her husband in trust for him, and dreamed of the time when he should marry some sweet and virtuous girl and she would have grandchildren to love and spoil and plan for. When the news of his marriage reached her and she saw the woman he had made his wife, she understood everything. She knew her boy

through and through and she knew just how he had been duped and entangled.

She was of that race of pioneer Californians who had entered an uninhabited country, swept aside Indian and Spaniard, and made it their own. They were isolated figures in a huge landscape, their characters, uncramped and bold, developing unrestricted in an atmosphere of physical and moral liberty. They grew as their instincts dictated; the bough was not bent into convenient forms by expediency or pressure from without. Public opinion had little or no weight with them, for there was none. It was the pleasure of this remote group in this rich and exuberant land to do away with tradition and be a law and precept unto themselves. What other people thought and did did not influence them. They had one fixed, dominating idea in a fluctuating code of morals—they knew what they wanted and they were determined to get it. They were powerful individualities whether for good or evil, and they resented with a passion any thwarting of their plans or desires, whether by the interposition of man or the hand of God.

Delia Ryan's life had been a long, ascending series of hardly-won triumphs. She had surmounted what would have seemed to a less bold spirit unsurmountable obstacles; gone over them, not around them. She had acquired the habit of success, of getting what she wanted. Failure or defiance of her plans amazed her as they might have amazed the confident, all-conquering, pagan gods. The center of her life was her family; for them she had labored, for them she would have died. Right and wrong in her mind were clearly defined till it came to her husband or children, and then they were transmuted into what benefited the Ryans and what did not. Rigidly fair and honorable in her dealings with the outside world, let a member of that world menace the happiness of one of her own, and she would sacrifice it, grind the ax without qualms, like a priestess grimly doing her duty.

The marriage of her son was the bitterest blow of her life. It came when she was old, stiffened into habits of dominance and dictatorship, when her ambitions for her boy were gaining daily in scope and splendor. A blind rage and determination to crush the woman were her first feelings, and remained with her but slightly mitigated by the softening passage of time. She was a partizan, a fighter, and she instituted a war against her daughter-

in-law which she conducted with all the malignant bitterness that marks the quarrels of women.

Dominick had not been married a month when she discovered the previous connection between him and his wife, and published it to the winds. A social power, feared and obeyed, she let it be known that to any one who received Mrs. Dominick Ryan her doors would be for ever closed. Without withdrawing her friendship from her son she refused ever to meet or to receive his wife. In this attitude she was absolutely implacable. She imposed her will upon the less strong spirits about her, and young Mrs. Ryan was as completely shut off from her husband's world as though her skirts carried contamination. With masculine largeness of view in other matters, in this one the elder woman exhibited a singular, unworthy smallness. The carelessly large checks she had previously given Dominick on his birthday and anniversaries ceased to appear, and masculine gifts, such as pipes, walking-sticks, and cigar-cases, in which his wife could have no participating enjoyment, took their place. She had established a policy of exclusion, and maintained it rigidly.

Young Mrs. Ryan had at first believed that this rancor would melt away with the flight of time. But she did not know the elder woman. She was as unmeltable as a granite rock. The separation from her son, now with age growing on her, ate like an acid into the mother's heart. She saw him at intervals, and the change in him, the growth of discouragement, the dejection of spirit that he hid from all the world, but that her eye, clairvoyant from love, detected, tore her with helpless wrath and grief. She punished herself and punished him, sacrificed them both, in permitting herself the indulgence of her implacable indignation.

Bernice, who had expected to gain all from her connection with the all-powerful Ryans, at the end of two years found that she was an ostracized outsider from the world she had hoped to enter, and that the riches she had expected to enjoy were represented by the three thousand a year her husband earned in the bank. Her attempts to force her way into the life and surroundings where she had hoped her marriage would place her had invariably failed. If her feelings were not of the same nature as those of the elder Mrs. Ryan, they were fully as poignant and bitter.

The effort to get an invitation to the ball had been the most daring the young woman had yet made. Neither she nor Dominick had thought it possible that Mrs. Ryan would leave her out. So confident was she that she would be asked that she had ordered a dress for the occasion. But when Dominick's invitation came without her name on the envelope, then fear that she was to be excluded rose clamorous in her. For days she talked and complained to her husband as to the injustice of this course and his power to secure the invitation for her if he would. By the evening of the ball she had brought him to the point where he had agreed to go forth and demand it.

It was a hateful mission. He had never in his life done anything so humiliating. In his shame and distress he had hoped that his mother would give it to him without urging, and Bernice, placated, would be restored to good humor and leave him at peace. She could not have gained such power over him, or so bent him to her bidding, had she not had in him a fulcrum of guilty obligation to work on. She continually reminded him of "the wrong" he had done her, and how, through him, she had lost the respect of her fellows and her place among them. All these slights, snubs and insults were his fault, and he felt that this was true. To-night he had gone forth in dogged desperation. Now in fear, frank fear of her, he went home, slowly, with reluctant feet, his heart getting heavier, his dread colder as he neared the house.

It was one of those wooden structures on Sacramento Street not far from Van Ness Avenue where the well-to-do and socially-aspiring crowd themselves into a floor of seven rooms, and derive satisfaction from the proximity of their distinguished neighbors who refuse to know them. It contained four flats, each with a parlor bay-window and a front door, all four doors in neighborly juxtaposition at the top of a flight of six marble steps.

Dominick's was the top flat; he had to ascend a long, carpeted stairway with a turn half-way up to get to it. Now, looking at the bay-window, he saw lights gleaming from below the drawn blinds. Berny was still up. A lingering hope that she might have gone to bed died, and his sense of reluctance gained in force and made him feel slightly sick. He was there, however, and he had to go up. Fitting his key into the lock he opened the hall door.

It was very quiet as he mounted the long stairs, but, as he drew near the top, he became aware of a windy, whistling noise and looking into the room near the stair-head saw that all the gas-jets were lit and turned on full cock, and that the gas, rushing out from the burner in a ragged banner of flame, made the sound. He was about to enter and lower it when he heard his wife's voice coming from the open door of her room.

"Is that you, Dominick?" she called.

Her voice was steady and high. Though it was hard, with a sort of precise clearness of utterance, it was not conspicuously wrathful.

"Yes," he answered, "it's I," and he forgot the gas-jets and walked up the hall. He did not notice that in the other rooms he passed the gas was turned on in the same manner. The whistling rush of its escape made a noise like an excited, unresting wind in the confined limits of the little flat.

The door of Berny's room was open, and under a blaze of light from the chandelier and the side lights by the bureau she was sitting in a rocking-chair facing the foot of the bed. She held in her hand a walking-stick of Dominick's and with this she had been making long scratches across the foot-board, which was of walnut and was seamed back and forth, like a rock scraped by the passage of a glacier. As Dominick entered, she desisted, ceased rocking, and turned to look at him. She had an air of taut, sprightly impudence, and was smiling a little.

"Well, Dominick," she said jauntily, "you're late."

"Yes, I believe I am," he answered. "I did not come straight back. I walked about for a while."

He slowly crossed the room to the fireplace and stood there looking down. There were some silk draperies on the mantel matched by those which were festooned over the room's single window. He fastened his eyes on the pattern stamped on the looped-up folds, and was silent. He thought Berny would realize from the fact that he had not come directly home that the invitation had been denied. This was his bungling, masculine way of breaking the news.

"Took a walk," she said, turning to the bed and beginning to rock. "It's a queer sort of hour to choose for walking," and lifting the cane she recommenced her occupation of scratching the foot-board with it, tracing

long, parabolic curves across the entire expanse, watching the cane's tip with her head tilted to one side. Dominick, who was not looking at her, did not notice the noise.

"I thought," she said, tracing a great arc from one side to the other, "that you were with your loving family—opening the ball, probably."

He did not move, but said quietly,

"It was impossible to get the invitation, Berny. I tried to do it and was refused. I want you to understand that as long as I live I'll never do a thing like that again."

"Oh, yes, you will," she said, laughing and shaking her head like an amused child. "Oh, yes, you will." She threw her head back and, looking at the ceiling, laughed still louder with a note of fierceness in the sound. "You'll do it and lots more things like it. You'll do it if I want you to, Dominick Ryan."

He did not answer. She hitched her chair closer to the bed as if to return to an engrossing pastime, and, leaning back luxuriously, resumed her play with the cane. This time Dominick noticed the noise and turned. She was conscious that he was looking at her, and began to scratch with an appearance of charmed absorption, such as an artist might display in his work. He watched her for a moment in silent astonishment and then broke out sharply,

"What are you doing?"

"Scratching the bed," she responded calmly.

"You must be mad," he said, striding angrily toward her and stretching a hand for the cane. "You're ruining it."

She whipped the cane to the other side, out of his reach.

"Am I?" she said, turning an eye of fiery menace on him. "Maybe I am, and what's that matter?" Then, turning back to the bed, "Too bad, isn't it, and the set not paid for yet."

"Not paid for!" he exclaimed, so amazed by the statement that he forgot everything else. "Why, I've given you the money for it twice!"

“Three times,” she amended coolly, “and I spent it on things I liked better. I bought clothes, and jewelry with it, and little fixings I wanted. Yes, the bedroom set isn’t all paid for yet and we’ve had it nearly two years. Who would have thought that the son of Con Ryan didn’t pay his bills!”

She rose, threw the cane into the corner, and, turning toward him, leaned back, half-sitting on the foot-board, her hands, palm downward, pressed on its rounded top. The chandelier was directly over her head and cast a powerful light on her face. This was small, pointed, and of that sallow hue which is often noticeable in the skins of brunette women who are no longer in their first youth. She had a nose that drooped a little at the tip and an upper lip which was long and closed firmly and secretively on the lower one. Her dark eyes, large and brilliant, had the slightest tendency toward a slanting setting, the outer corners being higher than the inner ones. Under the shower of light from above, her thick hair, bleached to a reddish auburn and worn in a loose knot on top of her head, cast a shadow over her forehead, and below this her eyes blazed on her husband. Many men would have thought her an unusually pretty woman, but no man, save one of her own sort, could have faced her at this moment without quailing.

Dominick and she had had many quarrels, ignominious and repulsive, but he had never before seen her in so savage a mood. Even yet he had not lost the feeling of responsibility and remorse he felt toward her. As he moved from the mantelpiece his eye had fallen on the ball-dress that lay, a sweep of lace and silver, across the bed, and on the bureau he had seen jewels and hair ornaments laid out among the powder boxes and scent bottles. The pathos of these futile preparations appealed to him and he made an effort to be patient and just.

“It’s been a disappointment,” he said, “and I’m sorry about it. But I’ve done all I could and there’s no use doing any more. You’ve got to give it up. There’s no use trying to make my mother give in. She won’t.”

“Won’t she?” she cried, her voice suddenly loud and shaken with rage. “We’ll see! We’ll see! We’ll see if I’ve married into the Ryan family for nothing.”

Her wrath at last loosened, her control was instantly swept away. In a moment she was that appalling sight, a violent and vulgar woman in a raging passion. She ran round the bed and, seizing the dress, threw it on the

floor and stamped on it, grinding the delicate fabric into the carpet with her heels.

“There!” she cried. “That’s what I feel about it! That’s the way I’ll treat the things and the people I don’t like! That dress—it isn’t paid for, but I don’t want it. I’ll get another when I do. Have I married Con Ryan’s son to need money and bother about bills? Not on your life! Did you notice the gas? Every burner turned on. Well, I did it just to have a nice bright house for you when you came home without the invitation. We haven’t paid the bill for two months—but what does that matter? We’re related to the Ryans. We don’t have to trouble about bills.”

He saw that she was beyond arguing with and turned to leave the room. She sprang after him and caught him by the arm, pouring out only too coherent streams of rage and abuse. It was the old story of the “wrongs” she had suffered at his hands, and his “ruin” of her. To-night it had no power to move him and he shook her off and left the room. She ran to the door behind him and leaning out, cried it after him.

He literally fled from her, down the hallway, with the open doorways sending their lurid light and hissing noise across his passage. As he reached the dining-room he heard her bang the door and with aggressive noise turn the key in the lock and shoot the bolt. Even at that moment the lack of necessity for such a precaution caused a bitter smile to move his lips.



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swept away**

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He entered the dining-room and sat down by the table, his head on his hands. It was very quiet; no noise came from the street outside, sinking into the deep restfulness of midnight, and from within there was only the tearing sound of the flaring gases and an occasional cool dropping from the filter in the pantry. He sat thus for some hours, trying to think what he should do. He found it impossible to come to any definite conclusion for the future; all

he could decide upon now was the necessity of leaving his wife, getting a respite from her, withdrawing himself from the sight of her. He had never loved her, but to-night the pity and responsibility he had felt seemed to be torn from his life as a morning wind tears a cobweb from the grass.

The dawn was whitening the window-panes when he finally got pen and paper and wrote a few lines. These, without prefix or signature, stated that he would leave the city for a short time and not to make any effort to find where he had gone or communicate with him. He wrote her name on the folded paper and placed it in front of the clock. Then he stole into his bedroom—they had occupied separate rooms for over six months—and packed a valise with his oldest and roughest clothes. After this he waited in the dining-room till the light was bright and the traffic of the day loud on the pavement, before he crept down the long stairway and went out into the crystal freshness of the morning.

CHAPTER IV

OUT OF NIGHT AND STORM

When Rose Cannon woke on the morning after her arrival at Antelope, a memory of the snowflakes of the evening before made her jump out of bed and patter barefooted to the window. It seemed to her it would be “lots of fun” to be snowed up at Antelope, and when she saw only a thin covering of white on the hotel garden and the diminishing perspective of roofs, she drew her mouth into a grimace of disappointment.

With hunched-up shoulders, her hands tucked under her arms, she stood looking out, her breath blurring the pane in a dissolving film of smoke. It was a cold little world. Below her the garden—the summer pride of Perley’s Hotel—lay a sere, withered waste, its shrubs stiff in the grip of the cold. The powdering of snow on its frost-bitten leaves and grizzled grass added to its air of bleakness. Beyond rose the shingled roofs of Antelope’s main street. From their white-coated slopes black stovepipes sent aloft spirals of smoke, a thinner, fainter gray than the air into which they ascended. The sky lowered, low-hanging and full of menace. The snowflakes that now and then idly circled down were dark against its stormy pallor. Rose, standing gazing up, wondered if her father would go on to Greenhide, the new camp twenty miles from Antelope, where an important strike had recently been made.

Half an hour later when they met at breakfast he told her he would not leave for Greenhide that morning. Perley had warned him not to attempt it, and he for his part knew the country well enough to realize that it would be foolhardy to start under such a threatening sky. It would be all right to stop over at Antelope till the weather made up its mind what it meant to do. It might not be fun for her, but then he had warned her before they left San Francisco that she would have to put up with rough accommodations and unaccustomed discomforts.

Rose laughed. Her father did not understand that the roughness and novelty of it all was what she enjoyed. He was already a man of means when she was born, and she had known nothing of the hardships and privations

through which he and her mother had struggled up to fortune. Rocky Bar the night before and Antelope this morning were her first glimpses of the mining region over which the pioneers had swarmed in '49, Bill Cannon, only a lad in his teens, among them.

Now she sat sidewise in her chair, sweeping with animated eyes the primitive dining-room, its walls whitewashed, its low ceiling hung with strands of pinked-out, colored paper, its board floor here and there crossed by strips of cocoanut matting. At one end a hole in the wall communicated with the kitchen and through this the naked arms of the Chinaman, brown against the uprolled ends of his white sleeves, protruded, offering dishes to the single waitress who was not always there to receive them.

The girl, Cora by name, was particularly delinquent this morning. Several times the Chinaman was forced to remove his arms and substitute his face in the opening while he projected an enraged yell of "Corla!" among the hotel guests. Her dereliction of duty was caused by an overpowering interest in the Cannons, round whom she hovered in enchanted observation. On ordinary occasions Cora was content to wait on the group of men, local bachelors whose lonely state made it more convenient for them "to eat" at the hotel, and who sat—two bending lines of masculine backs—at either side of a long table. Cora's usual method was to set the viands before them and then seat herself at the end of the table and enliven the meal with light conversation. To-day, however, they were neglected. She scarcely answered their salutations, but, banging the dishes down, hasted away to the Cannon table, where she stood fixedly regarding the strange young lady.

Perley's warnings of bad weather were soon verified. Early in the afternoon the idle, occasional snowflakes had begun to fall thickly, with a soft, persistent steadiness of purpose. The icy stillness of the morning gave place to a wind, uncertain and whispering at first, but, as the day advanced, gathering volume and speed. The office and bar filled with men, some of them—snow powdered as if a huge sugar-sifter had been shaken over them—having tramped in from small camps in the vicinity. Clamor and vociferations, mixed with the smell of strong drinks and damp woollens, rose from the bar. Constant gusts of cold air swept the lower passages, and snow was tramped into the matting round the hall stove.

At four o'clock, Willoughby, the Englishman who had charge of the shut-down Bella K. mine, came, butting head down against the wind, a group of dogs at his heels, to claim the hospitality of the hotel. His watchman, an old timer, had advised him to seek a shelter better stored with provisions than the office building of the Bella K. Willoughby, whose accent and manner had proclaimed him as one of high distinction before it was known in Antelope that he was "some relation to a lord," was made welcome in the bar. His four red setter dogs, shut out from that hospitable retreat by the swing door, grouped around it and stared expectantly, each shout from within being answered by them with plaintive and ingratiating whines.

The afternoon was still young when the day began to darken. Rose Cannon, who had been sitting in the parlor, dreaming over a fire of logs, went to the window, wondering at the growing gloom. The wind had risen to a wild, sweeping speed, that tore the snow fine as a mist. There were no lazy, woolly flakes now. They had turned into an opaque, slanting veil which here and there curled into snowy mounds and in other places left the ground bare. It seemed as if a giant paint-brush, soaked in white, had been swept over the outlook. Now and then a figure, head down, hands in pockets, the front of the body looking as though the paint-brush had been slapped across it, came into view, shadowy and unsubstantial in the mist-like density.

Rose looked out on it with an interest that was a little soberer than the debonair blitheness of her morning mood. If it kept up they might be snowed in for days, Perley had said. That being the case, this room, the hotel's one parlor, would be her retreat, her abiding place—for her bedroom was as cold as an ice-chest—until they were liberated. With the light, half-whimsical smile that came so readily to her lips, she turned from the window and surveyed it judicially.

Truly it was not bad. Seen by the light of the flaming logs pulsing on the obscurity already lurking in the corners, it had the charm of the fire-warmed interior, tight-closed against outer storm. A twilight room lit only by a fire, with wind and snow outside, is the coziest habitation in the world. It seemed to Rose it would make a misanthrope feel friendly, prone to sociable chat and confidence. When the day grew still dimmer she would draw the curtains (they were of a faded green rep) and pull up the old horsehair arm-chairs that were set back so demurely in the corners. Her eyes strayed to the melodeon and then to the wall above it, where hung a

picture of a mining millionaire, once of the neighborhood, recently deceased, a circlet of wax flowers from his bier surrounding his head, and the whole neatly incased in glass. Washington crossing the Delaware made a pendent on the opposite wall. On the center-table there were many books in various stages of unrepair and in all forms of bindings. These were the literary aftermath left by the mining men, who, since the early sixties, had been stopping at Antelope on their hopeful journeys up and down the mineral belt.

She was leaving the window to return to her seat by the fire when the complete silence that seemed to hold the outside world in a spell was broken by sudden sounds. Voices, the crack of a whip, then a grinding thump against the hotel porch, caught her ear and whirled her back to the pane. A large covered vehicle, with the whitened shapes of a smoking team drooping before it, had just drawn up at the steps. Two masculine figures, carrying bags, emerged from the interior, and from the driver's seat a muffled shape—a cylinder of wrappings which appeared to have a lively human core—gave forth much loud and profane language. The isolation and remoteness of her surroundings had already begun to affect the town-bred young lady. She ran to the door of the parlor, as ingenuously curious to see the new arrivals and find out who they were as though she had lived in Antelope for a year.

Looking down the hall she saw the front door open violently inward and two men hastily enter. The wind seemed to blow them in and before Perley's boy could press the door shut the snow had whitened the damp matting. No stage passed through Antelope in these days of its decline, and the curiosity felt by Rose was shared by the whole hotel. The swing door to the bar opened and men pressed into the aperture. Mrs. Perley came up from the kitchen, wiping a dish. Cora appeared in the dining-room doorway, and in answer to Miss Cannon's inquiringly-lifted eyebrows, called across the hall:

"It's the Murphysville stage on the down-trip to Rocky Bar. I guess they thought they couldn't make it. The driver don't like to run no risks and so he's brought 'em round this way and dumped 'em here. There ain't but two passengers. That's them."

She indicated the two men who, standing by the hall stove, were divesting themselves of their wraps. One of them was a tall upright old man with a sweep of grizzled beard covering his chest, and gray hair falling from the dome of a bald head.

The other was much younger, tall also, and spare to leanness. He wore a gray fedora hat, and against its chill, unbecoming tint, his face, its prominent, bony surfaces nipped by the cold to a raw redness, looked sallow and unhealthy. With an air of solicitude he laid his overcoat across a chair, brushing off the snow with a careful hand. Buttoned tight in a black cutaway with the collar turned up about his neck, he had an appearance of being uncomfortably compressed into garments too small for him. His shiny-knuckled, purplish hands, pinching up the shoulders of his coat over the chair-back, were in keeping with his general suggestion of a large-boned meagerly-covered lankness. The fact that he was smooth-shaven, combined with the unusual length of dark hair that appeared below his hat-brim, lent him a suggestion of something interestingly unconventional, almost artistic. In the region where he now found himself he would have been variously set down as a gambler, a traveling clergyman, an actor, or perhaps only a vender of patent medicines who had some odd, attractive way of advertising himself, such as drawing teeth with an electric appliance, or playing the guitar from the tail-board of his showman's cart.

Now, having arranged his coat to its best advantage, he turned to Perley and said with a curiously deep and resonant voice,

"And, mine host, a stove in my bedroom, a stove in my bedroom or I perish."

Cora giggled and threw across the hall to Miss Cannon a delighted murmur of,

"Oh, say, ain't he just the richest thing?"

"You've got us trapped and caged here for a spell, I guess," said the older man. "Any one else in the same box?"

"Oh, you'll not want for company," said Perley, pride at the importance of the announcement vibrating in his tone. "We've got Willoughby here from the Bella K. with his four setter dogs, and Bill Cannon and his daughter up from the coast."

“Bill Cannon!”—the two men stared and the younger one said,

“Bill Cannon, the Bonanza King from San Francisco?”

“That’s him all right,” nodded Perley. “Up here to see the diggings at Greenhide and snowed in same as you.”

Here, Rose, fearing the conversation might turn upon herself, slipped from the doorway into the passage and up the stairs to her own room.

An hour later as she stood before the glass making her toilet for supper, a knock at the door ushered in Cora, already curled, powdered and beribboned for that occasion, a small kerosene lamp in her hand. In the bare room, its gloom only partly dispelled by the light from a similar lamp on the bureau and the red gleam from the stove, Miss Cannon was revealed in the becoming half-dusk made by these imperfectly-blending illuminations, a pink silk dressing-gown loosely enfolding her, a lightly brushed-in suggestion of fair hair behind her ears and on her shoulders. Her comb was in her hand and Cora realized with an uplifting thrill that she had timed her visit correctly and was about to learn the mysteries of Miss Cannon’s coiffure.

“I brung you another lamp,” she said affably, setting her offering down on the bureau. “One ain’t enough light to dress decently by. I have three,” and she sank down on the side of the bed with the air of having established an intimacy, woman to woman, by this act of generous consideration.

“Them gentlemen,” she continued, “are along on this hall with you and your pa. The old one’s Judge Washburne, of Colusa, a pioneer that used to know Mrs. Perley’s mother way back in Sacramento in the fifties, and knew your pa real well when he was poor. It’s sort of encouraging to think *your* pa was ever poor.”

Rose laughed and turned sidewise, looking at the speaker under the arch of her uplifted arm. There were hair-pins in her mouth and an upwhirled end of blond hair protruded in a gleaming scattering of yellow over her forehead. She mumbled a comment on her father’s early poverty, her lips showing red against the hair-pins nipped between her teeth.

“And the other one,” went on Cora, her eyes riveted on the hair-dressing, her subconscious mind making notes of the disposition of every coil, “his name’s J. D. Buford. And I’d like you to guess what he is! An actor, a stage

player. He's been playing all up the state from Los Angeles and was going down to Sacramento to keep an engagement there. It just tickles me to death to have an actor in the house. I ain't never seen one close to before."

The last hair-pin was adjusted and Miss Cannon studied the effect with a hand-glass.

"An actor," she commented, running a smoothing palm up the back of her head, "that's just what he looked like, now I think of it. Perhaps he'll act for us. I think it's going to be lots of fun being snowed up at Antelope."

The sound of a voice crying "Cora" here rose from the hallway and that young woman, with a languid deliberation of movement, as of one who obeys a vulgar summons at her own elegant leisure, rose and departed, apologizing for having to go so soon. A few minutes later, the hour of supper being at hand, Rose followed her.

She was descending the stairs when a commotion from below, a sound of voices loud, argumentative, rising and falling in excited chorus, hurried her steps. The lower hall, lit with lamps and the glow of its stove, heated to a translucent red, was full of men. A current of cold could be felt in the hot atmosphere and fresh snow was melting on the floor. Standing by the stove was a man who had evidently just entered. Ridges of white lay caught in the folds of his garments; a silver hoar was on his beard. He held his hands out to the heat and as Rose reached the foot of the stairs she heard him say,

"Well, I tell you that any man that started to walk up here from Rocky Bar this afternoon must have been plumb crazy. Why, John L. Sullivan couldn't do it in such a storm."

To which the well-bred voice of Willoughby answered,

"But according to the message he started at two and the snow was hardly falling then. He must have got a good way, past the Silver Crescent even, when the storm caught him."

A hubbub of voices broke out here, and, seeing her father on the edge of the crowd, Rose went to him and plucked his sleeve, murmuring,

"What's happened? What's going on?"

He took his cigar out of his mouth and turned toward her, speaking low and keeping his eyes on the men by the stove.

“The telegraph operator’s just had a message sent from Rocky Bar that a man started from there this afternoon to walk up here. They don’t think he could make it and are afraid he’s lost somewhere. Perley and some of the boys are going out to look for him.”

“What a dreadful thing! In such a storm! Do you think they’ll ever find him?”

He shrugged, and replaced his cigar in his mouth.

“Oh, I guess so. If he was strong enough to get on near here they ought to. But it’s just what the operator says. The feller must have been plumb crazy to attempt such a thing. Looks as if he was a stranger in the country.”

“It’s a sort of quiet, respectable way of committing suicide,” said the voice of the actor behind them.

Rose looked over her shoulder and saw his thin, large-featured face, no longer nipped and reddened with cold, but wreathed in an obsequious and friendly smile which furrowed it with deep lines. Her father answered him and she turned away, being more interested in the preparations for the search party. As she watched these she could hear the desultory conversation behind her, the actor’s comments delivered with an unctuous, elaborate politeness which, contrasted with her father’s gruff brevity, made her smile furtively to herself.

A jingle of sleigh bells from without threw the party into the sudden bustle of departure. Men shrugged themselves into their coats and tied comforters over their ears. Perley emerged from the bar, shrouded in outer wrappings, and crowding a whisky flask into his pocket. The hall door was thrown open, and through the powdery thickness of the atmosphere the sleigh with its restive horses could be seen drawn up at the porch steps. Those left behind pressed into the doorway to speed the departure. Shouted instructions, last suggestions as to the best methods for conducting the search filled the air, drowning the despairing whines that Willoughby’s dogs, shut in the bar, sent after their master. With a broken jingle of bells the sleigh started and in a moment was swallowed up in the blackness of the storm.

Supper was an animated meal that evening. The suddenly tragic interest that had developed drew the little group of guests together with the strands of a

common sympathy. The judge and the actor moved their seats to the Cannons' table. Cora was sent to request the doctor—a young man fresh from his graduation in San Francisco who took his meals at the bachelor's table—to join them and add the weight of medical opinion to their surmises as to the traveler's chances of survival. These, the doctor thought, depended as much upon the man's age and physical condition, as upon the search party's success in finding him. And then they speculated as to the man himself, drawing inferences from the one thing they knew of him, building up his character from this single fact, deducing from it what manner of man he should be, and why he should have done so strangely foolhardy a thing.

After supper they retired to the parlor, piled the fire high and sat grouped before it, the smoke of cigars and cigarettes lying about their heads in white layers. It was but natural that the conversation should turn on stories of the great storms of the past. Rose had heard many such before, but to-night, with the wind rocking the old hotel and the thought of the lost man heavy at her heart, she listened, held in a cold clutch of fascinated attention, to tales of the emigrants caught in the passes of the Sierra, of pioneer mining-camps relieved by mule trains which broke through the snow blockade as the miners lay dying in their huts, of men risking their lives to carry succor to comrades lost in their passage from camp to camp on just such a night as this. Now and then one of Willoughby's dogs, long since broken from the confinement of the bar, came to the door and put in an inquiring head, the ears pricked, the eyes full of hopeful inquiry, a feathered tail wagging in deprecating friendliness. But its master was not there and it turned away, disappointed, to run up the hall, sniffing under closed doors and whimpering in uneasy loneliness.

Rose sat crouched over the fire, and as the fund of stories became exhausted and silence gradually settled on the group, her thoughts turned again to the traveler. She had been shocked at first, as the others were, by the thought of a fellow creature lost in the storm; but as the evening advanced, and the talk threw round his vague, undefined figure the investiture of an identity and a character, she began to see him less as a nebulous, menaced shape than as a known individuality. He seemed to be advancing out of the swirling blackness of the night into extending circles of the acquainted and the intimate. He was drawing near, drawing out of the limbo of darkness and mystery, into the light of their friendly fire, the grasp of their welcoming

hands. He took shape in her imagination; she began to see his outline forming and taking color. With every tick of the clock she felt more keenly that he was some one who needed her help, and whom she must rescue. By ten she was in a ferment of anguished expectancy. The lost traveler was to her a man who had once been her friend, now threatened by death.

The clock hand passed ten, and the periods of silence that at intervals had fallen on the watchers grew longer and more frequent, and finally merged into a stillness where all sat motionless, listening to the storm. It had increased with the coming of the dark and now filled the night with wildness and tumult. The wind made human sounds about the angles of the house, which rocked and creaked to its buffets. The gale was fitful. It died away almost to silence, seeming to recuperate its forces for a new attack, and then came back full of fresh energies. It struck blows on the doors and windows, like those of a fist demanding entrance. Billowing rushes of sound circled round the building, and then a rustling passage of sleet swept across the curtained pane.

It was nearly eleven, and for fifteen minutes no one had spoken a word. Two of the dogs had come in and lain down on the hearth-rug, their noses on their paws, their eyes fixed brightly and ponderingly on the fire. In the midst of the motionless semicircle one of them suddenly raised its head, its ears pricked. With its muzzle elevated, its eyes full of awakened intelligence, it gave a low, uneasy whimper. Almost simultaneously Rose started and drew herself up, exclaiming, "Listen!" The sound of sleigh bells, faint as a noise in a dream, came through the night.

In a moment the lower floor was shaken with movement and noise. The bar emptied itself on to the porch and the hall doors were thrown wide. The sleigh had been close to the hotel before its bells were heard, and almost immediately its shape emerged from the swirling whiteness and drew up at the steps. Rose, standing back in the parlor doorway, heard a clamor of voices, a rising surge of sound from which no intelligible sentence detached itself, and a thumping and stamping of feet as the searchers staggered in with the lost traveler. The crowd separated before them and they entered slowly, four men carrying a fifth, their bodies incrustated with snow, the man they bore an unseen shape covered with whitened rugs from which an arm hung, a limp hand touching the floor. Questions and answers, now clear and sharp, followed them, like notes upon the text of the inert form:

“Where’d you get him?”

“About five miles below on the main road. One of the horses almost stepped on him. He was right in the path, but he was all sprinkled over with snow.”

“He’s not dead, is he?”

“Pretty near, I guess. We’ve pumped whisky into him, but he ain’t shown a sign of life.”

“Who is he?”

“Search me. I ain’t seen him good myself yet. Just as we got him the lantern went out.”

There was a sofa in the hall and they laid their burden there, the crowd edging in on them, horrified, interested, hungrily peering. Rose could see their bent, expressive backs and the craning napes of their necks. Then a sharp order from the doctor drove them back, sheepish, tramping on one another’s toes, bunched against the wall and still avidly staring. As their ranks broke, the young girl had a sudden, vivid glimpse of the man, his head and part of his chest uncovered. Her heart gave a leap of pity and she made a movement from the doorway, then stopped. The lost traveler, that an hour before had almost assumed the features of a friend, was a complete stranger that she had never seen before.

He looked like a dead man. His face, the chin up, the lips parted under the fringe of a brown mustache, was marble white, and showed a gray shadow in the cheek. The hair on his forehead, thawed by the heat, was lying in damp half-curved semicircles, dark against the pallid skin. There was a ring on the hand that still hung limp on the floor. The doctor, muttering to himself, pulled open the shirt and was feeling the heart, when Perley, who had flown into the bar for more whisky, emerged, a glass in his hand. As his eye fell upon the man, he stopped, stared, and then exclaimed in loud-voiced amaze:

“My God—why, it’s Dominick Ryan! Look here, Governor”—to Cannon who was standing by his daughter in the parlor doorway, “come and see for yourself. If this ain’t young Ryan I’m a Dutchman!”

Cannon pushed between the intervening men and bent over the prostrate figure.

“That’s who it is,” he said slowly and unemotionally. “It’s Dominick Ryan, all right. Well, by ginger!” and he turned and looked at the amazed innkeeper, “that’s the queerest thing I ever saw. What’s brought him up here?”

Perley, his glass snatched from him by the doctor who seemed entirely indifferent to their recognition of his patient, shrugged helplessly.

“Blest if I know,” he said, staring aimlessly about him. “He was here last summer fishing. But there ain’t no fishing now. God, ain’t it a good thing that operator at Rocky Bar had the sense to telegraph up!”

CHAPTER V

NURSE AND PATIENT

When Dominick returned to consciousness he lay for a space looking directly in front of him, then moved his head and let his eyes sweep the walls. They were alien walls of white plaster, naked of all adornment. The light from a shaded lamp lay across one of them in a soft yet clear wash of yellow, so clear that he could see that the plaster was coarse.

There were few pieces of furniture in the room, and all new to him. A bureau of the old-fashioned marble-topped kind stood against the wall opposite. The lamp that cast the yellow light was on this bureau; its globe, a translucent gold reflection revealed in liquid clearness in the mirror just behind. It was not his own room nor Berny's. He turned his head farther on the pillow very slowly, for he seemed sunk in an abyss of suffering and feebleness. On the table by the bed's head was another lamp, a folded newspaper shutting its light from his face, and here his eyes stopped.

A woman was sitting by the foot of the bed, her head bent as if reading. He stared at her with even more intentness than he had at the room. The glow of the lamp on the bureau was behind her—he saw her against it without color or detail, like a shadow thrown on a sheet. Her outlines were sharply defined against the illumined stretch of plaster,—the arch of her head, which was broken by the coils of hair on top, her rather short neck, with some sort of collar binding it, the curve of her shoulders, rounded and broad, not the shoulders of a thin woman. He did not think she was his wife, but she might be, and he moved and said suddenly in a husky voice,

“What time is it?”

The woman started, laid her book down, and rose. She came forward and stood beside him, looking down, the filaments of hair round her head blurring the sharpness of its outline. He stared up at her, haggard and intent, and saw it was not his wife. It was a strange woman with a pleasant, smiling face. He felt immensely relieved and said with a hoarse carefulness of utterance,

“What time did you say it is?”

“A few minutes past five,” she answered. “You’ve been asleep.”

“Have I?” he said, gazing immovably at her. “What day is it?”

“Thursday,” she replied. “You came here last night from Rocky Bar. Perhaps you don’t remember.”

“Rocky Bar!” he repeated vaguely, groping through a haze of memory. “Was it only yesterday? Was it only yesterday I left San Francisco?”

“I don’t know when you left San Francisco—” the newspaper shade cracked and bent a little, letting a band of light fall across the pillow. She leaned down, arranging it with careful hands, looking from the light to him to see if it were correctly adjusted.

“Whenever you left San Francisco,” she said, “you got here last night. They brought you here, Perley and some other men in the sleigh. They found you in the road. You were half-frozen.”

He looked at her moving hands, then when they had satisfactorily arranged the shade and dropped to her sides, he looked at her face. Her eyes were soft and friendly and had a gentle, kind expression. He liked to look at them. The only woman’s eyes he had looked into lately had been full of wrathful lightnings. There seemed no need to be polite or do the things that people did when they were well and sitting talking in chairs, so he did not speak for what seemed to him a long time. Then he said,

“What is this place?”

“Antelope,” said the woman. “Perley’s Hotel at Antelope.”

“Oh, yes,” he answered with an air of weary recollection, “I was going to walk there from Rocky Bar, but the snow came down too hard, and the wind—you could hardly stand against it! It was a terrible pull. Perley’s Hotel at Antelope. Of course, I know all about it. I was here last summer for two weeks fishing.”

She stretched out her hand for a glass, across the top of which a book rested. He followed the movement with a mute fixity.

“This is your medicine,” she said, taking the book off the glass. “You were to take it at five but I didn’t like to wake you.”

She dipped a spoon into the glass and held it out to him. But the young man felt too ill to bother with medicine and, as the spoon touched his lips, he gave his head a slight jerk and the liquid was spilt on the counterpane. She looked at it for a rueful moment, then said, as if with gathering determination,

“But you *must* take it. I think perhaps I gave it wrong. I ought to have lifted you up. It’s easier that way,” and before he could answer she slipped her arm under his head and raised it, with the other hand setting the rim of the glass against his lips. He swallowed a mouthful and felt her arm sliding from behind his head. He had a hazy consciousness that a perfume came from her dress, and for the first time he wondered who she was. Wondering thus, his eyes again followed her hand putting back the glass, and watched it, white in the gush of lamplight, carefully replacing the book. Then she turned toward him with the same slight, soft smile.

“Who are *you*?” he said, keeping his hollowed eyes hard on her.

“I’m Rose Cannon,” she answered. “Rose Cannon from San Francisco.”

“Oh, yes,” with a movement of comprehension, the name striking a chord of memory. “Rose Cannon from San Francisco, daughter of Bill Cannon. Of course I know.”

He was silent again, overwhelmed by indifference and lassitude. She made a step backward from the bedside. Her dress rustled and the same faint perfume he had noticed came delicately to him. He turned his head away from her and said dryly and without interest,

“I thought it was some one else.”

The words seemed to arrest her. She came back and stood close beside him. Looking up he could see her head against the light that ran up from the shaded lamps along the ceiling. She bent down and said, speaking slowly and clearly as though to a child,

“The storm has broken the wires but as soon as they are up, papa will send your mother word, so you needn’t worry about that. But we don’t either of us know your wife’s address. If you could tell us——”

She stopped. He had begun to frown and then shut his eyes with an expression of weariness.

“That doesn’t matter,” he said. “Don’t bother about it. Let her alone.”

Again there was one of those pauses which seemed to him so long. He gave a sigh and moved restlessly, and she said,

“Are your feet very painful?”

“Yes, pretty bad,” he answered. “What’s the matter with them?”

“They were frost-bitten, one partly frozen.”

“Oh—” he did not seem profoundly interested. It was as if they were some one else’s feet, only they hurt violently enough to obtrude themselves upon his attention. “Thank you very much,” he added. “I’ll be all right tomorrow.”

He felt very tired and heard, as in a dream, the rustle of her dress as she moved again. She said something about “supper” and “Mrs. Perley coming,” and the dark, enveloping sense of stupor from which he had come to life closed on him again.

Some time later on he emerged from it and saw another woman, stout and matronly, with sleekly-parted hair, and an apron girt about her. He asked her, too, who she was, for the fear that he might wake and find his wife by his bedside mingled with the pain of his feet, to torment him and break the vast, dead restfulness of the torpor in which he lay.

It broke into gleams of interest and returning consciousness during the next two days. He experienced an acuter sense of illness and pain, the burning anguish of his feet and fevered misery of his body, bitten through with cold, brought him back to a realization of his own identity. He heard the doctor murmuring in the corner of “threatened pneumonia” and understood that he was the object threatened. He began to know and separate the strange faces that seemed continually to be bending over him, asking him how he felt. There was the doctor, Perley, Bill Cannon, and the old judge and three different women, whom he had some difficulty in keeping from merging into one composite being who was sometimes “Miss Cannon,” and sometimes “Mrs. Perley,” and then again “Cora.”

When on the fourth day the doctor told him that he thought he would “pull through” with no worse ailment than a frozen foot, he had regained enough of his original vigor and impatience under restraint to express a

determination to rise and “go on.” He was in pain, mental and physical, and the ministrations and attentions of the satellites that so persistently revolved round his bed rasped him into irritable moodiness. He did not know that all Antelope was waiting for the latest bulletins from Mrs. Perley or Cora. The glamour attaching to his sensational entry into their midst had been intensified by the stories of the wealth and position that had been his till he had married a poor girl, contrary to his mother’s wishes. He was talked of in the bar, discussed in the kitchen, and Cora dreamed of him at night. The very name of Ryan carried its weight, and Antelope, a broken congeries of white roofs and black smoke-stacks emerging from giant drifts, throbbed with pride at the thought that the two greatest names of California finance were snow-bound in Perley’s Hotel.

The doctor laughed at his desire to “move on.” The storm was still raging and Antelope was as completely cut off from the rest of the world as if it were an uncharted island in the unknown reaches of the Pacific. Propping the invalid up among his pillows he drew back the curtain and let him look out through a frost-painted pane on a world all sweeping lines and skurrying eddies of white. The drifts curled crisp edges over the angles of roofs, like the lips of breaking waves. The glimpse of the little town that the window afforded showed it cowering under a snow blanket, almost lost to sight in its folds.

“Even if your feet were all right, you’re tied here for two weeks anyway,” said the doctor, dropping the curtain. “It’s the biggest storm *I* ever saw, and there’s an old timer that hangs round the bar who says it’s as bad as the one that caught the Donner party in forty-six.”

The next day it stopped and the world lay gleaming and still under a frosty crust. The sky was a cold, sullen gray, brooding and cloud-hung, and the roofs and tree-tops stood out against it as though executed in thick white enamel. The drifts lay in suave curves, softly undulating like the outlines of a woman’s body, sometimes sweeping smoothly up to second stories, here and there curdled into an eddy, frozen as it twisted. A miner came in from an outlying camp on skees and reported the cold as intense, the air clear as crystal and perfectly still. On the path as he came numerous fir boughs had broken under the weight of snow, with reports like pistol shots. There was a rumor that men, short of provisions, were snowed up at the Yaller Dog mine just beyond the shoulder of the mountain. This gave rise to much

consultation and loud talking in the bar, and the lower floor of Perley's was as full of people, noise and stir, as though a party were in progress.

That afternoon Dominick, clothed in an old bath-robe of the doctor's, his swathed feet hidden under a red rug drawn from Mrs. Perley's stores, was promoted to an easy chair by the window. The doctor, who had helped him dress, having disposed the rug over his knees and tucked a pillow behind his back, stood off and looked critically at the effect.

"I've got to have you look your best," he said, "and you've got to act your prettiest this afternoon. The young lady's coming in to take care of you while I go my rounds."

"Young lady!" exclaimed Dominick in a tone that indicated anything but pleasurable anticipation. "What young lady?"

"*Our* young lady," answered the doctor. "Miss Cannon, the Young Lady of Perley's Hotel. Don't you know that that's the nicest girl in the world? Maybe you don't, but that's because your powers of appreciation have been dormant for the last few days. The people here were most scared to death of her at first. They didn't know how she was going to get along, used to the finest, the way she's always been. But, bless your heart, she's less trouble than anybody in the place. There's twelve extra people eating here, besides you to be looked after, and Mrs. Perley and Cora are pretty near run to death trying to do it. Miss Cannon wanted to turn in and help them. They wouldn't have it, but they had to let her do her turn here taking care of you."

"It's very kind of her," said the invalid without enthusiasm. "I noticed her here several times."

"And as easy as an old shoe," said the doctor. "Just as nice to Perley's boy, who's a waif that the Perleys picked up in the streets of Stockton, as if he was the Prince of Wales. I tell you heredity's a queer thing. How did Bill Cannon come to have a girl like that? Of course there's the mother to take into account, but—"

A knock on the door interrupted him. To his cry of "Come in," Rose entered, a white shawl over her shoulders, a book in her hand. While she and Dominick were exchanging greetings, the doctor began thrusting his

medicines into his bag, alleging the necessity of an immediate departure, as two cases of bronchitis and three of pneumonia awaited him.

“You didn’t know there were that many people in Antelope,” he said as he snapped the clasp of the bag and picked up his hat. “Well, I’ll swear to it, even if it does seem the prejudiced estimate of an old inhabitant. So long. I’ll be back by five and I hope to hear a good report from the nurse.”

The door closed behind him and Dominick and the young girl were left looking rather blankly at each other. It was the first time he had seen her when he had not been presented to her observation as a prostrate and fever-stricken sufferer of whom nothing was expected but a docile attitude in the matter of medicines. Now he felt the subjugating power of clothes. It did not seem possible that the doctor’s bath-robe and Mrs. Perley’s red rug could cast such a blighting weight of constraint and consciousness upon him. But with the donning of them his invalid irresponsibility seemed gone for ever. He had a hunted, helpless feeling that he ought to talk to this young woman as gentlemen did who were not burdened by the pain of frozen feet and marital troubles. Moreover, he felt the annoyance of being thus thrust upon the care of a lady whom he hardly knew.

“I’m very sorry that they bothered you this way,” he said awkwardly. “I—I—don’t think I need any one with me. I’m quite comfortable here by myself,” and then he stopped, conscious of the ungraciousness of his words, and reddening uncomfortably.

“I dare say you don’t want me here,” said Rose with an air of meekness which had the effect of being assumed. “But you really have been too sick to be left alone. Besides, there’s your medicine, you must take that regularly.”

The invalid gave an indifferent cast of his eye toward the glass on the bureau, guarded by the familiar book and spoon. Then he looked back at her. She was regarding him deprecatingly.

“Couldn’t I take it myself?” he said.

“I don’t think I’d trust you,” she answered.

His sunken glance was held by hers, and he saw, under the deprecation of her look, humor struggling to keep itself in seemly suppression. He was faintly surprised. There did not seem to him anything comic in the fact of

her distrust. But as he looked at her he saw the humor rising past control. She dropped her eyes to hide it and bit her under lip. This did strike him as funny and a slow grin broke the melancholy of his face. She stole a stealthy look at him, her gravity vanished at the first glimpse of the grin, and she began to laugh, holding her head down and making the stifled, chuckling sounds of controlled mirth suddenly liberated. He was amused and a little puzzled and, with his grin more pronounced than before, said,

“What are you laughing at?”

She lifted her head and looked at him with eyes narrowed to slits, murmuring,

“You, trying to get rid of me and being so polite and helpless. It’s too pathetic for words.”

“If it’s pathetic, why do you laugh?” he said, laughing himself, he did not know why.

She made no immediate reply and he looked at her, languidly interested and admiring. For the first time he realized that she was a pretty girl, with her glistening coils of blond hair and a pearl-white skin, just now suffused with pink.

“Why did you think I wanted to get rid of you?” he asked.

“You’ve almost said so,” she answered. “And then—well, I can see you do.”

“How? What have I done that you’ve seen?”

“Not any especial thing, but—I *think* you do.”

He felt too weak and indifferent to tell polite falsehoods. Leaning his head on the pillow that stood up at his back, he said,

“Perhaps I did at first. But now I’m glad you came.”

She smiled indulgently at him as though he were a sick child.

“I should think you wouldn’t have wanted me. You must be so tired of people coming in and out. Those days when you were so bad the doctor had the greatest difficulty in keeping men out who didn’t know you and had never seen you. Everybody in the hotel wanted to crowd in.”

“What did they want to do that for?”

“To see you. We were the sensation of Antelope first. But then you came and put us completely in the shade. Antelope hasn’t had such an excitement as your appearance since the death of Jim Granger, whose picture is down stairs in the parlor and who comes from here.”

“I don’t see why I should be an excitement. When I was up here fishing last summer nobody was in the least excited.”

“It was the way you came—half-dead out of the night as if the sea had thrown you up. Then everybody wanted to know why you did it, why you, a Californian, attempted such a dangerous thing.”

“There wasn’t anything so desperately dangerous about it,” he said, almost in a tone of sulky protest.

“The men down stairs seemed to think so. They say nobody could have got up here in such a storm.”

“Oh, rubbish! Besides, it wasn’t storming when I left Rocky Bar. It was gray and threatening, but there wasn’t a flake falling. The first snow came down when I was passing the Silver Crescent. It came very fast after that.”

“Why did you do it—attempt to walk such a distance in such uncertain weather?”

Dominick smoothed the rug over his knees. His face, looking down, had a curious expression of cold, enforced patience.

“I was tired,” he said slowly. “I’d worked too hard and I thought the mountains would do me good. I can get time off at the bank when I want and I thought I’d take a holiday and come up here where I was last summer. I knew the place and liked the hotel. I wanted to get a good way off, out of the city and away from my work. As for walking up here that afternoon—I’m very strong and I never thought for a moment such a blizzard was coming down.”

He lifted his head and turned toward the window, then raising one hand rubbed it across his forehead and eyes. There was something in the gesture that silenced the young girl. She thought he felt tired and had been talking too much and she was guiltily conscious of her laughter and loquacity.

They sat without speaking for some moments. Dominick made no attempt to break the silence when she moved noiselessly to the stove and pushed in more wood. His face was turned from her and she thought he had fallen asleep when he suddenly moved and said,

“Isn’t it strange that I have never met you before?”

She was relieved. His tone showed neither feebleness nor fatigue, in fact it had the fresh alertness of a return to congenial topics. She determined, however, to be less talkative, less encouraging to the weakening exertions of general conversation. So she spoke with demure brevity.

“Yes, very. But you were at college for four years, and the year you came back I was in Europe.”

He looked at her ruminatingly, and nodded.

“But I’ve seen you,” he said, “at the theater. I was too sick at first to recognize you, but afterward I knew I’d seen you, with your father and your brother Gene.”

It was her turn to nod. She thought it best to say nothing, and waited. But his eyes bent inquiringly upon her, and the waiting silence seemed to demand a comment. She made the first one that occurred to her:

“Whom were *you* with?”

“My wife,” said the young man.

Rose felt that an indefinite silence would have been better than this. All she knew of Dominick Ryan’s wife was that she was a person who had not been respectable and whose union with Dominick had estranged him from his people. Certainly, whatever else she was, young Mrs. Ryan was not calculated to be an agreeable subject of converse with the man who in marrying her had sacrificed wealth, family, and friends. The doctor’s chief injunction to Rose had been to keep the invalid in a state of tranquillity. Oppressed by a heavy sense of failure she felt that nursing was not her forte.

She murmured a vague sentence of comment and this time determined not to speak, no matter how embarrassing the pause became. She even thought of taking up her book and was about to stretch her hand for it, when he said,

“But it seems so queer when our parents have been friends for years, and I know Gene, and you know my sister Cornelia so well.”

She drew her hand back and leaned forward, frowning and staring in front of her, as she sent her memory backward groping for data.

“Well, you see a sort of series of events prevented it. When we were little our parents lived in different places. Ages ago when we first came down from Virginia City you were living somewhere else, in Sacramento, wasn’t it? Then you were at school, and after that you went East to college for four years, and when you got back from college I was in Europe. And when I came back from Europe—that’s over two years ago now—why then——”

She had again brought up against his marriage, this time with a shock that was of a somewhat shattering nature.

“Why, then,” she repeated falteringly, realizing where she was—“why, then—let’s see—?”

“Then I had married,” he said quietly.

“Oh, yes, of course,” she assented, trying to impart a suggestion of sudden innocent remembrance to her tone. “You had married. Why, of course.”

He vouchsafed no reply. She was distressed and mortified, her face red with anger at her own stupidity. In her embarrassment she looked down, smoothing her lace cuffs, and waiting for him to say something as he had done before. But this time he made no attempt to resume the conversation. Stealing a sidelong glance at him she saw that he had turned to the window and was gazing out. There was an expression of brooding gloom on his profile, his eyebrows drawn low, his lips close set. She judged rightly that he did not intend to speak again, and she took up her book and opened it.

Half an hour later, rising to give him his medicine, she saw that he had fallen asleep. She was at his side before she discovered it, thinking his eyes were drooped in thought. Standing with the glass in her hand she looked at him with something of a child’s shrinking curiosity and a woman’s pity for a strong creature weakened and brought low. The light in the room was growing gray and in it she saw his face, with the shadows in its hollows, looking thin and haggard in the abandonment of sleep. For the first time, seeing him clothed and upright, she realized that he was a personable man, a splendid man, and also for the first time she thought of him outside this

room and this house, and a sort of proud resentment stirred in her at the memory of the marriage he had made—the marriage with the woman who was not good.

An hour later when the doctor came back she was kneeling on the floor by the open stove door, softly building up the fire. From the orifice—a circle of brilliance in the dim room—a red glow painted her serious, down-bent face with a hectic color, and touched with a bright, palpitating glaze the curves of her figure. At the sound of the opening door she looked up quickly, and, her hands being occupied, gave a silencing jerk of her head toward the sleeping man.

The doctor looked at them both. The scene was like a picture of some primitive domestic interior where youth and beauty had made a nest, warmed by that symbol of life, a fire, which one replenished while the other slept.

CHAPTER VI

IN WHICH BERNY WRITES A LETTER

The morning after the quarrel Bernice woke late. She had not fallen asleep till the night was well spent, the heated seething of her rage keeping the peace of repose far from her. It was only as the dawn paled the square of the window that she fell into a heavy slumber, disturbed by dreams full of stress and strife.

She looked up at the clock; it was nearly ten. Dominick would have left for the bank before this, so the wretched constraint of a meeting with him was postponed. Sallow and heavy-eyed, her head aching, oppressed by a sense of the unbearable unpleasantness of the situation, she threw on her wrapper, and going to the window drew the curtain and looked out.

The bedroom had but one window, wedged into an angle of wall, and affording a glimpse of the green lawn and clipped rose trees of the house next door. There was a fog this morning and even this curtailed prospect was obliterated. She stood yawning drearily, and gazing out with eyes to which her yawns had brought tears. Her hair made a wild bush round her head, her face looked pinched and old. She was one of those women whose good looks are dependent on animation and millinery. In this fixity of inward thought, unobserved in unbecoming disarray, one could realize that she had attained the thirty-four years she could so successfully deny under the rejuvenating influences of full dress and high spirits.

During her toilet her thoughts refused to leave the subject of last night's quarrel. She and her husband had had disagreements before—many in the last year when they had virtually separated, though the world did not know it—but nothing so ignominiously repulsive as the scene of last evening had yet degraded their companionship. Bernice was ashamed. In the gray light of the dim, disillusioning morning she realized that she had gone too far. She knew Dominick to be long-suffering, she knew that the hold she had upon him was a powerful one, but the most patient creatures sometimes rebel, the most compelling sense of honor would sometimes break under too severe a strain. As she trailed down the long passage to the dining-room

she made up her mind that she would make the first overture toward reconciliation that evening. It would be difficult but she would do it.

She was speculating as to how she would begin, in what manner she would greet him when he came home, when her eyes fell on the folded note against the clock. Apprehension clutched her as she opened it. The few lines within frightened her still more. He had gone—where? She turned the note over, looking at the back, in a sudden tremble of fearfulness. He had never done anything like this before, left her, suddenly cut loose from her in proud disgust. She stood by the clock, staring at the paper, her face fallen into scared blankness, the artificial hopefulness that she had been fostering since she awoke giving place to a down-drop into an abyss of alarm.

The door into the kitchen creaked and the Chinaman entered with the second part of the dainty breakfast cooked especially for her.

“What time did Mr. Ryan leave this morning?” she said without turning, throwing the question over her shoulder.

“I dunno,” the man returned, with the expressionless brevity of his race particularly accentuated in this case, as he did not like his mistress. “He no take blickfuss here. He no stay here last night.”

She faced round on him, her eyes full of a sudden fierce intentness which marked them in moments of angry surprise.

“Wasn’t here last night?” she demanded. “What do you mean?”

He arranged the dishes with careful precision, not troubling himself to look up, and speaking with the same dry indifference.

“He not here for blickfuss. No one sleep in his bed. I go make bed—all made. I think he not here all night.”

His work being accomplished he turned without more words and passed into the kitchen. Berny stood for a moment thinking, then, with a shrug of defiance, left her buckwheat cakes untasted and walked into the hall. She went directly to her husband’s room and looked about with sharp glances. She opened drawers and peered into the wardrobes. She was a woman who had a curiously keen memory for small domestic details, and a few moments’ investigation proved to her that he had taken some of his oldest clothes, but had left behind all the better ones, and that the silver box of

jewelry on the bureau—filled with relics of the days when he had been the idolized son of his parents—lacked none of its contents.

More alarmed than she had been in the course of her married life she left the room and passed up the hall to the parlor. The brilliant, over-furnished apartment in which she had crowded every fashion in interior decoration that had pleased her fancy and been within the compass of her purse, looked slovenly and unattractive in the gray light of the morning. The smell of smoke was strong in it and the butts and ashes of cigars Dominick had been smoking the evening before lay in a tray on the center-table. She noticed none of these things, which under ordinary circumstances would have been ground for scolding, for she was a woman of fastidious personal daintiness. A cushioned seat was built round the curve of the bay-window, and on this she sat down, drawing back the fall of thick écru lace that veiled the pane. Her eyes were fastened with an unwinking fixity on the fog-drenched street without; her figure was motionless.

Her outward rigidity of body concealed an intense inward energy of thought. It suddenly appeared to her as if her hold on Dominick, which till yesterday had seemed so strong that nothing but death could break it, was weak, was nothing. It had been rooted in his sense of honor, the sense that she fostered in him and by means of which she had been able to make him marry her. Was this sense not so powerful as she believed, or—dreadful thought!—was it weakening under the friction of their life together? Had she played on it too much and worn it out? She had been so sure of Dominick, so secure in his blind, plodding devotion to his duty! She had secretly wondered at it, as a queer characteristic that it was fortunate he possessed. Deep in her heart she had a slight, amused contempt for it, a contempt that had extended to other things. She had felt it for him in those early days of their marriage when he had looked forward to children and wanted to live quietly, without society, in his own home. It grew stronger later when she realized he had accepted his exclusion from his world and was too proud to ask his mother for money.

And now! Suppose he had gone back to his people? A low ejaculation escaped her, and she dropped the curtain and pressed her hand, clenched to the hardness of a stone, against her breast.

The mere thought of such a thing was intolerable. She did not see how she could support the idea of his mother and sister winning him from her. She hated them. They were the ones who had wronged her, who had excluded her from the home and the riches and the position that her marriage should have given her. Her retaliation had been her unwavering grip on Dominick and the careful discretion with which she had comported herself as his wife. There was no ground of complaint against her. She had been as quiet, home-keeping and dutiful a woman as any in California. She had been a good housekeeper, a skilful manager of her husband's small means. It was only within the last year that she had, in angry spite, run into the debts with which she had taunted him. No wife could have lived more rigorously up to the letter of her marriage contract. It was easy for her to do it. She was not a woman whom light living and license attracted. She had sacrificed her honor to win Dominick, grudgingly, unwillingly, as close-fisted men part with money in the hope of rich returns. She did not want to be his mistress, but she knew of no other means by which she could reach the position of his wife.

Now suppose he had gone back to his people! It was an insupportable, a maddening thought. It plunged her into agitation that made her rise and move about the room with an aimless restlessness, like some soft-footed feline animal. Suppose he had gone home and told them about last night, and they had prevailed upon him not to come back!

Well, even if they had, hers was still the strong position. The sympathy of the disinterested outsider would always be with her. If she had been quarrelsome and ugly, those were small matters. In the great essentials she had not failed. Suppose she and the Ryans ever did come to an open crossing of swords, would not her story be *the* story of the two? The world's sympathy would certainly not go to the rich women, trampling on the poor little typewriter, the honest working-girl, who for one slip, righted by subsequent marriage, had been the object of their implacable antagonism and persecution.

She said this opposite the mirror, extending her hands as she had seen an actress do in a recent play. As she saw her pointed, pale face, her expression of worry gave way to one of pleased complacency. She looked pathetic, and her position was pathetic. Who would have the heart to condemn her when they saw her and heard her side of the story? Her spirits began to rise. With

the first gleam of returning confidence she shook off her apprehensions. A struggle of sunshine pierced the fog, and going to the window she drew the curtains and looked out on the veil of mist every moment growing brighter and thinner. The sun finally pierced it, a patch of blue shone above, and dropping the curtains she turned and looked at the clock. It was after eleven. She decided she would go out and take lunch with her sisters, who were always ready to listen and to sympathize with her.

These sisters were the only intimate friends and companions Bernice had, their home the one house to which she was a constant visitor. With all her peculiarities and faults she possessed a strong sense of kin. In her rise to fairer fortune, if not greater happiness, her old home had never lost its hold upon her, nor had she weakened in a sort of cross-grained, patronizing loyalty to her two sisters. This may have been accounted for by the fact that they were exceedingly amiable and affectionate, proud to regard Bernice as the flower of the family, whose dizzy translation to unexpected heights they had watched with unenvious admiration.

Hannah, the oldest of the family, was the daughter of a first marriage. She was now a spinster of forty-five, and had taught school for twenty years. Hazel was the youngest of the three, she and Bernice having been the offspring of Danny Iverson's second alliance with a woman of romantic tendencies, which had no way of expressing themselves except in the naming of her children. Hazel, while yet in her teens, had married a clerk in a jewelry store, called Josh McCrae. It had been a happy marriage. After the birth of a daughter, Hazel had returned to her work as saleslady in a fashionable millinery. Both sisters, Josh, and the child, had continued to live together in domestic harmony, in the house which Hannah, with the savings of a quarter of a century, had finally cleared of all mortgages and now owned. No household could have been more simply decent and honest; no family more unambitiously content. In such an environment Bernice, with her daring ambitions and bold unscrupulousness, was like that unaccounted-for blossom which in the floral world is known as a "sport."

But it did not appear that she regarded herself as such. With the exception of a year spent in Los Angeles and Chicago she had been a member of the household from her childhood till the day of her marriage. The year of absence had been the result of a sudden revolt against the monotony of her life and surroundings, an upwelling of the restless ambitions that preyed

upon her. A good position had been offered her in Los Angeles and she had accepted it with eagerness, thankful for the opportunity to see the world, and break away, so she said, from the tameness of her situation, the narrowness of her circle. The spirit of adventure carried her farther afield, and she penetrated as far across the continent as Chicago, where she was employed in one of the most prosperous business houses, earning a large salary. But, like many Californians, homesickness seized her, and before the year was out she was back, inveighing against the eastern manners, character, and climate, and glad to shake down again into the family nest. Her sisters were satisfied with her account of her wanderings, not knowing that Bernice was as much of an adept at telling half a story as she was at taking down a dictation in typewriting. She was too clever to be found out in a lie; they were altogether too simple to suspect her apparent frankness.

After the excursion she remained at home until her marriage. Her liaison with Dominick was conducted with the utmost secrecy. Her sisters had not a suspicion of it, knew nothing but that the young man was attentive to her, till she told them of her approaching marriage. This took place in the parlor of Hannah's house, and the amazed sisters, bewildered by Berny's glories, had waited to see her burst into the inner circles of fashion and wealth with a tiara of diamonds on her head and ropes of pearls about her throat. That no tiara was forthcoming, no pearls graced her bridal parure, and no Ryan ever crossed the threshold of her door, seemed to the loyal Hannah and Hazel the most unmerited and inexplicable injustice that had ever come within their experience.

It took Bernice some time to dress, for she attached the greatest importance to all matters of personal adornment, and the lunch hour was at hand when she alighted from the Hyde Street car and walked toward the house. It was on one of those streets which cross Hyde near the slope of Russian Hill, and are devoted to the habitats of small, thrifty householders. A staring, bright cleanliness is the prevailing characteristic of the neighborhood, the cement sidewalks always swept, the houses standing back in tiny squares of garden, clipped and trimmed to a precise shortness of grass and straightness of border. The sun was now broadly out and the house-fronts engarlanded with vines, their cream-colored faces spotless in fresh coats of paint, presented a line of uniform bay-windows to its ingratiating warmth. Hannah's was the third, and its gleaming clearness of window-pane and the stainless purity of

its front steps were points of domestic decency that its proprietor insisted on as she did on the servant girl's apron being clean and the parlor free from dust.

Berny had retained her latch-key, and letting herself in passed into the dustless parlor which connected by folding doors with the dining-room beyond. Nothing had been changed in it since the days of her tenancy. The upright piano, draped with a China silk scarf, stood in the old corner. The solar print of her father hung over the mantelpiece on which a gilt clock and a pair of China dogs stood at accurately-measured distances. The tufted arm-chairs were placed far from each other, severely isolated in the corners, as though the room were too remote and sacred even to suggest the cheerful amenities of social intercourse. A curious, musty smell hung in the air. It recalled the past in which Dominick had figured as her admirer. The few times that he had been to her home she had received him in this solemn, unadorned apartment in which the chandelier was lit for the occasion, and Hannah and Hazel had sat in the kitchen, breathless with curiosity as to what such a call might portend. She had been married here, in the bay-window, under a wedding bell of white roses. The musty smell brought it all back, even her sense of almost breathless elation, when the seal was set on her daring schemes.

From beyond the folding doors a sound of conversation and smitten crockery arose, also a strong odor of cooking. The family were already at lunch, and opening the door Berny entered in upon the midday meal which was being partaken of by her two sisters, Josh, and Hazel's daughter Pearl, a pretty child of eight.

Neither of her sisters resembled her in the least. Hannah was a woman who looked more than her age, with a large, calm face, and gentle, near-sighted eyes which blinked at the world behind a pair of steel-rimmed glasses. Her quarter-century of school teaching had not dried or stiffened her. She was fuller of the milk of human kindness, of the ideals and enthusiasms of youth, than either of her sisters. All the love of her kindly, maternal nature was given to Pearl, whom she was bringing up carefully to be what seemed to Hannah best in woman.

Hazel was very pretty and still young. She had the fresh, even bloom of a Californian woman, a round, graceful figure, and glossy brown hair, rippled

and arranged in an elaborate coiffure as though done by a hair-dresser. She could do this herself as she could make her own clothes, earn a fair salary at the milliner's, and sing to the guitar in a small piping voice. Her husband was ravished by her good looks and accomplishments, and thought her the most wonderful woman in the world. He was a thin, tall, young man with stooping shoulders, a long, lean neck, and an amiable, insignificant face. But he seemed to please Hazel, who had married him when she was nineteen, being haunted by the nightmare thought that if she did not take what chances offered, she might become an old maid like Hannah.

Berny sat down next to the child, conscious that under the pleasant friendliness of their greetings a violent curiosity as to whether she had been to the ball burned in each breast. She had talked over her chances of going with them, and Hazel, whose taste in all such matters was excellent, had helped her order the dress. Now, drawing her plate toward her and shaking out her napkin, she began to eat her lunch, at once too sore and too perverse to begin the subject. The others endured their condition of ignorance for some minutes, and then Hazel, finding that to wait was useless, approached the vital topic.

"Well, Berny, we've been looking over the list of guests at the ball in the morning papers and your name don't seem to be down."

"I don't see why it should," said Berny without looking up, "considering I wasn't there."

"You weren't there!" ejaculated Hannah. "They didn't ask you?"

"That's right," said Berny, breaking a piece of bread. "They didn't ask me."

"Well, I'll be jiggered!" exclaimed Josh. "That beats the Dutch!"

"I didn't believe Mrs. Ryan would do that," said Hannah, so pained that her generally observant eye took no note of the fact that Pearl was putting her fingers in her plate. "You're as good as her own flesh and blood, too,—her son's wife. It's not Christian, and I don't understand it."

"It's tough," said Josh, "that's what it is, tough!"

"If I were you," said Hazel with spirit, "husband or no husband, I'd never want to go inside that house or have any dealings with that crowd again. If they were down on their knees to me I'd never go near them. Just think

what it would be if Josh's mother thought herself too good to know me! I'd like to know what I'd feel about it."

"But she wouldn't, dearie," said Josh placatingly. "She'd be proud to have you related to her."

"I guess she'd better be," said Hazel, fixing an indignant glare on her spouse. "She'd find she'd barked up the wrong tree if she wasn't."

Considering that Josh's mother had been dead for twelve years and in her lifetime had been a meek and unassuming woman who let lodgings, Hazel's proud repudiation at her possible scorn seemed a profitless wasting of fires, and Josh forthwith turned the conversation back to the ball.

"Perhaps they did send you an invitation," he said to Berny, "and it got lost in the mails. That does happen, you know."

Berny's cheeks, under the faint bloom of rouge that covered them, flamed a sudden, dusky red. She had never been open with these simple relations of hers and she was not going to begin now. But she felt shame as she thought of Dominick's humiliating quest for the invitation that was refused.

"Oh, no," she said hurriedly. "It wasn't sent, that's all. Mrs. Ryan won't have me in the house. That's the fact and there's no use trying to get round it. Well, she can do without me. I seem able to support my existence without her."

Her tone and manner, marked by a sort of hard bravado, did not deceive her sisters, who had that extreme naïveté in expressing their intimate feelings which is peculiar to Californians. They looked at her with commiserating sympathy, not quite comprehending her attitude of independence, but feeling sorry for her, whatever pose she adopted.

"And your dress," said Hazel, "what will you do with that? When will you ever wear it—a regular ball-dress like that?"

"Oh, I'll wear it," said Berny with an air of having quantities of social opportunities not known by her sisters. "It won't be a loss."

"You could put a guimpe in and have sleeves to the elbow and wear it to the theater. With a white hat with plumes it would be a dead swell costume. And if you met any of the Ryans they'd see you were holding up your end of the line and not *quite* ready yet to go to the alms-house."

Hannah shook her head.

“I don’t see how she could do that—transparent neck and all. I don’t think that’s the kind of dress to wear in a theater. It’s too sort of conspicuous.”

“I think Hannah’s right,” said Josh solemnly, nodding at Berny. “It don’t seem to me the right thing for a lady. Looks fast.”

“What do you know about it, Josh McCrae?” said Hazel pugnaciously. “You’re a clerk in a jewelry store.”

“Maybe I am,” retorted Josh, “but I guess that don’t prevent me from knowing when a thing looks fast. Clerks in jewelry stores ain’t such gummurs as you might think. And, anyway, I don’t see that being a clerk in any kind of a store has anything to do with it.”

Hazel was saved the effort of making a crushing repartee, by Pearl, who had been silently eating her lunch, now suddenly launching a remark into the momentary pause.

“Did Uncle Dominick go to the ball?” she asked, raising a pair of limpid blue eyes to Berny’s face.

An instantaneous, significant silence fell on the others, and all eyes turned inquiringly to Berny. Her air of cool control became slightly exaggerated.

“No, he stayed at home with me,” she replied, picking daintily at the meat on her plate.

“But I suppose he felt real hurt and annoyed,” said Hannah. “He couldn’t have helped it.”

Berny did not reply. She knew that she must sooner or later tell her sisters of Dominick’s strange departure. They would find it out otherwise and suspect more than she wanted them to know. They, like the rest of the world, had no idea that Berny’s brilliant marriage was not the domestic success it appeared on the surface. She moved her knife and fork with an arranging hand, and, as Hazel started to speak, said with as careless an air as she could assume,

“Dominick’s gone. He left this morning.”

The news had even more of an effect than she had expected. Her four companions stared at her in wonderment. A return of the dread and

depression of the morning came upon her when she saw their surprise. She felt her heart sink as it had done when she read his note.

“Gone where?” exclaimed Hazel. This was the test question and Berny had schooled herself in an answer in the car coming up.

“Oh, up into the country,” she said nonchalantly. “He’s worn out. They work the life out of him in that horrible bank. He’s getting insomnia and thought he’d better take a change now before he got run completely down, so he left this morning and I’m a gay grass widow.”

She laughed and drank some water. Her laugh did not sound to her own ears convincing and she was aware that, while Hannah was evidently satisfied by her explanation, Hazel was eying her ponderingly.

“Well, if he’s got insomnia,” said Hannah, “he’d better take his holiday right now. That’s the best thing to do. Take it in the beginning. Before father took ill——”

Here Josh interrupted her, as Hannah’s reminiscences of the late contractor’s last illness were long and exhaustive.

“Where’d you say he’d gone?” he queried.

“I can’t remember the name,” Berny answered with skilfully-assumed indifference; “somewhere down toward Santa Cruz and Monterey, some new place. And he may not stay there. If he doesn’t like it, he’ll just move around from place to place.”

“Why didn’t you go, too?” said Pearl.

This was the second question Berny had dreaded. Now suddenly she felt her throat contract and her lips quiver. Her usually iron nerve had been shaken by her passion of the night before and the shock of the morning. The unwonted sensations of gloom and apprehension closed in on her again, and this time made her feel weak and tearful.

“I didn’t want to. I hate moving round,” she said, pushing her chair back from the table. Her voice was a little hoarse, and suddenly feeling the sting of tears under her eyelids she raised her hands to her hat and began to fumble with her veil. “Why should I leave my comfortable flat to go trailing round in a lot of half-built hotels? That sort of thing doesn’t appeal to me at

all. I like my own cook, and my own bed, and my own bath-tub. I'm more of an old maid than Hannah. Well, so long, people. I must be traveling."

She laid her napkin on the table and jumped up with an assumption of brisk liveliness. She paid no attention to the expostulations of her relatives, but going to the glass arranged her hat and put on her gloves. When she turned back to the table she had regained possession of herself. Her veil was down and through it her cheeks looked unusually flushed, and her dark eyes, with their slanting outer corners, brighter and harder than ever. She hurried through her good-bys on the plea that she had shopping to do, and almost ran out of the house, leaving a trail of perfumery and high, artificial laughter behind her.

For the next week she waited for news from Dominick and none came. It was a trying seven days. Added to her harassment of mind, the loneliness of the flat was almost unendurable. There was no one to speak to, no one to share her anxieties. Her position was unusually friendless. When her marriage had lifted her from the ranks of working women she had shown so cold a face to her old companions that they had dropped away from her, realizing that she wished to cut all ties with the world of her humble beginnings. New friends had been hard to make. The wives of some of the bank officials, and odd, aspiring applicants for such honors as would accrue from even this remote connection with the august name of Ryan, were all she had found wherewith to make a circle and a visiting list.

But she was intimate with none of them and was now too worried to seek the society of mere acquaintances. She ate her solitary meals in oppressive silence, feeling the Chinaman's eyes fixed upon her in ironic disbelief of the story she had told him to account for Dominick's absence. Eat as slowly as she would, her dinner could not be made to occupy more than twenty minutes, and after that there was the long evening, the interminable evening, to be passed. She was a great reader of newspapers, and when she returned from her afternoon shopping she brought a bundle of evening papers home in her hand. She would read these slowly, at first the important items, then go over them for matters of less moment, and finally scan the advertisements. But even with this occupation the evenings were of a vast, oppressive emptiness, and her worries crowded in upon her, when, the papers lying round her feet in a sea of billowing, half-folded sheets, she sat

motionless, the stillness of the empty flat and the deserted street lying round her like an expression of her own blank depression.

At the end of the week she felt that she must find out something, and went to the bank. It was her intention to cash a small check and over this transaction see if the paying teller would vouchsafe any information about Dominick. She pushed the check through the opening and, as the man counted out the money, said glibly,

“Do you hear anything of my wandering husband?”

The teller pushed the little pile of silver and gold through the window toward her and leaning forward, said, with the air of one who intends to have a leisurely moment of talk,

“No, we haven’t. Isn’t it our place to come to you for that? We were wondering where he’d gone at such a season.”

Berny’s delicately-gloved fingers made sudden haste to gather up the coins.

“Oh, he’s just loafing about,” she said as easily as was consistent with the disappointment and alarm that gripped her. “He’s just wandering round from place to place. He was getting insomnia and wanted a change of scene.”

She snapped the clasp of her purse before the man could ask her further questions, nodded her good-bys, and turned from the window. Her face changed as she emerged on the wide, stone steps that led to the street. It was pinched and pale, two lines drawn between the eyebrows. She descended the steps slowly, the flood of magnificent sunshine having no warming influence upon the chill that had seized upon her. Many of the passing throng of men looked at her—a pretty woman in her modishly-made dress of tan-colored cloth and her close-fitting brown turban with a bunch of white paradise feathers at one side. Under her dotted veil her carefully made-up complexion looked naturally clear and rosy, and her eyes, accentuated by a dark line beneath them, were in attractive contrast to her reddened hair. But she was not thinking of herself or the admiration she evoked, a subject which was generally of overpowering interest. Matters of more poignant moment had crowded all else from her mind.

The next week began and advanced and still no news from Dominick. He had been gone fourteen days, when one evening in her perusal of the paper

she saw his name. Her trembling hands pressed the sheet down on the table, and her eyes devoured the printed lines. It was one of the many short despatches that had come from the foot-hill mining towns on the recent storms in the Sierra. It was headed Rocky Bar and contained a description of the situation at Antelope and the snow-bound colony there. Its chief item of information was that Bill Cannon and his daughter were among the prisoners in Perley's Hotel. A mention was made, only a line or two, of Dominick's walk from Rocky Bar, but it was treated lightly and gave no idea of the real seriousness of that almost fatal excursion.

Berny read the two short paragraphs many times, and her spirits went up like the needle of a thermometer when the quicksilver is grasped in a warm hand. Her relief was intense, easeful and relaxing, as the sudden cessation of a pain. Not only was Dominick at last found, but he was found in a place as far removed from his own family and its influences as he was from her. And best of all he was shut up, incarcerated, with Bill Cannon, the Bonanza King. What might not come of it? Berny was not glad of the quarrel, but it seemed a wonderful piece of luck that that unpleasant episode should have sent him into the very arms of the man that she had always wanted him to cultivate and who was the best person in the world for him to impress favorably. If Bill Cannon, who had been a friend of his father's, took a fancy to Dominick, there was no knowing what might happen. In a sudden reaction of relief and hope Berny saw them almost adopted children of the Bonanza King, flouting the Ryans in the pride of their new-found honors.

It made her feel lenient to Dominick, whose indifference and neglect had put her to the torments of the last fortnight. After all, he could not have let her know his whereabouts. The wires were only just up, and the rural mail-carrier had not yet been able to effect an entrance into the snow-bound town. Why Dominick had chosen to go in this direction and had attempted an impossible walk in a heavy snowstorm Berny did not know, nor just now care much. A sensation as near remorse and tenderness as she could feel possessed her. Under its softening influence—spurred to generosity and magnanimity by the lifting of the weight of anxiety—she decided that she would write to him. She would write him a letter which would smooth out the difficulties between them and bring him home ready to forgive and be once more his old self, kind, quiet, and indulgent, as he had been in the first year of their marriage.

Then and there, without further waiting, she wrote the letter. It ran as follows:

“MY DEAR HUSBAND:—I have only just seen in the paper where you are, and, oh, the relief! For two weeks now I have been half crazy, wondering about you, waiting to hear from you. And nothing ever came. Dominick, dear, if you had seen me sitting here alone in the den every evening, thinking and waiting, looking at the clock and listening all the time, even when I was trying to read—listening for your footsteps which never came—you would have felt very sorry for me; even you, who were so angry that you left me without a word. It’s just been hell this last two weeks. You may not think by the way I acted that I would have cared, but I did, I do. If I didn’t love you would I mind how your people treated me? That’s what makes it so hard, because I love you and want you to be happy with me, and it’s dreadful for me to see them always getting in between us, till sometimes lately I have felt they were going to separate us altogether.

“Oh, my dear husband, don’t let that happen! Don’t let them drive me away from you! If I have been bad-humored and unreasonable, I have had to bear a lot. I am sorry for the past. I am sorry for what I said to you that night, and for turning on the gas and scratching the bed. I am ready to acknowledge that I was wrong, and was mean and hateful. And now you ought to be ready to forgive me and forget it all. Come back to me. Please come back. Don’t be angry with me. I am your wife. You chose me of your own free will. That I loved you so that I forgot honor and public opinion and had no will but yours, you know better than any one else in the world. It isn’t every man, Dominick, that gets that kind of love. I gave it then and I’ve never stopped giving it, though I’ve often been so put upon and enraged that I’ve said things I didn’t mean and done things I’ve been ready to kill myself for. Here I am now, waiting for you, longing for you. Come back to me.

Your loving wife,

BERNY.”

She read the letter over several times and it pleased her greatly. So anxious was she to have it go as soon as possible that, though it was past ten, she took it out herself and posted it in the letter-box at the corner.

CHAPTER VII

SNOW-BOUND

While the world went about its affairs, attended to its business, read its papers, sent its telegrams and wrote its letters, the little group at Antelope was as completely cut off from it as though marooned on a strip of sand in an unknown sea. A second storm had followed the original one, and the end of the first week saw them snowed in deeper than ever, Antelope a trickle of roofs and smoke-stacks, in a white, crystal-clear wilderness, solemn in its stillness and loneliness as the primeval world.

The wires were down; the letter-carrier could not break his way in to them. They heard no news and received no mail. Confined in a group of rude buildings, crouched in a hollow of the Sierra's flank, they felt for the first time what it was to be outside that circle of busy activity in which their lives had heretofore passed. They were face to face with the nature they thought they had conquered and which now in its quiet grandeur awed them with a sense of their own small helplessness. Pressed upon by that enormous silent indifference they drew nearer together, each individual unit gaining in importance from the contrasting immensity without, each character unconsciously declaring itself, emerging from acquired reticences and becoming bolder and more open.

They accepted their captivity in a spirit of gay good humor. The only two members of the party to whom it seemed irksome were Bill Cannon and the actor, both girding against a confinement which kept them from their several spheres of action. The others abandoned themselves to a childish, almost fantastic enjoyment of a situation unique in their experience. It was soon to end, it would never be repeated. It was an adventure charged with romance, accidental, unsought, as all true adventures are. The world was forgotten for these few days of imprisonment against the mountain's mighty heart. It did not exist for them. All that was real was their own little party, the whitewashed passages and walls of Perley's, the dining-room with its board floor and homely fare, and the parlor at night with a semicircle of faces round the blazing logs.

On the afternoon of the sixth day Dominick made his first appearance down stairs. He achieved the descent with slow painfulness, hobbling between Perley and the doctor. The former's bath-robe had been cast aside for a dignified dark-brown dressing-gown, contributed to his wardrobe by Cannon, and which, cut to fit the burly proportions of the Bonanza King, hung around the long, lank form of the young man in enveloping folds.

The parlor was empty, save for Miss Cannon sitting before the fire. Dominick had ceased to feel bashfulness and constraint in the presence of this girl, who had been pushed—against his will if not against her own—into the position of his head attendant. The afternoon when they had sat together in his room seemed to have brushed away all his shyness and self-consciousness. He thought now that it would be difficult to retain either in intercourse with a being who was so candid, so spontaneous, so freshly natural. He found himself treating her as if she were a young boy with whom he had been placed on a sudden footing of careless, cheery intimacy. But her outward seeming—what she presented to the eye—was not in the least boyish. Her pale, opaque blondness, her fine, rich outlines, her softness of mien, were things as completely and graciously feminine as the most epicurean admirer of women could have wished.

Now, at the sight of her bending over the fire, he experienced a sensation of pleasure which vaguely surprised him. He was hardly conscious that all the time he had been dressing and while he came down stairs he had been hoping that she would be there. He sent a quick glance ahead of him, saw her, and looked away. The pain of his feet was violent, and without again regarding her he knew that while he was gaining his chair and his attendants were settling him, she had not turned from her contemplation of the fire. He already knew her well enough to have a comfortable assurance of her invariable quick tact. It was not till the two men were leaving the room that she turned to him and said, as if resuming an interrupted conversation,

“Well, how do you like the parlor? Speak nicely of it for I feel as if it belonged to me.”

“It's a first-rate parlor,” he answered, looking about him. “Never saw a better one. Who's the gentleman with the wreath of wax flowers round his head?”

“That’s Jim Granger. He comes from here, you know; and you mustn’t laugh at those flowers, they came off his coffin.”

“My father knew him,” said the young man indifferently. “There were lots of queer stories about Jim Granger. He killed a man once up at Bodie. You’ve a fine fire here, haven’t you?”

“Fine. It’s never allowed to go out. What do you think I intend to do this afternoon? I’ve a plan for amusing and instructing you.”

“What is it?” he said somewhat uneasily. “I don’t feel in the least as if I wanted to be instructed.”

She rose and moved to the center-table which was covered with an irregular scattering of books.

“Before you came down I was looking over these books. There are lots of them. Mrs. Perley says they’ve been accumulating for years. Mining men have left them and some of them have the names of people I know written in them. I thought perhaps you might like to read some of them.”

Dominick sent a lazily disparaging glance over the books. He was not much of a reader at the best of times.

“What are they,” he said, “novels?”

“Mostly.” She sat down by the table and took up the volume nearest to her. “Here’s *Tale of Two Cities*. That’s a fine one.”

“I’ve read it. Yes, it’s splendid. It’s all about the French Revolution. The hero’s like a real person and heroes in books hardly ever are, only I’d have liked him better if he’d stopped drinking and married his girl.”

“I thought perhaps you might like me to read to you,” she said, turning a tentative glance on him. “That’s how I was going to amuse and instruct you.”

“I’m sure it would be much more amusing and probably just as instructive if you talked to me.”

“You’ve got to stay down here two hours. How could I talk and be amusing and instructive for two hours? You’d probably have a relapse and I’m quite sure the doctor’d find me in a dead faint on the hearth when he came in.”

“All right. Let’s try the books. Don’t let’s risk relapses and dead faints.”

“Very well, then, that’s understood. We’ll go through the library now. I’ll read the titles and you say if you like any of them.”

“Suppose I don’t?”

“You’ll surely have a preference.”

“All right. I’ll try to. Go on.”

“Here’s *Foul Play*, by Charles Reade. It seems to have been a good deal read. Some of the paragraphs are marked with a pencil.”

“I think I’ve read it, but I’m not sure. It sounds like a murder story. No, let’s pass on that.”

“Well, here’s *Mrs. Skaggs’ Husbands*, by Bret Harte. Does that sound as if you’d like it?”

“‘Husbands!’ No. We don’t want to read about a woman who has husbands. Pass on that, too.”

“The next is very nicely bound and looks quite fresh and new, as if nobody had read it much. It’s called *The Amazing Marriage*.”

“Oh, pass on that! I had it once and stuck in the third chapter. The last time I went East somebody gave it to me to read on the train. I read three chapters and I was more amazed than anybody in sight. The porter was a fresh coon and I gave it to him as my revenge. I’ll bet it amazed him.”

“You don’t seem to have anything in the nature of a preference, so far. I wonder how this will suit you. *Notre Dame de Paris*, by Victor Hugo.”

“I don’t understand French.”

“It’s in English and it’s quite worn out, as if it had been read over and over. Several of the pages are falling out.”

“Oh, I’ve read that. I just remember. It’s a rattling good story, too. About the hunchback and the gipsy girl who tells fortunes and has a pet goat. The priest, who’s a villain, falls off the steeple and clings to a gutter by his finger nails with his enemy watching him. It’s the finest kind of a story.”

“What a pity that you’ve read it! Oh, here’s one that’s evidently been a great favorite. It’s in paper and it’s all thumbed and torn. Somebody’s written across the top, ‘Of all the damned fool people——’. Oh, I beg your pardon, I read it before I realized. The name is *Wife in Name Only*. It doesn’t seem the kind of title that makes you want to read the book, does it?”

“‘Wife in Name Only!’” he gave a short laugh. “It certainly isn’t the kind of name that would make *me* want to read a book.”

“Nor me,” said a deep voice behind them.

They both turned to see Buford, the actor, standing back of the table, his tall, angular figure silhouetted against the pale oblong of the uncurtained window. He was smiling suavely, but at the same time with a sort of uneasy, assumed assurance, which suggested that he was not unused to rebuffs.

“That, certainly,” he said, “is not a name to recommend a book to any man—any man, that is, who has or ever had a wife.”

He advanced into the circle of the firelight, blandly beaming at the young man, who, leaning back in his chair, was eying him with surprised inquiry, never having seen him before. The look did not chill the friendly effusion of the actor who, approaching Dominick, said with the full, deep resonance of his remarkable voice,

“Congratulations, my dear sir, congratulations. Not alone on your recovery, but on the fact that you are here with us at all.” He held out his large hand, the skin chapped and red with the cold, and the long fingers closed with a wrenching grip on Dominick’s. “We were not sure, when you arrived among us a few nights ago, that we would have the felicity of seeing you so soon up and around—in fact, we were doubtful whether we would *ever* see you up and around.”

“Thanks, very kind of you. Oh, I’m all right now.” Dominick pressed the hand in return and then, bending a little forward, sent a glance of imploring query round the stranger’s shoulder at Rose.

She caught the eye, read its behest, and presented the new-comer:

“Mr. Ryan, this is Mr. Buford who is snowed in here with us. Mr. Buford came here the same day as you, only he came on the Murphysville stage.”

Buford sat down between them on one of the horsehair chairs that were sociably arranged round the table. The firelight threw into prominence the bony angles of his thin face and glazed the backward sweep of his hair, dark-brown, and worn combed away from his forehead, where a pair of heavy, flexible eyebrows moved up and down like an animated commentary on the conversation. When anything surprising was said they went up, anything puzzling or painful they were drawn down. He rested one hand on his knee, the fingers turned in, and, sitting bolt upright, buttoned tight into his worn frock-coat, turned a glance of somewhat deprecating amiability upon the invalid.

“You had a pretty close call, *a-pretty-close-call*,” he said. “If the operator at Rocky Bar hadn’t had the sense to wire up here, that would have been the end of *your* life story.”

Dominick had heard this from every member of the snowed-in party. Repetition was not making it any more agreeable, and there was an effect of abrupt ungraciousness in his short answer which was merely a word of comment.

“Didn’t the people at the Rocky Bar Hotel try to dissuade you from starting?” said Buford. “They must have known it was dangerous. They must have been worried about you or they wouldn’t have telegraphed up.”

“Oh, I believe they did.” The young man tried to hide the annoyance the questions gave him under a dry brevity of speech. “They did all that they ought to have done. I’ll see them again on my way down.”

“And yet you persisted!” The actor turned to Rose with whom, as he sat beside her at table, he had become quite friendly. “The blind confidence of youth, Miss Cannon, isn’t it a grand, inspiring thing?”

Dominick shifted his aching feet under the rug. He was becoming exceedingly irritated and impatient, and wondered how much longer he would be able to respond politely to the conversational assiduities of the stranger.

“Now,” continued Buford, “kindly satisfy my curiosity on one point. Why, when you were told of the danger of the enterprise, did you start?”

“Perhaps I liked the danger, wanted it to tone me up. I’m a bank clerk, Mr. Buford, and my life’s monotonous. Danger’s a change.”

He raised his voice and spoke with sudden rude defiance. Buford looked quickly at him, while his eyebrows went up nearly to his hair.

“A bank clerk, oh!” he said with a falling inflection of disappointment, much chagrined to discover that the child of millions occupied such a humble niche. “I—I—was not aware of that.”

“An assistant cashier,” continued Dominick in the same key of exasperation, “and I managed to get a holiday at this season because my father was one of the founders of the bank and they allow me certain privileges. If you would like to know anything else ask me and I’ll answer as well as I know how.”

His manner and tone so plainly indicated his resentment of the other’s curiosity that the actor flushed and shrank. He was evidently well-meaning and sensitive, and the young man’s rudeness hurt rather than angered him. For a moment nothing was said, Buford making no response other than to clear his throat, while he stretched out one arm and pulled down his cuff with a jerking movement. There was constraint in the air, and Rose, feeling that he had been treated with unnecessary harshness, sought to palliate it by lifting the book on her lap and saying to him,

“This is the book we were talking about when you came in, Mr. Buford, *Wife in Name Only*. Have you read it?”

She handed him the ragged volume, and holding it off he eyed it with a scrutiny all the more marked by the way he drew his heavy brows down till they hung like bushy eaves over his eyes.

“No, my dear young lady. I have not. Nor do I feel disposed to do so. ‘Wife in Name Only!’ That tells a whole story without reading a word. Were *you* going to read it?”

“No; Mr. Ryan and I were just looking over them. We were thinking about reading one of them aloud. This one happened to be on the pile.”

“To me,” continued Buford, “the name is repelling because it suggests sorrows of my own.”

There was a pause. He evidently expected a question which undoubtedly was not going to come from Dominick, who sat fallen together in the arm-chair looking at him with moody ill-humor. There was more hope from

Rose, who gazed at the floor but said nothing. Buford was forced to repeat with an unctuous depth of tone, "Suggests sorrows of my own," and fasten his glance on her, so that, as she raised her eyes, they encountered the commanding encouragement of his.

"Sorrows of your own?" she repeated timidly, but with the expected questioning inflection.

"Yes, my dear Miss Cannon," returned the actor with a melancholy which was full of a rich, dark enjoyment. "*My wife is one in name only.*"

There was another pause, and neither of the listeners showing any intention of breaking it, Buford remarked,

"*That* sorrow is mine."

"*What* sorrow?" said Dominick brusely.

"The sorrow of a deserted man," returned the actor with now, for the first time, something of the dignity of real feeling in his manner.

"Oh," the monosyllable was extremely non-committal, but it had an air of finality as though Dominick intended to say no more.

"Has she—er—left you?" said the girl in a low and rather awe-stricken voice.

The actor inclined his head in an acquiescent bow:

"She has."

Again there was a pause. Unless Buford chose to be more biographical, the conversation appeared to have come to a deadlock. Neither of the listeners could at this stage break into his reserve with questions and yet to switch off on a new subject was not to be thought of at a moment of such emotional intensity. The actor evidently felt this, for he said suddenly, with a relapse into a lighter tone and letting his eyebrows escape from an overshadowing closeness to his eyes,

"But why should I trouble you with the sorrows that have cast their shadow on me? Why should my matrimonial troubles be allowed to darken the brightness of two young lives which have not yet known the joys and the perils of the wedded state?"

The pause that followed this remark was the most portentous that had yet fallen on the trio. Rose cast a surreptitious glance at the dark figure of young Ryan, lying back in the shadows of the arm-chair. As she looked he stirred and said with the abrupt, hard dryness which had marked his manner since Buford's entrance,

"Don't take too much for granted, Mr. Buford. I've known some of the joys and perils of the wedded state myself."

The actor stared at him in open-eyed surprise.

"Do I rightly understand," he said, "that you are a married man?"

"You do," returned Dominick.

"Really now, I never would have guessed it! Pardon me for not having given you the full dues of your position. Your wife, I take it, has no knowledge of the risk she recently ran of losing her husband?"

"I hope not."

"Well," he replied with a manner of sudden cheery playfulness, "we'll take good care that she doesn't learn. When the wires are up we'll concoct a telegram that shall be a masterpiece of diplomatic lying. Lucky young man to have a loving wife at home. Of all of us *you* are the one who can best realize the meaning of the line, 'Tis sweet to know there is an eye to mark our coming and——'"

Dominick threw the rug off and rose to his feet.

"If you can get Perley to help me I'll go up stairs again. I'm tired and I'll go back to my room."

He tried to step forward, but the pain of his unhealed foot was unbearable, and he caught the edge of the table and held it, his face paling with sudden anguish. The actor, startled by the abruptness of his uprising, approached him with a vague proffer of assistance and was arrested by his sharp command:

"Go and get Perley! He's in the bar probably. I can't stand this way for long. Hurry up!"

Buford ran out of the room, and Rose somewhat timidly drew near the young man, braced against the table, his eyes down-bent, his face hard in

the struggle with sudden and unfamiliar pain.

“Can’t I help you?” she said. “Perley may not be there. Mr. Buford and I can get you up stairs.”

“Oh, no,” he answered, his words short but his tone more conciliatory. “It’s nothing to bother about. I’d have wrung that man’s neck if I’d had to listen to him five minutes longer.”

Here Perley and Buford entered, and the former, offering his support to the invalid, led him hobbling out of the door and into the hall. The actor looked after them for a moment and then came back to the fire where Miss Cannon was standing, thoughtfully regarding the burning logs.

“I’ve no doubt,” he said, “that young Mr. Ryan is an estimable gentleman, but he certainly appears to be possessed by a very impatient and ugly temper.”

Buford had found Miss Cannon one of the most amiable and charming ladies he had ever met, and it was therefore a good deal of a surprise to have her turn upon him a face of cold, reproving disagreement, and remark in a voice that matched it:

“I don’t agree with you at all, Mr. Buford, and you seem quite to forget that Mr. Ryan has been very sick and is still in great pain.”

Buford was exceedingly abashed. He would not have offended Miss Cannon for anything in the world, and it seemed to him that a being so compact of graciousness and consideration would be the first to censure an exhibition of ill-humor such as young Ryan had just made. He stammered an apologetic sentence and it did not add to his comfort to see that she was not entirely mollified by it and to feel that she exhaled a slight, disapproving coldness that put him at a great distance and made him feel mortified and ill at ease.

CHAPTER VIII

THE UNKNOWN EROS

The ten days that followed were among the most important of Dominick Ryan's life. Looking back at them he wondered that he had been so blind to the transformation of his being which was taking place. Great emotional crises are often not any more recognized, by the individuals, than great transitional epochs are known by the nations experiencing them. Dominick did not realize that the most engrossing, compelling passion he had ever felt was slowly invading him. He did not argue that he was falling in love with a woman he could never own and of whom it was a sin to think. He did not argue or think about anything. He was as a vessel gradually filling with elemental forces, and like the vessel he was passive till some jar would shake it and the forces would run over. Meantime he was held by a determination, mutinous and unreasoning as the determination of a child, to live in the present. He had the feeling of the desert traveler who has found the oasis. The desert lay behind him, burning and sinister with the agony of his transit, and the desert lay before him with its horrors to be faced, but for the moment he could lie still and rest and forget by the fountain under the cool of the trees.

He did not consciously think of Rose. But if she were not there he was uneasy till she came again. His secret exhilaration at her approach, the dead blankness of his lack of her when she was absent, told him nothing. These were the feelings he had, and they filled him and left no cool residue of reason wherewith to watch and guard. He was taken unawares, so dreadingly confident of his allegiance to his particular private tragedy that he did not admit the possibility of a defection. A sense of rest was on him and he set it down—if he ever thought of it at all—to the relief of a temporary respite. Poor Dominick, with his inexperience of sweet things, did not argue that respite from pain should be a quiescent, contented condition of being, far removed from that state of secret, troubled gladness that thrilled him at the sound of a woman's footstep.

No situation could have been invented better suited for the fostering of sentiment. His helpless state demanded her constant attention. The attitude of nurse to patient, the solicitude of the consoling woman for the disabled, suffering man, have been, since time immemorial, recognized aids to romance. Rose, if an unawakened woman, was enough of one to enjoy richly this maternal office of alternate cossetting and ruling one, who, in the natural order of things, should have stood alone in his strength, dictating the law. Perhaps the human female so delights in this particular opportunity for tyranny because it is one of her few chances for indulging her passion for authority.

Rose, if she did not quite revel in it, discreetly enjoyed her period of dominance. In the beginning Dominick had been not a man but a patient—about the same to her as the doll is to the little girl. Then when he began to get better, and the man rose, tingling with renewed life, from the ashes of the patient, she quickly fell back into the old position. With the inherited, dainty deceptiveness of generations of women, who, while they were virtuous, were also charming, she relinquished her dominion and retreated into that enfolded maidenly reserve and docility which we feel quite sure was the manner adopted by the ladies of the Stone Age when they felt it necessary to manage their lords.

She was as unconscious of all this as Dominick was of his growing absorption in her. If he was troubled she was not. The days saw her growing gayer, more blithe and light-hearted. She sang about the corridors, her smile grew more radiant, and every man in the hotel felt the power of her awakening womanhood. Her boyish frankness of demeanor was still undimmed by the first blurring breath of passion. If Dominick was not in the parlor her disappointment was as candid as a child's whose mother has forgotten to bring home candy. All that she showed of consciousness was that when he was there and there was no disappointment, she concealed her satisfaction, wrapped herself in a sudden, shy quietness, as completely extinguishing of all beneath as a nun's habit.

The continued, enforced intimacy into which their restricted quarters and indoor life threw them could not have been more effectual in fanning the growing flame if designed by a malicious Fate. There was only one sitting-room, and, unable to go out, they sat side by side in it all day. They read together, they talked, they played cards. They were seldom alone, but the

presence of Bill Cannon, groaning over the fire with a three-weeks-old newspaper for company, was not one that diverted their attention from each other; and Cora and Willoughby, as opponents in a game of euchre, only helped to accentuate the comradeship which leagued them together in defensive alliance.

The days that were so long to others were to them of a bright, surprising shortness. Playing solitaire against each other on either side of the fireplace was a pastime at which hours slipped by. Quite unexpectedly it would be midday, with Cora putting her head round the door-post and calling them to dinner. In the euchre games of the afternoon the darkness crept upon them with the stealthy swiftness of an enemy. It would gather in the corners of the room while Cora was still heated and flushed from her efforts to instruct Willoughby in the intricacies of the game, and yet preserve that respectful attitude which she felt should be assumed in one's relations with a lord.

The twilight hour that followed was to Dominick's mind the most delightful of these days of fleeting enchantment. The curtains were drawn, a new log rolled on the fire, and the lamp lit. Then their fellow prisoners began dropping in—the old judge stowing himself away in one of the horsehair arm-chairs, Willoughby and Buford lounging in from the bar, Mrs. Perley with a basket of the family mending, and the doctor all snowy from his rounds. The audience for Rose's readings had expanded from the original listener to this choice circle of Antelope's elect. The book chosen had been *Great Expectations*, and the spell of that greatest tale of a great romancer fell on the snow-bound group and held them entranced and motionless round the friendly hearth.

The young man's eyes passed from face to face, avoiding only that of the reader bent over the lamp-illuminated page. The old judge, sunk comfortably into the depths of his arm-chair, listened, and cracked the joints of his lean, dry fingers. Willoughby, his dogs crouched about his feet, looked into the fire, his attentive gravity broken now and then by a slow smile. Mrs. Perley, after hearing the chapter which describes Mrs. Gargery's methods of bringing up Pip "by hand," attended regularly with the remark that "it was a queer sort of book, but some way or other she liked it." When Cora was forced to leave to attend to her duties in the dining-room, she tore herself away with murmurous reluctance. The doctor slipped in at the third reading and asked Rose if she would lend him the book in the morning "to read up

what he had missed.” Even Perley’s boy, in his worn corduroys, his dirty, chapped hands rubbing his cap against his nose, was wont to sidle noiselessly in and slip into a seat near the door.

The climax of the day was the long evening round the fire. There was no reading then. It was the men’s hour, and the smoke of their pipes and cigars lay thick in the air. Cut off from the world in this cranny of the mountains, with the hotel shaking to the buffets of the wind and the snow blanket pressing on the pane, their memories swept back to the wild days of their youth, to the epic times of frontiersman and pioneer.

The judge told of his crossing of the plains in forty-seven and the first Mormon settlement on the barren shores of Salt Lake. He had had encounters with the Indians, had heard the story of Olive Oatman from one who had known her, and listened to the sinister tale of the Donner party from a survivor. Bill Cannon had “come by the Isthmus” in forty-eight, a half-starved, ragged lad who had run away from uncongenial drudgery on a New York farm. His reminiscences went back to the San Francisco that started up around Portsmouth Square, to the days when the banks of the American River swarmed with miners, and the gold lay yellow in the prospector’s pan. He had worked there shoulder to shoulder with men who afterwards made the history of the state and men who died with their names unknown. He had been an eye witness of that blackest of Californian tragedies, the lynching of a Spanish girl at Downieville, had stood pallid and sick under a pine tree and watched her boldly face her murderers and meet her death.

The younger men, warmed to emulation, contributed their stories. Perley had reminiscences bequeathed to him by his father who had been an alcalde in that transition year, when California was neither state nor territory and stood in unadministered neglect, waiting for Congress to take some notice of her. Buford had stories of the vicissitudes of a strolling player’s life. He had been in the Klondike during the first gold rush and told tales of mining in the North to match those of mining on the “mother lode.” Willoughby, thawed out of his original shyness, added to the nights’ entertainments stories of the Australian bush, grim legends of the days of the penal settlements at Botany Bay. Young Ryan was the only man of the group who contributed nothing to these Sierran Nights’ Entertainments. He sat silent in

his chair, apparently listening, and, under the shadow of the hand arched over his eyes, looking at the girl opposite.

But the idyl had to end. Their captivity passed into its third week, and signs that release was at hand cheered them. They could go out. The streets of Antelope were beaten into footpaths, and the prisoners, with the enthusiasm of children liberated from school, rushed into open-air diversions and athletic exercise. The first word from the outside world came by restored telegraphic communication. Consolatory messages poured in from San Francisco. Mrs. Ryan, the elder, sent telegrams as long as letters and showered them with the prodigality of an impassioned gratitude on the camp. Perley had one that he could not speak of without growing husky. Willoughby had one that made him blush. Dominick had several. None, however, had come from his wife and he guessed that none had been sent her, his remark to Rose to "let her alone" having been taken as a wish to spare her anxiety. It was thought that the mail would be in now in a day or two. That would be the end of the fairy tale. They sat about the fire on these last evenings discussing their letters, what they expected, and whom they would be from. No one told any more stories; the thought of news from "outside" was too absorbing.

It came in the early dusk of an afternoon near the end of the third week. Dominick, who was still unable to walk, was standing by the parlor window, when he saw Rose Cannon run past outside. She looked in at him as she ran by, her face full of a joyous excitement, and held up to his gaze a small white packet. A moment later the hall door banged, her foot sounded in the passage, and she entered the room with a rush of cold air and a triumphant cry of:

"The mail's come!"

He limped forward to meet her and take from her hand the letter she held toward him. For the first moment he looked at her, not at the letter, which dwindled to a thing of no importance when their eyes met over it. Her face was nipped by the keen outside air into a bright, beaming rosiness. She wore on her head a man's fur cap which was pulled well down, and pressed wisps of fair hair against her forehead and cheeks. A loose fur-lined coat enveloped her to her feet, and after she had handed him his letter she pulled

off the mittens she wore and began unfastening the clasps of the coat, with fingers that were purplish and cramped from the cold.

“There’s only one for you,” she said. “I waited till the postmaster looked all through them twice. Then I made him give it to me and ran back here with it. The entire population of Antelope’s in the post-office and there’s the greatest excitement.”

Her coat was unfastened and she threw back its long fronts, her figure outlined against the gray fur lining. She snatched off her cap and tossed it to an adjacent chair and with a quick hand brushed away the hair it had pressed down on her forehead.

“I got seven,” she said, turning to the fire, “and papa a whole bunch, and the judge, quantities, and Willoughby, three. But only one for you—poor, neglected man!”

Spreading her hands wide to the blaze she looked at him over her shoulder, laughing teasingly. He had the letter in his hands still unopened.

“Why,” she cried, “what an extraordinary sight! You haven’t opened it!”

“No,” he answered, turning it over, “I haven’t.”

“I’ve always heard that curiosity was a feminine weakness but I never knew it till now,” she said. “Please go on and read it, because if you don’t I’ll feel that I’m preventing you and I’ll have to go up stairs to my own room, which is as cold as a refrigerator. Don’t make me polite and considerate against my will.”

Without answering her he tore open the letter and, moving to the light of the window, held the sheet up and began to read.

There was silence for some minutes. The fire sputtered and snapped, and once or twice the crisp paper rustled in Dominick’s hands. Rose held her fingers out to the warmth, studying them with her head on one side as if she had never seen them before. Presently she slid noiselessly out of her coat, and dropped it, a heap of silky fur, on a chair beside her. The movement made it convenient to steal a glance at the young man. He was reading the letter, his body close against the window-pane, his face full of frowning, almost fierce concentration. She turned back to the fire and made small, surreptitious smoothings and jerks of arrangement at her collar, her belt, her

skirt. Dominick turned the paper and there was something aggressive in the crackling of the thin, dry sheet.

“Perley got a letter from your mother,” she said suddenly, “that he was reading in a corner of the post-office, and it nearly made him cry.”

There was no answer. She waited for a space and then said, projecting the remark into the heart of the fire,

“Yours must be a most *interesting* letter.”

She heard him move and looked quickly back at him, her face all gay challenge. It was met by a look so somber that her expression changed as if she had received a check to her gaiety as unexpected and effectual as a blow. She shrank a little as he came toward her, the letter in his hand.

“It *is* an interesting letter,” he said. “It’s from my wife.”

Since those first days of his illness, his wife’s name had been rarely mentioned. Rose thought it was because young Mrs. Ryan was a delicate subject best left alone; Dominick, because anything that reminded him of Berny was painful. But the truth was that, from the first, the wife had loomed before them as a figure of dread, a specter whose presence congealed the something exquisite and uplifting each felt in the other’s heart. Now, love awakened, forcing itself upon their recognition, her name came up between them, chilling and grim as the image of death intruding suddenly into the joyous presence of the living.

The change that had come over the interview all in a moment was startling. Suddenly it seemed lifted from the plane of every-day converse to a level where the truth was an obligation and the language of polite subterfuge could not exist. But the woman, who hides and protects herself with these shields, made an effort to keep it in the old accustomed place.

“Is—is—she well?” she stammered, framing the regulation words almost unconsciously.

“She’s well,” he answered, “she’s very well. She wants me to come home.”

He suddenly looked away from her and, turning to the chimneypiece, rested one hand upon it and gazed down at the logs. A charred end projected and he pushed it in with his slippered foot, his down-bent face, the lips set and brows wrinkled, looking like the face of a sullen boy who has been unjustly

punished. An icy, invading chill of depression made Rose's heart sink down into bottomless depths. She faltered in faint tones,

"Well, you'll be there soon now."

"I don't know," he answered without moving. "I don't know whether I shall."

"You don't know whether you'll be home soon? The roads are open; the postman has come in."

"I don't know whether I'll go home," he repeated.

The snapping of the fire sounded loud upon the silence that followed. The thrill of strong emotions rising toward expression held them in a breathless, immovable quietude.

"Don't you want to go home?" said the young girl. Her voice was low and she cleared her throat. In this interchange of commonplace sentences her heart had begun to beat so violently that it interfered with the ease of her speech.

Dominick leaned forward and dropped the crumpled letter into the fire.

"No, I don't want to. I hate to."

To this she did not reply at all, and after a moment he continued: "My home is unbearable to me. It isn't a home. It's a place where I eat and sleep, and I'd prefer doing that anywhere else, in any dirty boarding-house or fourth-rate hotel—I'd rather——"

He stopped abruptly and pushed the log farther in. The letter was caught up the chimney in a swirl of blackened scraps.

"But your wife?" said Rose.

This time her voice was hoarse but she did not know it. She had lost the consciousness of herself. It was a profound moment, the deepest she had so far known, and all the forces of her being were concentrated upon it. The young man answered with deliberation, still not moving.

"I don't want to see my wife. We are—we are—uncongenial. There is nothing but unhappiness between us."

"Don't you love her?" said the girl.

“No. I never did,” he answered.

For a moment neither dared speak. They did not look at each other or stir. They hardly seemed to breathe. A movement, a touch, would have rent the last thin crust of reserve that covered what were no longer unsuspected fires. Dominick knew it, but the girl did not. She was seized by what to her was a sudden, inexplicable fear, and the increased, suffocating beating of her heart made her feel dizzy. She suddenly wished to fly, to escape from the room, and him, and herself. She turned to go and was arrested by Cora’s voice in the hall:

“Say, you folks, are you in there?”

Cora’s visage followed her voice. She thrust it round the door-post, beamingly smiling under a recently-applied coat of powder.

“Do you want to tackle a game of euchre? Mr. Willoughby and I’ll lay you out cold unless that British memory of his has gone back on him and he’s forgot all I taught him last time.”

They were too bewildered to make any response. Rose gathered up her coat and dropped it again, looking stupidly from it to the intruder. Cora turned back to the passage, calling,

“Here they are, Mr. Willoughby, all ready and waiting for us. Now we’ll show them how to play euchre.”

Before Willoughby appeared, responsive to this cheerful hail, Cora had pulled the chairs round the table and brought out the cards. A few moments later, they were seated and the game had begun. Cora and her partner were soon jubilant. Not only did they hold the cards, but their adversaries played so badly that the tale of many old scores was wiped off.

The next day the first movements of departure began. Early in the afternoon Buford and Judge Washburne started for Rocky Bar in Perley’s sleigh. The road had been broken by the mail-carrier, but was still so deeply drifted that the drive was reckoned a toilsome undertaking not without danger. Perley’s two powerful horses were harnessed in tandem, and Perley himself, a mere pillar of wrappings, drove them, squatted on a soap box in front of the two passengers. There were cries of farewell from the porch and tappings on the windows as the sleigh started and sped away to the diminishing jingle of

bells. A sadness fell on those who watched it. The little idyl of isolation was over.

On the following day Bill Cannon and his daughter were to leave. A telegram had been sent to Rocky Bar for a sleigh and horses of the proper excellence to be the equipage of a Bonanza Princess. Rose had spent the morning packing the valises, and late in the afternoon began a down-stairs search for possessions left in the parlor.

The dusk was gathering as she entered the room, the corners of which were already full of darkness, the fire playing on them with a warm, varying light. Waves of radiance quivered and ran up the ceiling, here and there touching the glaze on a picture glass or china ornament. The crude ugliness of the place was hidden in this unsteady, transforming combination of shadow and glow. It seemed a rich, romantic spot, flushed with fire that pulsed on an outer edge of mysterious obscurity, a center of familiar, intimate life, round which coldness and the dark pressed.

She thought the room was unoccupied and advanced toward the table, then started before the uprising of Dominick's tall figure from a chair in a shadowed corner. It was the first time they had seen each other alone since their conversation of the day before. Rose was startled and agitated, and her brusque backward movement showed it. Her voice, however, was natural, almost easy to casualness as she said,

"I thought there was no one here, you've hidden yourself in such a dark corner. I came to gather up my books and things."

He advanced into the light, looking somberly at her.

"It's true that you're going to-morrow?" he said almost gruffly.

"Oh, yes, we're really going. Everything's been arranged. Horses and a sleigh are expected any moment now from Rocky Bar. They rest here all night and take us down in the afternoon. I think papa'd go crazy if we had to stay twenty-four hours longer."

"I'll follow in a day or two," he said, "probably go down on Tuesday, the doctor says."

She began gathering up the books, reading the titles, and putting aside those that were not hers.

“I’m so sorry it’s over,” she said in a preoccupied voice without any particular regret in it. “*The Mill on the Floss* is Mrs. Perley’s, I think.”

“I’m sorry, too,” he commented, very low.

She made no reply, selected another book, and as she held it up looking at the back, said,

“But it’s not like a regular good-by. It’s not as if you were going in one direction and we in another. We’ll see you in San Francisco, of course.”

“I don’t think so,” he answered.

She laid the book on the table and turned her face toward him. He stood looking into the fire, not seeing the face, but conscious of it, of its expression, of its every line.

“Do you mean that we’re not going to see you down there at all?”

“Yes, that’s just about what I meant,” he replied.

“Mr. Ryan!” It was hardly more than a breath of protest, but it was as stirring to the man as the whisper of love.

He made no comment on it, and she said, with a little more of insistence and volume,

“But why?”

“It’s best not,” he answered, and turned toward her.

His shoulders were squared and he held his head as a man does who prepares himself for a blow. His eyes, looking straight into hers, enveloped her in a glance soft and burning, not a savage glance, but the enfolding, possessive glance, caressing and ardent, pleading and masterful, of a lover.

The books that she was holding fell to the table, and they looked at each other while the clock ticked.

“It’s best for me not to come,” he said huskily, “never to come.”

“Very well,” she faltered.

He came a little nearer to her and said,

“You know what I mean.”

She turned away, very pale, her lips trembling.

“And you’d like me to come if I could—if I were free?”

He was close to her and looked down to see her face, his own hard, the bones of the jaw showing through the thin cheeks.

“You’d like me to?” he urged.

She nodded, her lips too dry to speak.

“O Rose!” he whispered, a whisper that seemed to melt the strength of her heart and make her unvanquished, maiden pride dissolve into feebleness.

He leaned nearer and, taking her by the arms just above the elbows, drew her to himself, into an embrace, close and impassioned, that crushed her against him. She submitted passively, in a dizzy dream that was neither joy nor pain, but was like a moment of drugged unreality, fearful and beautiful. She was unconscious of his lips pressed on her hair, but she felt the beating of his heart beneath her cheek.

They stood thus for a moment, rising above time and space. They seemed to have been caught up to a pinnacle of life where the familiar world lay far beneath them. A joy, divine and dreamy, held them clasped together, motionless and mute, for a single point of time beyond and outside the limitations that had heretofore bound them.

Bill Cannon had a question to ask his daughter and he came down stairs to the parlor where she had told him she was going. He had dressed himself for supper, the most important item of his toilet being a pair of brown leather slippers. They were soft and made no sound, and stepping briskly in them he advanced to the half-open parlor door, pushed it open and entered the quiet room. On the hearth-rug before the fire stood a woman clasped in the arms of Dominick Ryan.

Though the face was hidden, the first glance told him it was his daughter. The young man’s head was bowed on hers, his brown hair rising above the gleaming blondness of hers. They were absolutely motionless and silent. For an amazed moment the father stared at them, then turned and tiptoed out of the room.

He mounted several steps of the staircase and then descended, stepping as heavily as he could, and, as he advanced on the parlor, coughed with

aggressive loudness. He was on the threshold when he encountered his daughter, her head lowered, her gait quick, almost a run. Without a word he stepped aside and let her pass, the rustling of her skirt diminishing as she ran up the hall and mounted the stairs.



Dominick was standing on the hearth-rug, his head raised like a stag's; his eyes, wide and gleaming, on the doorway through which she had passed. Cannon stopped directly in front of him and fixed a stony, menacing glare on him.

“Well, Dominick Ryan,” he said in a low voice, “I saw that. I came in here a moment ago and saw that. What have you got to say about it?”

The young man turned his eyes slowly from vacancy to the angry face before him. For a moment he looked slightly dazed, staring blankly at Cannon. Then wrath gathered thunderously on his brow.

“Let me alone!” he said fiercely, thrusting him aside. “Get out of my way and let me alone! I can’t talk to you now.”

He swept the elder man out of his path, and, lurching and staggering on his wounded feet, hurled himself out of the room.

CHAPTER IX

THE SONS OF THEIR FATHERS

It was at the end of the Bonanza times, that period of startling upheavals and downfalls, when miners had suddenly become millionaires, and rich men found themselves paupers, that Bill Cannon built his mansion in San Francisco. He had made his fortune in Virginia City, not in a few meteoric years, as the public, who loves picturesque histories, was wont to recount relishingly, but in a series of broken periods of plenty with lean years in between. The Crown Point and Belcher rise made him a man of means, and its collapse was said to have ruined him. Afterward, wiseacres shook their heads and there were rumors that it was not Bill Cannon who was ruined. In the dead period which followed this disastrous cataclysm of fortune and confidence, he was surreptitiously loyal to the capricious town from which men had withdrawn their affection and belief as from a beguiling woman, once loved and trusted, now finally proved false.

In those short years of mourning and lost faith between the downfall of Crown Point and the rise of the Con. Virginia and the Rey del Monte, Bill Cannon "lay low." His growing reputation as an expert mining man and a rising financier had suffered. Men had disbelieved in him as they did in Virginia, and he knew the sweetness of revenge when he and the great camp rose together in titanic partnership and defied them. His detractors had hardly done murmuring together over the significant fact that Crown Point "had not scooped every dollar he had" when the great ore-body was struck on the thousand-foot level of the Rey del Monte, and Bill Cannon became a Bonanza King.

That was in seventy-four. The same year he bought the land in San Francisco and laid the foundation for the mansion on Nob Hill. His wife was still living then, and his son and daughter—the last of seven children, five of whom had died in infancy—were as yet babies. A year later the house was completed and the Cannon family, surrounded by an aura of high-colored, accumulating anecdote, moved down from Nevada and took possession.

Mrs. Cannon, who in her girlhood had been the prettiest waitress in the Yuba Hotel at Marysville and had married Bill Cannon when he was an underground miner, was the subject of much gossip in the little group which at that time made up San Francisco's fashionable world. They laughed at her and went to her entertainments. They told stories of her small social mistakes, and fawned on her husband for positions for their sons. He understood them, treated them with an open cynical contempt, and used them. He was big enough to realize his wife's superiority, and it amused him to punish them for their patronizing airs by savage impertinences that they winced under but did not dare resent. She was a silent, sensitive, loving woman, who never quite fitted into the frame his wealth had given her. She did her best to fill the new rôle, but it bewildered her and she did not feel at ease in it. In her heart she yearned for the days when her home had been a miner's cabin in the foot-hills, her babies had known no nurse but herself, and her husband had been all hers. Those were her *beaux jours*.

She died some twelve years after the installation in San Francisco. Bill Cannon had loved her after his fashion and always respected her, and the withdrawal of her quiet, sympathetic presence left a void behind it that astonished, almost awed him. The two children, Eugene and Rose, were eighteen and thirteen at the time. She had adored them, lived for them, been a mother at once tender and intelligent, and they mourned her with passion. It was to dull the ache left by her death, that Gene, a weak and characterless changeling in this vigorous breed, sought solace in drink. And it was then that Rose, assuming her mother's place as head of the establishment, began to show that capacity for management, that combination of executive power and gentle force—bequests from both parents—that added admiration to the idolizing love the Bonanza King had always given her.

The house in which this pampered princess ruled was one of those enormous structures which a wealth that sought extravagant ways of expending itself reared upon that protuberance in the city's outline called by San Franciscans Nob Hill. The suddenly-enriched miners of the Comstock Lode and the magnates of the railway had money waiting for investment, and the building of huge houses seemed as good a one as any other.

Here, from their front steps, they could see the city sweeping up from its low center on to the slopes of girdling hills. It was a gray city, crowding down to the edge of the bay, which, viewed from this height, extended far

up into the sky. In summer, under an arch of remote, cold blue, its outlines blurred by clouds of blown dust, it looked a bleak, unfriendly place, a town in which the stranger felt a depressing, nostalgic chill. In winter, when the sun shone warm and tender as a caress, and the bay and hills were like a mosaic in blue and purple gems, it was a panorama over which the passer-by was wont to linger. The copings of walls offered a convenient resting-place, and he could lean on them, still as a lizard in the bath of sun.

Bill Cannon's house had unbroken command of this view. It fronted on it in irregular, massive majesty, with something in its commanding bulkiness that reminded one of its owner. It was of that epoch when men built their dwellings of wood; and numerous bay-windows and a sweep of marble steps flanked by sleeping stone lions were considered indispensable adjuncts to the home of the rich man who knew how to do things correctly. Round it spread a green carpet of lawns, close-cropped and even as velvet, and against its lower story deep borders of geraniums were banked in slopes of graduated scarlet and crimson. The general impression left by it was that of a splendor that would have been ostentatious and vulgar had not the studied elegance of the grounds and the outflung glories of sea, sky and hills imparted to it some of their own distinction and dignity.

On the day following their departure from Antelope, Cannon and his daughter reached home at nightfall. The obsequiously-welcoming butler—an importation from the East that the Bonanza King confided to Rose he found it difficult to refrain from kicking—acquainted them with the fact that “Mr. Gene had been up from San Luis Obispo” for two days, waiting for their arrival. Even as he spoke a masculine voice uttered a hail from the floor above and a man's figure appeared on the stairway and ran quickly down. Cannon gave a careless look upward.

“Ah there, Gene,” he observed, turning to the servant who was helping him off with his coat. “Come up to town for a spell?”

The young man did not seem to notice anything especially ungracious in the greeting or probably was used to it.

“Yes, just up for a look around and to see how you and Rosey were. Got snowed in, didn't you?” he said, looking at his sister.

She kissed him affectionately and drew him to the light where she subjected him to a sharp, exploring scrutiny. Evidently the survey was satisfactory, for she gave him a little slap on the shoulder and said,

“Good boy, Gene, San Luis is agreeing with you. Yes, we were snowed in for nearly three weeks. Papa’s been half crazy. And you’ve been in town two days, Prescott says. It must have been dull here all alone.”

“Oh, I haven’t been dull. I’ve been going round seeing the boys and”—his sister’s sudden, uneasy look checked him and he answered it with quick reassurance of glance and tone. “Everything strictly temperance. Don’t you get uneasy. I’ve lived up to my promises. The ranch is mine all right, father.”

He had a high, rather throaty voice, which, without seeing his face, would have suggested weakness and lack of purpose. Now as he looked at his father with a slight and somewhat foolish air of triumph, the old man responded to his remark with a sound which resembled a grunt of scornful incredulity.

“Really, Gene,” said his sister, her manner of fond gratification in marked contrast to her father’s roughness, “that’s the best news I’ve heard for a year. It’s worth being snowed up to hear that when you come out. Of course you’ll get the ranch. I always knew you would. I always knew you could pull up and be as straight as anybody if you tried.”

The old man, who had been kicking off his rubbers, here raised his head with a bull-like movement, and suddenly roared at the retreating butler who was vanishing toward the dining-room.

“My cigars. Where in hell are they? Why doesn’t somebody attend here?”

The servant, with a start of alarm and a murmured excuse, disappeared for a moment, to reappear, hurrying breathlessly with a box of cigars. Cannon selected one and turned to the stairway.

“How long are you down for?” he said to his son as he began ascending.

“I thought a week, perhaps two,” answered the young man. “A feller gets darned lonely, down there in the country.”

There was something apologetic, almost pleading in his words and way of speech. He looked after his father’s receding figure as if quite oblivious to

the rudeness of the large, retiring back and the manner of careless scorn.

“Make it three,” said the Bonanza King, turning his head slightly and throwing the sentence over his shoulder.

Gene Cannon was now twenty-nine years of age and had drunk since his eighteenth year. His mother had died in ignorance of his vice. When his father discovered it, it simply augmented the old man’s impatience against the feeble youth who would carry on his name and be one of the inheritors of his fortune. Bill Cannon had never cared much for his only son. He had early seen the stuff of which the boy was made. “Doesn’t amount to a hill of beans,” he would say, throwing the words at his wife over the bitten end of his cigar. He could have forgiven the drinking, as he could other vices, if Gene had had some of his own force, some of that driving power which had carried him triumphant over friend and foe. But the boy had no initiative, no brains, no energy. “How did *I* ever come to have such a son?” he queried sometimes in an access of disgust in which the surprise was stronger than the disgust. The question possessed a sort of scientific interest for him which was deeper than the personal and over which the disappointed magnate would ponder.

As Gene grew older and his intemperance assumed more serious proportions, the father’s scorn grew more open and was augmented by a sort of exasperated dislike. The Bonanza King had no patience with those who failed from ill-health or the persistent persecutions of bad luck. His contention was that they should not have been ill, and they should have conquered their bad luck. He had no excuses for those who were beaten back against the wall—only death should be able to do that. But when it came to a useless, hampering vice, a weakness that in itself was harmless enough, but that was allowed to gain paralyzing proportions, his original contempt was intensified into a fierce intolerance which would have been terrifying if it had not been tempered with an indifferent disdain.

Rose’s attitude toward her brother was a source of secret wonder to him. She loved the feeble youth; a tie of the deepest affection existed between them, upon which Gene’s intemperance seemed to have no effect. The Bonanza King had always admitted that the ways of the gentler sex were beyond his comprehension, but that the two women he had known best—his wife and his daughter—should have lavished the tenderest love upon an

intemperate, incompetent, useless weakling was to him one of the fathomless mysteries of life.

It was Rose's suggestion that Gene should be withdrawn from temptation by sending him to the country. As the only son of Bill Cannon he was the object of a variety of attentions and allurements in the city to which a stronger-willed man might have succumbed. The father readily agreed to the plan. He could graciously subscribe to all Rose said, as the removal of Gene's amiable visage and uninspired conversation would not cause him any particular distress or sense of loss.

But when Rose unfolded the whole of her scheme he was not so enthusiastically in accord with her. It was that Gene should be put on his father's ranch—the historic Rancho of the Santa Trinidad near San Luis Obispo—as manager, that all responsibility should be placed in his hands, and that if, during one year's probation, he should remain sober and maintain a record of quiet conduct and general good behavior, the ranch should be turned over to him as his own property, to be developed on such lines as he thought best.

The Rancho of the Santa Trinidad was one of the finest pieces of agricultural property in California. The Bonanza King visited it once a year, and at intervals received crates of fruit and spring chickens raised upon it. This was about all he got out of it, but when he heard Rose calmly arranging to have it become Gene's property, he felt like a man who suddenly finds himself being robbed. He had difficulty in restraining a roar of refusal. Had it been any one but Rose he would not have restrained it.

Of course he gave way to her, as he always did. He even gave way gracefully with an effect of a generosity too large to bother over trifles, not because he felt it but because he did not want Rose to guess how it "went against him." Under the genial blandness of his demeanor he reconciled himself to the situation by the thought that Gene would certainly never keep sober for a year, and that there was therefore no fear of the richest piece of ranch land in the state passing into the hands of that dull and incapable young man.

The year was nearly up now. It had but three months to run and Gene's record had been exemplary. He had come to the city only twice, when his father noticed with a jealously-watchful eye that he had been resolutely

abstemious in the matter of liquor and that his interest in the great property he managed had been the strongest he had so far evinced in anything. The thought that Gene might possibly live up to his side of the bargain and win the ranch caused the old man to experience that feeling of blank chagrin which is the state of mind of the unexpectedly swindled. He felt like a king who has been daringly and successfully robbed by a slave.

At dinner that evening Gene was very talkative. He told of his life on the ranch, of its methodical monotony, of its seclusion, for he saw little of his neighbors and seldom went in to the town. Rose listened with eager interest, and the old man with a sulky, glowering attention. At intervals he shot a piercing look at his boy, eying him sidewise with a cogitating intentness of observation. His remarks were few, but Gene was so loquacious that there was little opportunity for another voice to be heard. He prattled on like a happy child, recounting the minutest details of his life after the fashion of those who live much alone.

In the light of the crystal lamp that spread a ruffled shade of yellow silk over the center of the table, he was seen to be quite unlike his father or sister. His jet-black hair and uniformly pale skin resembled his mother's, but his face in its full, rounded contours, slightly turned-up nose, and eyebrows as thick as strips of fur, had a heaviness hers had lacked. Some people thought him good-looking, and there was a sort of unusual, Latin picturesqueness in the combination of his curly black hair, which he wore rising up in a bulwark of waves from his forehead, his white skin, and the small, dark mustache, delicate as an eyebrow, that shaded his upper lip. It was one of his father's grievances against him that he would have made a pretty girl, and that his soft, affectionate character would have been quite charming in a woman. Now, listening to him, it seemed to the older man as if it were just the kind of talk one might expect from Gene. The father had difficulty in suppressing a snort of derision when he heard the young man recounting to Rose his troubles with his Chinese cook.

Before dinner was over Gene excused himself on the plea that he was going to the theater.

"I'm such a hayseed now," he said as he rose, "that I don't want to miss a thing. Haven't seen a play for six months and I'm just crazy to see anything,

Monte Cristo, Uncle Tom's Cabin, East Lynne. I'm not proud, anything'll suit me."

"Don't you ever go into San Luis?" growled his father sulkily. "They have plays there sometimes, I suppose."

"Oh yes, but I'm keeping out of harm's way. The boys in San Luis don't know how it is with me. They don't understand and I'm not going to put myself in the way of temptation. You know, father, I *want that ranch.*"

He turned a laughing glance on his father; and the old man, with a sheepishly-discomfited expression, grunted an unintelligible reply and bent over his plate.

He did not raise his head till Gene had left the room, when, looking up, he leaned back in his chair and said with a plaintive sigh,

"What a damned fool that boy is!"

Rose was up in arms at once.

"Why, papa, how can you say that! Especially when you see how he's improved. It's wonderful. He's another man. You can tell in a minute he's not been drinking, he takes such an interest in everything and is so full of work and plans."

"Is he?" said her father dryly. "Maybe so, but that don't prevent him from being a damned fool."

"You're unjust to Gene. Why do you think he's a fool?"

"Just because he happens to be one. You might as well ask me why I think the sun rises in the east and sets in the west. That's what it does, and when I say it does, I'm not criticizing or complaining, I'm only stating the plain facts."

Rose made a murmur of protest and he went on.

"You're queer cattle, you women. I suppose a feller could live in the world a hundred years and not understand you. There's Delia Ryan, for example, the brainiest woman I know, could give most men cards and spades and beat 'em hands down. Last night at Rocky Bar they were telling me that she's written to the operator there and told him she'll get him a position here in the Atlantic and Pacific Cable Company, in which she's a large

stock-holder, that'll double his salary and give him a chance he'd never have got in this world. She wants to pay off a mortgage on a ranch Perley has in the Sacramento Valley and she's sent Mrs. Perley a check for five hundred dollars. She's offered Willoughby a first-rate job on the Red Calumet group of mines near Sonora in which Con had a controlling interest, and she's written to the doctor to come down and become one of the house physicians of the St. Filomena Hospital, which she practically runs. She's ready to do all this because of what they did for Dominick, and yet she, his own mother, won't give the boy a cent and keeps him on starvation wages, just because she wants to spite his wife."

He looked at his daughter across the table with narrowed eyes. "What have you got to say for yourself after that, young woman?" he demanded.

Rose had evidently nothing to say. She raised her eyebrows and shook her head by way of reply. Her face, in the flood of lamplight, looked pale and tired. She was evidently distraught and depressed; a very different-looking Rose from the girl he had taken away with him four weeks earlier. He regarded her for an anxiously-contemplative moment and then said,

"What's the matter? Seems to me you look sort'er peaked."

"I?" she queried with a surprised start. "Why, I'm quite well."

"Well's you were before you went up to the mines?"

A color came into her cheeks and she lowered her eyes:

"I'm a little tired, I think, and that always makes me look pale. It was a hard sort of trip, all those hours in the sleigh, and that hotel at Rocky Bar was a dreadful place. I couldn't sleep. There was a cow somewhere near—it sounded as if it were in the next room—and the roosters all began to crow in the middle of the night. I'll be all right to-morrow."

Her father drew his coffee-cup toward him and dropped in a lump of sugar. No word had passed between him and his daughter as to the scene he had witnessed two days before in the parlor of Perley's Hotel. She was ignorant of the fact that he had seen it and he intended that she should remain ignorant of it. But the next morning he had had an interview with Dominick Ryan, in which the young man, confronted with angry questions and goaded past reserve by shame and pain, had confessed the misery of his marriage and the love that in an unguarded moment had slipped beyond his control.

Cannon had said little to him. Beyond telling him that he must not see Miss Cannon again, his comments on Dominick's confessions had been brief and non-committal. It was not his business to preach to Delia Ryan's boy, and a large experience of men had given him a practically limitless tolerance of any and all lapses of which the human animal is capable. They only concerned him as they bore on his own affairs. In this particular case they did bear on his affairs, closely and importantly, on the affair of all others dearest and nearest to him—the happiness of his daughter. He knew that in this three weeks of imprisonment she had come to feel for Dominick Ryan a sentiment she had never before felt for any man. He had seen her in the young man's arms, and, knowing Rose as he knew her, that was enough.

Driving down from Antelope in the sleigh he thought about it hard, harder than he had ever before in his life thought of any sentimental complication. He was enraged—coldly and grimly enraged—that his girl should have stumbled into such a pitfall. But it was not his habit to waste time and force in the indulgence of profitless anger. The thing had happened. Rose, who had been courted many times and never warmed to more than pity for her unsuccessful suitors, had suddenly, by a fateful, unpremeditated chance, met her mate—the man she loved. And the most maddening part of it was that he was the man of all others her father would have chosen for her had such a choice been possible.

He bit on his cigar, turning it over between his teeth, and looked sidewise at her as she sat silent in the sleigh beside him. She was unquestionably pale, pale and listless, her body wrapped in enveloping furs, sunk in an attitude of weariness, her eyes full of dejected reverie. Even to his blindly-groping, masculine perceptions her distraught looks, her dispirited silence, told of melancholy preoccupation. She was not happy—his Rose, who, if she had wanted it and he could have bought, begged or stolen it, would have had the moon.

To-night, in her white dress, the mellow radiance of the lamp throwing out her figure against the shadowy richness of the dining-room walls, she bore the same appearance of despondency. Her luster was dimmed, her delicate skin had lost its dazzling, separated bloom of pink and white, her glance was absent and unresponsive. Never, since the death of her mother, now ten years back, had he seen her when it was so obvious that she harbored an inner, unexpressed sense of trouble.

“I guess the city’s the best place for you,” he said. “Roughing it don’t seem to suit you if cows and chickens keep you awake all night. I’ve seen the time when the hotel at Rocky Bar would have been considered the top notch of luxury. I wish you could see the places your mother lived in when I first took her up there. You’re a spoiled girl, Rose Cannon.”

“Who spoiled me, I wonder?” she said, looking at him with a gleam of humor in her eyes.

“We’re not calling names to-night,” he answered, “anyway, not since Gene’s gone. All my desire to throw things and be ugly vanishes when that boy gets out. So the noises at Rocky Bar kept you awake?”

“Yes, and I was wakeful, anyway.”

She looked down at her cup, stirring her coffee. He thought she appeared conscious and said,

“What made you wakeful, guilty conscience?”

“Guilty conscience!” she repeated in a tone that was full of indignant surprise. “Why should I have a guilty conscience?”

“Lord knows! Don’t fire off these conundrums at me. I don’t know all your secrets, honey.”

She did not answer. He glanced furtively at her and saw that her face had flushed. He took a cigar from the box the butler had set at his elbow and bit off the end:

“How should I know the secrets of a young lady like you? A long time ago, perhaps, I used to, after your mother died and you were my little Rosey, fourteen years old. Lord, how cunning you were then! Just beginning to lengthen out, a little woman and a little girl, both in one. You didn’t have secrets in those days or wakeful nights either.”

He applied a match to the end of the cigar and drew at it, his ears strained for his daughter’s reply. She again made none and he shot a quick glance at her. She was still stirring her coffee, her eyebrows drawn together, her eyes on the swirl of brown in the cup. He settled himself in his chair, a bulky figure, his clothes ribbed with creases, his head low between his shoulders, and a reek of cigar smoke issuing from his lips.

“How’d you like it up there, anyway?”

“Up where?”

“Up at Antelope. It was a sort of strange, new experience for you.”

“Oh, I liked it so much—I loved part of it. I liked the people much better than the people down here, Mrs. Perley, and Cora, and Perley, and Willoughby—did you ever know a nicer man than Willoughby?—and Judge Washburne. *He* was a real gentleman, not only in his manners but down in his heart. And even Perley’s boy, he was so natural and awkward and honest. I felt different from what I do here, more myself, less as if outside things were influencing me to do things I didn’t always like to do or mean to do. I felt as if I were doing just what I ought to do—it’s hard to express it—as if I were being true.”

“Oh,” said her father with a falling inflection which had a sound of significant comprehension.

“Do you know what I mean?” she asked.

“I can make a sort of guess at it.”

He puffed at his cigar for a moment, then took it from his mouth, eyed the lit end, and said,

“How’d you like Dominick Ryan? You haven’t said anything about him.”

Her voice, in answering, sounded low and careful. She spoke slowly, as if considering her words:

“I thought he was very nice, and good-looking, too. He’s not a bit like Cornelia Ryan, or his mother, either. Cornelia has such red hair.”

“No, looks like the old man. Good deal like him in character, too. Con Ryan was the best feller in the world, but not hard enough, not enough grit. His wife had it though, had enough for both. If it hadn’t been for her, Con would never have amounted to anything—too soft and good-natured, and the boy’s like him.”

“How?” She raised her head and looked directly at him, her lips slightly parted.

“Soft, too, just the same way, soft-hearted. An easy mark for any one with a hard-luck story and not too many scruples. Why did he marry that woman? I don’t know anything about it, but I’d like to bet she saw the stuff he was made of and cried and teased and nagged till she got him to do it.”

“I don’t see that he could have done anything else.”

“That’s a woman’s—a young girl’s view. That’s the view Dominick himself probably took. It’s the sort of idea you might expect him to have, something ornamental and impractical, that’s all right to keep in the cupboard and take out and dust, but that don’t do for every-day use. That sort of thing is all very well for a girl, but it doesn’t do for a man. It’s not for this world and our times. Maybe it was all right when a feller went round in armor, fighting for unknown damsels, but it won’t go in California to-day. The woman was a working woman, she wasn’t any green girl. She earned her living in an office full of men, and I guess there wasn’t much she didn’t know. She saw through Dominick and gathered him in. It’s all very well to be chivalrous, but you don’t want to be a confounded fool.”

“Are you a ‘confounded fool’ when you’re doing what you think right?”

“It depends on what you think right, honey. If it’s going to break up your life, cut you off from your kind, make an outcast of you from your own folks, and a poverty-stricken outcast at that, you’re a confounded fool to think it’s right. You oughtn’t to let yourself think so. That kind of a moral attitude is a luxury. Women can cultivate it because they don’t have to get out in the world and fight. They keep indoors and get taken care of, and the queer ideas they have don’t hurt anybody. But men——”

He stopped, realizing that perhaps he was talking too frankly. He had long known that Rose harbored these Utopian theories on duty and honor, which he thought very nice and pretty for her and which went gracefully with her character as a sheltered, cherished, and unworldly maiden. It was his desire to see what effect the conversation was having on her that made him deal so unceremoniously with ideals of conduct which were all very well for Bill Cannon’s daughter but were ruinous for Dominick Ryan.

“If you live in the world you’ve got to cut your cloth by its measure,” he continued. “Look at that poor devil, tied to a woman that’s not going to let him go if she can help it, that he doesn’t care for——”

“How do you know he doesn’t care for her?” The interruption came in a tone of startled surprise and Rose stared at him, her eyes wide with it.

For a moment the old man was at a loss. He would have told any lie rather than have let her guess his knowledge of the situation and the information given him by Dominick. He realized that his zeal had made him imprudently garrulous, and, gazing at her with a slightly stupid expression, said in a slow tone of self-justification,

“Well, that’s my idea. I guessed it. I’ve heard one thing and another here and there and I’ve come to the conclusion that there’s no love lost between them. It’s the natural outcome of the situation, anyway.”

“Yes, perhaps,” she murmured. She placed her elbow on the table and pressed the tips of her fingers against her cheek. Her hand and arm, revealed by her loose lace sleeve, looked as if cut out of ivory.

“And then,” went on her father remorselessly, “the results of being a confounded fool don’t stop right there. That’s one of the worst things of allowing yourself the luxury of foolishness. They go on—roll right along like a wheel started on a down-hill grade. Some day that boy’ll meet the right woman—the one he really wants, the one that belongs to him. He’ll be able to stand it all right till then. And then he’ll realize just what he’s done and what he’s up against, and things may happen.”

The smoke wreaths were thick in front of his face, and peering through them he saw the young girl move her fingers from her cheek to her forehead, where she gently rubbed them up and down.

“Isn’t that about the size of it?” he queried, when she did not answer.

“Yes, maybe,” she said in a voice that sounded muffled.

“It’ll be a pretty tough proposition and it’s bound to happen. A decent feller like that is just the man to fall in love. And he’d be good to a woman, he’d make her happy. He’s a good husband lost for some nice girl.”

Rose’s fingers ceased moving across her forehead. Her hand rested there, shading her eyes. For a moment the old man—his vision precipitated into the half-understood wretchedness of Dominick Ryan’s position—forgot her, and he said in a hushed voice of feeling,

“By God, I’m sorry for the poor boy!”

His daughter rose suddenly with a rustling of crushed silks. The sound brought him back in an instant and he leaned over the arm of his chair, his cigar in his left hand, his right waving the smoke wreaths from before his face. Rose's hand, pressing her crumpled napkin on the table, shone pink in the lamplight, her shoulder gleamed white through its lace covering, but her face was averted.

"Going up now?" he asked, leaning still farther over the chair-arm to see her beyond the lamp's wide shade.

She appeared not to hear and moved toward the door.

"Going to bed already, Rosey?" he asked in a louder key.

"Yes, I'm tired," her voice came a little hoarse and she did not look at him. At the doorway she stopped, her hand on the edge of the portière, and without turning, cleared her throat and said, "The cow and the chickens were too much for me. I'm too sleepy to talk any more. Good night, papa."

"Good-night, Rosey," he answered.

The portière fell softly behind her, and her footfall was lost in the thickness of the carpets. Though he had not seen her face, her father had an alarming, an almost terrifying idea, that his darling had left the table in tears.

He sat on for some time, stonily motionless, save for the movement of his lips as he puffed out clouds of smoke. The soft-footed servants, coming to clear the table, fled before his growled command to "get out and let him alone." As he smoked he looked straight before him with fixed, unwinking eyes, his face set in furrows of thought. At long intervals he stirred in his chair, ponderously, like an inert, heavy animal, and now and then he emitted a short sound, like a grunted comment on some thought, which, by its biting suddenness, seemed to force an ejaculation out of him.

CHAPTER X

DOMINICK COMES HOME

Three days after the return of the Cannons, Dominick Ryan also came home. He had answered Berny's letter the day the Cannons left, a few hours after that interview with the Bonanza King, in which, driven to bay by the old man's questions, he had torn the veil from his married life.

After that there was a period of several hours when he sat in his room thinking over what had happened. It seemed to him that he had played a dastardly part. He saw himself a creature of monumental, gross selfishness, who had cajoled a young girl, in a moment of softness and sentiment, into an action which had done nothing but distress and humiliate her. He, who should have been the strong one, had been weak. It was he who should have seen how things were going; he, the married man, who had allowed himself to feel and to yield to a love that ought to have been hidden for ever in his own heart.

He felt that it would be a sort of expiation to go back to his wife. That was where he belonged. Rose must never again cross his path, have a place in his thoughts, or float, a soft beguiling image, in his memory. He had a wife. No matter what Berny was, she was the woman he had married. She had not deceived him. It was he who had done her a wrong, and he owed her a reparation.

In his raw state, his nerves still thrilling with the memory of that moment's embrace, he saw Berny from her own point of view. He lost the memory of the complacent mistress in the picture of the unloved wife, on whose side there was much to be said. Morbidity colored his vision and exaggerated his sense of culpability. If she had an ugly temper, had it not been excited, fed and aggravated by the treatment she had received from his family? If they had maintained a different attitude toward her, the poor girl might have been quite a pleasant, easy-going person. In all other ways she had been a good wife. Since their marriage, no other man had ever won a glance from her. She had often enough assured Dominick of that fact, and he, for his part, knew it to be true. She had struggled to keep a comfortable home on

their small income. If she was not congenial to him—if her companionship was growing daily more disagreeable—was it all her fault? He had known her well before he married her, six months of the closest intimacy had made him acquainted with every foible of her character. It was no story of a youth beguiled and deceived by a mature woman in the unequal duel of a drawing-room courtship.

Her letter intensified his condition of self-accusation, chafed and irritated his soreness of shame till it became a weight of guilt. It also stirred afresh the pity, which was the strongest feeling he had for her. It was the tenderest, the most womanly letter, Berny had ever written him. A note of real appeal sounded through it. She had humiliated herself, asked his pardon, besought of him to return. As he thought of it, the vision of her alone in the flat, bereft of friends, dully devoid of any occupation, scornful of her old companions, fawningly desirous of making new ones who refused to know her, smote him with an almost sickening sense of its pitifulness. He felt sorry for her not alone because of her position, but because of what she was, what her own disposition had made her. She would never change, her limitations were fixed. She would go on longing for the same flesh-pots to the end, believing that they represented the highest and best.

Berny had realized that her letter was a skilful and moving production, but she did not know that it was to gain a hundredfold in persuasive power by falling on a guilty conscience. It put an end to Dominick's revolt, it quenched the last sparks of the mutinous rage which had taken him to Antelope. That same afternoon in his frigid bedroom at the hotel, he answered it. His reply was short, only a few lines. In these he stated that he would be back on the following Saturday, the tenderness of his injured foot making an earlier move impossible.

The letter reached Berny Friday and threw her into a state of febrile excitement. Her deadly dread of Dominick's returning to his family had never quite died out. It kept recurring, sweeping in upon her in moods of depression, and making her feel chilled and frightened. Now she knew he was coming back to her, evidently not lovingly disposed—the letter was too terse and cold for that—but, at any rate, he was coming home. Once there, she would set all her wits to work, use every art of which she was mistress, to make him forget the quarrel and enter in upon a new era of sweet reasonableness and mutual consideration.

She set about this by cleaning the house and buying new curtains for the sitting-room. Such purifications and garnishments would have agreeably impressed her on a home-coming and she thought they would Dominick. In the past year she had become much more extravagant than she had been formerly, a characteristic which had arisen in her from a state of rasperd irritation against the restricted means to which Mrs. Ryan's rancor condemned her. She was quite heavily in debt to various tradespeople; and to dressmakers and milliners she owed sums that would have astounded her husband had he known of them. This did not prevent her from still further celebrating his return by ordering a new dress in which to greet him and a new hat to wear the first time they went out together. How she was to pay for these adornments, she did not know nor care. The occasion was so important that it excused any extravagance, and Berny, in whose pinched, dry nature love of dress was a predominant passion, was glad to have a reason for adding new glories to her wardrobe.

On the Saturday morning she went out betimes. Inquiry at the railway office told her that the train which connected with the branch line to Rocky Bar did not reach the city till six in the evening. She ordered a dinner of the choicest viands and spent part of the morning passing from stall to stall in the market on Powell Street spying about for dainties that might add a last elaborating touch to the lengthy menu. The afternoon was dedicated to the solemn rites of massaging, manicuring, and hair-waving at a beauty doctor's. On an ordinary occasion these unwonted exertions in the pursuit of good looks would have tired her, but to-day she was keyed to a pitch where she did not notice small outside discomforts.

Long before six she was dressed, and standing before the mirror in her room she laid on the last perfecting touches with a short stick of hard red substance and a circular piece of mossy-looking white stuff, which she rubbed with a rotary motion round and round her face. Her new dress of raspberry pink crape betrayed the hand of an expert in its gracefully-falling folds and the elegance with which it outlined her slim, long-waisted shape. Her artificially-reddened hair waved back from her forehead in glossy ripples; her face, all lines and hollows rubbed from it, looked fresh and youthful. With the subdued light falling on her through the silk and paper lamp shades, she looked a very pretty woman, the darkness of her long

brilliant eyes thrown into higher relief by the whiteness of her powdered face.

She was tremulously nervous. Every sound caused her to start and move to that part of the parlor whence she could look down the long passageway to the stair-head. Large bunches of greenery were massed here in the angles of the hall and stood in the corners of the sitting-room. Bowls filled with violets and roses were set on the table and mantelpiece, and the scent of these flowers, sweet and delicate, mingled with the crude, powerful perfume that the woman's draperies exhaled with every movement. At intervals she ran into her bedroom, seized the little, round, soft wad of white and rubbed it over her face with a quick concentric movement, drawing her upper lip down as she did so, which gave to her countenance with its anxious eyes an exceedingly comical expression.

It was nearly seven o'clock when the bell rang. With a last hasty look in the glass, she ran down the passageway to the stair-head. It was necessary to descend a few steps to a turn on the stairs from whence the lever that opened the door could be worked. As she stood on the small landing, thrown out in bright relief by a mass of dark leafage that stood in the angle of the wall, the door opened and Dominick entered. He looked up and saw her standing there, gaily dressed, a brilliant, animated figure, smiling down at him.

"Ah, Berny," he said in a quiet, unemotional voice, "is that you?"

It was certainly not an enthusiastic greeting. A sensitive woman would have been shriveled by it, but Berny was not sensitive. She had realized from the start that she would probably have to combat the lingering surliness left by the quarrel. As Dominick ascended, her air of smiling welcome was marked by a bland cheery unconsciousness of any past unpleasantness. She was not, however, as unconscious as she looked. She noted his heaviness of demeanor, the tired expression of his lifted face. He came up the stairs slowly, not yet being completely recovered, and it added to the suggestion of reluctance, of difficult and spiritless approach, that seemed to encompass him in an unseen yet distinctly-felt aura.

As he rose on a level with her, she stretched out her hands and, laying them on his shoulders, drew him toward her and kissed him. The coldness of his cheek, damp with the foggy night air, chilled the caress and she drew back

from him, not so securely confident in her debonair, smiling assurance. He patted her lightly on the shoulder by way of greeting and said,

“How are you? All right?”

“Oh, I’m all right,” she answered with brisk, determined sprightliness. “You’re the one to ask about. You walk stiff, still. How are your feet?”

She was glad to turn her eyes away from his face. It looked very tired, and the slight smile with which he had greeted her stayed only on his lips and did not extend to his fatigued eyes. He was evidently angry still, angry and unforgiving, and that he should be so, when she was so anxious to forget the ugly episode of the quarrel and be gay and friendly again, dashed her spirits and made her feel unsure of herself and upset. She was determined, however, to show him that she had forgotten all about it, and as he turned the angle of the stairway she thrust her hand inside his arm and walked up beside him. They might have been a happy married couple, reunited after an absence, slowly coming up the stairs together arm in arm.

A few minutes later they were seated opposite each other at dinner. The little table glowed and gleamed, all Berny’s bravery of silver and glass mustered for its adornment. The choice and delicate dinner began with a soup that Dominick especially liked, a fact which Berny hoped he would notice and mention. She was one of those women who have an unfailing memory for what people like to eat; a single expression of preference would remain in her mind for years. Dominick and she had not lived together for a month before she knew everything in the way of food he liked or disliked. When she was annoyed with him, or especially bitter against his mother, she would order nothing but dishes that he did not care for, and when she was in a more friendly mood, as to-night, she would take pains and time to arrange a menu composed of those he preferred. He usually did not notice these rewards and punishments, but Berny always thought he did and was “too stubborn,” as she expressed it to herself, to show that he was affected by them.

She observed to-night that he neither remarked, nor seemed to relish his food, but she made no comment, talking on in a breathless, lively way, asking questions of his trip, his accident, and the condition of his feet, as though there were no mortifying recollections connected with the cause of his sudden departure. Her only indication of embarrassment was a tendency

to avoid anything like a moment of silence and to fly from one subject to another. Dominick answered her questions and told her of his wanderings with a slow, careful exactness. Save in the freezing of his feet, which matter he treated more lightly than it deserved, he was open with her in recounting the small happenings of what he called "his holiday," from the time of his walk from Rocky Bar to the day of his departure from Antelope.

They had progressed through the fish to the entrée when her questions passed from his personal wanderings and adventures to his associates. She had been very anxious to get to this point, as she wanted to know what degree of intimacy he had reached with the Bonanza King. Several times already she had tried to divert the conversation toward that subject, but it had been deflected by the young man, who seemed to find less personal topics more to his taste. Now she was advancing openly upon it, inquiring about the snow-bound group at Perley's, and awarding to any but the august name for which her ears were pricked a perfunctory attention. It was part of the natural perversity of man that Dominick should shy from it and expend valuable time on descriptions of the other prisoners.

"There was an actor there," he said, "snowed in on his way to Sacramento, a queer-looking chap, but not bad."

"An actor?" said Berny, trying to look interested. "What did he act?"

"Melodrama, I think. He told me he played all through the northwest and east as far as Denver. The poor chap was caught up there and was afraid he was going to lose a Sacramento engagement that I guess meant a good deal to him. He was quite interesting, been in the Klondike in the first rush and had some queer stories about the early days up there."

Berny's indifferent glance became bright and fixed under the steady effect of sudden interest.

"Been in the Klondike?" she repeated. "What was his name?"

"Buford, James Defay Buford. He'd been an actor at the opera house at Dawson."

"Buford," said Berny, turning to place a helping of pease on the plate the Chinaman held toward her. "I never heard of him. I thought perhaps it might have been some actor I'd seen play. I'd like to know an actor in private life. They must be so different."

She ladled a second spoonful of pease on to her own plate, and as she began to eat them, said,

“It must have been interesting having the Cannons up there. When I read in the paper that they were up at Antelope too, I was awfully glad because I thought it would be such a good thing for you to get to know the old man well, as you would, snowed in that way together.”

“I knew him before. My father and mother have been friends of his for years.”

“I know that. You’ve often told me. But that’s a different thing. I thought if he got to know you intimately and liked you, as he probably would”—she glanced at him with a coquettish smile, but his face was bent over his plate—“why, then, something might come of it, something in a business way.” She again looked at him, quickly, with sidelong investigation, to see how he took the remark. She did not want to irritate him by alluding to his small means, anyway on this night of reconciliation.

“It would be so useful for you to get solid with a man like Bill Cannon,” she concluded with something of timidity in her manner.

Despite her caution, Dominick seemed annoyed. He frowned and gave his head an impatient jerk.

“Oh, there was nothing of that kind,” he said hurriedly. “We were just snowed in at the same hotel. There was no question of intimacy or friendship about it, any more than there was between Judge Washburne and me, or even the actor.”

Berny was exceedingly disappointed. Had the occasion been a less momentous one she would have expressed herself freely. In her mind she thought it was “just like Dominick” to have such an opportunity and let it go. A slight color deepened the artificial rose of her cheeks and for a moment she had to exert some control to maintain the silence that was wisdom. She picked daintily at her food while she wrestled with her irritation. Dominick showed no desire to resume the conversation, and a silence of some minutes’ duration rested over them, until she broke it by saying with a resolute cheerfulness of tone,

“Rose Cannon was there too, the paper said. I suppose you got to know her quite well?”

“I don’t know. I saw a good deal of her. There was only one sitting-room and we all sat there. She was there with the others.”

“What’s she like?” said Berny, her curiosity on the subject of this spoiled child of fortune overcoming her recent annoyance.

“You’ve seen her,” he answered, “you know what she looks like.”

“I’ve never seen her to know who she was. I suppose I’ve passed her on the streets and at the theaters. Is she cordial and pleasant, or does she give herself airs because she’s Bill Cannon’s daughter?”

Dominick moved his feet under the table. It was difficult for him to answer Berny’s questions politely.

“She doesn’t give herself the least airs. She’s perfectly simple and natural and kind.”

“That’s just what I’ve heard,” his wife said, giving her head an agreeing wag. “They say she’s just as easy and unassuming as can be. Did you think she was pretty when you saw her close to?”

“Really, Berny, I don’t know,” answered the victim in a tone of goaded patience. “She looks just the same close to as she does at a distance. I don’t notice people’s looks much. Yes, I suppose she’s pretty.”

“She has blonde hair,” said Berny, leaning forward over her plate in the eagerness of her interest. “Did it look to you as if it was bleached?”

He raised his eyes, and his wife encountered an unexpected look of anger in them. She shrank a little, being totally unprepared for it.

“How should I know whether her hair was bleached or not?” he said sharply. “That’s a very silly question.”

Berny was quite taken aback.

“I don’t see that it is,” she said with unusual and somewhat stammering mildness. “Most blonde-haired women, even if they haven’t bleached their hair, have had it ‘restored.’”

Dominick did not answer her. The servant presented a dish at his elbow and he motioned it away with an impatient gesture.

Berny, who was not looking at him, went on.

“What kind of clothes did she wear? They say she’s an elegant dresser, gets almost everything from Paris, even her underwear. I suppose she didn’t have her best things up there. But she must have had something, because the papers said they’d gone prepared for a two weeks’ trip.”

“I never noticed anything she wore.”

“Well, isn’t that just like you, Dominick Ryan!” exclaimed his wife, unable, at this unmerited disappointment, to refrain from some expression of her feelings. “And you might know I’d be anxious to hear what she had on.”

“I’m very sorry, but I haven’t an idea about any of her clothes. I think they were always dark, mostly black or brown.”

“Did you notice,” almost pleadingly, “what she wore when she went out? Mrs. Whiting, the forelady at Hazel’s millinery, says she imported a set of sables, muff, wrap and hat, for her this autumn. Hazel says it was just the finest thing of its kind you ever laid your eyes on. Did she have them up there?”

“I couldn’t possibly tell you. I don’t know what sables are. I saw her once with a fur cap on, but I think it belonged to Willoughby, an Englishman who was staying there, and used to have his cap hanging on the pegs in the hall. It’s quite useless asking me these questions. I don’t know anything about the subject. Did you wind the clock while I was away?”

He looked at the clock, a possession of his own, given him in the days when his mother and sister delighted to ornament his rooms with costly gifts and in which he had never before evinced the slightest interest.

“Of course, I wound it,” Berny said with an air of hurt protest. “Haven’t I wound it regularly for nearly three years?”

This brought the subject of Rose Cannon to an end and she was not alluded to again during the dinner. The conversation reverted to such happenings in the city as Berny thought might interest her husband, and it seemed to her that he was more pleased to sit and listen to her chatter of her sisters, the bank, the theaters, and the shops, than to dilate any further on his adventures in the snow-bound Sierra.

When the dinner was over, they returned to the front of the flat, where next to the parlor there was a tiny hall-room fitted up as a smoking-room and

den. It was merely a continuation of the hall, and “the cozy corner” which Berny had had a Polk Street upholsterer construct in it, occupied most of the available space, and crowded such visitors as entered it into the corners. It had been Berny’s idea to have this room “lined with books” as she expressed it, but their joint possessions in this line consisting of some twenty-five volumes, and the fact that the contracted space made it impossible to accommodate both the books and the cozy corner, Berny had decided in favor of the latter. She now seated herself on the divan that formed the integral part of this construction, and, piling the pillows behind her, leaned luxuriously back under the canopy of variegated stuffs which was supported by two formidable-looking lances.

Dominick sat in his easy chair. He always smoked in this room and read the papers, and presently he picked them up from the table and began to look them over. The conversation languished, became spasmodic, and finally died away. Berny, leaning back on the cushions, tried several times to revive it, but her husband from among the spread sheets of the evening press answered her with the inarticulate sounds of mental preoccupation, and sometimes with no sound at all, till she abandoned the attempt and leaned back under the canopy in a silence that was not by any means the somnolent quietude of after-dinner torpor.

The clock hands were pointing to half-past nine when a ring at the bell was followed by the appearance of the Chinaman at the door, stating that the expressman had come with Mr. Ryan’s valises. Dominick threw down his papers and left the room. As Berny sat silent, she could hear the expressman’s gruff deep voice in the hall and the thuds of the valises as he thumped them down at the stair-head. Dominick answered him and there were a few more remarks, followed by the retreating sound of the man’s heavy feet on the stairs and the bang of the hall door. She sat looking at the clock, waiting for her husband to return, and then as he did not come and the hall seemed singularly quiet she leaned forward and sent an exploring glance down its dim length. Dominick was not there, but a square of light fell out from the open doorway of his room.

“Dominick,” she called, “what are you doing?”

He came to the door of the room in his shirt-sleeves, a tall figure looking lean and powerful in this closer-fitting and lighter garb.

“I’m unpacking my things, and then I’m going to bed.”

“Oh!” she answered with a falling inflection, leaning forward, with her elbows planted on her knees, craning her neck to see more plainly down the narrow passageway. “It’s only half-past nine; why do you want to go to bed so early?”

“I’m tired, and it will take me some time to get these things put away.”

“Can I help you?” she asked without moving.

“No, thanks. There’s nothing much to bother about. Good night, Berny,” and he stepped back into the room and shut the door.

Berny sat as he had left her for a space, and then drew back upon the divan and leaned against the mound of pillows. She made the movement charily and slowly, her face set in a rigidity of thought to which her body seemed fixed and obedient. She sat thus for an hour without moving, her eyes staring before her, two straight lines folded in the skin between her brows.

So he was still angry, angry and unforgiving. That was the way she read his behavior. The coldness that he exhaled—that penetrated even her unsensitive outer shell—she took to be the coldness of unappeased indignation. He had never before been just like this. There was a something of acquired forbearance and patience about him—a cultivated thing, not a spontaneous outward indication of an inner condition of being—which was new to her observation. He was not sulky or cross; he was simply withdrawn from her and trying to hide it under a manner of careful, guarded civility. It was different from any state she had yet seen him in, but it never crossed her mind that it might be caused by the influence of another woman.

He was still angry—that was what Berny thought; and sitting on the divan under the canopy with its fiercely-poised lances she meditated on the subject. His winning back was far from accomplished. He was not as “easy” as she had always thought. A feeling of respect for him entered into her musings, a feeling that was novel, for in her regard for her husband there had previously been a careless, slighting tolerance which was not far removed from contempt. But if he had pride enough to keep her thus coldly at arm’s length, to withstand her attempts at forgiveness and reconciliation, he was more of a man than she thought, and she had a harder task to handle

than she had guessed. She did not melt into anything like self-pity at the futility of her efforts, which, had Dominick known of them, would have seemed to him extremely pathetic. That they had not succeeded gave her a new impetus of force and purpose, made her think, and scheme with a hard, cool resolution. To “make up” and gain ascendancy over Dominick, independent and proudly indifferent, was much more worth while than to bully Dominick, patient, enduring, and ruled by a sense of duty.

CHAPTER XI

THE GODS IN THE MACHINE

On the second Sunday after their return from Antelope, Bill Cannon resolved to dedicate the afternoon to paying calls. This, at least, was what he told his daughter at luncheon as he, she, and Gene sat over the end of the meal. To pay calls was not one of the Bonanza King's customs, and in answer to Rose's query as to whom he was going to honor thus, he responded that he thought he'd "start in with Delia Ryan."

Rose made no comment on this intelligence. The sharp glance he cast at her discovered no suggestion of consciousness in the peach-like placidity of her face. It gratified him to see her thus unsuspecting, and in the mellowing warmth of his satisfaction he turned and addressed a polite query to Gene as to how he intended spending the afternoon. Gene and Rose, it appeared, were going to the park to hear the band. Gene loved a good band, and the one that played in the park Sunday afternoons was especially good. The Sunday before, Gene had heard it play *Poet and Peasant* and the *Overture of William Tell*, and it was great! That was one of the worst things about living on a ranch, Gene complained, you didn't have any music except at the men's house at night when one of the Mexicans played on an accordion.

The old man, with his elbow on the table, and a short, blunt-fingered hand stroking his beard, looked at his son with narrowed eyes full of veiled amusement. When he did not find Gene disagreeably aggravating as his only failure, he could, as it were, stand away from him and realize how humorous he was if you took him in a certain way.

"What's the Mexican play?" he growled without removing his hand.

"*La Paloma*," answered Gene, pleased to be questioned thus amicably by his autocratic sire, "generally *La Paloma*, but he *can* play *The Heart Bowed Down* and the Toreador song from *Carmen*. I want him to learn the *Miserere* from *Trovatore*. It's nice to sit on the porch after dinner and listen while you smoke."

“Sort of Court Minstrel,” said his father, thumping down his napkin with his hand spread flat on it. “Don Eugenio Cannon, with his minstrel playing to him in the gloaming! It’s very picturesque. Did you ever think of having a Court Fool too, or perhaps you don’t feel as if you needed one?”

He arose from his chair before Gene, who never quite understood the somewhat ferocious humor of his parent, had time to reply.

“Well, so long,” said the old man; “be good children and don’t get into mischief, and Rose, see that your brother doesn’t get lost or so carried away by the *Poet and the Peasant* that he forgets the dinner hour. *Adios, girlye.*”

A half-hour later he walked down the flight of marble steps that led in dignified sweep from the front door to the street. It was a wonderful day and for a moment he paused, looking with observing eyes at the prospect of hill and bay which seemed to glitter in the extreme clearness of the atmosphere. Like all Californians he had a strong, natural appreciation of scenic and climatic beauty. Preoccupied with thoughts and schemes which were anything but uplifting, he yet was sensitively responsive to the splendors of the view before him, to the unclouded, pure blue of the vault above, to the balmy softness of the air against his face. Some one had once asked him why he did not live in Paris as the ideal home of the man of great wealth and small scruples. His answer had been that he preferred San Francisco because there were more fine days in the year there than anywhere else he knew of.

Now he paused, sniffing the air with distended nostril and inhaling it in deep, grateful inspirations. His eye moved slowly over the noble prospect, noted the deep sapphire tint of the bay, the horizon, violet dark against a pale sky, and the gem-like blues and amethysts of the distant hills. He turned his glance in the other direction and looked down the gray expanse of the street, the wide, clear, stately street, with its air of clean spaciousness, sun-bathed, silent, almost empty, in the calm quietude of the Sabbath afternoon. The bustling thoroughfares of greater cities, with their dark, sordid crowds, their unlovely, vulgar hurry, their distracting noise, were offensive to him. The wonder crossed his mind, as it had done before, how men who could escape from such surroundings chose to remain in them.

He walked forward slowly, a thick-set, powerful figure, his frock-coat buttoned tight about the barrel-like roundness of his torso, a soft, black felt

hat pulled well down on his head. His feet were broad and blunt like his hands, and in their square-toed shoes he planted them firmly on the pavement with a tread of solid, deliberate authority. His forward progress had something in it of an invincible, resistless march. He was thinking deeply as he walked, arranging and planning, and there was nothing in his figure, or movements, or the expression of his face, which suggested the sauntering aimlessness of an afternoon stroll.

When he turned into Van Ness Avenue the Ryan house was one block beyond him, a conglomerate white mass, like a crumbling wedding cake slowly settling on a green lawn. He surveyed it as he approached, noting its ugliness with a musing satisfaction. Its size and the bright summery perfection of surrounding grass and flower beds lent it impressiveness and redeemed it from the position of a colossal blight on the prospect to which architect and builder had done their best to relegate it. Prosperity, a complacent, overwhelming prosperity, was suggested not only by its bulk but by the state of studied finish and neatness that marked mansion and grounds. There did not seem to be a wilting flower bed or withered leaf left on a single stalk in the garden borders. Every window-pane gleamed like a mirror innocent of dust or blemishing spot. The marble steps up which Cannon mounted were as snowily unsullied as though no foot had passed over them since their last ablution.

The door was opened by a Chinaman, who, taking the visitor's card, left him standing in the hall, and, deaf to his queries as to where he should go, serenely mounted the stairs. Cannon hesitated a moment, then hearing a sound of voices to his right, entered the anteroom that gave on that suite of apartments into which Dominick had walked on the night of the ball. They were softly lit by the afternoon sun filtering through thin draperies, and extended in pale, gilt-touched vista to the shining emptiness of the ball-room. The old man was advancing toward the voices when he suddenly saw whence they proceeded, and stopped. In the room just beyond him Cornelia Ryan and a young man were sitting on a small, empire sofa, their figures thrown out in high relief against the background of silk-covered wall. Cornelia's red head was in close proximity to that of her companion, which the intruder saw to be clothed with a thatch of sleek black hair, and which he recognized as appertaining to a young man whose father had once been shift boss on the Rey del Monte, and who bore the patronymic of Duffy.

Cornelia and Jack Duffy had the appearance of being completely engrossed in each other's society. In his moment of unobserved survey, Cannon had time to note the young woman's air of bashful, pleased embarrassment and the gentleman's expression of that tense, unsmiling earnestness which attends the delivery of sentimental passages. Cornelia was looking down, and her flaming hair and the rosy tones of her face, shading from the faintest of pearly pinks to deepening degrees of coral, were luminously vivid against the flat surface of cream-colored wall behind her, and beside the black poll and thin, dark cheek of her companion. That something very tender was afoot was quickly seen by the visitor, who softly withdrew, stepping gingerly over the fur rugs, and gaining the entrance to the hall with a sensation of flurried alarm.

An open door just opposite offered a refuge, and, passing through it with a forward questing glance alert for other occupants who might resent intrusion, the old man entered a small reception-room lit by the glow of a hard coal fire. The room was different in furnishings and style from those he had left. It had the austere bleakness of aspect resultant from a combination of bare white walls and large pieces of furniture of a black wood upon which gold lines were traced in ornamental squares. An old-fashioned carpet was on the floor, and several tufted arm-chairs, begirt with dangling fringes, were drawn up sociably before the fire. This burned cheerily, a red focus of heat barred by the stripes of a grate, and surmounted by a chastely severe white mantelpiece. He had been in the room often before and knew it for Mrs. Ryan's own particular sanctum. When a celebrated decorator had been sent out from New York to furnish the lower floor of the house, she had insisted on retaining in this apartment the pieces of furniture and the works of art which she approved, and which the decorator wished to banish to the garret. Mrs. Ryan had her way as she always did, and the first fine "soote" of furniture which she and Con had bought in the days of their early affluence, and various oil paintings also collected in the same era of their evolution, went to the decking of the room she used for her own and oftenest sat in.

Cannon approached the fire, and stood there looking up at the life-size portrait in oils of the late Cornelius Ryan, which hung over the chimneypiece. The artist had portrayed him as a thickly-whiskered man with the complexion of a healthy infant and eyes of baby blue. A watch

chain, given him by his colleagues in the old days at Shasta, and formed of squares of quartz set in native gold, was painted with a finished carefulness which had pleased Mrs. Ryan even more than the likeness had done. In showing the picture, she was wont to say proudly, "Just look at the watch chain! Seems as if you could almost hear the ticking of the watch."

Cannon was speculating as to the merits of the likeness when he heard the silken rustling of skirts, and turned to greet his old friend. She came in smiling, with extended hand, richly clad, the gleam of a fastening jewel at her neck. Her hair was dressed with a shining, smooth elaboration, drawn up tightly at the sides and arranged over her forehead in careful curls. As she and her visitor exchanged the first sentences of greeting he noticed that she looked much older and more worn than she had done the last time he had seen her, but her face was as full of pugnacious force as ever. While Delia Ryan's body lived her spirit would hold its dominion. She had ruled all her life and would do so to the end.

They sat down on either side of the fire and the old man said,

"I don't know whether I ought to be in here. The Chinaman left me to my fate, and I had to nose about myself and find out where I belonged."

"Oh, that's Lee," she answered with a short laugh. "He waits on the door every other Sunday. We've had him ten years and no one's ever been able to make him show people into the parlor. He thinks it better to leave them standing in the hall till one of us sees the card. Then he'll go down and tell them as sociably as you please 'to go right in and sit down.' I asked him why he didn't do it at first, and he said 'they might steal something.'"

Cannon looked into the fire with an amused eye.

"I guess he thought I was after the spoons. It's a dangerous habit, for I took the first turning to the right and butted into Cornelia and a young man who gave me to understand I'd come the wrong way around."

"What did they say?" said the mother, her face stiffening with sudden disapproving surprise.

"They didn't say anything. That was just it. They didn't even see me. But they certainly led me to believe that I'd got somewhere where I wasn't wanted. I may not be smart, but a hint doesn't have to be much harder than the kick of a mule for me to see it."

Mrs. Ryan looked at him consideringly.

“Yes,” she said, nodding, “it’s a case, I guess.”

“It ought to be satisfactory,” he answered. “Pat Duffy, the father of those boys, was one of the finest fellers I ever knew. He was shift boss on the Rey del Monte in seventy-one when I was the superintendent. He got out of Virginia with his pile, didn’t lose it like the others. He had an easy three million when he came down here and bought the Bristed house on Pine Street. And Jack’s the best of his children. Maggie, who married the English baronet, was a nice sort of girl, but she’s never come back, and Terry’s smart enough, but not the kind you can bank on. Jack’s a good, straight boy. Cornelia couldn’t do better.”

“That’s what I think,” said the mother, who, however, looked grave and worried. “Cornelia’s thirty. It’s time for her to settle, and she’ll make a good wife. They’ll live here, too. There’ll be no kicking up of their heels and going off to Europe or New York and thinking themselves too good to come back to California, like Maggie Duffy and her baronet. I want them here. I want to see some grandchildren round this house before I die. I want to know where Con’s money is going to.”

She sighed, and it was obvious that her heart was heavy.

“Yes,” she said, “it’s a good marriage and I’m pleased at it. Jack’s a Roman Catholic but you can’t have everything down here in this world.”

The Ryans were Protestants, almost the only prominent Irish-American family in San Francisco which belonged to that church. Cornelius Ryan had been a North-country man, and went out with the Orange men when they paraded. He had been firm in his faith and so had his wife, and with the Hibernian’s violent devotion to creed they had made public their antipathy to the Church of Rome and their hopes that their children would not make alliances with its members.

“Oh well,” said Cannon with a shrug of vague tolerance, “a man’s beliefs don’t matter. With a woman it’s a different thing. She brings up the children and takes her religion hard. Jack won’t interfere with Cornelia that way.”

“Perhaps not,” said the mother. There was a slight pause and then she said with a sigh,

“Well, thank God, one of my children’s going to marry as I want.”

She was gazing into the fire and did not notice the quick look, sly and piercing, that her companion shot at her. The conversation had suddenly, without any effort of his, fallen upon the subject to which he had intended directing it.

“Yes,” he said, looking away from her, “you’ve had one disappointment. That’s enough.”

“Disappointment!” she echoed in a loud voice. “Disappointment? I’ve lost my son; lost him as if he was dead—worse than if he was dead, for then I’d know he was happy and safe somewhere.”

It was a cry of pain, Rachel mourning for her child. The note of feeling in it checked the remark on Cannon’s lips. He understood what her suffering was and respected it.

“Why, Bill Cannon,” she went on, turning the perturbed fierceness of her face on him, “how often do you think I see my boy? What ties do you think he has with his home? He came up here after he’d got back from Antelope, but before that I’d only seen him once in six weeks.”

“That’s pretty hard,” he commented, his elbow on the arm of the chair, his chin sunk in the cup of his up-curved hand. “That’s pretty tough. I didn’t know it was as bad as that.”

“Nobody knows anything about him. He won’t let them. He won’t let me. He’s proud, and trying to hide it all. That’s the reason he comes up here so seldom. He knows I can see into him, see through him, clear through him, and he don’t want me to see how miserable he is.”

“Oh!” said the old man, moving slightly and raising his eyes to look at her. The interjection was full of significance, pregnant with understanding, appreciation and enlightenment. He was surprised himself. He had thought, and had understood from Dominick, that no one, especially no one of his own people, knew of the young man’s domestic infelicities. Neither of them was shrewd enough to realize that the mother would guess, would know by instinct.

“And what do you suppose he came up for that once?” pursued Mrs. Ryan. “You could guess a lot of times but you’d never strike it. He came up here

the night of my ball to ask me to give him an invitation for his wife!”

She stared at her visitor with her face set in a stony hardness, a hardness reminiscent of that which had marked it when Dominick had asked for the invitation. Cannon saw it and checked the remark that rose to his lips. He was going to say “Why didn’t you give it to him?” and he saw that it was too light a comment for what had been a tragic occasion. All he did was to utter a grunt that might have meant anything and was consequently safe.

“That’s what his marriage has done for him, and that’s the state that woman has ground him down to. She’d worked on him till she’d got him to come up here and ask for it a few minutes before the people began to arrive! That’s what she made him do.”

“And you wouldn’t give it?” he inquired mildly, inwardly surprised, as he had been often before, at the rancor displayed by women in their quarrels.

“Give it?” she exclaimed, “well, I guess not. It would have been my surrender. I’d have thrown up the fight for ever when I did that.” And then as if she had read his thoughts: “It’s not natural meanness either. There’s only one hope for me—for me and for Dominick, too. Divorce.”

He did not move his chin from its resting-place in his up-curved hand, but made a slight assenting motion with his head, and said,

“I suppose that’s the only thing.”

“That’s been my hope since the day when I first saw her. I didn’t know then she’d been anything to Dominick before the marriage, but I knew the first look I had at her what she was. That long, mean nose and those sly eyes, and seven years older than the boy if she was a day. You didn’t have to tell me any more. I saw then just like a flash in the dark what my son had let himself in for. And then, not a month after, I heard the rest about her, and I knew that Dominick had started in to ruin his life about the best way he knew how.”

Cannon gave another grunt, and this time it contained a recognizable note of sympathy. She went on, absorbed in her recital, anxious to pour out her griefs, now that she had begun.

“Right there from the start I thought of divorce. I knew it was the only way out and was bound to come in time. The woman had married Dominick for

money and position. I knew that, saw it in her face along with other things. There was no love in that face, just calculation, hard and sharp as a meat ax. I shut down on the money right there and then. Dominick had three thousand a year, so I knew he couldn't starve, but three thousand a year wasn't what she'd married him for."

"She's got along on it for over two years."

"That's it. She's beaten me so far. I'm the keeper of Con Ryan's fortune and I just closed my hand on it and said to her in so many words, 'Not a cent of this for you.' I thought she'd tire of struggling along in a flat with one Chinaman and not a soul to come near her. But she's stood it and she's going to go on standing it. Where she's concerned, I did something the smartest men and women sometimes do—underrated the brains of my enemy."

"She's pretty smart, I guess," said Cannon, raising a gravely-commenting eye to his companion's face.

"That's what she is,—smart and long-headed. She's more far-sighted than women of her kind usually are and she's got her eye on the future. She's not going to give us a chance for divorce. She's not going to make any breaks or mistakes. There's not a more respectable woman in San Francisco. She doesn't go with any one but her husband and her own sisters, two decent women that you can't believe have the same blood in them. She's the quietest, most domestic kind of a wife. It don't matter, and nobody knows, that she's making her husband the most miserable man in the country. That doesn't cut any ice. What does is that there's no ground for divorce against her. If she had the kind of husband that wouldn't put up with anything from a woman, all he could do would be to leave her and she'd go round then getting everybody's sympathies as a virtuous, deserted wife."

The old man gave his head an appreciative jerk, and murmured,

"A pretty smart woman, all right."

"She's all that—that and more. It's the future that she's banking on. I'm nearly seventy years of age, Bill Cannon, and this has broken me up more than anything that's gone before. I'm not the woman I was before my boy married. And what's going to happen when I die? I've only got two living children. Outside them there's nobody but some distant relations that Con

made settlements on before he died. If I left all I've got to Cornelia, or divided it up between Cornelia and charity, cutting off my son because he'd made a marriage I didn't like, would such a will as that stand? Why had I left nothing to my only son? Because he'd married a woman I didn't think good enough? And what was there against her? She'd been a typewriter and her husband's mistress for six months before he married her. The mistress part of it had been condoned by marriage and good conduct—and after all, how many families in San Francisco and other places were founded on just those beginnings? As for her being a typewriter, Delia Ryan herself had been a washerwoman, washed for the miners with these hands;”—she held out her blunt, beringed hands with one of those dramatic gestures natural to the Irish—“when Con was working underground with his pick I was at the wash-tub, and I made money that way for him to run the mine. Where's the California jury that would hesitate to award Dominick, and through him, his wife her part of the fortune that Con and I made?”

“Well, that's all possible,” Cannon said slowly, “but it's so far off. It's all surmise. You may live twenty years yet. I fancy she'd find a twenty-years' wait under the present conditions rather wearying.”

The old woman shook her head, looking very sad.

“I'm not the woman I was,” she repeated, “this last thing's broken me more than anything that went before. I lost three children by death, and it wasn't as hard as losing my youngest boy the way I have.”

“Have you any idea whether Dominick has ever thought of divorce?” he asked.

“I've the clearest kind of an idea that he hasn't. You don't know Dominick. He's the best boy in the world. He'll blame himself for everything that's gone wrong, not that woman. She's smart enough to let him, too. And suppose he was a different kind and did think of it? That's all the good it would do him. Men don't sue women for divorce except under the greatest provocation, and Dominick's got no provocation at all. My hopes were that the woman herself would sue—that we'd freeze her out with small means and cold shoulders—and you see that's just what she's determined not to do!”

Cannon dropped his supporting hand on the chair-arm and began to caress gently a large tassel that hung there.

“She could be approached in another way,” he said with a suggestion of pondering deliberation.

“What way?”

“You say she married Dominick for money. Have you never thought of buying her off?”

He looked at Mrs. Ryan and met her eyes staring anxiously and, in a sort of way, shyly into his.

“Yes,” she said in a low voice, “I have.”

“Have you tried it?”

“No,—I—I—I don’t think I dared,” she said almost desperately. “It was my last trump.”

He realized, and, though he was unmoved by it, felt the pathos of this admission from the proud and combative woman who had so long and so successfully domineered over her world.

“I suppose it *is* a sort of death-bed remedy,” he said, “but it seems to me it’s about time to try it. Your idea that she’s going to wait till you die and then claim part of the estate as Dominick’s wife is all very well, but she’s not the kind of woman to be willing to wait patiently through the rolling years on three thousand dollars per annum. She’s a good bit older than he is and it isn’t making her any happier to see her best days passing with nothing doing. I should think you stood a pretty good chance of getting her to listen to reason.”

“Offering her a sum down to leave him?” she said, looking at the fire, her brows knit.

“Exactly. Offer her a good sum on the stipulation that she leaves him and goes away to New York or Europe. Then in the course of time she can write him asking him to grant her a divorce on some such technical grounds as desertion, or incompatibility, or anything else that’s respectable. He’ll have to give it to her. He can’t do anything else. And there you are!”

“What if she refuses?” she said in a low voice, and he saw she was afraid of this refusal which would shatter her last hope.

“Raise your offer,” he answered briskly. “She probably will refuse the first time.”

She pondered, eying the fire with heavy immobility.

“Yes,” she said, nodding. “It sounds reasonable. It’s about the only thing left.”

“If I can be of any assistance to you,” he said, “you just call on me. I’m willing to help in this thing all I can. It goes against me to see Dominick caught in a trap this way just at the beginning of his life.”

“A boy,” said his mother, “that would have made some good girl so happy.”

Cannon rose from his chair.

“That’s just it!” he said, “and there are not so many of ’em round that we can afford to lose one of the best. I’ve always liked Dominick and getting to know him so well up at Antelope I grew downright fond of him. He’s a fine boy.”

He smiled at her with his most genial air, beaming with disinterested affection for Dominick and the desire to be helpful in a grievous strait. Mrs. Ryan looked brighter and more hopeful than she had done at the beginning of the interview.

“It’s very good of you,” she said, “to come and listen to an old woman’s complaints. But as we get on, we seem to take them harder. And you know what my boy was to me?”

“About the same thing that my girl is to me,” Cannon answered as he turned away to look on the table for his hat.

There was a little more talk, and then the set phrases of farewell brought the interview to a close. Though momentous, it had not lasted long. As he left the room, Cannon heard the single note of half-past three chime from the clock on the mantelpiece.

Outside he stood for a moment on the top of the marble steps, looking downward with absent eyes. He was completely engrossed with the just-

ended conversation, parts of which repeated themselves in his mind as he stared unseeingly down the wide, unencumbered vista of the street.

Carriages flashed past through strips of sunshine; automobiles whirled by, leaving dust and gasoline in their wake. On the sidewalks there were many foot passengers: lazily sauntering couples, lovers, family parties, and little groups bound for the cars which would whisk them over the dunes to the park. As he slowly began to descend, one of these groups, formed of three women, a man, and a child, approached the bottom of the steps. They were walking down the avenue in a close, talkative bunch. The descending magnate was apprised of their proximity by the high, cackling sound of the women's voices and an aura of perfume which extended from them into the surrounding ether. He paid no attention to them, his eye, with its look of inward brooding, passing indifferently over the faces turned eagerly toward him.

They were not so unmoved. Their glances were trained full on him, their eyes wide in the unblinking intensity of their scrutiny. Even the child, who was skipping along beside the eldest of the women, inspected him with solemn care. Brushing by in their gay Sunday raiment they drew together to discuss him, their heads in a cluster, their voices lowered. He was so used to being the object of such interest that he did not bother to look at them, and was therefore unaware that one of the women, quite pretty, with reddish hair and dark eyes, had turned as she moved away and surveyed him over her shoulder.

CHAPTER XII

BERNY MAKES A DISCOVERY

It was near eleven o'clock on that same Sunday morning, when Berny, wrapped and heavy-eyed, emerged from her room. She shuffled down the passage to the dining-room, sending her voice before her in a shrill summons to the Chinaman. The morning papers were scattered over the table as Dominick had left them and she gathered them up, sitting sideways in her chair and running her eye down their columns, while the servant set out her breakfast. She was still sleepy, and frequent yawns interrupted her perusal of the lines of print which interested her above all written matter. A kimono clothed her slim form and from beneath its hem her foot protruded, thrust bare into a furred slipper. She folded the paper over to bring the society column into a prominence easy of access, and, propping it up against a bowl of fruit, read as she ate her breakfast.

Toward the end of the meal she inquired of the servant at what time her husband had gone out, and received the reply that Mr. Ryan had had his breakfast and left the flat two hours earlier. There was nothing disconcerting or unusual about this, as Dominick always went for a walk on fine Sunday mornings, but her mind was far from easy and she immediately fell to wondering why he had departed so early, and the slight ferment of disquietude that was always with her stirred again and made her forget the society column and let her Spanish omelet grow cold.

There was something strange about Dominick since he had come back, something that intrigued her, that she could not satisfactorily explain. She assured herself that he was still angry, but in the deeper places of her understanding the voice that whispers the truth and will not be gainsaid told her it was not that. Neither was it exactly antagonism. In a way he had been studiously kind and polite to her, a sort of consciously-guarded politeness, such as one might practise to a guest with whom one was intimate without being friendly. She tried to explain to herself just what this change was, and when it came to putting the matter in words she could not find the right ones. It was a coldness, a coldness that was not harsh and did not express

itself in actions or phrases. It went deeper; it was exhaled from the inner places of his being.

Sometimes as she talked to him she would meet his eyes fixed on her with a deep, vacant glance, which she suddenly realized was unseeing and unheeding. In the evening as he sat reading in the cramped confines of the den she surreptitiously watched him and saw that a moment often came when he dropped his book, and with his long body limp in the arm-chair, his chin sunk on his breast, would sit with a brooding gaze fixed on nothing. Once, as he was dreaming this way, she said suddenly,

“What are you thinking of, Dominick? Antelope?”

He started and turned upon her a face that had reddened consciously.

“Why should I think of Antelope?” he said, and she was aware that her remark had startled him and made him uncomfortable.

“For no particular reason,” she answered lightly; “you just looked as if you were thinking of something a long way off.”

She tried to reassure herself that it all rose from the quarrel. To believe that comforted her and gave her confidence, but it was hard to think it, for not only did her own instinct proclaim against it, but Dominick’s manner and attitude were in distinct refutation of any such theory. He was not sullen, he was absent; he was not resentful, he was indifferent. And in small outward ways he tried to please her, which was not after the manner of a sore and angry man. On this very Sunday he had agreed to meet her and her family in the park at the band stand at four. She always dined with her sisters on Sunday and if the weather was fine they went to the park and listened to the music. It was nearly a year now since Dominick had joined these family parties, preferring to walk on the Presidio hills and the Cliff House beach with a friend from the bank. But on the evening before he had promised to meet them; been quite agreeable about it, Berny had thought, when her pleadings and importunities had finally extorted from him a promise to join them there.

She left the dining-room and walked up the hallway to the parlor, her head drooped, anxieties gnawing at her. The little room was flooded with sunshine, and she parted the lace curtains and, throwing up the window, leaned out. The rich, enveloping warmth surrounded her, clasped her,

seemed to sink deep into her and thaw the apprehensions that were so cold at her heart. She drew in the sweet, still air, that did not stimulate but that had in it something of a crystalline youth and freshness, like the air of an untainted world, concerned with nothing but the joy of living. The scents of flowers were in it; the mellowness of the earth and its fruits. Peace was the message of this tranquil Sunday morning, peace was in the sunshine, in the sound of bells with which the air was full, in the fall of feet—light, joyous feet—on the pavement, in the voices of passers-by and the laughter, sweet and broken, of children. It was not right for any one to harbor cankering cares on such a day. The earth was happy, abandoned to the sunshine, irresponsible, care free, rejoicing in the perfect moment. The woman felt the restoring processes that Nature, in its tireless generosity, offers to all who will take them. She felt eased of her troubles, soothed and cheered, as though the enwrapping radiance that bathed her held an opiate for jangled nerves. Blinking in the brightness she leaned on the window-sill, immovable, quieted, feeling the warmth suffuse her and dissipate those alarms that half an hour earlier had been so chill and heavy.

As she dressed, the sense of well-being and confidence increased. She looked very well this morning. Since Dominick's return she had looked haggard and thin. Sometimes she had seemed to see, showing shadowy through her reflected face in the mirror, the lines and hollows of that face when time should have put a stamp on it that neither massage nor pigments would efface. A sudden moment of revelation showed her herself as an old woman, her nose pointed, her mouth a thin, tight line. This morning the glass gave her back none of these disconcerting hints. She was at her best, and as she dressed carefully and slowly, she had the satisfaction of seeing that each added article of apparel increased her good looks. When she finally put on her new hat—the one she had bought in celebration of Dominick's return—and over it tied a white and black dotted veil, she was so gratified with the picture she presented that she was reluctant to leave it and pirouetted slowly before the glass, surveying her back and side views, and finally lifting her skirt that she might see the full effect of her lilac petticoat as it burst into sight in an ebullition of pleats and frills.

Walking up the avenue she was bridlingly conscious that her brilliant appearance drew its tribute of glances. Many people looked at her, and their sidelong admiration was an even more exhilarating tonic than the sunshine.

She walked with a light, elastic step, spreading perfume on the air, her progress accompanied by a rich, seductive rustle. Once or twice she passed members of that exclusive world from which she had stolen Dominick. She swept by them, languidly indifferent, her eyes looking with glacial hauteur over their heads. The sound made by her brushing silk petticoats was gratifyingly aggressive. She imparted to them a slight disdainful swing, and lifted her dress skirt daintily higher, conscious of the impeccable amplitude of her emerging lilac frills.

The habit of dining with her own people on Sunday had been one she had never abandoned, even in the first aspiring days of her marriage. It was a sort of family reunion and at first Dominick had been a not unwilling participant in its domestic festivities. The solid bourgeois respectability of his wife's relations appealed to him. For all his advantages in money and education he was of the same class himself, and while Berny was, if not a beloved spouse, a yet endurable one, he had found the Sunday gatherings and subsequent hejira to the park not entirely objectionable. For over a year now he had escaped from it, pleading the need of open air and exercise, and his sisters-in-law, who had at first protested, had grown used to his absence and accepted it as something to bear uncomplainingly.

The day was so fine that they hurried through their dinner, a hearty and lavish meal, the *chef-d'œuvre* of Hannah's housekeeping, and, loath to lose a moment of the sunshine, determined to walk down to Van Ness Avenue and there catch an outgoing car to the park. It was the middle of the afternoon and the great thoroughfare lay still and idle in the slanting light. There was something foreign, almost tropical in its vista, in the scene that hung like a drop curtain at the limit of sight—pale blue hills dotted with ochre-colored houses—in the background of sky deep in tint, the foliage dark against it as if printed upon its intense glaring blue, in the sharp lines of palms and spiky leaves crossing stuccoed walls. The people that moved slowly along the sidewalks fitted into this high-colored exotic setting. There was no hurry or crowding among them. They progressed with an un-American deliberation, tasting the delicate sweetness of the air, rejoicing in the sky and the sun, pausing to look at the dark bushiness of a dracæna against a wash of blue, the skeleton blossom of a Century plant, the pool of thick scarlet made by a parterre of geranium.

The three sisters—Hannah and Pearl leading, Berny and Hazel walking behind with Josh—fared buoyantly down the street. As they passed, they commented on the houses and their inmates. They had plenty of stories of the dwellers in those solemn palaces, many of whom were people whose humble beginnings they knew by heart, and whose rapid rise had been watched almost awe-stricken by an admiring and envious community.

As the Ryan house loomed into view their chatter ceased and their eyes, serious with staring attention, were fixed on the mansion which had so stubbornly closed its doors on one of them. Sensations of varying degrees of animosity stirred in each of them, except the child, still too young to be tainted by the corroding sense of worldly injustice. She skipped along sidewise, her warm, soft hand clasped in her Aunt Hannah's decently-gloved palm. Some wave or vibration of the intense feelings of her elders passed to her, and as they drew nearer the house she, too, began to grow grave, and her skipping quieted down into a sober walk.

"That's Uncle Dominick's house, isn't it?" she said to Hannah.

Hannah nodded. By far the most amiable and wide-minded of the sisters, she could not rise above the sense of rankling indignation that she felt against the Ryans for their treatment of Berny.

"That's the biggest house in San Francisco," said Pearl over her shoulder to her parents. "Ain't it, Popper?"

"I guess it is," answered Josh, giving his head a confirmatory wag, "and even if it ain't, it's big enough, the Lord knows!"

"I can't see what a private family wants with all that room," said Hannah with a condemnatory air. "There must be whole sootes of rooms on that upper floor that nobody lives in."

"Don't you fret. They're all occupied," said Berny. "Each one of them has their own particular soote. Cornie has three rooms all of her own, and even the housekeeper has a private bath!"

"And there's twelve indoor servants," said Hazel. "They want a lot of space for them. Twelve servants, just think of it!"

"Twelve servants!" ejaculated Hannah almost with a groan. "Well, that don't seem to me right."

They were close to the house now and silence fell on them, as though the antagonism of its owners was exhaled upon them from the mansion's aggressive bulk, like an unspoken curse. They felt overawed, and at the same time proud that one of their number should have even the most distant affiliations with a family too exclusive to know her. The women with their more responsive and sensitive natures felt it more delicately than Josh, who blunderingly expressed one of the thoughts of the moment by remarking,

"Some day you'll live in there, Berny, and boss the twelve servants."

"Rats!" said Berny, giving her head an angry toss. "I'd rather live in my flat and boss Sing."

Josh's whistle of facetious incredulity died away incomplete, for at that moment the hall door opened and a portly masculine shape emerged upon the porch. Berny, at the first glance, was not sure of its identity, but her doubts were dispelled by her brother-in-law's quick sentence, delivered on the rise of a surprised breath.

"Bill Cannon, by gum! What's he doing there?"

This name, as powerful to conjure with in the city as in the mining-camps, cast its instantaneous spell upon the sisters, who stared avid-eyed upon the great man. He for his part seemed oblivious to their glances and to their presence. He stood on the top step for a musing moment, looking down with that sort of filmy fixity of gaze which is noticeable in the glance of the resting eagle. His appearance was a last crowning touch to the proud, unapproachable distinction of the Ryans.

"Don't he look as if he was thinking?" said Hazel in a whisper. "I wonder what's on his mind."

"Probably that Monday's pay-day and he don't know whether he can scratch through," said the jocose Josh.

Berny did not say anything. She felt the interest in Cannon that she did in all conquering, successful people, and in her heart it gave her a sense of added importance to think that the family she had married into and who refused to know her was on friendly terms with the Bonanza King.

A half-hour later they had found seats in front of the band stand in the park, and, settling themselves with a great rustling and preening of plumage,

prepared to enjoy the music. Hannah and Pearl were given two chairs at the end of a row, and Hazel and Berny, with Josh as escort, secured four on the line immediately behind. Dominick had not yet appeared, so the sisters spread their skirts over a vacant seat between them, and Berny, in the intervals of inspecting the people around her, sent exploring glances about for the tall figure of her husband.

She was very fond of the park and band stand on such Sunday afternoons. To go there had been one of the great diversions of her girlhood. She loved to look at this holiday gathering of all types, among which her own class was largely represented. The outdoor amphitheater of filled benches was to her what the ball-room and the glittering horseshoe at the opera are to the woman of society. She saw many old friends among the throng, girls who had been contemporaries of hers when she had first “gone to work,” and had long since married in their own world and now dragged children by the hand. She looked them over with an almost passionate curiosity, discomfited to see the fresh youth of some, and pleased to note that others looked weighed down with maternal cares. Berny regarded women who had children as fools, and the children grouped about these mothers of her own age—three and four sometimes, with the husband carrying a baby—were to her only annoying, burdensome creatures that made the party seem a little ridiculous, and had not half the impressiveness or style of her elegant costume and lilac frills.

The magnificent afternoon had brought out a throng of people. Every seat in the lines of benches was full and foot passengers kept constantly coming up, standing for a few measures, and then moving on. They were of all kinds. The beauty of the day had even tempted the more fashionable element out, and the two sisters saw many elegantly-dressed ladies of the sort on whom Hazel fitted hats all day, and that evoked in Berny a deep and respectful curiosity. Both women, sitting high in their chairs, craned their necks this way and that, spying through breaks in the crowd, and following attractive figures with dodging movements of their heads. When either one saw anything she liked or thought interesting she laid a hand on the other’s knee, giving it a slight dig, and designated the object of her attention in a few broken words, detached and disconnected like notes for a sentence.

They were thus engaged when Hazel saw Dominick and, rising, hailed him with a beckoning hand. He made his way toward them, moving deliberately,

once or twice pausing to greet acquaintances. He was taller than any man in the surrounding throng and Berny, watching him, felt a sense of proprietary pride swelling in her when she noted his superiority. The son of an Irish laborer and a girl who had begun life as the general servant in a miner's boarding-house, he looked as if his forebears might have been the flower of the nation. He wore a loose-fitting suit of gray tweed, a wide, gray felt sombrero, and round his waist a belt of yellow leather. His collar turning back from his neck exposed the brown strength of his throat, and on lifting his hat in a passing salutation, his head with its cropped curly hair, the ears growing close against it, showed golden brown in the sunlight.

With a phrase of greeting he joined them, and then as they swept their skirts off the chair they had been hiding, slipped in front of Berny and sat down. Hazel began to talk to him. Her conversation was of a rallying, joking sort, at which she was quite proficient. Berny heard him laugh and knew by the tone of his voice that he was pretending and was not really amused. She had nothing particular to say to him, feeling that she had accomplished enough in inducing him to join them, and, sitting forward on the edge of her chair, continued to watch the people. A blonde coiffure some rows in front caught her eye and she was studying its intricacies through the interstices that came and went between the moving heads, when the sudden emergence into view of an unusually striking female figure diverted her attention. The woman had come up from behind and, temporarily stopped by the crowd, had come to a standstill a few rows in front of where the sisters sat. She was accompanied by a young man dressed in the Sunday dignity of frock-coat and silk hat. As he turned to survey the lines of filled chairs, Berny saw that he had a pale skin, a small black mustache, and dark eyes.

But her interest in him was of the slightest. Her attention was immediately riveted upon the woman, who became the object of a glance which inspected her with a piercing eagerness from her hat to the hem of her shirt. Berny could not see her face, but her habiliments were of the latest mode and of an unusual and subdued elegance which bespoke an origin in a more sophisticated center than San Francisco. Berny, all agog with curiosity, stared at the lady's back, noting not only her clothes but a certain carelessness in the way they were put on. Her hat was not quite straight. The comb, which crossed the back of her head and kept her hair smooth, was crooked, and blonde wisps hung from it over her collar. The hand that

held up her skirt in a loose perfunctory manner, as though these rich encasings were possessions of no moment, was covered by a not particularly clean white glove.

Such unconsciousness added the distinction of indifference to the already marked figure. Berny wondered more than ever who it was and longed to see the averted face. She was about to lean across Dominick and attract Hazel's attention by a poking finger directed against her knee, when the woman, with a word to her companion, moved her head and let a slow glance sweep over the rows of faces.

"Hazel," Berny hissed across Dominick, "look at that girl. Who is she?"

She did not divert her eyes from the woman's face, which she now saw in profile. It was pretty, she thought, more from a rich, unmingled purity of coloring than from any particular beauty of feature. The head with its gravely-traveling glance continued to turn till Berny had the satisfaction of seeing the face in three-quarters. A moment later the moving eyes lighted indifferently on Hazel, then ceased to progress, suddenly, brusquely, as though checked by the imperative stoppage of regulating machinery.

Only a person watching closely would have noticed it, but Berny was watching with the most vigilant closeness. She saw the infusion of a new and keener interest transform the glance, concentrate its lazy, diffused attention into something that had the sharpness and suddenness of a leaping flame. The next moment a flood of color rose clearly pink over the face, and then, most surprising of all, the lady bent her head in a grave, deliberate bow.

Berny turned, startled—and in a vague, undefined way, disturbed, too—to see who had been the object of this salutation. To her astonishment it was Dominick. As she looked at him, he replaced his hat and she saw—to the augmentation of that vague sense of disturbance—that he was as pale as the bowing woman was pink.

"Dominick," she exclaimed, "who's that?"

"Miss Cannon," he said in a low tone.

"Rose Cannon?" hissed Hazel on the other side of him, her face thrust forward, and tense in the interest of the moment, "Bill Cannon's daughter?"

“Yes. I met her at Antelope.”

“Berny, did you see her dress?” Hazel hung over her brother-in-law in her excitement. “That’s straight from Paris, I’ll bet you a dollar.”

“Yes, I saw it,” said Berny in a voice that did not sound particularly exhilarated; “maybe it is.”

She looked back at Miss Cannon who had turned away and was moving off through the crowd with her escort. Then she leaned toward Dominick. His voice had not sounded natural; as she placed her arm against his she could feel that he trembled.

She said nothing but settled back in her chair, dryly swallowing. In those few past moments her whole world had undergone a revolution that left her feeling dazed and a little sick. It was as if the earth had suddenly whirled around and she had come up panting and clutching among familiar things reversed and upset. In an instantaneous flash of illumination she saw everything—the look in the woman’s eyes, her rush of color, Dominick’s voice, his expression, the trembling of his arm—it was all perfectly plain! This was the girl he had been shut in Antelope with for three weeks. Now she knew what the change was, the inexplicable, mysterious change that had so puzzled her.

She felt bewildered, and under her bewilderment a pain, a fierce, unfamiliar pain, gripped her. She did not for the moment say anything or want to speak, and she felt as a child does who is dazed and stupefied by an unexpected assault of ill treatment. The slight sensation of inward sinking, that made her feel a little sick, continued and she sat in a chilled and drooping silence, all her bridling conceit in herself and her fine clothes stricken suddenly out of her.

She heard Hazel asking Dominick questions about Miss Cannon, and she heard Dominick’s answers, brief and given with a reticent doggedness. Then Hazel asked him for the time and she was conscious of his elbow pressing against her arm as he felt for his watch. As he drew it out and held it toward the questioner, Berny suddenly leaned forward, and, catching his hand with the watch in it, turned its face toward her. The hand beneath hers was cold, and shook. She let it go and again sank back in her chair. The

feeling of sickness grew stronger and was augmented by a sense of physical feebleness, of being tremulous and cold deep down in her bones.

Hazel rose to her feet, shaking her skirts into place.

“Let’s go on,” she said, “it’s getting chilly. Come along, Josh. I suppose if you were let alone, you’d sit here till sundown listening to the music in a trance.”

Dominick and Josh rose and there was an adjusting and putting-on of wraps. Berny still sat motionless, her hands, stiff in their tight gloves, lying open on her lap.

“Come along, Berny,” said Hazel. “It’s too cold to sit here any longer. Why, how funny you look, all pale and shriveled up! You’re as bad as Josh. You and he ought to have married each other. You’d have been a prize couple.”

Josh laughed loudly at this sally, leaning round the figure of his wife to present his foolish, good-humored face, creased with a grin, to Berny.

“Are you willing, Berny?” he cried gaily. “I can get a divorce whenever you say. It will be dead easy; brutal and inhuman treatment. Just say the word!”

“There’ll be brutal and inhuman treatment if you don’t move on and stop blocking the way, Josh McCrae,” said Hazel severely. “I want to go out that side and there you are right in the path, trying to be funny.”

The cheerful Josh, still laughing, turned and moved onward between the seats, the others following him. The mass of the crowd was not yet leaving, and as the little group moved forward in a straggling line toward the drive, the exciting opening of the *William Tell Overture* boomed out from the sounding board. It was a favorite piece, and they left lingeringly, Hazel and Josh particularly fascinated, with heads turned and ears trained on the band. Josh’s hand, passed through his wife’s arm, affectionately pressed her against his side, for despite the sharpness of their recriminations they were the most loving of couples.

Berny was the last of the line. In the flurry of departure her silence had passed unnoticed, and that she should thus lag at the tail of the procession was not in any way remarkable, as, at the best of times, she was not much of a walker and in her high-heeled Sunday shoes her progress was always deliberate.

Looking ahead of her, she saw the landscape still as a picture under the slanting, lurid sunlight. It seemed to be painted with unnaturally glaring tints, to be soaked in color. The grass, crossed with long shadows, was of the greenness of an aniline dye. The massed foliage of tree groups showed a melting richness of shades, no one clearly defined, all fused in a thick, opaque lusciousness of greens. The air was motionless and very clear. Where a passing carriage stirred the dust the powdery cloud rose, spreading a tarnishing blur on the crystalline clarity of the scene. The sun injected these dust films with gold, and they settled slowly, as if it made them heavy like ground-up particles of metal.

Yet, to Berny, this hectic prospect looked gray; all color seemed sucked from it. It appeared pale and alien, its comfortable intimacy gone. She was like a stranger walking in a strange place, a forlorn, remote land, where she felt miserable and homesick. The sense of being dazed was passing from her. Walking forward with short, careful steps, she was slowly coming to the meaning of her discovery—adjusting herself to it, realizing its significance. She had an uncomfortable sensation of not being able to control the muscles round her mouth, so that if spoken to she would have had difficulty in answering, and would have been quite unable to smile.

An open carriage passed her, and she drew aside, then mechanically looked after it as it rolled forward. There was a single figure in it—a woman. Berny could see her head over the lowered hood, and the little parasol she held, white with a black lace cover and having a joint in the handle. Her eyes followed this receding head, moving so evenly against the background of trees. It soared along without sinking or rising, with the even, forward flight of a bird, passed Hannah and Josh and Hazel, turning to drop on them quick looks, which seemed, from its elevated position and the shortness of the inspection, to have something of disdain in them.

As the carriage drew near Dominick, who walked at the head of the line with Pearl by the hand, Berny saw the head move, lean forward, and then, as the vehicle overhauled and passed the young man, turn at right angles and bow to him. The wheel almost brushed his shoulder. He drew back from it with a start and lifted his hat. Hazel, who was walking just in front of Berny, turned and projecting her lips so that they stood out from her face in a red circle, hissed through them,

“Old Lady Ryan!” and then in a slightly louder key,

“You take a hatchet and I’ll take a saw,

And we’ll cut off the head of my mother-in-law.”

CHAPTER XIII

THE ROOT OF ALL EVIL

The conversation with her old friend had upset Mrs. Ryan. These were grievances she did not talk of to all the world, and the luxury of such plain speaking was paid for by a re-awakened smart. The numb ache of a sorrow was always with her, but her consciousness of it was dulled in the diversion of every day's occupations. Bringing it to the surface this way gave it a new vitality, and when the conversation was over and the visitor gone it refused to subside into its old place.

She went slowly up stairs, hearing the low murmur of voices from the sitting-room where Cornelia and Jack Duffy were still secluded. Even the thought of that satisfactorily-budding romance did not cheer her as it had done earlier in the day. As she had told Cannon, she was not the woman she had been. Old age was coming on her and with it a softening of her iron nature. She wanted her son, her Benjamin, dearly beloved with all the forces of her maturity as his father had been with all the glow of her youth.

In her own room she threw aside the lace curtains, and looking out on the splendor of the afternoon, determined to seek cheer in the open air. Like all Californians she had a belief in the healing beneficence of air and sunlight. As the sun had soothed Berny of her sense of care so now it wooed her enemy also to seek solace in its balm. She rang for the servant and ordered the carriage. A few minutes later, clad in rich enshrouding black, a small and fashionable bonnet perched on her head, she slowly made her way down stairs and out to the sidewalk where the victoria, glittering in the trim perfection of its appointments and drawn by a pair of well-matched chestnuts, stood at the curb.

The man on the box touched his hat with respectful greeting and the Chinese butler, who had accompanied her down the steps, arranged the rug over her knees and stepped back with the friendly "good-by," which is the politeness of his race. They respected, feared, and liked her. Every domestic who had ever worked in Delia Ryan's service from the first "hired girl" of her early Shasta days to the staff that now knew the rigors of her dominion,

had found her a just and generous if exacting mistress. She had never been unfair, she had never been unkind. She was one of themselves and she knew how to manage them, how to make them understand that she was master, and that no drones were permitted in her hive; how to make them feel that she had a heart that sympathized with them, not as creatures of an alien class remotely removed from her own, but as fellow beings, having the same passions, griefs and hopes as herself.

As the carriage rolled forward she settled back against the cushioned seat and let her eyes roam over the prospect. It was the heart of the afternoon, still untouched by chill, not a breath stirring. Passing up the long drive which leads to the park, the dust raised by wheels hung ruddy in the air. The long shadows of trees striped the roadway in an irregular black pattern, picked out with splatterings of sunshine, like a spilled, gold liquid. Belts of fragrance, the breaths of flowering shrubs, extended from bushy coppices, and sometimes the keen, acrid odor of the eucalyptus rose on the air. From this lane of entrance the park spread fan-like into a still, gracious pleasance. The rich, golden light slept on level stretches of turf and thick mound-shaped groups of trees. The throb of music—the thin, ethereal music of out-of-doors—swelled and sank; the voices of children rose clear and fine from complicated distances, and once the raucous cry of a peacock split the quietness, seeming to break through the pictorial serenity of the lovely, dreamy scene.

Mrs. Ryan sat without movement, her face set in a sphinx-like profundity of expression. People in passing carriages bowed to her but she did not see them and their salutes went unreturned. Her vision was bent back on scenes of her past, so far removed from what made up the present, so different and remote from her life to-day, that it did not seem as if the same perspective could include two such extremes. Even her children were not links of connection between those old dead times and now. They had been born when Con's fortunes were in the ascendant. They had known none of the privations of the brave days when she and her man had faced life together, young, and loving, and full of hope.

The carriage ascended a slight rise, and the sea, a glittering plain, lay in full view. It met the sky in a white dazzle of light. All its expanse coruscated as if each wave was crested with tinsel, and where they receded from the beach it was as though a web of white and shining tissue was drawn back,

torn and glistening, from the restraining clutch of the sand. The smooth bareness of fawn-colored dunes swept back from the shore. They rose and fell in undulations, describing outlines of a suave, fluid grace, lovely as the forms of drifting snow, or the swell of waves. Ocean and dunes, for all the splendor of sky and sun that overarched and warmed them, suggested a gaunt, primeval desolation. They had the loneliness of the naked earth and the unconquerable sea—were a bit of the primordial world before man had tamed and softened it.

Mrs. Ryan swept them with a narrow, inward gaze which saw neither, but, in their place, the house in Virginia City, where she and Con had lived when they were first married in the early sixties. It was of “frame”—raw, yellow boards with narrow strips of wood nailed over every seam to keep the wind out. There had been a rough porch on one side where her wash-tub had stood. Out-of-doors there in the summer weather she had bent over the wash-board most of the day. She had made enough money to furnish the prospect hole that Con was working, with tools and miner’s supplies. Little Dick was born there; he had died afterward in Shasta. He used to lie in a wash-basket on the soiled linen in the sun. He would have been forty-five now, sixteen years older than Dominick.

She gave an order to the coachman who, drawing up, turned the horses, and the carriage started on its return trip. The sun was behind it, painting with level, orange rays the thick foliage of trees and the backs of foot passengers. Whatever it touched had the appearance of being overlaid with a gilded glaze through which its natural colors shone, deepened and brilliant.

Mrs. Ryan’s memories had leaped from Virginia City to Shasta. After Con’s prospect at Gold Hill had “petered” they had moved to California, been members of that discouraged route which poured, impoverished in pocket and enfeebled in health, from the wreck of the gutted Nevada camp back to their own Golden State and its beguiling promises. They had opened a grocery in Shasta in sixty-eight, first a little place where Con and she waited behind the counter, then, when they began to prosper, a big store on the corner. “Ryan’s” was written over the entrance in the beginning, when they had no money to spend, in black on a strip of canvas, after that in gold letters on a handsome sign. She had kept the books there while Con had managed the business, and they had done well. It was the beginning of their prosperity and how they had worked for it! Night after night up till

midnight and the next morning awake before the birds. Two children had died there and three had been born. It had been a full life, a splendid life, the best a woman could know, working for her own, making them a place in the world, fighting her way up, shoulder to shoulder with her man.

Money had been her goal. She had not wanted to hoard it; of itself it meant nothing to her. She had wanted it for her children: to educate them better than she had been educated, to give them the advantages she had never known, to buy pleasures and position and consideration for them. She had felt the insignificance of poverty, and she was determined that they should never feel it. They should have the power that it seemed to Delia Ryan money alone gave, the thing she had none of, when, in her ragged girlhood, she winced and chafed under the dominance of those she felt to be her inferiors. She was a materialist by nature, and life had made her more of one. Money conquered, money broke the trail that led everywhere, money paid the gate entrance to all paradises. That was what she had always thought. And now when she was close on seventy, and her strength to fight for the old standards and ward off the creeping chill of age was weakened, she had come to realize that perhaps it was not the world-ruling power she had thought it. She had come to see it could turn upon one in strange ways. It carried power and it carried a curse. Dominick, whose life it was to have made brilliant, whose career it was to have crowned, Dominick had lost all through it.

She was thinking this as the carriage swept into the wider reach of the drive near the band stand. Though the music was still throbbing on the air, people were already leaving. Broken lines were detaching themselves from the seated mass in the chairs, disappearing among the trees, and straggling out into the road. The wheels of the victoria almost brushed the shoulders of a little party that moved in irregular file between the grass edge and the drive. Mrs. Ryan let her uninterested glance touch the hatted heads of the women and then move forward to the man who headed the column. He held by the hand a pretty, fair-haired child, who, leaning out from his restraining grasp, walked a little before him, looking back laughingly into his face. Mrs. Ryan's eyes, alighting on his back, became suddenly charged with a fierce fixity of attention. The carriage overhauled him and before he looked up she leaned forward and saw his profile, the brow marked by a frown, the child's

gay prattle causing no responsive smile to break the brooding gravity that held his features.

As he felt the vibration of the wheel at his shoulder he started aside and looked up. When he recognized his mother his face reddened, and, with a quick smile, he lifted his hat. Her returning salute was serious, almost tragically somber. Then the victoria swept on, and he and the child, neither for a moment speaking, looked after the bonneted head that soared away before them with a level, forward vibration, like a floating bird, the little parasol held stiffly erect on its jointed handle.

As Mrs. Ryan passed down the long park entrance she thought no more of the past. The sight of her son, heading the file of his wife's relations, his face set in an expression of heavy dejection, scattered her dreams of retrospect with a shattering impact. She had never seen him look so frankly wretched; and to intensify the effect of his wretchedness was the sprawling line of Iversons which surrounded him. They seemed, to her furious indignation, like a guard cutting him off from his kind, imprisoning him, keeping him for themselves. They were publicly dragging him at their chariot wheels for all the world to see. His wife instead of getting less was getting more power over him. She had made him ask for the invitation to the ball and now she made him escort herself and her sisters about on holidays.

The old woman's face was dark with passion, her pale lips set into a tight line. Money! Money might make trouble and bring disappointment, but it would talk to those people. Money was all they were after. Well, they could have it!

She let three days go by before she made the move she had determined on ten minutes after she had passed Dominick. The Wednesday morning following that Sunday—apparently a day of innocuous and simple happenings, really so fraught with Fate—she put on her outdoor things and, dispensing with the carriage, went down town on the car to see Bill Cannon.

The Bonanza King's office was on the first floor of a building owned by himself on one of the finest Montgomery Street corners. It had been built in the flush times of the Comstock and belonged to that epoch of San Francisco architecture where long lines of windows were separated by short columns and overarched by ornate embellishments in wood. As Mrs. Ryan

approached, the gold letters on these windows gleamed bravely in the sun. They glittered even on the top-story casements, and her eye, traveling over them, saw that they spelled names of worth, good tenants who would add to the dignity and revenues of such an edifice. She owned the corner opposite, and it gave her a pang of emulative envy to notice how shabby her building looked, a relic of the sixties which showed its antiquity in walls of brick, painted brown, and a restrained meagerness of decoration in the matter of cornices. For some time she had been thinking of tearing it down and raising a new, up-to-date structure on the site. It would yield a fine interest on the investment and be a good wedding jointure for Cornelia.

With her approach heralded by a rustling of rich stuffs and a subdued panting, she entered the office. A long partition down one side of the room shut off an inner sanctum of clerks. Through circular openings she could see their faces, raised expectantly from ledgers as their ears caught the frou-frou of skirts and a step, which, though heavy, was undoubtedly feminine. She stopped at one of the circular openings where the raised face looked older and graver than its fellows, and inquired for Mr. Cannon, giving her name. In a moment the clerk was beside her, knocking at a door which gave egress to still more sacred inner precincts. Opening this, he bowed her into the dimly-lit solemnity of the Bonanza King's private office. Back in the outer room among the clerks he relieved the strained curiosity of their faces with the remark,

“Greek's meeting Greek in there. It's Mrs. Con Ryan.”

The private office looked out on an alley shut in a perpetual twilight by the towering walls of surrounding buildings. The long windows that ran from the floor to the ceiling could not let in enough light ever to make it a bright room, and the something of dimness seemed appropriate to the few massive pieces of furniture and the great safe in the corner, with its lock glimmering from the dusk of continual shadow. Men from windows across the alley could look into the office and see to whom Bill Cannon was talking, and it was known that, for this reason, he had another suite of rooms on one of the upper floors. But that that most competent of business women, Con Ryan's widow, should come to his lair to parley with him was natural enough, and if the watchers across the alley saw her it only added to their sober respect for the man who was visited in his office by the richest woman in California.

She did not waste time beating about the bush. Sitting beside the desk, facing the pale light from the long windows, she very quickly plunged into the matter of her errand. It was a renewal of the conversation of the previous Sunday. Cannon sat in his swivel chair, looking meditatively at her. He had expected her, but not so soon, and as he watched her his face showed a mild friendly surprise breaking through its observant attention. It would have been difficult for any one, even so astute a woman as Mrs. Ryan, to guess that her request for his assistance in severing Dominick's marriage bonds was affording the old man the keenest gratification.

Their talk lasted nearly an hour. Before the interview ended they had threshed out every aspect of the matter under discussion. There would be no loose ends or slighted details in any piece of work which engaged the attention of this bold and energetic pair of conspirators. The men on the other side of the alley looked down on them, wondering what business was afoot between Mrs. Con Ryan and Bill Cannon, that they talked so long in the big dim office with its gloomy mahogany furniture and the great black safe looming up in the corner.

CHAPTER XIV

THE GOD DESCENDS

Two days after this momentous combination of her enemies, Berny was sitting in the parlor of her flat, writing a letter. It was three o'clock in the afternoon and she had just dressed herself for her daily jaunt down town, where she spent an hour or two looking into the shop windows, pricing articles of apparel, taking a glass of soda water, and stopping for chats with acquaintances under awnings and in open doorways. Her life was exceedingly barren of occupation and companionship. When she had married, she had dropped all work save such as seemed to her fitting for the wife of a rich man. Outside her sisters she had no friends. She knew the wives of several of the bank officials and to them, as representing a rise in the social scale, she clung hopefully. The letter she was now writing was to one of them who had taken a sick child to the country.

She had finished it, and was inscribing her signature, when a ring at the bell caught her ear. She raised her head listening, and then bent it again over the letter. Visitors were too rare at the Sacramento Street flat for her to cherish any delusive hopes. Writing the address in her best hand, she did not hear a foot ascending the stairs, nor know that it actually was a visitor, till a tap on the door-post of the room made her turn and ejaculate a startled "Come in!" The door that led from the parlor to the hall had been removed, and a bamboo portière hung in the opening. A large masculine hand thrust apart the hanging strands, and Bill Cannon, hat in hand, confident and yet apologetic, entered the room.

He had been surprised when he had seen how small and unpretentious was the home of Con Ryan's only son. He was more than ever surprised when the Chinaman, with the unveiled impudence of those domestics when the employes of masters they do not like, had waved his proffered card aside, and with a jerk of his head motioned him forward to a doorway at the end of the passage. Now, on entering, he took in, in an impressionistic sweep, the overcrowded, vulgar garishness of the little room, saturated with the

perfume of scents and sachets, and seeming to be the fitting frame for the woman who rose from a seat by the desk.

She looked at him inquiringly with something of wariness and distrust in her face. She was the last of the ascending scale of surprises he had encountered, for she was altogether better-looking, more a person to be reckoned with, than he had expected. His quick eye, trained to read human nature, recognized the steely determination of this woman before she spoke, saw it in the level scrutiny of her eyes, in the decision of her close mouth. He felt a sensation, oft experienced and keenly pleasurable, of gathering himself together for effort. It was the instinct of an old warrior who loves the fray.

Berny, on her side, knew him at the first glance, and her sensations were those of disturbance and uneasiness. She remembered him to be a friend of the Ryans', and she had arrived at the stage when any friend of the Ryans' was an enemy of hers. She was instantly in arms and on the defensive. Rose had not yet taken shape in her mind as a new, menacing force conniving against her. Besides, she had no idea that Rose reciprocated the sentiment that Dominick cherished for her. Her discovery had only made her certain that Dominick loved another woman. But this had shaken her confidence in everything, and she looked at the old man guardedly, ready for an attack and bracing herself to meet it.

"You'll pardon this intrusion, won't you?" he said in a deep, friendly voice, and with a manner of cordial urbanity. "I tried to do it correctly, but the Chinaman had other designs. It was he who frustrated me. Here's the card I wanted him to take to you."

He approached her, holding out a card which she took, still unsmiling, and glanced at. Her instinct of dissimulation was strong, and, uneasy as she was, she pretended to read the name, not wanting him to see that she already knew him.

"Mr. William G. Cannon," she read, and then looked up at him and made a slight inclination of her head as she had seen actresses do on the stage. "Won't you sit down, Mr. Cannon?" she added, and completed the impressiveness of her greeting by a gesture, which also suggested a histrionic origin, toward an adjacent chair.

He backed toward the chair, pulling it out into the unencumbered space in the middle of the floor, his movements deliberate and full of design, as if he felt comfortably at home. Subsiding into the seat, which had arms and was rather cramped for his large bulk, he laid his hat among the knick-knacks of a near-by table and said smilingly,

“Now, let me make my apologies for coming. In the first place, I’m an old man. We’ve got a few privileges to compensate us for the loss of so much that’s good. Don’t you think that’s fair, Mrs. Ryan?”

Berny liked him. There was something so easy and affable in his manner, something that made her feel he would never censure her for her past, or, in fact, think about it at all. But she was still on her guard, though the embarrassment she had felt on his entrance disappeared.

“I don’t know,” she said vaguely. “I don’t know why an old man should have more privileges than a young one.”

“But you do know,” he said quickly, and giving a short, jolly laugh, “that an old man who’s known your husband all his life can have the privilege of calling on you without an introduction. You’ll admit that, won’t you?”

He leaned out of the narrow chair, his broad face creased with a good-humored smile, and his eyes, keen and light-colored, sharp on hers. Berny felt doubtful as to whether she liked him so much. She, too, had a large experience of men, and the hard intelligence of the eyes in the laughing face made her more than ever on the defensive.

“I’m sure I’m very glad you came,” she said politely; “any friend of Dominick’s is welcome here.”

“I’ve been that for a good many years. My friendship with the Ryans goes back to the days before Dominick was born. I knew Con and Delia well in the old times in Virginia when we were all young there together, all young, and strong, and poor. I’ve known Dominick since he was a baby, though I haven’t seen much of him of late years.”

“Nor of his wife either,” Berny was going to say, but she checked herself and substituted, “Is that so?” a comment which seemed to her to have the advantages of being at once dignified and elegantly non-committal.

“Yes, I knew Con when he was working on a prospect of his own called the Mamie R at Gold Hill. I was a miner on the Royal Charles close by on steady wages. Con was in for himself. He was playing it in pretty hard luck. If it hadn’t been for his wife he couldn’t have hung on as long as he did. She was a fine, husky, Irish girl, strong as a man; and the washing she used to do on the back porch of the shanty kept them.”

“Yes, I’ve heard that,” said Berny, much interested, and hoping that her visitor would continue to indulge in further reminiscences of Mrs. Ryan’s lowly beginnings.

“That was forty-five years ago,” he went on, “and the fellows that were on top then are underneath now, and vice versa. But Delia Ryan’s just about the same. There’s no shifting, or changing, or not knowing her own mind about her. She’s one of the strongest women in California; one of the biggest women anywhere.”

This was not what Berny had expected, and was more than she could subscribe to. The distinguished position of her guest made her want to be polite, but there was a limit to her powers of diplomatic agreement. A silver blotter stood on the desk, and she took it up and began absently rolling it back and forth over her letter.

“She seems to be a great friend of yours?” she said, watching the blotter with lowered eyes.

“She’s all that,” he answered heartily. “One of the greatest. She is to any one who knows her well. She’s a big nature; nothing picayune or small about her. A true friend and a fair enemy. She’s the most generous woman I ever knew.”

“We haven’t seen much of her generosity,” said Berny. Her words did not come with suddenness, but slowly, with a measured and biting deliberation.

“You’ve got your chance to see it now,” answered the old man.

Berny looked at him, a side glance from the corner of one long, dark eye. Her face was perfectly grave and the eyes fixed on him were imbued with a considering, apprehensive expectancy. He looked very large, squeezed into the small chair, but he seemed oblivious to the fact that there was anything ridiculous in his appearance, as well as to his own discomfort. The easy good-humor had gone from his face. It was alert, shrewd, and eagerly

interested. Berny knew now that he had not come to pay his respects to Dominick's wife. A sensation of internal trembling began to possess her and the color deepened in her face.

"How have I got my chance?" she said. "I guess if you know the Ryans so well you must know that they won't have anything to do with me."

"They'll have a good deal to do with you if you'll let them," he answered.

There was a momentary pause, during which—now conscious of battle and menace—Berny strove to control her rising excitement and keep her head cool. He watched her with a glance which had the boring penetration of a gimlet.

"That's funny," she said, "not wanting to speak to me for two years and then all of a sudden wanting to have a good deal to do with me. It's a sort of lightning-change act, like you see at the Orpheum. I guess I'd understand it better if I knew more about it."

"Then I'll tell you. Will you let me speak frankly, Mrs. Ryan? Have I got your permission to go right ahead and talk the plain talk that's the only way a plain man knows?"

"Yes," said Berny. "Go right ahead."

He looked at the carpet for a considering moment, then raised his eyes and, gazing into hers with steady directness, said,

"It wouldn't be fair if I pretended not to know that you and your husband's family are unfriendly. I know it, and that they have, as you say, refused to know you. They've not liked the marriage; that's the long and the short of it."

"And what right have they got—" began Berny, raising her head with a movement of war, and staring belligerently at him. He silenced her with a lifted hand:

"Don't let's go into that. Don't let's bother ourselves with the rights and wrongs of the matter. We could talk all afternoon and be just where we were at the beginning. Let's have it understood that our attitude in this is businesslike and impersonal. They don't like the marriage—that's admitted. They've refused to know you—that's admitted. And let us admit, for the

sake of the argument, that they've put you in a damned disagreeable position."

Berny, sitting stiffly erect, all in a quiver of nerves, anger, and uncertainty, had her eyes fixed on him in a glare of questioning.

"That's all true," she said grimly. "That's a statement I'll not challenge."

"Then we'll agree that your position is disagreeable, and that it's been made so by the antagonism of your husband's family. Now, Mrs. Ryan, let me tell you something that maybe you don't understand. You're never going to conquer or soften your mother-in-law. I don't know anything about it, but perhaps I can make a guess. You've thought you'd win her over, that you'd married her son and made him a good wife and that some day she'd acknowledge that and open her doors and invite you in. My dear young lady, just give up building those castles in the air. There's nothing in them. You don't know Delia Ryan. She'll never bend and the one thing that'll break her is death. She's got no hard feelings against you except as her son's wife. That's the thing she'll never forgive you for. I'm not saying it's not pretty tough on you. I'm just stating a fact. What I do say is that she's never going to be any different about it. She's started on her course, and she's going to go straight along on the same route till she comes to the place where we've all got to jump off."

At the commencement of this speech, a surge of words had boiled up within Berny. Now as he stopped she leaned toward him and the words burst out of her lips.

"And what right has she got to act that way, I'd like to know? What's she got against me? What's wrong with me? Dominick Ryan married me of his own free will. He chose me and he was of age. I'd been a typewriter in the Merchants and Mechanics Trust Company, honestly earning my living. Is that what she don't like about me? I might have got my living another way, a good sight easier and pleasanter, but I wasn't that kind. Maybe she didn't like a decent working-girl for her son's wife? And what was she to kick? Didn't you just say now she washed for the miners in Virginia? Didn't she used to keep a two-room grocery at Shasta? I don't see that there's anything so darned aristocratic about that. There were no more diamond tiaras and crests on the harness in her early days than there are in mine. She's forgetting old times. You can just tell her I'm not."

She came to a breathless close, her body bent forward, her dark eyes burning with rage and excitement. This suddenly sank down, chilled, and, as it were, abashed by the aspect of her listener, who was sitting motionless in his chair, his hands clasped over the curving front of his torso, his chin sunk on his collar, and his eyes fixed upon her with a look of calm, ruminating attention. Her words had not only failed to heat him to controversy, but he had the air of patiently waiting for them to cease, when he could resume the matter under discussion.

“It’s natural enough that you should feel that way about it,” he said, “but let’s put out of the argument these purely personal questions. You think one way and Mrs. Ryan thinks another. We recognize that and assume that it is so. We’re not passing judgment. I’d be the last one to do that between two ladies. What I came to talk of to-day was not the past but the present; not the wrongs you’ve suffered from the Ryans, but the way they can be righted.”

“There’s only one way they can be righted,” she said.

“Well now, let’s see,” persuasively. “We’re both agreed that your position in San Francisco is hard. Here you are in the town where you were born and raised, leading a lonely life in what, considering your marriage, we might call reduced circumstances. You have—you’ll excuse my plain talking—little or no social position. Your life is monotonous and dull, when, at your age, it should be all brightness and pleasure. In the height of your youth and beauty you’re cramped in a small flat, deprived of the amusements of your age, ostracized from society, and pinched by lack of money. That seems to me a pretty mean position for a woman of your years and appearance.”

Berny made no answer. She was confused by his thus espousing her cause, using almost the words she herself would have used in describing her unmerited trials. She was one of those women who, with an almost unbreakable nerve, when attacked or enraged, tremble. She was seized now with this trembling and to control it clasped her hands tight in her lap and tried to hold her body stiff by will power.

“It is from this situation,” he went on, his voice slightly lowered, “that Mrs. Ryan offers to release you.”

A gleam of light zigzagged through the woman's uncomprehension, and the trembling seemed to concentrate in her knees and stomach.

"To release me?" she repeated with a rising inflection.

"Yes. She'll make it possible for you to escape from all this, to live in the way you ought to live, and to have the position and amusements you are entitled to. As I said to you before, she's got no ill feeling toward you except as her son's wife. She wishes you well, and to prove it she is ready to make you the most generous offer."

Berny's rigidity relaxed and she leaned against the chair-back. She said nothing, but her eyes remained fixed on his face.

"I told you she was generous and see if I am not right," he continued. "She will make you a rich woman, independent of any one, the money yours to do with as you like, if you'll consent to the few conditions she exacts."

"What are they?"

"That you will leave your husband for a year and at the end of that time ask him to give you your liberty, he suing you for divorce on the ground of desertion."

There was a pause. Berny had moved her eyes from the old man's face, and was looking at the blotter upon which her hand had again closed. The cheek turned to him was a deep rose pink. He looked at her unembarrassed and inquiring, as though he had made an ordinary business proposition.

"It's a bribe," she said slowly, "a bribe to leave my husband."

"Oh, I wouldn't say *that*," he answered with a deprecating shrug. "Call it a deal, a settlement. The terms are easy and favorable. You'll not find one of them unjust or unfair. You're to leave the city, going preferably to Chicago or New York and staying there for the period of desertion. Seven thousand dollars will be set aside for your expenses. At the end of the year you are to write to Dominick telling him you no longer want to live with him and asking him to give you your freedom. After the divorce is granted the sum of fifty thousand dollars will be handed over to you, the one condition being that you will leave the country and go to Europe. It is also understood, of course, that the matter's to be kept a secret from Dominick. He must think

that you are acting entirely from your own free will. He mustn't guess his mother's had any part in it."

"She's not ashamed to try to buy me off, but she's ashamed to have her precious boy know it!"

The old man looked at her with a slight, indulgent smile, inwardly wondering how Dominick Ryan had endured life with this woman.

"Oh, it's best not to have Dominick know," he said easily; "not because there's anything to be ashamed of, but on general principles it's best to have as few complications as possible in the way of other people's butting in. What good would there be in Dominick's knowing?"

She rolled the blotter back and forth for a moment without answering, then said,

"So Mrs. Ryan offers me fifty thousand dollars to desert my husband?"

"With one condition—that you leave the country. Just look what that's going to mean!" He rose from the narrow, upholstered seat, took a light chair that stood near by and, setting it close to her, sat sideways on it, one hand extended toward her. "Fifty thousand dollars is a good bit of money over here, but over there it's a fortune. You'd be a rich woman with that amount in your own right. You could take an apartment in Paris, or a slice of some prince-feller's palace down in Rome. On the income of that capital, safely invested, you could live in a style that only a millionaire can manage over here—have your own carriage, dress like a queen, go to the opera. They like Americans, especially when they've got money. First thing you know you'd be right in it, knowing everybody, and going everywhere. You're nobody here, worse than nobody. Over there you'd be one of the people everybody was talking about and wanted to know. You're not only a pretty woman, you're a smart woman; you could get on top in no time, marry into the nobility if you wanted."

Berny, her eyes on the blotter, said nothing.

"And what's the alternative over here?" the tempter continued. "Staying on as an outsider, being in a position where, though you're lawfully married and are living decently with your husband, you're ostracized as completely as if you weren't married at all; where you've hardly got enough to pay

your way, cramped up in a corner like this, never going anywhere or seeing anybody. Does that kind of life appeal to you? Not if *I* know anything.”

Berny lifted her head and looked at him. The color was now burning in her cheeks and her eyes seemed to hold all the vitality of her rigid face.

“You tell Mrs. Ryan,” she said slowly, “that I’ll lie dead in my coffin before I’ll take her money and leave my husband.”

They looked at each other for a silent moment, two strong and determined antagonists. Then the old man said mildly and pleasantly,

“Now don’t be too hasty; don’t jump at a decision in the heat of the moment. Just at the first glimpse this way, you may feel surprised—may take it as sort of out of the way and interfering. But when you’ve thought it over, it will look different. Take time. You don’t have to make your mind up now, or to-morrow, or the day after. Turn it over, look at the other side, sleep on it for a few nights. Think a bit of the things I’ve said. You don’t want to be hasty about it. It’s not the kind of offer you get every day.”

“No, it’s not!” said Berny fiercely. “It’s too dirty for most people. It’s too dirty for any one but Mrs. Ryan, and you can tell her I said so.”

She rose to her feet, still clenching the blotter in her hand. He rose too, interested, annoyed and disappointed, for he knew with a cynical certainty just about what she was going to say.

“Yes,” she cried, stiff and quivering like a leaf, “go and tell her! Tell her just what I said. I’ll see her in hell before I’ll take a cent of her money, or budge an inch out of this house. She’s a fine one to give herself such airs, and think herself too good to know me and then offer to buy me off like a kept woman. Tell her I’m her son’s wife, and I’ll stay so till she’s good and dead, and Dominick’s got his share of his father’s estate. Tell her I’m here to stay, right here, here in this flat, just round the corner from where she lives, and that I’m Mrs. Ryan as well as she is, and that I’m going to stay so. This is my home, here in San Francisco, where she’s tried to ruin me and freeze me out, and here I stick.”

She glared at him as he stood, one hand on the back of his chair, his eyes thoughtfully fixed on her.

“I wouldn’t be too hasty if I were you,” he said pacifically. “Things done in a hurry are rarely satisfactory. It’s a bad way to do business. You’re apt to let good chances slip by.”



**“I’ll lie dead in my coffin before I’ll
take her money”**

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“Don’t be afraid,” she said with grim significance. “I’m not going to let mine slip by. I’ve married Dominick Ryan and I’m going to stay by him.”

He turned to the table and picked up his hat, which was a soft, black felt wide-awake. As he dented it into shape, he said,

“You’re sort of heated up and excited now, and a person’s brain don’t work well in that state. You don’t want to come to any important conclusions when you’re not cool and able to think. Sleep on this thing for one night, anyway. You can call me up on the telephone to-morrow, or probably it would be better to send a line by a messenger.”

“You’re very much interested in this affair, aren’t you?” she said with sudden malicious meaning.

For the first time in the interview he was slightly taken aback. Her face held a reserve of knowledge with which she seemed to be silently taunting him.

“Naturally,” he said with an air of simple frankness, “as an old family friend would be.”

“And that’s the only reason?”

“What other could there be?”

“Oh, I don’t know”—she turned and dropped the blotter on the desk with a nonchalant movement—“I was just wondering.”

He eyed her for a second without speaking, and in this one moment of scrutiny allowed a look of dislike and menace to creep into his face. Then he said genially,

“Well, I guess this brings our interview to an end. It’s not been just what you’d call a pleasant one, but I for one can say it’s left no hard feelings. I hope you’ll admit as much.”

She shrugged her shoulders and turned to the desk.

“I’m not a good one at lies,” she said. “I leave that to the Ryans and their old family friends.”

He laughed good-humoredly and answered,

“That’s all right. You never can hurt me by plain speaking. That’s the only kind I know. I guess we’re neither of us great at guff. Remember that I’ll

expect a visit or a letter from you.”

“You’ll have to wait a long time for either,” she said without moving.

“Well, I’m a patient man, and everything comes to him who waits.”

She looked over her shoulder with a slight acid smile.

“Not *everything*,” she said.

“So long,” he answered, giving his hat a farewell wave at her. “I’ve enjoyed meeting you and hope we’ll soon meet again in a more friendly way. *Hasta Manana, Señora!*”

She wheeled so that she faced him and gave a short nod, then watched him as he walked to the door. Here he turned, bowed deeply and respectfully, and passed out into the hall, the bamboo strands of the portière clashing together behind him. A moment later she heard the bang of the street door.

She stood motionless in the middle of the room, her face deeply flushed, her eyes fixed on the swaying curtain. For the first few moments a blind excitement held her, and then from the welter of this, her thoughts separated themselves and took definite directions. Rage, triumph, bewilderment, alarm, surged to the surface of her mind. Shaken by one after another she stood rigid in the intensity of her preoccupation, not noticing the shaking of her knees or the thumping of her heart.

Her two predominant sensations were rage and triumph. The insult of the bribe burned in her—this flinging money at her as it might be flung at a cast-off mistress. It deepened her detestation of the Ryans, and at the same time gave her a sense of intimacy with them. It made them more on a par with her, drew them down from the lofty heights whence they had scornfully ignored her, to a place beside her, a place where they, as well as she, did underhand, disreputable things they did not want known.

And it showed her her power. Standing in the middle of the room with her eyes still staring at the now motionless portière strands, she saw, stretching away into a limitless gilded distance, her negotiations with her husband’s family. If their desire to rupture the marriage took them thus far, where might it not take them? She stared into a future where she saw herself extracting money in vast amounts from them. It was fortune—twice, three times this first paltry sum—waiting for her when she chose to stretch her

hand and take it. She could be rich, as the old man said; she could go abroad, see the world, have all the joys that riches give, when she chose to let Mrs. Ryan humbly pay her such a sum as she would accept.

With a quick catch of her breath, she turned and moved to the window, stirred to her depth with the exultation of unexpected power. And standing there, the thought of the old man suddenly swept across her, and with it, transfixing her in an attitude of frozen, inward contemplation, the memory of his daughter. New vistas, extending away through the abruptly-illuminated dimness of her previous ignorance, suddenly opened before her, and she sent her startled vision exploring down them. At the end of them, waiting for Dominick in an attitude of welcome, was the pink and white girl she had seen in the park.

The discovery was made so quickly, came upon her flushed complacency with such a shock of unexpectedness, that even her sharp, suspicious mind could not for the moment take it in. Then Miss Cannon's face, as she had seen it in that moment of recognition in the park, rose with confirming clearness on her memory, and she saw straight to the heart of the plot. It was not the Ryans alone who wanted to buy her off. It was the Cannons as well. They not only wanted Dominick to get rid of her; they wanted him to get rid of her so that he could marry Rose Cannon. The other girl was behind it all, accounted for the participation of the Bonanza King, accounted probably for the whole move—the pink and white girl in the French clothes who had all her life had everything and now wanted Berny Iverson's husband.

Poor Dominick, whom Berny had held contemptuously as a disappointing and aggravating appurtenance of hers, suddenly rose in her estimation into a valuable possession whose worth she had not before realized. It was enough that another woman wanted him, was, through underhand channels, trying to get him. All in a minute, Berny had changed from the negligent proprietor of a valueless and lightly-held object, to the possessor of an article of rare worth, which she was prepared jealously to guard. With a sort of proud challenge she felt that she stood valiantly facing the marauders, protecting her treasure against their predatory advances. And her hatred against Mrs. Ryan began to extend toward Bill Cannon, and beyond him toward the fair-faced girl, who grew red to her forehead when she accidentally encountered Dominick Ryan.

CHAPTER XV

THE MOONLIGHT NIGHT

A few nights after this, there was a full moon. Dominick, walking home from the bank, saw it at the end of the street's vista, a large, yellowish-pink disk floating up into the twilight. The air about it was suffused with a misty radiance, and its wide glowing face, having a thin look like a transparency of paper with a light behind it, seemed, though not yet clear of the housetops, already to dominate the sky. The evening was warm, like the early summer in other climates; and Dominick, walking slowly and watching the great yellow sphere deepening in color as it swam majestically upward, thought of evenings like this in the past when he had been full of the joy of life and had gone forth in the spirit of love and adventure.

The sight of his home dispelled these memories and brought upon him the sense of his daily environment and its distastefulness. The determination to accept his fate which had been with him on his return from Antelope had of late been shaken by stirrings of rebellion. Uplifted by the thought of his love for a woman hopelessly removed from him, but who would always be a lodestar to worship reverently and to guide him up difficult paths, he had been able to face his domestic tragedy with the high resolution of the martyr. But this exalted condition was hard to maintain in the friction of daily life with Berny. Before, she had merely been a disagreeable companion of whom he had to make the best. Now, she was that, intensified by a comparison which threw out her every fault and petty vulgarity into glaring prominence. And more than that—she was the angel with the flaming sword, the self-incurred, invited, domesticated angel—the angel come to stay—who barred the way to Paradise.

She seemed to him to have changed within the last week. When he had first come home from Antelope she had been Berny in one of her less familiar but recognizable moods—Berny trying to be agreeable, wearing her best clothes every day, ordering the things for dinner he liked, talking loudly and incessantly. Then, quite suddenly, he became aware of a change in her. She grew silent, absent-minded, morose. He had tried to make their lives easier

by always being polite and carefully considerate of her and she had responded to it. For the last few days she had made no effort to assist him in this laudable design. Instead, she had been unresponsive, preoccupied, uninvitingly snappish in her replies. Several times he had been forced into the novel position of “making conversation” throughout dinner, exerting his wits for subjects to talk about that he might lift the gloom and elicit some response from the mute, scowling woman opposite.

To-night, the period of ill-humor seemed over. Berny was not only once again her animated self, she was almost feverishly garrulous. Dinner had not progressed past the fish when she began to question him on his recent experiences at Antelope. The subject had come up several times since his return, but for the last few days he had had a respite from it, and hoped its interest had worn away. She had many queries to make about Bill Cannon, and from the father it was but a natural transition to the daughter, so much the more attractive of the pair. Dominick was soon inwardly writhing under an exceedingly ingenious and searching catechism.

Had he been less preoccupied by his own acute discomfort, he might have noticed that Berny herself gave evidence of disturbance. As she prodded him with her questions, her face was suffused with unusual color, and the eagerness of her curiosity shone through the carelessness with which she sought to veil it. Certain queries she accompanied with a piercing glance of investigation, watching with hungry sharpness the countenance of the persecuted man. Fearful of angering her, or, still worse, of arousing her suspicions, Dominick bore the examination with all the fortitude he had, but he rose from the table with every nerve tingling, rasped and galled to the limit of endurance.

He did not come into the den immediately but roamed about, into the parlor, down the passage, and into his own room. He spread the scent of his cigar and its accompanying films of smoke all through the flat, a thing that Berny would never have ordinarily allowed. To-night she was too occupied in listening to his prowling steps to bother about minor rules and regulations. She saw in his restlessness a disturbance evoked by her questionings.

“Aren’t you coming into the den?” she called, as she heard him pacing steadily along the passageway.

“No,” he called back. “The moonlight’s shining in at every window. It makes me restless. I don’t feel like sitting still.”

She sat on the divan, a paper spread before her face, but her eyes were slanted sidewise, unblinking in the absorption of her attention. Suddenly she heard a rattling sound which she knew to be from the canes and umbrellas in the hat-rack. She cast away the paper, and, drawing herself to the edge of the divan, peered down the passage. Dominick was standing by the hat-rack, his hat on the back of his head, his hand feeling among the canes.

“You’ve got your hat on,” she called in a high key of surprise. “You’re not going out?”

“Yes, I am,” he answered, drawing out the cane he wanted. “It’s a fine night, and I’m going for a walk.”

“For a walk?”—there was hesitancy in her tone, and for a horrible moment, he thought she was going to suggest coming with him. “Where are you going to?”

“Oh, I don’t know, just prowl about. I want some exercise.”

“Are you going to your mother’s?” she ventured, not without some timidity.

“No,” he said, “I’m not going anywhere in particular. Good night.”

She sat forward, listening to his descending feet and the bang of the hall door. A glance at the window showed her it was, as he said, a fine night, deluged with the radiance of the moon. Probably he was just going out for a walk and not to see anybody. He was always doing queer things like that. But,—Berny sat staring in front of her, biting her nails and thinking. Uneasiness had been planted in her by Dominick’s flight to Antelope. More poignant uneasiness had followed that first attack. Now the bitter corrosive of jealousy began to grow and expand in her. Sitting huddled on the divan, she thought of Dominick, walking through the moonlight to Rose Cannon, and another new and griping pang laid hold upon her.

Outside, Dominick walked slowly, keeping to the smaller and less frequented streets. It was a wonderful night, as still as though the moon had exerted some mesmeric influence upon the earth. Everything was held motionless and without sound in a trance-like quietude. In the gardens not a

blossom stirred. Where leaves extended from undefined darknesses of foliage, they stood out, stem and fiber, with a carved distinctness, their shadows painted on the asphalt walks in inky silhouette. There was no lamplight to warm the clear, still pallor of the street's vista. It stretched between the fronts of houses, a river of light, white and mysterious, like a path in a dream.

It was a night for lovers, for trysts, and for whispered vows. Dominick walked slowly, feeling himself an outsider in its passionate enchantment. The scents that the gardens gave out, and through which he passed as through zones of sweetness, were part of it. So were the sounds that rose from the blotted vagueness of white figures on a porch, from impenetrable depths of shadow—laughter, low voices, little cries. In the distance people were singing snatches of a song that rose and fell, breaking out suddenly and as suddenly dropping into silence.

His course was not aimless, and took him by a slow upward ascent to that high point of the city, whence the watcher can look down on the bay, the rugged, engirdling hills, and the hollow of North Beach. Here he stood, resting on his cane, and gazing on the far-flung panorama, with the white moon sailing high and its reflection glittering across the water. Along the bases of the hills the clotted lights of little towns shone in faintly-glimmering agglomerations. At his feet the hollow lay like a black hole specked with hundreds of sparks. Each spark was the light of a home, symbol of the fire of a hearth. He stood looking down on them, thinking of what they represented, that cherished center round which a man's life revolves, and which he, by his own sin and folly, had lost for ever.

He walked on, skirting the hollow, and moving forward through streets where old houses brooded in overgrown gardens. The thin music of strings rose on the night, and two men passed him playing on the mandolin and guitar. They walked with quick, elastic steps, their playing accurately in accord, their bodies swaying slightly to its rhythm. They swung by him, and the vibrating harmonies, that sounded so frail and attenuated in the suave largeness of the night, grew faint and fainter, as if weighed upon and gradually extinguished by the dense saturation of the moonlight.

Music was evidently a mode of expression that found favor on this evening of still brilliance. A few moments later a sound of singing rose on the air

and a youthful couple came into view, walking close together, their arms twined about each other, caroling in serene indifference to such wayfarers as they might meet. They passed him, their faces uplifted to the light, their mouths open in the abandon of their song. Unconscious of his presence, with upraised eyes and clasping arms, they paced on, filling the night with their voices—a boy and girl in love, singing in the moonlight. Dominick quickened his steps, hastening from the sound.

The moon was now high in the sky and the town lay dreaming under its spell. Below him he could see the expanse of flat roofs, shining surfaces between inlayings of shadow, with the clefts of the streets cut through at regular intervals like slices made by a giant knife. Now and then he looked up at the dome above, clear and solemn, the great disk floating in solitary majesty across the vast and thoughtful heaven.

That part of California Street which crested the hill was but a few blocks beyond him, and before his mind would acknowledge it, his feet had borne him that way. He thought only to pass the Cannon house, to look at its windows, and see their lights. As it rose before him, a huge, pale mass checkered with shadows, the longing to see it—the outer shell that hid his heart's desire—passed into a keener, concentrated agitation that seemed to press out from his soul like a cry to her.

The porch yawned black behind pillars that in the daytime were painted wood and now looked like temple columns wrought in marble. Dominick's glance, sweeping the lines of yellowed windows, finally rested on this cavern of shadow, and he approached stealthily, as a robber might, his body close to the iron fence. Almost before his eyes had told him, he knew that a woman was standing there, leaning against the balustrade that stretched between the columns. A climbing rose spread, in a mottling of darkness, over the wall beside her. Here and there it was starred with the small white faces of blossoms. As the young man drew near she leaned over the balustrade, plucked one of the blossoms, and, slowly shredding the leaves from the stem, stretched out her hand and let them fall, like a languid shower of silver drops, to the grass.

Dominick halted below her, leaning against the fence and looking up. She did not see him and stretched out her hand again for another blossom. The petals of this one fell through her fingers, one by one, and lay, a scattering

of white dots, on the darkness of the grass. She bent over the balustrade to look at them, and in doing so, her eyes encountered the man below.

For a moment they looked at each other without speaking, then she said, her voice at the lowest note that would reach him,

“What are you doing there?”

“Watching you.”

“Have you been standing there long?”

“No, only a few minutes. Why are you pulling the roses to pieces?”

She gave a little laugh and said something that sounded like “I don’t know,” and moved back from the balustrade.

He thought she was going, and clutched the iron spikes of the fence, calling up to her in a voice of urgent feeling, curiously out of keeping with the words, the first remark that came into his head:

“This is very different from Antelope, isn’t it?”

She came forward again and looked out and up at the sky.

“Yes,” she said gravely, “we had no moonlight there, nothing but storms and gray clouds.”

“But it was lovely,” he answered in the same key. “The clouds and the storms didn’t matter. Those were three—three great weeks.”

He ended lamely but they were the best words he could get, trying to say something that would keep her there, trying to see her through the vaporous light. She bent over the railing looking for another rose, but there were no more within her reach and she gave the short, nervous laugh she had given before and turned her eyes on him again. Then he realized that she was agitated. The knowledge augmented his own perturbation and for a moment he did not trust himself to speak. He gazed at her fixedly, the look of a lover, and was not conscious that she wavered under it, till she suddenly drew a quick breath, turned her head sidewise, and said, with an effort at naturalness,

“Well, I must go in. The roses are all picked and papa’ll be wondering where I am.”

It seemed to Dominick just then that he could not lose her. She must stay a moment longer. Urgency that was imploring was in his voice as he said,

“Don’t go! don’t go! Stay just one moment longer! Can’t you come down and talk for a minute? Come part of the way down. I want to speak to you for a little bit longer. It may be months before I see you again.”

She listened, wavered, and was won over. Without answer she turned from the shadow of the porch into the light on the top of the steps, and from there slowly descended, her skirt gathered in one hand, and the other touching the baluster. She was in black and from its dead density her arms, bare to the elbow, shone as white as the arms of a marble woman. The baluster ended in a lion crouching in sleep on a slab of stone, and she paused here and Dominick went up the few steps from the street to meet her. With the sleeping lion between them they looked at each other with troubled eyes.

The moonlight seemed to have drawn from the meeting the artificialities of worldly expression, which in the sensible, familiar daylight would have placed it on the footing of a casual, to-be-expected encounter. The sun beating down on lovers beats some of their sentimental transports out of them. Now in this mystic, beautifying luminosity, the acquired point of view, the regard for the accepted conventions of every-day seemed to have receded to a great distance, to be thin, forgotten things that had nothing to do with real life. For a moment Berny ceased to be a living presence, standing with a flaming sword between them. They almost forgot her. The memory that pressed upon them was that of their last meeting. It shone in their eyes and trembled on their lips. The sleeping lion that separated them was a singularly appropriate symbol.

Low-voiced and half-spoken sentences belonged to this romantic moment. The moonlit night around them was still and empty, but Dominick spoke as though other ears than hers were listening:

“I’ve wanted so to see you. I came by to-night hoping that perhaps I could catch a glimpse of your shadow on the curtain. I didn’t expect anything like this.”

He stopped, looking at her, and not listening to the few words of her answer.

“I think I wanted you so that my will called you out,” he said in an impassioned whisper.

She said nothing and suddenly his hand sought hers, clasped it tight on the head of the lion, and he whispered again,

“Oh, Rose, if I could see you now and then—only for a moment like this.”

He felt her hand, small and cold, crush softly inside his, and almost immediately was conscious of her effort to withdraw it. He instantly loosened his fingers, let hers slide from his grasp, and drew back.

“Good night,” she said hurriedly, and without looking at him turned and went up the steps.

“Good night,” he called after her, following her ascending figure with his eyes.

When she reached the shadow at the top of the steps, she called “Good-by,” passed into the engulfing blackness, and was gone. He waited till he heard the door bang behind her, then descended the steps and walked slowly home, his eyes on the pavement.

Berny was in her own room ready for bed when she heard his ascending footsteps. She was occupied in rubbing a skin-food into her face, with careful circular motions and pinchings of her finger-tips. It was a task that required deep attention and which she performed three nights in the week with conscientious regularity. With her face gleaming with grease she crept to her door and listened, heard his cane slide into the umbrella holder, and the door of his room shut with a softness which told her that he thought her asleep. She walked back to the glass and resumed her manipulations, but with diminished zeal. The clock on the bureau marked the hour at half-past ten. Dominick had been out two hours. Would a man walk round a city—even a crank like her husband—all by himself for two hours?

CHAPTER XVI

FAMILY AFFAIRS

Every summer afternoon the trade winds blow through San Francisco, winging their way across miles of chill, salt sea, and striking the bulwarked city with a boisterous impact. The long streets seem as paths, lines of least resistance, and the winds press themselves into the narrow limits and whoop buoyantly along, carrying before them dust, rags, scraps of paper—sometimes hats.

Their period of highest recognized activity is from May till September, but before that, vagrant breezes, skirmishers sent out in advance, assault the city. They follow on still, sunny mornings, which show not the slightest warning symptom of the riotous forces which are designing to seize upon and disrupt the tranquillity of the afternoon. Eleven sees them up and stirring; by midday they have begun the attack. The city, in a state of complete unpreparedness, is at their mercy and they sweep through it in arrogant triumph, veiled in a flying scud of dust. Unsuspecting wayfarers meet them at corners, and stand, helpless victims of a playfulness, fierce and disconcerting as that of tigers. Hats, cleverly running on one rim, career along the sidewalk. Ladies have difficulties with parasols, heretofore docile and well-behaved. Articles of dress, accustomed to hang decorously, show sudden ambitions to rise and ride the elements. And those very people who in winter speak gratefully of the winds as “the scavengers of San Francisco” may be heard calling curses down on them.

Such a wind, the first of the season, was abroad on a bright morning in early April, and Cornelia Ryan was out in it. It was a great morning for Cornelia. Even the wind could not ruffle her joyousness. She was engaged. Two evenings before, Jack Duffy, who had been hovering round the subject for a month, poised above it, as a hawk above delightful prey, had at last descended and Cornelia’s anxieties were at an end. She had been so relieved, elated, and flustered that she had not been able to pretend the proper surprise, but had accepted blushing, stammering and radiant. She had been blushing, stammering and radiant when she told her mother that

night, and to-day, forty-eight hours later, she was still blushing, stammering, and radiant.

It was not alone that she was honestly in love with Jack, but Cornelia, like most maidens in California and elsewhere, was in love with being admired, deferred to, and desired. And despite her great expectations and her prominent position, she had had rather less of this kind of delightful flattery than most girls. Walking down town in the clear, sun-lit morning, she was, if not handsome, of a fresh and blooming wholesomeness, which is almost as attractive and generally wears better. The passers-by might readily have set her down as a charming woman, for whom men sighed, and in this surmise been far from the mark. She had had few lovers before Jack Duffy. That matter-of-fact sturdiness, that absence of softness and mystery so noticeable in Californian women, was particularly accentuated in her case, and had robbed her of the poetic charm of which beauty and wealth can never take the place.

But to-day she was radiant, a sublimated, exultant Cornelia, loved at last and by a man of whom she could completely and unreservedly approve. There were times when Cornelia—she was thirty—had feared that she might have to go abroad and acquire a foreign husband, or, worse still, move to New York and make her selection from such relics of decayed Knickerbocker families as were in the market. She was woman enough to refuse to die unwed. Now these dark possibilities were dispelled. In her own state, in her own town, she had found her mate, Jack Duffy, whose father had known her father and been shift boss under Bill Cannon in the roaring days of Virginia City. It was like royalty marrying into its own order, the royalty of Far Western millions, knowing its own ramifications having its own unprinted Almanach de Gotha—deep calling unto deep!

The wind was not yet out in force; its full, steady sweep would not be inaugurated till early in the afternoon. It came now in gusts which fell upon Cornelia from the back and accelerated her forward progress, throwing out on either side of her a flapping sail of skirt. Cornelia, who was neat and precise, usually resented this rough handling, but to-day she only laughed, leaning back, with one hand holding her hat. In the shops where she stopped to execute various commissions she had difficulty in suppressing her smiles. She would have liked to delay over her purchases and chat with the

saleswomen, and ask them about their families, and send those who looked tired off for a month into the country.

It was after midday when she found herself approaching that particular block, along the edge of which the flower-venders place their baskets and display their wares. In brilliantly-colored mounds the flowers stood stacked along the outer rim of the sidewalk, a line of them, a man behind each basket vociferating the excellence of the bouquet he held forward to the passer's inspection. In the blaze of sun that overlaid them, the piled-up blossoms showed high-colored and variegated as a strip of carpeting.

Cornelia never bought flowers at the street corners. The town house was daily supplied from the greenhouses at the country place at Menlo. When sick friends, anniversaries, or entertainment called for special offerings they were ordered from expensive florists and came in made-up bunches, decorated with sashes of ribbon. But to-day she hesitated before the line of laden baskets. Some of the faces behind them looked so dreary, and Cornelia could not brook the sight of a dreary face on this day of joy. The dark, wistful eyes of an Italian boy holding out a bunch of faded jack roses, stiffly set in a fringe of fern, made a sudden appeal to her and she bought the roses. Then the old man who was selling carnations looked so lean and grizzled that he must be cheered, and two bunches of the carnations were added to the roses. The boys and men, seeing that the brilliant lady was in a generous mood, collected about her, shouting out the excellences of their particular blossoms, and pressing sample bunches on her attention.

Cornelia, amused and somewhat bewildered, looked at the faces and bought recklessly. She was stretching out her hand to beckon to the small boy with the wilted pansies, who was not big enough to press through the throng, when a man's voice behind her caught her ear.

"Well, Cornelia, are you trying to corner the curb-stone market?"

She wheeled swiftly and saw her brother, laughing and looking at the stacked flowers in the crook of her arm.

"Dominick!" she exclaimed, "you're just the person I want to see. I was going to write to you. I've got lots to tell you."

"Come along then and take lunch with me. I was on my way up to Bertrand's when I saw you. They'll give us a good lunch there and you can

tell me all your secrets.”

The flower sellers, who had been listening with unabashed eagerness, realized that their prey was about to be ravished from them, and raised their voices in a chorus of wailing appeal. As Cornelia moved forward they moved round her, thrusting bouquets under her eyes in a last hope, the boy with the wilted pansies, on the brink of tears, hanging on the outskirts of the crowd. Cornelia might have forgotten him, but her eye, sweeping back for an absent moment, saw his face, bereft of all hope—a face of childish despair above his drooping pansies.

“Here, boy with the pansies,” she called, and sent a silver dollar through the air toward him, “that’s for you. Keep it and the flowers, too. I’ve too many now and can’t carry any more. Maybe he’ll sell them to some one else,” she said to Dominick, as they crossed the street. “He’s such a little boy to be earning his bread!”

They walked up the street toward Bertrand’s, a French restaurant which for years had enjoyed the esteem of the city’s gourmets. The wind was now very high. It tore at Cornelia’s clothes and made it necessary for Dominick to hold his hat on, his hand spread flat on the crown. A trail of blossoms, torn from the flowers each carried, sprinkled the pavement behind them. Cornelia, with her head down and her face toward her brother, shouted remarks at him, every now and then pausing in a stifle of laughter to struggle with her draperies, which at one moment rose rebellious, and at the next were wound about her in an umbrella-like sheath.

They had often met this way in the past, when the elder Mrs. Ryan’s wrath had been in its first, untameable freshness, and her son had seen her seldom. In those days of estrangement, Cornelia had been the tie between Dominick and his home. She loved her brother and was sorry for him, and had felt the bitterness of the separation, not alone as a family misfortune, but as a scandal over which mean people talked. Had it rested with her, she would long ago have overlooked the past and have opened the door to her sister-in-law. Not that she felt any regard or interest in Berny Iverson; her feeling for her was now, and always would be, largely composed of that undying unfriendliness and repugnance that the naturally virtuous woman feels for her sister with the *tache*. But Cornelia was of a younger and milder generation than her mother. She had not fought hard for what she had and,

like Dominick, there was more of the sunny-tempered, soft-hearted Con Ryan in her than of the strong and valiant woman who had made him and given him his place in the world.

In the restaurant they found a vacant table in a corner, and Cornelia had to bottle up her good news while Dominick pondered over the bill of fare. She was impatient and drummed on the table with her fingers, while her eyes roamed about the room. Once or twice, she bowed to people that she knew, then let her glance pass in an uninterested survey over the bare walls and the long line of windows that gave on the street. The place had an austere, severe, unadorned air. Its bleakness of naked wall and uncovered stone floor added to the foreignness that was contributed by the strong French accent of the waiters, and the arrangement of a cashier's desk near the door, where a pleasant-faced woman sat between a large bouquet of roses and a drowsy gray cat.

The orders given and the first stages of lunch appearing, Cornelia could at last claim her brother's full attention. Planting her elbows on the table and staring at him, she said,

"I told you how awfully anxious I was to see you, and how I was going to write to you, didn't I?"

Dominick nodded. He was buttering a piece of bread and showed no particular acceleration of curiosity at this query.

"Well, now, what do you suppose I was going to write about?" asked his sister, already beginning to show a heightened color.

"Can't imagine. Nothing wrong with mother, I hope?"

Since his marriage Cornelia had been in the habit of communicating frequently with her brother by letter. It was the best way of keeping him informed of family affairs. The telephone at the senior Ryan house was sufficiently secluded to make it a useful medium of private communication, but the telephone at the junior Ryan house did not share this peculiarity, and Dominick discouraged his sister's using it.

"No, mother's all right," said Cornelia. "And it's nothing wrong about anybody. Quite the other way; it's something about me, and it's something cheerful. Guess!"

Her brother looked up and his eye was caught by her rosily-blushing cheeks.

“Dear me, Cornie,” he said with a look of slowly-dawning comprehension, “it really isn’t—it really can’t be——?”

The waiter here interrupted further confidence by setting forth the lunch with many attentive bowings and murmurings. By the time he had presented one dish for Cornelia’s approval, removed it with a flourish and presented another, her impatience broke out in an imploring,

“Yes, Etienne, it’s all *perfectly* lovely. *Do* put it on the table and let’s eat it. That’s what it’s for, not to hand round and be stared at, as if it were a diamond necklace that I was thinking of buying.”

Etienne, thus appealed to, put the viands on the table, and Dominick, deeply interested, leaned forward and said,

“What is it? Go ahead. I’m burning up with curiosity.”

“Guess,” said his sister, bending over her plate.

“Is it that you’re going to be married? Oh, Cornie, it can’t be.”

“And why can’t it be?” looking very much hurt. “What’s there so queer about that?”

“Nothing, only I meant that I hadn’t heard any rumors about it. *Is it that?*”

“Yes, it is, Dominick Ryan, and I don’t see why you should be so surprised.”

“Surprised! I’m more than surprised. I’m delighted—haven’t been so pleased for years. Who is it?”

“Jack Duffy.”

“Oh, Cornie, that’s the best yet! That’s great! It’s splendid. I wish I could kiss you, but I can’t here in the open restaurant. Why didn’t you tell me somewhere where we would be alone? I’d just like to give you a good hug.”

Cornelia, who had been a little hurt at her brother’s incredulity, was now entirely mollified and once again became bashfully complacent.

“I thought you’d like it,” she said. “I thought you’d think that was just about right. Any girl would be proud of *him*.”

“He’s one of the best fellows in the state—one of the best anywhere. He’ll make you a first-rate husband. You’re a lucky girl.”

“I know I am. You needn’t tell me. There are not many men anywhere like Jack Duffy. I’ve always said I wouldn’t marry the tag, rag and bobtail other girls are satisfied with. *My* husband was going to be a gentleman, and if Jack’s anything, he’s that.”

“You’re right there. He’s one of Nature’s gentlemen—the real kind.”

Cornelia thought this savored of condescension, and said, rallying to the defense of her future lord,

“Well, that’s all right, but he’s educated too. He’s not one of those men who have good hearts and noble yearnings but look like anarchists or sewing-machine agents. Jack graduated high at Harvard. He went there when he was only eighteen. There’s no one’s had a better education or done better by it. His father may have been Irish and worked as shift boss on the Rey del Monte, but Jack’s quite different. He’s just as much of a gentleman as anybody in this country.”

Cornelia’s attitude on matters of genealogy was modern and Californian. Ireland was far behind her and Jack, as were also those great days in Nevada of which her mother and Bill Cannon spoke, as the returned Ulysses might have spoken of the ten years before Troy. She and Jack would eventually regard them as a period of unsophistication and social ferment which it were wisest to touch on lightly, and of which they would teach their children nothing.

“And then,” Cornelia went on, determined not to slight any detail of her fiancé’s worthiness, “there’s never been anything fast or wild about Jack. He’s always been straight. There’s been no scandalous stories about him, as there have about Terence.”

“Never. Terence committed all the scandals for the family.”

“Well, Terence is in New York, thank Heaven!” said Cornelia with pious fervor, “and we won’t have to have anything to do with him or his wife either. Even if we go to Europe, we need only stay there a few days.”

The irregular career of Terence had been a thorn in the side of the respectable Duffys, he, some years earlier, having married his mistress, a chorus girl in a local theater, and attempted to force her upon the exclusive circles in which his people moved. It was not the least galling feature of Terence's unconventional course that, having doubled his fortune by successful speculations, he had removed to New York where, after several spirited assaults and vigorous rebuffs, his wife had reached social heights toward which other Californians of spotless record and irreproachable character had clambered in vain.

"Well," said Dominick, "mother ought to be satisfied with *this* marriage. It's a good thing one of her children is going to settle down the way she likes."

"Oh, she's delighted. She's not been in such good spirits for a long time, and she's as interested as I am in arranging everything. We want to have a large house wedding; the two families and all their connections, and all our intimate friends, and all the people who've entertained us,—and—and—the whole crowd. Of course, it'll be a lot of people. Mommer said she didn't see how we could cut it down to less than five or six hundred. But I don't see why we need to, the house is big enough."

"Plenty," said Dominick. He set down his knife and fork and looked at his sister. "Our family don't take up much room. There's just three of us."

"Then you're coming?" she said quickly, her anxiety flashing out into an almost pained intensity of eagerness. "You'll come? You must, Dominick. You've got to give me away."

He looked away from her in moody discomfort. The eternal discussions created by his marriage were becoming more and more hateful to him. Why should his unloved and unloving wife perpetually stand between him and his own people—his mother and sister—women to whom he owed allegiance, even as he did to her? The call of his home and the binding ties of kin were growing stronger as the obligation of his marriage had weakened and lost its hold.

Cornelia leaned across the table and spoke with low-toned, almost tremulous earnestness:

"You know that if it were I, I'd ask your wife. You know that all the hard feelings I may once have had against her have gone. If it were for me to say,

I'd have received her from the start. What I've always said is, 'What's the good of keeping up these fights? No one gets anything by them. They don't do any one any good.' But you know mommer. The first thing she said when we talked about the house wedding, and I said you'd give me away, was, 'If he'll come without his wife.' Those were her very words, and you know when she says a thing she means it. And, Dominick, you *will* come? You're the only brother I've got. You're the only man representative of the family. You can't turn me down on my wedding day."

There were tears in her eyes and Dominick saw them and looked down at his plate.

"All right," he said quietly. "I'll come. When is it to be?"

"Oh, Dominick," his sister breathed in an ecstasy of relief and gratitude. "I knew you would. And I'll do anything for you I can. If mommer wouldn't get so dreadfully angry, I'd call on your wife, but you know I can't offend her. She's my mother, and I can't stand up against her. But some day I'll pay you back—I will indeed."

"Oh, that's all right, Cornie," he said, turning to summon the waiter. "I can't let my sister get married without me. Tell mother I'll come. You haven't yet told me when it's to be."

"June," said the prospective bride, once more beginning to blush and beam, "early in June. The roses are so fine then, and we can have the house so beautifully decorated. We've already begun to plan the trousseau. It's going to be just stunning, I tell you; the dresses from New York and all the lingerie and things like that from Paris. Mommer says she'll give me fifteen thousand dollars for it. And she's going to give me, besides, a string of pearls that hangs down to here"—Cornelia indicated a point on her person with a proud finger—"or else a house and lot anywhere in town that I like. Which would you take?"

Dominick was saved from the responsibility of stating a preference on this important point by Etienne, the waiter, presenting his hat to him with the low bow of the well-tipped garçon. With a scraping of chair legs, they rose and, threading their way among the now crowded tables, passed out into the wind-swept streets. Here they separated, Cornelia, with her armful of wilting flowers, going home, and Dominick back to the bank.

He was entering the building when he met Bill Cannon, also returning to his office from a restaurant lunch at a small Montgomery Street chop-house, where, every day at one, he drank a glass of milk and ate a sandwich. The Bonanza King stopped and spoke to the young man, his greeting marked by a simple friendliness. Their conversation lasted a few minutes, and then Dominick entered the bank.

Two hours later, while he was still bending over his books, in the hushed seclusion of the closed building, Bill Cannon was talking to Berny in the parlor of the Sacramento Street flat. This interview was neither so long, and (on Berny's part) did not show the self-restraint which had marked the first one. The offer of one hundred thousand dollars which the old man made her was refused with more scorn and less courtesy than had been displayed in her manner on the former occasion.

CHAPTER XVII

A CUT AND A CONFESSION

Berny was extremely unsettled. She had never been in such a condition of worry and indecision. She was at once depressed and elated, triumphant and cast down, all in a bubble of excitement and uncertainty. A combination of violent feelings, hostile to one another, had possession of her and used her as a battle-ground for shattering encounters.

She loved money with the full power of her nature—it was her strongest, her predominating passion—and now for the first time in her life it was within her grasp. She could at any moment become possessed of a fortune, undisputedly her own, to do with as she liked. She lay awake at night thinking of it. She made calculations on bits of paper as she footed up the bills at her desk.

But then on the other hand, there was Dominick, Dominick suddenly become valuable. He was like a piece of jewelry held in slight esteem as a trifling imitation and suddenly discovered to be real and of rich worth. Insignificant and strange are the happenings which determine the course of events. The sage had told her that one more inch in the length of Cleopatra's nose would have altered the face of the world and changed the course of history. Had Berny not gone to the park on that Sunday afternoon, and seen a woman's face change color at the sight of her husband, she might have come to terms with Mrs. Ryan and now have been on her way to Chicago in the first stage of the plan of desertion.

It was another woman's wanting Dominick that made Berny more determined to cling to him than if he had been the Prince Charming of her dreams. She carried about with her a continual feeling of self-congratulation that she had discovered the full significance of the plot in time. Her attitude was that of the quarreling husband and wife who fight furiously for the possession of a child for which neither cares. To herself she kept saying, "They want my husband, do they? Well, I'll take mighty good care, no matter how much they want him and he wants to go, they don't get him."

It made her boil with rage to think of them all, with Dominick at their head, getting everything they wanted and sending her off to Paris, even though Paris might be delightful, and she have a great deal better time there than she ever had in San Francisco.

All these thoughts were in her mind as she walked down town one afternoon for her usual diversion of shopping and promenading. Of late she had not been sleeping well and the fear that this would react upon her looks had spurred her to the unwonted exertion of walking. The route she had chosen was one of those thoroughfares which radiate from Market Street, and though not yet slums, are far removed from the calm, wide gentility of the city's more dignified highways. With all her cleverness, she had never shaken off the tastes and instincts of the class she had come from. She felt more at home in this noisy byway, where children played on the pavements and there were the house-to-house intimacies, the lack of privacy, of the little town, than she did on the big, clean-swept streets where the houses presented a blank exterior to the gaze, and most of the people were transported in cars or carriages. Even the fact that the Tenderloin was in close proximity did not modify her interest with a counteracting disgust; though she was not one of the women who have a lively curiosity as to that dark side of life, it did not, on the other hand, particularly repel her. She viewed it with the same practical utilitarianism with which she regarded her own virtue. That possession had been precious to her for what she could gain with it. When she had sacrificed it to her ambition, she had not liked giving it up at all, but had reconciled herself to doing so because of the importance of the stake involved.

Walking loiteringly forward she crossed Powell Street, and approached the entrance of that home of vaudeville, the Granada Theater. This was a place of amusement that she much favored, and of which she was a frequent patron. Dominick did not like it, so she generally went to the matinee with one of her sisters. There had been a recent change of bill, and as she drew near she looked over the posters standing by the entrance on which the program for the coming week was printed in large letters. Midway down one of these, her eye was caught by a name and she paused and stood reading the words:

“JAMES DEFAY BUFORD
The Witty, Brilliant and Incomparable

MONOLOGIST
In His Unrivalled Monologue
Entitled
KLONDIKE MEMORIES”

She remembered at once that this was the actor Dominick had spoken of as having been snowed in with them at Antelope. Dominick had evidently not expected he would come to San Francisco. He had said the man had been going to act in Sacramento. After standing for some moments looking at the words, she moved on again with the short, mincing step that was habitual to her, and which always made walking a slow and undesirable mode of progression. She seemed more thoughtful than she had been before she saw the program, and for some blocks her face wore an absent and somewhat pensive air of musing.

Her preoccupation lasted up Grant Avenue and down Post Street till it was finally dispelled by the sight of that attractive show-window in which a large dry-goods establishment exhibits the marvels of new millinery. It was April, and the spring fashions were just in from Paris, filling the window with a brilliant display of the newest revolutionary modes of which San Francisco had so far only heard. Women stood staring, some dismayed at the introduction of styles which they felt would have a blighting, not to say obliterating effect on their own beauty. Others, of practical inclinations, studied the new gowns with an eye to discoveries whereby their wardrobes might be induced to assume a deceptive air of second youth.

Berny elbowed her way in among them and pressed herself close to the glass, exploring, with a strained glance, the intricacies of back draperies turned from view. She wished Hazel was there with her. Hazel was wonderfully sharp at seeing how things were put together, and could carry complications of trimming and design in her head without forgetting them or getting them mixed. The discovery that skirts were being cut in a new way gave Berny a shock of painful surprise, especially when she thought of her raspberry crape, still sufficiently new to be kept in its own box between layers of tissue paper, and yet at the stage when the necessity of paying for it was at a comfortable, unvexing distance.

She was standing with her back to the street when a woman next her gave a low exclamation and uttered the name of Mrs. Con Ryan. Berny wheeled

about just as the exceedingly smart victoria of Mrs. Cornelius Ryan drew up at the curb and that august matron prepared to descend from it. In these afternoon shopping excursions she had often met her mother-in-law, often met her and invariably seen her turn her head and fix her eyes in the opposite direction. Now, however, matters were on another footing. If Mrs. Ryan had not recognized Berny, or spoken to her, or received her, she had at least opened negotiations with her, negotiations which presupposed a knowledge of her existence if not a desire for her acquaintance. Berny did not go so far as to anticipate a verbal greeting, but she thought, in consideration of recent developments, she was warranted in expecting a bow.

She moved forward almost in Mrs. Ryan's path, paused, and then looked at the large figure moving toward her with a certain massive stateliness. This time Mrs. Ryan did not turn her head away. Instead, she looked at the young woman directly and steadily, looked at her full in the eye with her own face void of all recognition, impassive and stonily unmoved as the marble mask of a statue. Berny, her half-made bow checked as if by magic, her face deeply flushed, walked on. She moved down the street rapidly, her head held high, trembling with indignation.

Such are the strange, unaccountable contradictions of the female character that she felt more incensed by this cut than by any previous affront or slight the elder woman had offered her. The anticipated bow, neither thought of nor hoped for till she had seen Mrs. Ryan alighting from the carriage, was suddenly a factor of paramount importance in the struggle between the two. So small a matter as a nod of the elder woman's head would have made the younger woman more pliable, more tractable and easily managed, than almost any other action on her mother-in-law's part. Berny, bowed to, would have been a more docile, reasonable person than either Mrs. Ryan or Bill Cannon had had yet to deal with; while Berny, cut, flamed up into a blaze of mutinous fury that, had they known it, would have planted dismay in the breasts of those bold conspirators.

As she walked down the street she was at first too angry to know where she was going, but after a few moments of rapid progress she saw that she was approaching the car line which passed close to her old home. In the excitement of her wrath, the thought of her sisters—the only human beings who could be relied on unquestioningly and ungrudgingly to offer her

sympathy—came to her with a sense of consolation and relief. A clock in a window showed her it was nearly five. Hannah would have been home for some time, and Hazel might be expected within an hour. Without more thought she hailed an up-town car.

As the car whisked her up the long hill from Kearney Street she thought what she would say to her sisters. Several times of late she had contemplated letting them into the secrets—or some of the secrets—of her married life and its present complications. She wanted their sympathy, for they were the only people she knew who were interested in her through affection, and did not blame her when she did things that were wrong. She also wanted to surprise them and to impress them. She wanted to see their eyes grow round, and their faces more and more startled, as she told of what Mrs. Ryan was trying to do, and how the sum of one hundred thousand dollars was hers—their sister's—when she chose to take it. They were good people, the best people for her to tell it to. They did not know too much. They could be relied upon for a blind, uninquiring loyalty, and she could now (as she had before) tell them, not all—just enough—suppressing, as women do, those facts in the story which it were best for her to keep to herself.

She found them both at home, Hazel having been allowed to leave her work an hour earlier than usual. Sitting in a small room in the back of the house, they were surrounded by the outward signs of dressmaking. Yards of material lay over the chairs, and on a small wooden table, which fitted close to her body and upon which portions of the material lay neatly smoothed out, Hannah was cutting with a large pair of shears.

Hazel sat near by trimming a hat, a wide, flat leghorn, round which she twined a wreath of brier roses. Black velvet bows held the wreath in place, and Hazel skewered these down with long black pins, several of which she held in her mouth. Berny knew of old this outburst of millinery activity which always marked the month of April. It was the semi-annual rehabilitation of Pearl's wardrobe, and was a ceremonial to which all the females of the family were supposed to contribute. In her own day she herself had given time and thought to it. She had even been in sympathy with the idea of the family's rise and increase of distinction through Pearl, who was going to be many steps farther up the social ladder than her mother and her aunt, if those devoted women could possibly accomplish it.

Now, watching her sisters bent over their tasks after the heat and burden of their own day's work, she felt a deep, heartfelt sense of gratitude that she had escaped from this humble, domestic sphere in which they seemed so content. Whether Pearl's summer hat should be trimmed with pink or blue had once been a question which she had thought worthy of serious consideration. How far she had traveled from the world of her childhood could not have been more plainly shown her than by the complete indifference she now felt to Pearl, her hat, and its trimmings.

She had come prepared to surprise her sisters, and to shake out of them, by her revelations, the amazed and shocked sympathy she felt would ease her of her present wrath and pain. She was too overwrought to be diplomatic or to approach the point by preparatory gradations. Thrown back in the one arm-chair in the room, her head so pressed against its back that her hat was thrust forward over her forehead, she told them of her meeting with Mrs. Ryan, and the cut which she had received.

Neither Hannah nor Hazel expressed the outraged astonishment at this insult that Berny had anticipated. In fact, they took it with a tranquillity which savored of indifference. For the moment, she forgot that they knew nothing of her reason for expecting Mrs. Ryan to recognize her, and to her quivering indignation was added a last wounding sense of disappointment. The sight of Hazel, holding the leghorn hat off at arm's length and studying it with a preoccupied, narrowed eye, was even more irritating than her remark, made mumblingly because of the pins in her mouth:

"I don't see why you should feel so bad about that. I should think you'd have got sort of used to it by this time. She's been cutting you for over two years now."

"Do you think that makes it any better?" said Berny in a belligerent tone, not moving her head, but shifting her eyes to stare angrily at Hazel from under her projecting hat-brim. "Do you think you'd get used to it if Josh's mother cut you on the street?"

It was hard to compass the idea of Josh's deceased parent, who had left behind her a memory of almost unique meekness, cutting anybody. It made Hazel laugh and she had to bend her head down and take the pins out of her mouth before she could answer.

“Well, if she’d been doing it for over two years, I think I’d have got sort of broken to it by now,” she said. “What makes you so mad about it all of a sudden?”

“Maybe things aren’t just the same as they’ve been for the last two years,” said Berny darkly. “Maybe there’s a reason for Mrs. Ryan’s bowing to me.”

These words had the effect that the victim of the cut desired. Her sisters paused in their work and looked at her. There had been times lately when Hannah had felt uneasy about Berny’s fine marriage, and she now eyed the younger woman with sober intentness over the glasses pushed down toward the tip of her nose.

“Reason?” said Hazel. “What reason? Have you and she been trying to make up?”

“I don’t know whether you’d call it that or not,” said Berny.

“Have things really changed between you and her, Berny?” she asked gravely.

Hannah put down the shears and laid her hands on the table. She felt the coming revelations.

“Well, yes, I guess you’d say they have,” said Berny slowly, letting every word make its impression. “She’s trying to buy me off to leave Dominick. I suppose you’d call that a change.”

If Berny wanted to surprise her sisters, she certainly now had the satisfaction of realizing her hopes. For a moment they stared at her, too amazed to speak, even Hannah, who had scented difficulties, being completely unprepared—after the way of human nature—for the particular difficulty that had cropped up. It was Hazel who first spoke.

“Buy you off to leave Dominick? Give you money to go away from him, do you mean?”

“That’s what I said,” returned her sister with dry grimness. “She’s made me two offers to leave my husband, wants me to get out and, after I’ve gone for a year, ask him to bring suit for desertion.”

“My Lord!” murmured Hannah in a hushed voice of horror.

“Well, that beats anything I’ve ever heard!” exclaimed Hazel. “That beats the ball, and not speaking to you, and all the rest. It’s the worst yet! What’s made her do it? What’s the matter with her?”

“The same thing that’s always been the matter with her—she doesn’t like me, she wants to get rid of me. She tried to freeze me out first by not speaking to me, and leaving us to scramble along the best way we could on Dominick’s salary. Now, she’s seen that that won’t work, and she’s gone off on a new tack. She’s a woman of resources. If she finds the way blocked in one direction, she tries another.”

“She’s actually offered you money to leave Dominick?” asked Hannah. “Said she’d give it to you if you’d desert him and let him get a divorce?”

“That’s it,” returned her sister, in the same hard tone, tapping with her finger-tips on the arms of the chair. “That’s the flattering offer she’s made me twice now.”

“How much did she offer you?” said Hazel.

This was a crucial question. Berny knew its importance and sat up, pushing back her disarranged hat.

“One hundred thousand dollars,” she said calmly.

There was a second pause which seemed charged with astonishment, as with electrical forces. The sisters, their hands fallen in their laps, fastened their eyes on the speaker in a stare of glassy amaze.

“A hundred thousand dollars!” gasped Hazel. “Why—why—Berny!”

She stopped, almost trembling in the excitement of her stunned incredulity.

“*A hundred thousand dollars!*” Hannah echoed, each word pronounced with slow, aghast unbelief. “Oh, it *can’t* be that much!”

“It’s that much now,” said Berny, her calmness accentuated to the point of nonchalance, “and if I want I can make them double it, raise it to a quarter of a million. Two hundred and fifty thousand dollars isn’t so much when you’ve got millions in trunks. What’s that to the Ryans?”

She looked at her sisters with a cool, dispassionate glance, feeling that it had been worth while to tell them. Hannah’s face was a pale, uninteresting mask of shocked surprise—the kind of face with which one would imagine

Hannah's greeting such intelligence. But through the astonishment of Hazel's a close and intimate understanding of the possibilities of the situation, an eagerness of rising respect for it and for the recipient of such honors, was discernible and appealed to Berny's vanity and assuaged her more uncomfortable sensations.

"You could get a quarter of a million?" Hazel persisted. "How do you know that?"

Berny looked at her with disdain which was softened by a slight, indulgent smile.

"My dear, if they want it bad enough to offer one hundred thousand, they want it bad enough to offer two. The money is nothing to them, and I'm a good deal. I shouldn't be surprised if I could get more." She thought of Bill Cannon's participation in the matter, and let an expression of sly, knowing mysteriousness cross her face. But Bill Cannon's participation was a fact she did not intend to mention. He was a part of the story that she had decided to suppress.

"But two hundred and fifty thousand dollars!" said Hazel. "Why, it's a fortune! The interest on it alone would make you rich. You could go to Europe. You could have a house on Pacific Avenue. Just fancy! And three years ago you were working for twenty a week in the Merchants and Mechanics Trust Company. Do you remember when they agreed to give you that you thought you were on velvet? Twenty dollars a week! That looks pretty small now, doesn't it?"

"But she doesn't intend to take it, Hazel McCrae!" said Hannah in a deep voice of shocked disapproval. "You talk as if she was going to accept their outrageous offer."

Hazel's face, which, as her fancy ranged over these attractive possibilities, had shown varying stages of flushed and exhilarated excitement, now suddenly fell. Conscious that she had exhibited a condition of mind that was low and sordid, she hastily sought to obliterate the effect of her words by saying sharply,

"Of course, I knew she wasn't going to accept. I never had such an idea. I'd be the first one to turn it down. I was just thinking what she *could* do if she *did*."

“Oh, there’s any amount of things I could do,” said Berny. “They want me to go abroad and live there. That was”—she was going to say “one of the conditions,” but this, too, she decided to suppress, and said instead—“one of the things they suggested. They told me the income of the money would go twice as far there. Then the year while I was deserting Dominick—I was to go to Chicago, or New York, and desert him that way—I’d have seven thousand dollars for my expenses. They weren’t mean about it, I’ll say that much for them.”

“And then laying it all out like that!” said Hannah. “It’s just the most scandalous thing I’ve ever heard of. I’ve never had much opinion of Mrs. Ryan, but I really didn’t believe she’d go that far.”

“But Dominick?” said Hazel suddenly; “what about Dominick? What did he say?”

The matter of Dominick was the difficult part of the revelation. Berny felt the necessity of a certain amount of dissembling, and it helped to chill the excitement and heat that had carried her up to her sisters and on to this point. Dominick’s part of the story was one of the subjects upon which she had decided to let her remarks be as notes about the text, and expurgated notes at that. Now, she realized it was a complicated matter of which to tell only half, and looking on the floor pricked the carpet with the tip of her parasol, and tried to maintain her tone of airy indifference.

“Dominick doesn’t know anything about it,” she said. “He’s never to know. They were pretty decided on that point. He’s to be deserted without his own knowledge or consent.”

“But to take his wife away from him!” Hannah cried. “To rob him of her! They must be crazy.”

“Dominick can get along all right without me,” said Dominick’s wife, looking at the tip of her parasol as she prodded the carpet.

Hazel, the married sister, heard something in these words that the spinster did not recognize. A newly-wakened intelligence, startled and suspicious, dawned on her face.

“Dominick’s not so dead in love with me,” continued Berny, with her eyes following the parasol tip. “He could manage to bear his life without me. He

—” she paused, and then said, enraged to hear that her voice was husky —“doesn’t care a button whether I live or die.”

The pause that greeted this statement was entirely different from its predecessors. There was amazement in it, and there was pain. Neither listener could for a moment speak; then Hannah said with a solemnity full of dignity,

“I can’t believe that, Berny.”

“You needn’t if you don’t want to,” returned Berny, still not looking up. “If you like to keep on believing lies, it’s all the same to me. But I guess I know more about Dominick Ryan, and what he feels, than you do, and I tell you he doesn’t care a hang for me. He gave up caring”—she paused, a memory of the ball, the quarrel, and the fatal visit to Antelope flashing through her mind—“over a year ago. I guess,” she raised her head and looked coolly at her sisters, “he won’t lay awake nights at the thought of losing me.”

They looked at her without speaking, their faces curiously different in expression from what they had been after her first confessions. All excitement had gone from them. They looked more wounded and hurt than she did. They were women, dashed and mortified, by a piece of news that had abashed them in its admitted failure and humiliation of another woman.

“I—I—can’t believe it,” faltered Hannah. “Dominick’s always so kind, so attentive, so——”

She came to a stop, checked by an illuminating memory of the Sundays on which Dominick now never came to dinner, of his absence from their excursions to the park, of his mysterious mid-winter holiday to the Sierra.

“Have you had a row?” said Hazel. “Everybody has them some time and then you make up again, and it’s just the same as it was before. Fighting with your husband’s different from other fighting. It doesn’t matter much, or last.”

Berny looked down at the parasol tip. Her lips suddenly began to quiver, and tears, the rare burning tears of her kind, pricked into her eyes.

“We haven’t lived together for over eight months,” she said.

The silence that greeted this remark was the heaviest of all the silences.

“Why didn’t you tell us before?” said Hazel, in a low, awed voice.

For a moment, Berny could not answer. She was ashamed and angry at the unexpected emotion which made it impossible for her to command her voice, and made things shine before her eyes, brokenly, as through crystal. She was afraid her sisters would think she was fond of Dominick, or would guess the real source of the trouble.

“I was afraid something was wrong,” said Hannah, mechanically picking up the shears, her face pale and furrowed with new anxieties.

The concern in her tone soothed Berny. It was something not only to have astonished her family, but to have disturbed their peace by a forced participation in her woes. It had been enraging to think of them light-heartedly going their way while she struggled under such a load of care.

“It was all right till last autumn,” she said in a stifled voice, “and then it all got wrong—and—and—now it’s all gone to pieces.”

“But what made Dominick change?” said Hazel, with avid, anxious eagerness. “Everything was happy and peaceful a year ago. What got hold of him to change him?”

Berny felt that she had told enough. It had been harder telling, too, than she had imagined. The last and greatest secret that she had determined to keep from her sisters was that of Dominick’s love for another woman—what she regarded as his transfer of affection, not yet having guessed that his heart had never been hers. Now she raised her head and looked at the two solemn-faced women, angrily and bitterly, through the tears that her eyes still held.

“I don’t know, and I don’t care what’s changed him,” she said defiantly. “I stood by my side of the bargain, and that’s all I know. I’ve made him a good wife, as good a one as I knew how. I’ve been bright and pleasant when his family treated me like dirt. I’ve not complained and I’ve made the best of it, staying indoors and going nowhere, when any other woman would have been getting some sort of fun out of her life. I’ve managed that miserable little flat on not half enough money, and tried to keep out of debt, when any one else in the world would have run up bills all over for Mrs. Ryan to pay. Nobody can say I haven’t done my part all right. Maybe I’ve got my faults—most of us have—but I haven’t neglected my duty this time.”

She rose abruptly from her seat, pushing it back and feeling that she had better go before she said too much. She realized that in her hysterical and overwrought state she might become too loquacious and afterward regret it. For the moment she believed all she said. Her sisters, full of sincere sympathy for her, believed it too, though in periods of cooler reflection they would probably question some of her grievances; notably that one as to the small income, three thousand a year, representing to them complete comfort, not to say affluence.

As she rose, Hazel rose too, her face full of suspicious concern.

“It’s not another woman, is it, Berny?” she almost whispered.

Berny had told so many lies that she did not bother about a few more. Moreover, she was determined not to let her sisters know about Rose Cannon—not yet, anyway.

“No,” she said with short scorn, turning to pick up her feather boa. “Of course it’s not. He’s not that kind of a man. He’s too much of a sissy. Another woman! I’d like to tell him that.”

She gave a sardonic laugh and turned to the glass, disposing her boa becomingly and adjusting her hat. Hannah, shaking herself loose from the encircling embrace of the cutting table, rose too, exclaiming,

“Don’t go yet. You must tell us more of this. I’ve not heard anything for years that’s upset me so. If Dominick’s not in love with somebody else, what’s got into him? Why doesn’t he care for you any more? A man doesn’t stop loving his wife for no cause whatever. It isn’t in human nature.”

“Well, it’s in Dominick’s nature,” said Dominick’s wife, pulling on her gloves. “Maybe that isn’t human nature, but it’s the nature of the man I’m married to and that’s all that concerns me. Remember, you’re not to say a word about this. It’s all a secret.”

“Why should we talk about it?” said the practical Hazel. “It’s bad enough to have had it happen. You don’t want to go round gossiping about a member of your family getting thrown down.”

To their pressing invitations to remain longer, Berny was deaf. She had said her say and wanted to go. The interview had undoubtedly eased her of some of the choking exasperation that had followed Mrs. Ryan’s cut; and it was a

source of comfort to think that she had now broken the ice and could continue to come and pour out her wrongs and sorrows into the ever-attentive ears of her sisters. But now she wanted to get away from them, from their penetrative questions, and their frank curiosity, the curiosity of normal, healthy-minded women, whose lives had lacked the change and color of which hers had been full. She cut her good-bys short and left them to their own distracted speculations, staring blankly at each other, amid the scattered millinery of the disordered room.

When she reached home, she found on the hall table a note which the Chinaman told her had been left by a messenger. It was from Bill Cannon and contained but a few lines. These, of a businesslike brevity, expressed the writer's desire to see her again, and politely suggested that, if she could come to his office on any one of the three specified afternoons, between the hours of two and four, he would be deeply honored and obliged.

Berny, frowning and abstracted, was standing with the note in her hand when Dominick opened the hall door and came up the stairs. His eye casually fell on the square of paper, but he asked no question about it, hardly seemed to see it. Yet her state of suspicion was so sensitively active that his lack of interest seemed fraught with meaning, and pushing the letter back into its envelope she remarked that it was a note from her dressmaker. Even the fact that his answer was an indifferent, barely-articulated sound seemed significant to her, and she took the letter into her bedroom and hid it in her handkerchief box, as though her husband, instead of being the least, was the most curious and jealous of men.

CHAPTER XVIII

BUFORD'S GOOD LUCK

In his "Klondike Monologue" at the Orpheum, Buford, the actor, made a sudden and unexpected hit. The morning after his first appearance, both Dominick and Berny read in the paper eulogistic notices of the new star. Dominick was particularly interested. He remembered Buford's state of worry while at Antelope and was glad to see that the unlucky player was, in the parlance of his own world, "making good."

The evening papers contained more laudatory paragraphs. Buford's act was spoken of with an enthusiasm which taxed the vocabulary of the writers who found that the phrases they had been using to describe the regular vaudeville performances were not adequate for so sparkling an occasion.

It was a rambling monologue of mining-camp anecdotes, recollections, and experiences, delivered with confidential, simple seriousness. Buford's appearance in an immense, fur-lined overcoat with buttons made of gold nuggets and a voluminous fur cap on his head, was given the last touch of grotesqueness by a tiny tinsel spangle fastened on the end of his nose. This adornment, on his entrance hardly noticeable, was soon the focusing point of every eye. It looked as if it grew on its prominent perch, and as he spoke, a slight, vibrating movement, which he imparted to that portion of his visage, made the tinsel send out continuous, uneasy gleams. The more serious his discourse was and the more portentously solemn his face, the more glimmeringly active was the spangle, and the more hysterically unrestrained became the laughter of the audience. Altogether, Buford had made a success. Three days after his first appearance, people were talking about "The Klondike Monologue" as a few weeks before they had been talking about the last play of Pinero's as presented by a New York company.

From what Buford had told him, Dominick knew that the actor's luck had been bad, and that the period of imprisonment at Antelope was a last, crowning misfortune. Through it he feared that he had forfeited his Sacramento engagement, and the young man had a painful memory of the long jeremiad that Buford, in his anxiety and affliction, had poured out to

himself and Rose Cannon. That the actor was evidently emerging from his ill fortune was gratifying to Dominick, who, in the close propinquity forced upon them by the restricted quarters of Perley's Hotel, had grown to like and pity the kindly, foolish and impractical man.

Now, from what he heard, Buford's hard times should be at an end. Such a hit as he had made should give him the required upward impetus. Men Dominick knew, who had theatrical affiliations, told him that Buford was "made." The actor could now command a good salary on any of the vaudeville circuits in the country, and if "he had it in him" he might ascend the ladder toward the heights of legitimate comedy. His humorous talent was unique and brilliant. It was odd, considering his age, that it had not been discovered sooner.

Berny was very anxious to see him. Hazel and Josh had seen him on one of the first evenings and pronounced him "simply great." She extorted a promise from Dominick that, at the earliest opportunity, he would buy tickets for her, and, if he could not accompany her himself, she could go with one of her sisters. Dominick did not want to go. He had no desire to see Buford and be reminded of the three weeks' dream which had interrupted the waking miseries of his life, and more than that he hated, secretly and intensely, sitting beside Berny, talking to her and listening to her talk, during the three hours of the performance. The horrible falseness of it, the appearance of intimacy with a woman toward whom he only felt a cold aversion, the close proximity of her body which he disliked, even accidentally, to brush against, made him shrink from the thought as from the perpetration of some mean and repulsive deception.

He stopped to buy the tickets one midday on his way to lunch. He made up his mind to buy three, then Berny could either take her two sisters, or Hazel and Josh, whose craving for the theater was an unassuageable passion. The good seats were sold out for days ahead and he had to be content with three orchestra chairs for an evening at the end of the following week. He was turning from the ticket office window when a sonorous voice at his elbow arrested him:

"Mr. Ryan," it boomed out, "do I see you at last? Ever since my arrival in the city I have hoped for the opportunity of renewing our acquaintance."

It was Buford, but a rejuvenated and prosperous Buford, the reflection of his good fortune shining from his beaming face and fashionable figure. The red rasped look had left his features and the hollows beneath his high cheek-bones were filled out. He was dressed in gray with an almost foppish nicety, a fedora hat of a paler tint on his head, and a cravat of a dull red rising in a rich puffed effect below his collar. His shoes shone with the glassy polish of new patent leather; the red-brown kid gloves that he carried exhaled an attractive odor of russia-leather. He held out his hand to Dominick, and the young man grasped it with real heartiness.

“Glad to see you, Buford,” he said, “and glad to hear you’ve made such a success of it. I haven’t seen it myself, but I hear it’s a great show.”

Buford, who had seen him buying the tickets, said blandly,

“But you’re going? You’ve been buying tickets, haven’t you? Oh, I’ve got to have your opinion—nobody’s I’d think more of than Mr. Dominick Ryan’s.”

Dominick, with the consciousness that he had just been planning not to go reddening his face, stammered with embarrassed evasiveness,

“I’ve just been buying tickets and couldn’t get them before the end of next week. You’re such a confounded success that everything’s sold out days ahead. My wife wants to see you, and that’s the best I could do for her. Her sister went on the second night and says you’re the hit of the program. And then the papers! You’ll soon be one of the stars of the nation.”

Buford acknowledged these compliments with cool, acquiescent complacency.

“I have struck my gait,” he said, nodding his head in condescending acceptance. “I have at last won my spurs.”

“But you didn’t expect to come down here when you were at Antelope. Didn’t you tell me your engagement was for two weeks in Sacramento, and that you were afraid you’d forfeited it by being snowed in there? How was it you came down after all?”

“The luck turned. The tide that comes in the affairs of men came in mine. I must say it had got down to about the lowest ebb. You’re right about forfeiting my engagement. Got to Sacramento three weeks behind time and

found they'd procured a substitute, and all I had for my pains was a blackguarding because the Lord had seen fit to snow me in in the Sierras."

Dominick laughed, and the actor allowed a slight, sour smile to disturb the professional gravity of his face.

"Yes," he nodded, "that's the way of the transgressor, especially when his transgressions ain't of his own doing. After I'd been there two weeks, I hadn't a V between me and starvation. I looked for jobs with the water squelching in my boots, and finally I had to do a turn in a fifth-rate variety performance that showed in a sort of cellar down a flight of stairs. That's where the 'Klondike Monologue' was born. Like lots of other good things, it had a pretty mean beginning. I just pieced it together from bits and scraps that were the tailings of the two years I had spent in that Arctic mill up there. It caught on from the start—let the public alone to recognize a good thing when they see one! That dirty cellar was pretty well sprinkled the first week, and the second they had the standing room signs out. I didn't introduce the spangle till the end of the engagement. Some people think it a great touch."

He looked with sober questioning at Dominick, who said apologetically,

"So I hear, but I haven't seen it."

Buford raised his flexible brows with an air of stimulated, excusing memory.

"True, true," he replied, "I had forgotten. Two nights after I had introduced the spangle, one of the 'Granada' people saw me. I didn't know it at the time, but I am a true artist; whatever my audience, I give it of my best, and, in that instance, it was only one more case of bread cast upon the waters. There'd been a vacancy here. Estradilla, the Spanish Snake Dancer, was taken suddenly sick, collapsed after her third performance, tied her intestines up in a knot with her act, they say, and the wonder was she hadn't done it before. Anyhow, they had to substitute in a hurry, heard of my Klondike act and sent a man up to see if I'd do to fill in. The next week I was here and—you know the rest."

"They say every man has his chance. You didn't suppose the snowstorm that caught you at Antelope was going to be the foundation of yours?"

Buford raised his brows till they about touched his hair, and said with his most magisterial sonority of tone,

“No, no indeed. The ways of Fate—or let me say Providence—are truly inscrutable. I thought that lock-up in the Sierras would be my undoing, and I’m sure I never imagined the two years I spent in that accursed Arctic were going to return to roost as blessings. I turned my face to the North in a bitter hour, and it was in a bitter hour that I adopted the stage.”

Dominick was exceedingly surprised. He had supposed Buford always to have been an actor, to have been born to it. If he had heard that the man had made his debut as an infant prodigy or even in his mother’s arms in swaddling clothes, he would have felt it was in keeping with Buford’s character, and just what he suggested. Now, in a tone expressing his surprise, the young man queried,

“Then you went on the stage up there? You’ve only been on a few years?”

“Nearly four,” said the actor. He looked down at his shoe for a moment as if considering, and repeated without looking up, “It will be four next September. Trouble drove me to those far distant lands and hard luck drove me on the stage. I’d never had anything to do with it till then; I hadn’t a stage game about me. There’d even been a time when I had a strong prejudice against the theater and never went to one. But a man must live and——”

He stopped, his attention arrested by a hand laid softly on his sleeve. A youth of Hebraic countenance had issued from a door behind him, and, touching his arm with a hesitating, unclean finger, began to speak in a low tone. Buford turned to the boy. Dominick backed away from them toward the box-office window. As they conferred he took a card out of his wallet, and hastily traced the address of the flat below his name. He had it ready to offer Buford, when the actor, his conference over, came toward him.

“Duty calls,” said Buford. “I am sorry, but they want me inside. But this is not going to be our only meeting. I’m booked for two weeks longer here, and I’m hoping to see something more of you.”

Dominick gave him the card, with assurances that he would be glad to see him, and that his own home was a better meeting-place than the bank. At

this mark of friendship, the actor was openly gratified. He looked at the card with a smile and said,

“Most certainly I’ll avail myself of this privilege. I hope later to be able to place a box at your disposal. Madame, you say, is very desirous of seeing me. Well, I’ll see to it that she does so under the most favorable conditions. Though I have never met her, I think I may ask you to convey my respects to her.”

He bowed impressively as though saluting Berny in person, and then, with a last dignified farewell to Dominick, turned toward the door which opened at his approach, disclosing the waiting Jew boy. As the actor drew near, Dominick heard the boy break into low-toned remonstrances, and then the door closed upon Buford’s sonorous and patronizing notes of reproof.

CHAPTER XIX

ROSE'S POINT OF VIEW

The following Sunday, at ten o'clock in the morning, Dominick noiselessly descended the stairs of the flat and let himself out into the street. He had had a sleepless night, and as he stood in the dazzling sunshine, debating which way he should go, his face showed the hollows and lines left by hours of worried wakefulness.

His day—the holiday of his week of steady work—was without engagement. The friend with whom he usually walked over the suburban hills had moved to the country. His rest from labor would take the form of a day spent away from his home in the open air. As he had eaten his breakfast he had planned his itinerary, carefully considering the best distribution of these twelve treasured hours of liberty. He would spend the morning walking, anywhere—the direction did not matter much—anywhere where there was quiet and a view. He would take his lunch at any little joint—country hotel, city chop-house—he happened to pass, and in the afternoon he would walk again, on for hours, probably over the Presidio Hills where the poppies were beginning to gild the slopes, or along the beach where there were unfrequented nooks in which a man could lie and look at the water, and think. A whole day away from Berny and the flat, in the healing balm of the sunshine and the clean, untroubled air, was the best way to renew the fund of philosophy and patience that of late he had felt was almost exhausted.

The ferment of his wakeful night was still in his blood as he walked across the city, aiming for the eminence of Telegraph Hill. He walked slowly without looking up; his eyes on the tip of his cane as it struck the pavement. It was a superb day, calm, still, breathing peace, like that other Sunday when he had gone to the park with the Iversons and seen Rose Cannon. But the splendors of the morning did not divert his mind from its heavy musings. With down-drooped head, watching the striking tip of the cane as though in it there lay some mystic solution of his difficulties, he walked on,

a slow-moving figure, a man wrestling with his own particular world-problem, facing his fate and repudiating it.

There had been times lately when he had felt he could no longer endure the present conditions of his life. As he had lain thinking in the darkness of the previous night, it had come upon him, with the clearness of conviction, that he could not stand it. The future with Berny had loomed before him, crushing, unbearable, and he had seen no end to it, and repeated to himself that he must be free of it. It had been awful as a nightmare, and turning on his bed he had wondered how he had endured the situation so long.

Now, as he walked through the sweet, gay morning he felt a renewal of courage and reasoned with himself, using the old arguments with which for two years he had been subduing his rebellion and curbing the passion and impatience of his youth. Because a man had married an uncongenial woman, was that an excuse for him to leave her, to put her away from him when she had honestly tried to live up to her marriage contract? Summing it all up in a sentence—his wife had a bad temper and he had ceased to care for her, was that a reason for him to separate from her?

Last night he had used none of these arguments. He had felt too strongly to reason about the righteousness of moral obligation. Lying in the dark, listening to the striking of the clocks, he had said to himself that he could not stand Berny any longer—he could not live in the house with her. He did not hate her, it was far from that. He wished her well; to hear that she was happy and prosperous somewhere where he did not have to dine with her and sit in the den with her every evening, would have given him the greatest satisfaction. He felt that the sight of her was daily growing more unbearably and unnaturally obnoxious to him. Little personal traits of hers had a strange, maddening power of exciting his dislike. In the evening the rustling of the sheets of the newspaper as she turned and folded them filled him with a secret anger. He would sit silent, pretending to read, waiting for that regular insistent rustling, and controlling himself with an effort. As they sat opposite each other at breakfast, the sound she made as she crunched the toast seemed to contain something of her own hard, aggressive personality in it, and he hated to hear it. In the dead depression of the night, he had felt that to listen to that rustling of newspapers every night and that crunching of toast every morning was a torment he could no longer bear.

In the clear light of the morning, patience had come and the old standards of restraint and forbearance reasserted themselves. The familiar pains, to which he had thought himself broken, had lost much of their midnight ghouliness. The old ideals of honor and obligation, with which he had been schooling himself for two years, came back to his mind with the unerring directness of homing pigeons. He went over the tale of Berny's worthiness and his own responsibility in the misfortunes of her life and disposition. It was a circular process of thought that always returned to the starting place: what right had he to complain of her? Had not most of the disappointments that had soured and spoiled her come from his doing, his fault, his people?

He breathed a heavy sigh and looked up. To this question and its humbly acquiescing answer these reflections always brought him. But to-day it was hard to be acquiescent. The rebellion of the night was not all subdued. The splendor of the morning, the pure arch of sky, the softness of the air, called to him to rejoice in his strength, to be glad, and young. He raised his head, breathing in the sweet freshness, and took off his hat, letting the sun pour its benediction on his head. His spirit rose to meet this inspiring, beneficent nature, not in exhilaration, but in revolt. The thought of Rose gripped him, and in the strength of his manhood he longed for her.

He ascended the hill by one of the streets on its southern slope, violently steep, the upward leaps of its sidewalk here and there bridged by flights of steps. Every little house was disgorging its inmates, garbed in the light Sunday attire of the Californian on pleasure bent. The magnificent day was calling them, not to prayer and the church, but to festival. Families stood on the sidewalks, grouped round the Sunday symbol of worship, a picnic-basket. Lovers went by in smiling pairs, arm linked in arm. A pagan joy in life was calling from every side, from the country clothed in its robe of saffron poppies, from the sky pledged to twelve hours of undimmed blue, from the air mellowed to a warmth that never burns, from the laughter of light hearts, the smiles of lovers, the eyes of children.

Dominick went up the hill in the clear, golden sunlight, and in his revolt he pushed Berny from his mind, and let Rose come in her place. His thoughts, always held from her, sprang at her, encircled her, seemed to draw her toward him as once his arms had done. She was a sacred thing, the Madonna of his soul's worship, but to-day she seemed to bend down from

her niche with less of the revered saint than of the loving woman in the face his fancy conjured up.

Standing on the summit of the hill, where the wall of the quarry drops down to the water front and the wharves, he relinquished himself to his dream of her. The bay lay at his feet, a blue floor, level between rusty, rugged hills. There was an island in it, red-brown, incrusting with buildings, that seemed to clutch their rocky perch with long strips and angles of wall. In the reach of water just below there was little shipping, only a schooner beating its way to sea. The wind was stiffer down there than on the sheltered side of the hill. The schooner, with sails white as curds against the blue, was tacking, a long, slantwise flight across the ruffled water. She left a thin, creamy line behind her which drifted sidewise into eddying curves like a wind-lashed ribbon. Dominick, his eyes absently on her, wondered if she were bound for the South Seas, those waters of enchantment where islands, mirrored in motionless lagoons, lie scattered over plains of blue.

A memory crossed his mind of a description of some of these islands given him by a trader he had once met. They were asylums, lotus-eating lands of oblivion, for law-breakers. Those who had stepped outside the pale, who had dared defy the world's standards, found in them a haven, an elysian retreat. They rose before his mental vision, palm-shaded, lagoon-encircled, played upon by tropic breezes, with glassy waves sliding up a golden beach. There man lived as his heart dictated, a real life, a true life, not a bitter tale of days in protesting obedience to an immutable, heart-breaking law. There he and Rose might live, lost to the places they had once filled, hidden from the world and its hard judgments.

The thought seized upon his mind like a drug, and he stood in a tranced stillness of fascinated imagination, his eyes on the ship, his inner vision seeing himself and Rose standing on the deck. He was so held under the spell of his exquisite, enthralling dream, that he did not see a figure round the corner of the rough path, nor notice its slow approach. But he felt it, when its casual, roaming glance fell on him. As if called, he turned sharply and saw Rose standing a few yards away from him, looking at him with an expression of affrighted indecision. As his glance met hers, the dream broke and scattered, and he seemed to emerge out of a darkness that had in it something beautiful and baleful, into the healthy, pure daylight.

The alarm in Rose's face died away, too. For a moment she stood motionless, then moved toward him slowly, with something of reluctance about her approach. She seemed to be coming against her will, as if obeying a summons in his eyes.

"I wasn't sure it was you," she said. "And then when I saw it was, I was going to steal away before you saw me. But you turned suddenly as if you heard me."

"I felt you were there," he answered.

It was natural that with Rose he should need to make no further explanation. She understood as she would always understand everything that was closely associated with him. He would never have to explain things to her, as he never, from their first meeting, felt that he needed to talk small talk or make conversation.

She came to a stop beside him, and they stood for a silent moment, looking down the bare wall of the quarry, a raw wound in the hill's flank, to the docks below where the masts of ships rose in a forest, and their lean bowsprits were thrust over the wharves.

"You came just in time," he said. "I walked up here this morning to have a think. I don't know where the think was going to take me when you came round that corner and stopped it. What brought you here?"

"Nothing in particular. It was such a fine morning I thought I'd just ramble about, and I came this way without thinking. My feet brought me without my knowledge."

"My think brought you," he said. "That's the second time it's happened. It was a revolutionary sort of think, and there was a lot about you in it."

He looked down at her, standing by his shoulder, and met her eyes. They were singularly pellucid, the clearest, quietest eyes he thought he had ever looked into. His own dropped before them to the bay below, touched and then quickly left the schooner which was beating its way toward them on the return tack.

"If you could only always come this way when I want you, everything would be so different, so much easier," he said in a low tone. "I was

surrounded by devils and they were getting tight hold of me when you came round that corner.”

He glanced at her sidewise with a slight, quizzical smile.

This time she did not answer his look, but with her eyes on the bay, her brows drawn together, asked,

“New devils or old ones?”

“The old ones, but they’ve grown bigger and twice as hard to manage lately. They——” he broke off, his voice suddenly roughened, and said, “I don’t seem to know how to live my life.”

He turned his face away from her. The demons she had exorcised had left him weakened. In the bright sunshine, with the woman he loved beside him, he felt broken and beaten down by the hardships of his fate.

“Sit down and talk to me,” she said quietly. “No one can hear you. It’s like being all alone in the world up here on the hilltop. We can sit on this stone.”

There was a broken boulder behind them, close to the narrow foot-way, and she sat on it, motioning him to a flat piece of rock beside her. Her hands were thrust deep in the pockets of her loose gray coat, the wisps of fair hair that escaped below the rim of her hat fanning up and down in faint breaths of air, like delicate threads of seaweed in ocean currents.

“Tell me the whole thing,” she said. “You and I have never talked much about your affairs. And what concerns you concerns me.”

He pricked at the earth with the tip of his cane, ashamed of his moment of weakness, and yet fearing if he told her of his cares it might return.

“It’s just what you know,” he began slowly. “Only as every day goes by it seems to get worse. I’ve never told you much about my marriage. I’ve never told anybody. Many men make mistakes in choosing a wife and find out, and say to themselves early in the game, that they *have* made a mistake and must abide by it. I don’t think I’m weaker than they are, but somehow ——”

He stopped and looked at the moving tip of his cane. She said nothing, and after taking a deep breath he went on.

“I knew all about her when I married her. I was young, but I wasn’t a green fool. Only I didn’t seem to realize, I didn’t guess, I didn’t dream, that she was going to stay the way she was. I seemed to be at the beginning of a sort of experiment that I was sure was going to turn out well. I didn’t love her, but I liked her well enough, and I was going to try my best to have things go smoothly and make her happy. When she was my wife, when I’d try to make everything as comfortable and pleasant as I could, then I expected she’d—she’d—be more like the women men love, and even if they don’t love, manage to get on with. But it didn’t seem to go well even in the beginning, and now it’s got worse and worse. Perhaps it’s my fault. I’m not one of those fellows who can read a woman like a book. When a person tells me a thing, I think they mean it; I’m not looking into them to see if they mean just the opposite.”

He stopped again and struck lightly at a lump of earth with his cane. He had pushed his hat back from his forehead and his face bore an expression of affected, boyish nonchalance which was extremely pathetic to Rose.

“Maybe there are men who could stand it all right. She’s very nice part of the time. She’s a first-class housekeeper. I give her two hundred dollars a month, and on that little bit she runs the flat beautifully. And she’s quiet. She doesn’t want to be out all the time, the way some women do. She’s as domestic as possible, and she’s been very decent and pleasant since I came back. The way she was treated over the ball would have riled any woman. I didn’t tell you about that—it’s a mean story—but she got no invitation and was angry and flared up. We had a sort of an uncomfortable interview, and—and—that was the reason I went to Antelope. I didn’t think I’d ever go back to her then. I was pretty sore over it. But—” he paused, knocking the lump of clay into dust, “I thought afterward it was the right thing to do. I’d married her, you see.”

Rose did not speak, and after a moment he said in a low voice,

“But it’s—it’s—awfully hard to live with a person you don’t get on with. And it’s the sort of thing that goes on and on and on. There isn’t any end; there isn’t any way out.”

Once more he stopped, this time clearing his throat. He cleared it twice, and then said,

“I oughtn’t to say this. I oughtn’t to complain. I know I’m a chump and a coward to talk this way to you, but—” he dropped his voice to a note of low, inward communing, and said, “it’s so hopeless. I can’t see what to do.”

He leaned forward and rested his forehead on the head of his cane, hiding his face from her. The silence between them vibrated with the huskiness of his voice, the man’s voice, the voice of power and protection, roughened with the pain he was unused to and did not know how to bear.

Rose sat looking at him, her soul wrung with sympathy. Her instinct was to take the bowed head in her arms and clasp it to her bosom, not as a woman in love, but as a woman torn by pity for a suffering she could not alleviate. She made no movement, however, but kept both hands deep in her pockets, as she said,

“I don’t see why you shouldn’t talk this way to me. I think I’m the one person in the world that you ought to speak to about it.”

“I can’t talk to anybody else, not to any friend, not to my own mother. It’s my affair. No one else had any responsibility in it. I brought it on myself and I’ve got to stand by it myself. But you—you’re different.”

He drew himself up, and, staring out into the great wash of sun and air before him, went on in a louder voice, as if taking a new start.

“I was thinking last night about it, looking it in the face. The dark’s the best time for that, you seem to see things clearer, more truthfully. And I came to the conclusion it would be better if I ended it. I didn’t see that I had any obligation to go on martyrizing myself for ever. I didn’t see that anybody was benefiting by it. I thought we’d be happier and make something better of our lives if we were apart, in different houses, in different towns.”

“Does she want to leave you?”

The question seemed to touch a nerve that startled and then stiffened him. He answered it with his head turned half toward her, the eyebrows lifted, a combative note in his voice:

“I don’t know whether she does or not.” He stopped and then said, with his face flushing, “No, I don’t think she does.”

“How can you leave her then?”

“Well, I can—” he turned on her almost angrily and met her clear eyes. “Oh, I can’t go into particulars,” he said sharply, looking away again. “It’s not a thing for you and me to discuss. Incompatibility is a recognized ground of separation.”

He fell to striking the lump of clay again, and Rose said, as if offering the remark with a sort of tentative timidity,

“You said just now you had nothing to complain of against her. It doesn’t seem fair to leave a woman—a wife—just because she’s hard to live with and you no longer like her.”

“Would you,” he said with a manner so full of irritated disagreement as to be almost hectoring, “advocate two people living on together in a semblance of friendship, who are entirely uncongenial, rub each other the wrong way so that the sight of one is unpleasant to the other?”

“Are you sure that’s the way she feels about you?”

He again looked away from her, and answered in a sullen tone, as though against his will,

“I don’t know.”

They were silent for a space, and he went on.

“Doesn’t it strike you as wrong, cowardly, mean, for a man and woman to tear their lives to pieces out of respect for what the world says and thinks? Every semblance of love and mutual interest has gone from our companionship. Isn’t it all wrong that we should make ourselves miserable to preserve the outward forms of it? We’re just lying to the world because we haven’t got the sand to tell the truth. You ask me if my views on this matter are hers. I don’t know, that’s the truth.” A memory of Berny’s futile and pathetic efforts to make friends with him on his return swept over him and forced him to say, “Honestly, I don’t think she wants to leave me. I think the situation doesn’t drive her crazy the way it does me. I think she doesn’t mind it. I don’t know why, but she doesn’t seem to. But surely, any woman living would rather be free of a man she no longer cared for, than forced to live on in a false relation with him, one irritating the other, the two of them every day growing more antagonistic.”

“She would not want to be free if she loved him.”

“Loved him!” he ejaculated, with angry scorn. “She never loved me or anybody else. Love is not in her. Oh, you don’t know! I thought last night I’d offer her all I had, the flat, the furniture, my salary, everything I could rake and scrape together, and then I’d tell her I was going to leave her, that I couldn’t stand living that way any longer. I was going to take a room somewhere and give her everything I could. I was going to be as generous to her as I knew how. I’d not say one word against her to anybody. That was what I thought I’d do last night.”

“But this morning you think differently.”

“How do you know that?”

“Because those are not your real thoughts—they’re the dark, exaggerated ones that come when a person lies awake at night. It’s as if, because you couldn’t see your surroundings, you were in another sort of world where the proportions are different. You couldn’t do that to your wife. You couldn’t treat her that way. You say in many ways she’s been a good wife. It isn’t she that’s stopped caring, or finds her life with you disagreeable.”

“Then, am I to suffer this way for ever—see my life ruined for a fault man after man commits and goes scott free?”

“Your life isn’t ruined. Things don’t last at such a pressure. Something will change it. By and by, you’ll look back on this and it’ll seem hundreds of miles away and you’ll wonder that you were so discouraged and hopeless.”

“Yes,” he said bitterly, “maybe when I’m fifty. It’s a long time between then and now, a long time to be patient.”

Manlike, he was wounded that the woman of his heart should not side with him in everything, even against his own conscience. Had Rose been something closer to him, a sister, a wife, this would have been one of the occasions on which he would have found fault with her and accused her of disloyalty.

“I thought you’d understand,” he said, “I thought you’d see how impossible it is. You make me feel that I’m a whining coward who has come yelping round like a kicked dog for sympathy.”

“I care so much that I do more than sympathize,” she said in a low voice.

This time he did not answer, feeling ashamed at his petulance.

“With any one else it would be just sympathy,” she said, “but with you there’s more than that. It’s because I care, that I expect more and demand more. Other men can do the small, cowardly, mean things that people do, and find excuses for, but not you. I could make excuses for them too, but I must never have to make excuses for you. You’re better than that, you’re yourself, and you do what’s true to yourself and stand on that. You’ve got to do and be the best. Maybe it won’t be what you want or what’s most comfortable, but that mustn’t matter to you. If you’re not to be happy that mustn’t matter either. What pleases you and me mustn’t matter if it’s not the thing for a man like you to do. You can’t shirk your responsibilities. You can’t stick to something you’ve done just while it’s pleasant and then, when it’s hard, throw it up. Lots of people do that, thousands of them. Just as you said now—hundreds of men do what you have done and go scott free. That’s for them to do if they want to, but not for you. Let them drop down if they want, that’s no reason why you should. Let them go on living any way that’s agreeable to them, *you* know what you ought to do and you must do it. It doesn’t matter about them, or the world, or what anybody says. The only thing that matters is that the thing you know in your heart is the thing that’s true for you.”

“You expect too much of weak human nature,” he said.

“No,” she answered, “I don’t. I only expect what you can do.”

He turned and looked at her.

“Then I’m to live for the rest of my life with a wife I don’t care for, separated from the woman I love? What is there in that to keep a man’s heart alive?”

“The knowledge that we love each other. That’s a good deal, I think.”

It was the first time she had said in words that she loved him. There was no trace of embarrassment or consciousness on her face; instead she seemed singularly calm and steadfast, much less moved than he. Her words shook him to the soul. He turned his eyes from her face and grasping for her hand, clasped it, and pressed it to his heart, and to his lips, then loosed it and rose to his feet, saying, as if to himself,

“Yes, that’s a good deal.”

There was silence between them for some minutes, neither moving, both looking out at the hills and water. From the city below, sounds of church bells came up, mellow and tranquil, ringing lazily and without effort. Other sounds mingled with them, refined and made delicate by distance. It was like being on an island floating in the air above the town. Rose got up and shook the dust from her coat.

“The churches are coming out, it must be nearly one. It will be lunch-time before I get home.”

He did not turn or answer, but stood with his hand on the metal rope that protected the quarry’s ledge, looking down. Her eyes followed his, and then brought up on the schooner bearing away on its long tack, strained and careening in the breeze that, down there in the open, blew fresh and strong from the great Pacific.

“It’s a schooner,” she said absently. “Where do you suppose it’s going?”

“I don’t know. Somewhere a long way off, I hope. My devils are sailing away on it.”

They stood side by side, gazing down at it till she moved away with a sudden “Good-by.”

“Good-by,” he answered, and stretched out his hand.

But she was already some feet in advance and had begun to move quickly.

“Good-by, Rose,” he cried after her, with something in his voice of the wistful urgency in a child’s when it is left behind.

“Good-by,” she called over her shoulder without looking back. “Good-by.”

He followed her with his eyes till she disappeared round the bend of the path, then turned back and again dropped his glance to the schooner.

He stood watching it till it passed out of sight beneath the shoulder of the hill, straining and striving like a wild, free creature in its forward rush for the sea.

CHAPTER XX

THE LITTLE SPIDER

Berny had been turning over in her mind the advantages of accepting the money—had been letting herself dwell upon the delights of possible possession—when at the Sunday dinner that afternoon Josh McCrae threw her back into the state of incensed rejection with which she had met the first offer. With his face wreathed in joyous grins, he had apprised her of the fact that only an hour earlier, while walking on Telegraph Hill, he had seen Dominick there talking with Miss Cannon.

A good deal of query followed Josh's statement. There was quite an outburst of animated interrogations rising from the curiosity the Iversons felt concerning Bill Cannon's daughter, and under cover of it Berny controlled her face and managed to throw in a question or two on her own account. There had been a minute—that one when Josh's statement had struck with a shocking unexpectedness on her consciousness—when she had felt and looked her wrath and amaze. Then she had gripped her glass and drunk some water and, swallowing gulpingly, had heard her sister's rapid fire of questions, and Josh, proud to have imparted such interesting information, answering importantly. Putting down her glass, she said quite naturally,

"Where did you say you saw them—near the quarry?"

"Just by the edge, talking together. I was going to walk along and join them, and then I thought they looked so sort of sociable, I'd better not butt in. Dominick got to know her real well up in the Sierra, didn't he?"

"Yes, of course," she said hurriedly. "They grew to be quite friends. They must have met by accident on the hill. Dominick's always walking in those queer, deserted places."

"You haven't got acquainted with her yet, have you?" said the simple Josh, whose touch was not of the lightest. "It would be a sort of grind on the Ryans if you get really solid with her."

“Oh, I can know her whenever I want,” Berny answered airily, above a discomfort of growing revelation that was almost as sharp as a pain. “Dominick’s several times asked me if I wanted to meet her, but it always was at times when I’d other things to do. We’re going to ask her to the flat to tea some time.”

On ordinary occasions, Berny would never have gone to this length of romantic invention, for she was a judicious liar and believed, with the sage, that a lie was too valuable a thing to waste. But just now she was too upset, too preyed upon by shock and suspicion, to exercise an artistic restraint, and she lied recklessly, unmindful of a future when her listeners would expect to see her drafts on the bank of truth cashed.

She was quiet for the rest of the afternoon, but it was not till she had reached her own home, silent in its untenanted desertion, that she had an opportunity to turn the full vigor of her mind on what she had heard.

She had been jealous of Rose since that fatal Sunday when she had discovered why Dominick was changed. It was not the jealousy of disprized love, it was not the jealousy of thwarted passion. It was a subtle compound of many ingredients, the main one a sense of bursting indignation that two people—one of them a possession of her own—should dare to seek for happiness where she had found only dullness and disappointment. She had an enraging premonition that Rose would probably succeed where she had failed. It made her not only jealous of Rose, it made her hate her.

Josh’s words increased this, and caused her suspicions, which, if not sleeping, had of late been dormant, to wake into excited activity. Dominick’s lonely Sunday walks she now saw shared by the girl who was trying to buy his freedom. Incidents that before she had taken at their face value now were suddenly fraught with disturbing significance. Why did Dominick go out so often in the evening? Since the moonlight night, he had been out twice, once not coming back till eleven. The confirmation of sight could hardly have made her more confident that he must spend these stolen hours with Rose Cannon in the palatial residence on Nob Hill. And it was not the most soothing feature in the case that Berny should picture them in one of the artistically-furnished parlors of which she had heard so much and seen nothing but the linings of the window curtains. Here, amid glories of upholstery, from the sight of which she was for ever debarred, Rose and

Dominick talked of the time when he should be free. Berny, like the tiger lashing itself to fury with its own tail, thought of what they said, till she became sure her imaginings were facts; and the more she imagined, the more enraged and convinced she became.

She put from her mind all intention of ever taking the money. She wanted it desperately, terribly; she wanted it so much that when she thought of it it made her feel sick, but the joys of its possession were at the unrealizable distance of dreams, while the fact of her husband's being enticed away by another woman was a thing of close, immediate concern, a matter of the moment, as if some one were trying to pick her pocket. As an appurtenance of hers, Dominick might not have been a source of happiness, but that was no reason why he should be a source of happiness to some one else.

Berny did not argue with any such compact clearness. She was less lucid, less defined and formulated in her ideas and desires than she had been when Bill Cannon made the first offer. Anger had thickened and obscured her clarity of vision. Suspicions, harbored and stimulated by a mind which wished for confirmation of the most extravagant, had destroyed the firm and well-outlined conception of what she wanted and was willing to fight for. In fact, she had passed the stage in the controversy when she was formidable because she stood with the strength of sincerity in her position, her demands, and refusals. Now the integrity of her defiance was gone. She wanted the money. She wanted to take it, and her refusal to do so was false to herself and to her standards.

She knew that the interview for which Bill Cannon had asked was for a last, deciding conversation. He was to make his final offer. It was a moment of torture to her when she wondered what it would be, and her mind hovered in distracted temptation over the certain two hundred thousand dollars and the possible quarter of a million. It was then that she whipped up her wrath, obscured for the moment by the mounting dizziness of cupidity, and thought of Rose and Dominick in the Japanese room, or the Turkish room, or the Persian room, into which she had never been admitted. The thought that they were making love received a last, corrosive bitterness from the fact that Berny could not see the beautiful and expensive surroundings of these sentimental passages.

She was in this state of feverish distractedness when she went to Bill Cannon's office. She had chosen the last of the three days he had specified in his note, and had left the flat at the time he had mentioned as the latest hour at which he would be there. She had chosen the last day as a manner of indicating her languid interest in the matter to be discussed, and had also decided to be about fifteen minutes late, as it looked more indifferent, less eager. Bill Cannon would never know that she was dressed and ready half an hour before she started, and had lounged about the flat, watching the clocks, and starting at every unrecognized sound.

She was received with a flattering deference. As her footstep sounded on the sill of the outer office, a face was advanced toward one of the circular openings in the long partition, immediately disappeared, and then a door was thrown back to admit to her presence a good-looking, well-dressed young man. His manner was all deferential politeness. A murmur of her name, just touched with the delicately-questioning quality imparted by the faintest of rising inflections, accompanied his welcoming bow. Mr. Cannon was expecting her in the private office. Special instructions had been left that she should be at once admitted. Would she be kind enough to step this way?

Berny followed him down the long strip of outer office where it flanked the partition in which the regularly-recurring holes afforded glimpses of smooth bent heads. She walked lightly, and had an alert, wary air as though it might be a good thing to be prepared for an ambush. She had been rehearsing her part of the interview for days; and like other artists, now that the moment of her appearance was at hand, felt extremely nervous, and had a sense of girding herself up against unforeseen movements on the part of the foe.

Nothing, however, could have been more disarmingly friendly than the old man's greeting. As the door opened and the clerk pronounced her name, he rose from his seat and welcomed her in a manner which was a subtle compound of simple cordiality and a sort of masonic, unexpressed understanding, as between two comrades bound together by a common interest. Sitting opposite him in one of the big leather chairs, she could not but feel some of her resentment melting away, and her stiffly-antagonistic pose losing something of its rigidity as he smiled indulgently on her, asking about herself, about Dominick, finally about her sisters, with whose names and positions he appeared flatteringly familiar.

Berny answered him cautiously. She made a grip at her receding anger, conscious that she needed all her sense of wrong to hold her own against this crafty enemy. Even when he told her he had heard with admiration and wonder of Hannah's fine record in the primary school department, her smile was guarded, her answer one of brief and watchful reserve. She wished he would get to the point of the interview. Her mind could not comfortably contain two subjects at once, and it was crammed and running over with the all-important one of the money. Her eyes, fixed on him, did not stray to the furnishings of the room or the long windows that reached to the ceiling and through the dimmed panes of which men on the other side of the alley stood looking curiously down on her.

"Well," he said, when he had disposed of Hannah's worthiness and even celebrated the merits of Josh in a sentence of appreciation, "it's something to have such a good sterling set of relations. They're what make the 'good families' in our new West out here. And they're beginning to understand that in Europe. When they see your people in Paris, they'll recognize them as the right kind of Americans. The French ain't as effete as you'd think from what you hear. They know the real from the imitation every time. They've had their fill of Coal Oil Johnnys and spectacular spenders. What they're looking for is the strong man and woman who have carved out their own path."

Berny's eyes snapped into an even closer concentration of attention.

"Maybe that's so," she said, "but I don't see when my sisters are ever going to get to Paris."

"They'll go over to see you," he answered. "I guess I could manage now and then to get 'em passes across the continent."

He rested one elbow on the desk against which he was sitting, and with his hand caressing his short, stubby beard, he looked at Berny with eyes of twinkling good nature.

"Come to think of it," he added, "I guess I could manage the transportation across the ocean, too. It oughtn't to cost 'em, all told, more'n fifty dollars. It seems hard luck that Miss Hannah, after a lifetime of work, shouldn't see Paris, and——"

“What makes you think I’m going to be there?” said Berny sharply. She found any deviation from the subject in hand extremely irritating, and her manner and voice showed it.

“Oh, of course you are,” he said, with a little impatient, deprecating jerk of his head. “You can’t be going to persist in a policy that’s simply cutting your own throat.”

“I rather fancy I am,” she answered in a cool, hard tone. To lend emphasis to her words, she unbent from her upright attitude and leaned against the chair-back in a sudden assumption of indifference. Her eyes, meeting his, were full of languid insolence.

“I don’t feel that I’ll go to Paris at all,” she said. “I think little old San Francisco’s good enough for me.”

He looked away from her at the papers on the desk, eyed them for a thoughtful moment, and then said,

“I didn’t think you were as short-sighted as that. I’ll tell you fair and square that up to this I’ve thought you were a pretty smart woman.”

“Well, I guess from this on, you’ll have to put me down a fool.”

She laughed, a short, sardonic laugh, and her adversary smiled politely in somewhat absent response. With his eyes still on the papers, he said,

“No, no—I can’t agree to that. Short-sighted is the word. You’re not looking into the future, you’re not calculating on your own powers of endurance. How much longer do you think you can stand this battle with your husband and the Ryans?”

In the dead watches of the night, Berny had asked herself this question, and found no answer to it. She tried to laugh again, but it was harder and less mirthful than before.

The old man leaned forward, shaking an admonitory forefinger at her.

“Don’t you know, young woman, that’s a pretty wearing situation? Don’t you know to live in a state of perpetual strife will break down the strongest spirit? The dropping of water will wear away a stone. You *can’t* stand the state of siege and warfare you’ve got yourself into much longer. Your rage is carrying you along now. You’re mad as a whole hive full of hornets and

the heat of it's keeping you going, furnishing fuel to the engines, so to speak. But you can't keep up such a clip. You'll break to pieces and you'll break suddenly. Then what'll happen? Why, the Ryans'll come with a big broom and sweep the pieces out. They won't leave one little scrap behind. That flat on Sacramento Street will be swept as clean of you as if you'd never had your dresses hanging in the cupboard or your toothbrush on the wash-stand. Old Delia's a great housekeeper. When she gets going with a broom there's not a speck escapes her."

His narrowed eyes looked into hers with that boring steadiness that she was beginning to know. He was not smiling now, rather he looked a man who knew he was talking of very momentous things and wanted his companion to know it too.

"That's all talk," Berny snapped. "If that's all you've got to say to me, I'd better be going."

"No, no," he stretched out an opened hand and with it made a down-pressing gesture that was full of command. "Don't move yet. These are just suggestions of mine, suggestions I was making for your good. Of course, if you don't care to follow them, it's your affair, not mine. I've done my duty, and, after all, that's what concerns me most. What I asked you to come here for to-day was to talk about this matter, to talk further, to thresh it out some more. I've seen Mrs. Ryan since our last meeting."

He paused, and Berny sat upright, her eyes on him in a fixity of listening that was almost a glare. She was tremulously anxious and yet afraid to hear the coming words.

"What did she say?" she asked with the same irritation she had shown before.

"She doubles her offer to you. She'll give you two hundred thousand dollars to leave her son."

"Well, I won't," said Berny, drawing herself to the edge of the chair. "She can keep her two hundred thousand dollars."

"That two hundred thousand dollars, well invested, would give an income of from twelve to fifteen thousand a year. On that, in Paris, you'd be a rich woman."

“I guess I’ll stay a poor one in San Francisco.”

He eyed her ponderingly over the hand that stroked his beard.

“I wonder,” he said slowly, “what’s making you act like this? You stump me. Here you are, poor, treated like dirt, ostracized as if you were a leper, with the most powerful family in California your open enemy, and you won’t take a fortune that’s offered you without a condition, and go to a place where you’d be honored and courted and could make yourself anything you’d like. I can’t make it out. You beat me.”

Berny was flattered. Even through the almost sickening sense of longing that the thought of the lost two hundred thousand dollars created in her, she was conscious of the gratified conceit of the woman who is successfully mysterious.

“Don’t bother your head about it,” she said as lightly as she could. “Think I’m crazy, if that makes it any easier for you.”

“I can’t think *that*,” he answered, conveying in the accented monosyllable his inability to think lightly of her mental equipment. “There’s something underneath it all I don’t know. You’ve not been quite open, quite as open as I think *my* frankness deserves. But, of course, a man can’t force a lady’s confidence. If you don’t want to give me yours, I’ve got to be content without it.”

Berny emitted a vague sound of agreement. She once more drew herself to the edge of the chair, taking the renewed, arranging grip of departure on her purse. She wanted to go.

“Well,” she said with the cheerful lengthening of the word, which is the precursor of the preliminary sentence of farewell, “I guess——” but he stopped her again with the outspread, authoritative hand.

“Don’t be in such a hurry; I’ve not finished yet. There’s more to be said, and it’s worth losing a few moments over.” His face was so much more commanding than his words that she made no attempt to move, though each minute deepened her desire to leave.

“This is just between you and me,” he went on slowly, his voice lowered, dropped to the key of confidences. “It’s a little matter between us that no one else needs to know anything about. My part of it just comes from the

fact that I want to do a good turn not only to Delia Ryan, but to you. I'm sorry for you, young woman, and I think you're up against it. Now, here's my proposition; I'll add something to that money myself. I'll give you another hundred thousand. I'll put it with Mrs. Ryan's pile, and it'll run your fortune up well past a quarter of a million."

His eyes fixed upon her were hard in his benevolently-smiling face.

"What do you think about it?" he asked, as she was speechless. "Three hundred thousand dollars in a lump's a goodish bit of money."

Berny felt dizzy. As her rancor had seemed slipping from her in the earlier part of the interview, now she felt as if her resolution was suddenly melting. She was confused between the strangling up-rush of greed and the passion that once again rose in her against the old man, who showed such a bold determination to sweep her from his daughter's path. She was no longer mistress of herself. Inward excitement, the unfamiliar struggle with temptation, had upset and unnerved her. But she did not yet know it, and she answered slowly, with a sort of sullenness, that might have passed as the heaviness of indifference.

"What do you want to give it to me for?"

"Because I'm sorry for you. Because I want you to get out of this hole you're in, and go and make something of your life."

Before she knew it, Berny said low, but with a biting incisiveness,

"Oh, you liar!"

Cannon was surprised. He looked for a staring moment at her pale face, stiff over its strained muscles, and said in a tone of cheerful amaze,

"Now, what do you mean by that?"

"Just what I say," she said. "You're a liar and you know it. Every word you've said to me's been a lie. Why, Mrs. Ryan's better than you. She don't come covering me with oily stories about wanting me to be happy. You think that I don't know why you're offering me this money. Well, old man, I do. You want to get my husband for your own daughter, Rose Cannon."

It was Cannon's turn to be speechless. He had not for years received so unexpected and violent a blow. He sat in the same attitude, not moving or

uttering a sound, and looking at Berny with a pair of eyes that each second grew colder and more steely. Berny, drawn to the edge of her chair, leaned toward him, speaking with the stinging quickness of an angry wasp.

“You thought I didn’t know it. Well, I do. I know the whole thing. I’ve just sat back and watched you two old thieves thinking everything was hidden, like a pair of ostriches. And you being so free with your glad hand and being sorry for me and wanting me to make the most of my life! You said I was a smart woman. Well, I’m evidently a lot smarter than you thought I was.”

“So it seems,” he said. “Smart enough to do some very neat inventing.”

“Inventing!” she cried, “I wish there was some inventing about it. *I* don’t take any pleasure in thinking that another woman’s trying to buy my husband.”

He dropped his hand from his chin, and moved a little impatiently in his chair.

“Come,” he said with sudden authority, “I can’t waste my time this way. Are you going to take the money or not?”

His manner, as if by magic, had changed. Every suggestion of deference, or consideration had gone from it. The respect, with which he had been careful to treat her, had suddenly vanished; there was something subtly brutal in his tone, in the very movement of impatience he made. It was as if the real man were at last showing himself.

She uttered a furious phrase of denial and sprang to her feet. His manner was the last unbearable touch on the sore helplessness of her futile rage. His chair had been standing sideways toward the desk, and now, with a jerk of his body, he swept it back into position.

“All right, then go!” he said, without looking at her.

Berny had intended going, rushing out of the place. Now at these words of dismissal, flung at her as a bone to a dog, she suddenly was rooted to the spot. All her reason, balance, and common sense were swept away in the flood of her quivering, blind anger.

“I will *not* go,” she cried, at the pitch of folly, “I will *not* till I’m good and ready. Who are you to order me out? Who are you to tell me what I’m to

do? A man who tries to buy another woman's husband for his daughter, and then pretends he and she are such a sweet, innocent pair! Wouldn't people be surprised if they knew that Miss Rose Cannon wanted my husband, was getting her father to make bids for him, and was meeting him every Sunday!"

"Stop!" thundered the old man, bringing his open hand down on the table with a bang.

The tone of his voice was bull-like, and the blow of his hand so violent that the fittings of the heavy desk rattled. Berny, though not frightened, was startled and drew back. For a moment she thought he was going to rise and forcibly put her out. Then she looked sidewise and saw two men at a window on the other side of the alley gazing interestedly down at them. Cannon was conscious of the observers at the same time. He restrained the impulse to spring to his feet which had made her shrink, and rose slowly.

"Look here," he said quietly, "you don't seem to understand that this interview's at an end."

"No," she said with a stubborn shake of her head, "I'm not through yet."

"There's nothing more for you to say unless you want to accept Mrs. Ryan's offer."

"Yes, there is, there's lots more for me to say, but since you seem in such a hurry to get rid of me, I'll have to wait and say it to your daughter next time I see her."

She paused, daring and impudently bold. She was a woman of remarkable physical courage, and the old man's aspect, which might have affrighted a less audacious spirit, had no terrors for her. He stood by the desk, his hands on his hips, the fingers turned toward his back, and his face, the chin drawn in, fronting her with a glowering fixity of menace.

"When do *you* ever see my daughter?" he asked, the accented pronoun pregnant with scorn.

"Oh, on the streets, in the stores, walking round town. I often meet her. I've wanted several times lately to stop and tell her what I think of the way she's acting. She doesn't think that I know all about what she's doing. She'll be surprised when she hears that I do and what *I* think about it."

She faced the old man's motionless visage with an almost debonair audacity.

"You can offer me money," she said, "but you can't muzzle me."

Cannon, without changing his attitude, replied,

"I can do a good many things you don't think of. Take my advice, young woman, and muzzle yourself. Don't leave it for me to do. I've had nothing but friendly feelings for you up to this, and I'd hate to have you see what a damned ugly enemy I can be."

He gave his head a nod, dropped his hands and turned from her. As he moved, a small spider that had been hidden among the papers on the desk started to scuttle over the yellow blotting pad. It caught his eye.

"Look there," he said, indicating it, "that little spider thinks it can have things all its own way on my desk. But—" and he laid his great thumb on it, crushing it to a black smudge—"that's what happens to it. Now, Mrs. Dominick Ryan, that's not the first little spider that's come to grief trying to run amuck through my affairs. And it don't seem, as things look now, as if it was going to be the last. It's not a healthy thing for little spiders to think they can run Bill Cannon."

He rubbed his soiled thumb on the edge of the blotter, and Berny looked at the stain that had been the spider.

"Best not butt into places where little spiders are not wanted," he said, and then looking at her sidewise, "Well, is it good-by?"

Something in the complete obliteration of the adventurous insect—or the words that had accompanied its execution—chilled Berny. She was not frightened, nor less determined, but the first ardor of her defiance was as though a cold breath had blown on it. Still she did not intend to leave, ignominiously withdrawing before defeat. She wanted to say more, rub it in that she knew the reason for his action, and let him see still plainer in how slight esteem she held his daughter. But the interlude of the spider had been such a check that she did not know exactly how to begin again. She stood for a moment uncertain, and he said,

"Will you take the money?"

"No!" she said loudly. "Don't ask me that again!"

“All right,” he answered quietly, “that ends our business. Do you know your way out, or shall I ring for Granger to see you to the door?”

There was a bell on the desk and he extended his hand toward it. She guessed that Granger was the polished and deferential young man who had greeted her on her entrance, and the ignominy of being escorted out under a cloud—literally shown the door by the same youth, probably no longer polished or deferential, was more than she could bear.

“I’m going,” she said fiercely. “Don’t dare to touch that bell! But just be sure of one thing, Bill Cannon, this is not the last you or your daughter will hear of me.”

He bowed with an air of irony that was so slight it might not have been noticed.

“Any messages from you will be received by me with pleasure. But when it comes to other things”—her hand was on the door-knob but she had to listen—“remember the little spider.”

“Rats!” she said furiously, and tore open the door.

“Good afternoon, Mrs. Ryan,” he cried. “Good afternoon!”

She did not answer, but even in her excitement was conscious that the clerks behind the partition might be listening, and so shut the door, not with the bang her state of mind made natural, but with a soft, ladylike gentleness. Then she walked, with a tapping of little heels and a rustle of silken linings, down the long, narrow office and out into the street.

CHAPTER XXI

THE LION'S WHELP

It was late, almost dark, that evening when Cannon left his office. He had sat on after Berny's departure, sunk in a reverie, which was not compounded of those gentle thoughts that are usually associated with that state of being. In the past, when he had been struggling up from poverty, he had had his fierce fights, and his mortifying defeats. He had risen from them tougher and more combative than ever, filled with the lust of vengeance which in the course of time was assuaged. But of late years few (and these antagonists of his own measure) had had the temerity to cross swords with him.

Now he had been defied in his stronghold and by the sort of person that he looked upon as a worm in the path—the kind of worm a man did not even tread on but simply brushed aside. It was incredible in its audacity, its bold insolence. As he walked down Montgomery Street to the car, he pondered on Berny, wonderingly and with a sort of begrudging, astonished admission of a courage that he could not but admire. What a nerve the woman had to dare to threaten him! To threaten Bill Cannon! There was something wild, uncanny, preposterous in it that was almost sublime, had the large, elemental quality of a lofty indifference to danger, that seemed to belong more to heroic legend than to modern life in the West. But his admiration was tempered by his alarm at the thought of his daughter's learning of the sordid intrigue. The bare idea of Rose's censuring him—and he knew she would if she ever learned of his part in the plot—was enough to make him decide that some particularly heavy punishment would be meted out to the woman who dared shatter the only ideal of him known to exist.

But he did not for a moment believe that Berny would tell. She was angry and was talking blusteringly, as angry women talk. He did not know why she was in such a state of ill temper, but at this stage of the proceedings he did not bother his head about that. For the third time she had refused the money—that was the only thing that concerned him. If she refused three hundred thousand dollars, she would refuse anything. It was as much to her

as a million would be. She would know it was as large a sum as she could expect. If that would not buy her, nothing would. Her threats were nonsense, bluff and bluster; the important thing was, she had determined, for some reason of her own, to stick to Dominick Ryan.

How she had found out about Rose he could not imagine, only it was very enraging that she should have done so. It was the last, and most detestable fact in the whole disagreeable business. Brooding on the subject as the car swept him up the hill, he decided that she had guessed it. She was as sharp as a needle and she had put this and that together, the way women do, and had guessed the rest. Pure ugliness might be actuating her present line of conduct, and that state of mind was rarely of long duration. The jealous passions of women soon burn themselves out. Those shallow vessels could not long contain feelings of such a fiery potency, especially when harboring the feeling was so inconvenient and expensive. No one knew better than Berny how well worth her while it would be to cultivate a sweet reasonableness. This was the only gleam of hope left. Her power to endure the present conditions of her life might give out.

That was all the consolation the Bonanza King could extract from the situation, and it did not greatly mitigate his uneasiness and bad humor. This latter condition of being had other matter to feed it, matter which in the interview of the afternoon had been pushed into the background, but which now once again obtruded itself upon his attention. It was the first of May. By the morning's mail he had received a letter from Gene announcing, with the playful blitheness which marked all the young man's allusions to the transfer of the Santa Trinidad Ranch, that the year of probation was up and he would shortly arrive in San Francisco to claim his own.

Gene's father had read this missive in grim-visaged silence. The sense of self-approval that he might have experienced was not his; he only felt that he had been "done". Two months before, thinking that the ranch was slipping too easily from his grasp, that he was making too little effort to retain his own, he had hired a detective to go to San Luis Obispo and watch the career of Gene for signs of his old waywardness. On the thirtieth of April the man had reported that Gene's course had been marked by an abstinence as genuine and complete as the most exacting father could wish.

The old man crumpled up the letter and threw it into the waste-paper basket, muttering balefully, like a cloud charged with thunder. It was not that he wished Gene to drink again; it was that he hated most bitterly giving him the finest piece of ranch land in California. It was not that he did not wish his son to be prosperous and respectable, only he wished that this happy condition had been achieved at some one else's expense.

His mood was unusually black when he entered the house. The servant, who came forward to help him off with his coat, knew it the moment he saw the heavy, scowling face. The piece of intelligence the man had to convey—that Mr. Gene Cannon had arrived half an hour earlier from San Luis Obispo—was not calculated to abate the Bonanza King's irritation. He received it with the expressionless grunt he reserved for displeasing information, and, without further comment or inquiry, went up the stairs to his own rooms. From these he did not emerge till dinner was announced, when he greeted Gene with a bovine glance of inspection and the briefest sentence of welcome.

Gene, however, was not at all abashed by any lack of cordiality. At the best of times, he was not a sensitive person, and as this had been his portion since his early manhood, he was now used to it. Moreover, to-night he was in high spirits. In his year of exile he had learned to love the outdoor life for which he was fitted, and had conceived a passionate desire to own the splendid tract of land for which he felt the love and pride of a proprietor. Now it was his without let or hindrance. He was the owner of a principality, the lord of thousands of teeming acres, watered by crystal streams and shadowed by ancient oaks. He glowed with the joy of possession, and if anything was needed to complete his father's discomfiture, it was Gene's naïve and bridling triumph.

Always a loquacious person, a stream of talk flowed from him to which the old man offered no interruption, and in which even Rose found it difficult to insert an occasional, arresting question. Gene had any number of new plans. His head was fuller than it had been for years with ideas for the improvement of his land, the development of his irrigating system, the planting of new orchards, the erecting of necessary buildings. He used the possessive pronoun continually, rolled it unctuously on his tongue with a new, rich delight. He directed most of his conversation toward Rose, but every now and then he turned on his father, enthusiastically dilating on a

projected improvement certain to increase the ranch's revenues by many thousands per annum.

The old man listened without speaking, his chin on his collar, his eyes fixed in a wide, dull stare on his happy boy. At intervals—Gene almost clamoring for a response—he emitted one of those inarticulate sounds with which it was his custom to greet information that he did not like or the exact purport of which he did not fathom.

The only thing which would have sweetened his mood would have been a conversation, peaceful and uninterrupted, with his daughter. He had not seen as much of her as usual during the last few days, as she had been confined to her room with a cold. This was the first evening she had been at dinner for four days, and the old man had looked forward to one of their slow, enjoyable meals together, with a long, comfortable chat over the black coffee, as was their wont. Even if Rose did not know of his distractions and schemes, she soothed him. *She* never, like this chattering jackass from San Luis Obispo—and he looked sulkily at his son—rubbed him the wrong way. And he had hardly had a word with her, hardly, in fact, had heard her voice during the whole meal.

When it was over, and she rose from her seat, he asked her to play on the piano in the sitting-room near by.

“Give us some music,” he said, “I want to hear something pleasant. The whole day I’ve been listening to jays and knaves and fools, and I want to hear something different that doesn’t make me mad or make me sick.”

Rose left the room and presently the sound of her playing came softly from the sitting-room across the hall. Neither of the men spoke for a space, and the old man, casting a side look at Gene, was maliciously gratified by the thought that his son was offended. But he had reckoned without his offspring's amiable imperviousness to the brutalities of the parental manner, wrought to-night to a condition of absolute invulnerability by the young man's unclouded gladness. Gene, his eyes on his coffee-cup, was in anything but a state of insulted sullenness, as was proved by his presently looking up and remarking, with innocent brightness,

“You didn’t expect I’d get it, did you, Pop? I knew from the start you were sure I’d slip up before the year was out.”

His father eyed him without replying, a blank, stony stare, before which Gene did not show the slightest sign of quailing. He went on jubilantly in his high, throaty voice.

“I wasn’t dead certain of it myself at the start. You know it isn’t the easiest thing in the world to break off drinking habits that have had you as long as mine had me. But when I went down there and lived right on the land, when I used to get up in the morning and look out of my window across the hills and see the cattle dotted all over them, and the oaks thick and big and bushy, and feel the air just as soft as silk, I said to myself, ‘By gum, Gene Cannon, you’ve got to have this ranch if you die for want of whisky.’”

“Well, you’ve got it!” said his father in a loud, pugnacious tone. “You’ve got it, haven’t you?”

“Well, I guess I have,” said Gene, his triumph tempered by an air of modesty, “and I guess I earned it fair. I stuck to the bargain and there were times when I can tell you it was a struggle. I never once slipped up. If you don’t believe my word, I can bring you men from down there that know me well, and they’ll testify that I speak the truth.”

The father raised his eyebrows but said nothing. If there was anything further needed to show him what a complete, consistent fool his son was, it was the young man’s evident impression that the Santa Trinidad Ranch had been relinquished upon his own unsupported testimony. That was just like Gene. For weeks the detective had trotted at his heels, an entirely unsuspected shadow.

“It was Rose who really put me up to it,” he went on. “She’d say to me I could do it, I only had to try; any one could do anything they really made their minds up to. If you said you couldn’t do a thing, why, then you couldn’t, but if you said you could, you got your mind into that attitude, and it wasn’t hard any more. And she was right. When I got my mind round to looking at it that way, it came quite easily. Rose’s always right.”

This, the first statement of his son’s to which the Bonanza King could subscribe, did not placate the old man. On the contrary, it still further inflamed his sense of angry grievance. It was bad enough to have Gene stealing the ranch—that’s all it was—but to have him chuckling and grinning over it, when that very day Rose’s chances of happiness had come

to a deadlock, was just what you might expect of such a fool. Out of the fullness of the heart the mouth spoke, growled rather,

“I was just waiting to hear you give some credit to Rose. Here you are talking all through dinner like a megaphone all about yourself and your affairs, and not giving a thought to your sister.”

Gene stared at his parent in ingenuous, concerned amaze.

“Not a thought to Rose?” he repeated, in a high, surprised key. “Oh, yes I have—lots of thoughts. I was just telling you now about how she braced me up.”

“Braced you up! Of course she braced you up. Hasn’t she been doing it all her life? But you can’t think of anything but yourself. Don’t you ever look at your sister and think about her and how *she* feels?”

“Yes,” said Gene, giving his head a confirmatory wag, “I do, I do whenever I’m in town. You see, being away on the ranch so much——”

The old man leaned back in his chair, emitting a loud, interrupting groan. Gene stared at him with a dawning uneasiness. He had begun to grasp the fact that his father was in a state of mind which had complications that included more than the old familiar contemptuousness of his every-day mood. He decided to advance more gingerly, for even Gene’s imperviousness to snubs did not make him proof against the Bonanza King’s roused displeasure.

“I’m sure,” he said mildly, “no man ever had a more unselfish sister than I have, or was more devoted to her than I am.”

“Then, why the hell,” said the old man, “do you go on talking about yourself and your damned concerns, bothering the life out of her when she’s got troubles of her own?”

The look of foolish amaze on Gene’s face deepened into one of genuine concern.

“Troubles of her own? What troubles has she got?”

One of the most aggravating features of the situation was that Gene could not be told why Rose was troubled and his father was cross. While they were bent under unaccustomed cares, he went happy and free, with nothing

to think of except the ranch he had stolen. If he had been any other kind of person, he could have been taken into the secret and might have helped them out. The Bonanza King had thought of ways in which a young and intelligent man could have been of assistance in inducing Mrs. Dominick Ryan to listen to reason. Gene, if he'd had any ability, if he'd had the brains of a mouse, could have made love to her, induced her to run away with him, and then they could have given her the money and got rid of her without any more fuss. He could have been of incalculable value and here he was, perfectly useless, too much of a fool even to be *told* the position, moved by the mere gross weight of his stupidity into an outside place of tranquil ignorance. That his father could not force him to be a sharer in the family troubles made the old man still more angry, and it was a poignant pain to him that the only way he could show his rage was by roaring wrathfully.

"Yes, Rose has troubles. Of course she has, but what have they got to do with you, who don't care about a thing but your damned ranch?"

"What's the matter with her?" said Gene, roused into active uneasiness and quite oblivious to his father's insults. "I didn't know anything was wrong. She didn't tell me."

"No, and she won't," said the father. "And let me tell you if I catch you asking her any questions or giving her any hints that I've said anything to you, you can stay on your ranch and never come back into this house. I won't have Rose worried and upset by every fool that comes along."

"Well, but how am I to find out what's the matter with her," said the altogether baffled brother, "if you won't tell me, and I'm not to ask her?"

"You needn't find out. It's her affair—hers and mine. Don't you go poking your nose in and trying to find out. I don't want you butting into Rose's affairs."

"Just now," said Gene in an aggrieved tone, "you said I didn't take any interest in anything but my ranch. Now, when I want to take an interest in Rose, you tell me not to butt in. I love my sister more than most men, and I'd like to know if anything's wrong with her."

"She's got a cold," said Cannon.

He spoke sharply and looked at Gene with a sidelong eye full of observant malice. The young man gazed back at him, confused, for a moment half

inclined to laugh, thinking his father, in a sudden unaccustomed playfulness, was joking with him.

“Well, if it’s only a cold,” he stammered, “it’s nothing to tear up the ground about. I thought it was something serious, that Rose was unhappy about something. But a cold——”

He was interrupted by the sudden appearance of Rose herself, her hand drawing back the portière that veiled the doorway. She, who knew her father so well, had decided that in his present mood it was better to curtail his after-dinner chat with Gene. Her quick eye took in their two faces, and she felt that her brother had probably had a trying half-hour.

“I’m tired of making music,” she said. “I’ve played my whole repertoire. Now I want Gene to come back into the sitting-room with me and tell me about the linen and the furniture I’m to send down to the ranch. We’ll talk it over to-night and make a list and arrange for the packing to-morrow.”

The young man rose, very glad to go with her, still uneasy and puzzled.

“How’s your cold, Rosey?” he said. “I didn’t know it was bad or I’d have asked more about it.”

“Oh, it’s all right,” she said carelessly. “It was never really bad, but I stayed in my room for a few days to be safe.” Her eye caught her father’s, half-shut and full of brooding scorn, shot through with a gleam of sardonic humor. Gene’s half-hour must have been even more trying than she had at first thought.

“Come along, Gene,” she said, holding out her hand to him, “we’ll leave the old man to his dreams. I know he never listened to a note of my music and only told me to play as an excuse to get rid of me.”

She threw a laughing look at her father, who answered it with a lazy, fond cast of his eye in her direction. Taking Gene’s hand, she drew him into the hall and dropped the portière. The father could hear their voices diminishing and growing muffled as they passed up the hall to the sitting-room.

He sat on as they had left him in his favorite crumpled-up attitude. After all, it was a good thing the boy did not know, was of the kind who could not be trusted with any information of importance. He did not want Gene or anybody else to interfere. He, Rose’s father, and he alone, without any

outside assistance, would reach up and pick out for her any star that sparkled in the heavens, any moon for which she might choose to cry. She wanted Dominick Ryan for her husband. She should have him and it would be her father who would get him for her. He would give her Dominick Ryan, as he would a pearl necklace or a new automobile to which she had taken a fancy.

It whetted the old man's lust of battle that Dominick was so hard to get. Sitting fallen together in his chair he thought about new ways of approaching Berny, new ways of bribing, or wheedling, or terrifying her into giving up her husband. He was not at the end of his rope yet, by any means. And it lent an added zest to the game that he had an adversary of so much spirit. He was beginning to respect her. Even if he had not been fighting for Rose, he would have gone on with the struggle for its own sake. It was not Bill Cannon's way to enter a contest, and then be beaten—a contest with a spitfire woman at that.

CHAPTER XXII

OUT OF THE FULLNESS OF THE HEART

That night it was Berny's turn to be wakeful. In the silence of the sleeping house and the warm darkness of her curtained room, she lay tossing on her bed, hearing the clear, musical striking of the parlor clock as it marked the hours. When the first thin streak of gray painted a pale line between the window curtains she rose and took a sleeping powder and soon after fell into a heavy slumber.

This held her in the dead, motionless unconsciousness that a drug brings, through the long morning hours. Dominick's noiseless departure hardly disturbed the hushed quiet of the little flat. The Chinaman, trained by his exacting mistress to make no sound while she slept, went about his work with a stealthy step and cautious touch, even in the kitchen, shut off by space and muffling doors, continuing his care. He had had more than one experience with the wrath of Mrs. Ryan when she had been roused from late slumbers by a banged door or a dropped pan.

It was nearly lunch-time when she awoke, slowly emerging from the black, unbroken deadness of her sleep to a momentarily augmenting sense of depression. She rose, her body seeming to participate in the oppressed discomfort of her mind, and, going to the bedroom window, drew the curtain and looked out.

The day promised little in the way of cheering influences. Fog hung heavy in the air, a gray veil depending from a gray haze of sky. That portion of her neighbor's garden which the window commanded was drenched with it, the flowers drooping moistly as if it weighed on them like a heavy substance under the pressure of which they bent and dripped. The stretch of wall that she could see gleamed with dampness. A corner of stone, on which a drop regularly formed, hung and then fell, held her eyes for a few vacantly-staring moments. Then she turned away, muttering to herself,

"Good Lord, what a day!"

She was at her lunch when the telephone bell rang. She dropped her napkin and ran to the instrument which was in the hall. She did not know what she expected—or rather she did not expect anything in particular—but she was in that state of feverish tension when she seemed the focus of portentous happenings, the point upon which events of sinister menace might, at any moment, bear down. Bill Cannon might be calling her up, for what purpose she could not guess, only for something that would be disagreeable and perturbing.

It was, however, her husband's voice that answered her. He spoke quickly, as if in a hurry, telling her that he would not be home to dinner, as a college friend of his from New York had just arrived and he would dine and go to the theater with him that evening. Berny's ear, ready to discover, in the most alien subjects, matter bearing on her husband's interest in Rose Cannon, listened intently for the man's name. As Dominick did not give it she asked for it, and to her strained and waiting attention it seemed to come with an intentional indistinctness.

"What is his name?" she called again, her voice hard and high. "I didn't catch it."

It was repeated and for the second time she did not hear it. Before she could demand it once more, Dominick's "Good-by" hummed along the wire and the connection was cut.

She did not want any more lunch and went into the parlor, where she sat down on the cushioned window-seat and looked out on the vaporous transparencies of the fog. She had waked with the sense of weight and apprehension heavy on her. As she dressed she had thought of the interview of yesterday with anger and also with something as much like fear as she was capable of feeling. She realized the folly of the rage she had shown, the folly and the futility of it, and she realized the danger of an open declaration of war with the fierce and unscrupulous old man who was her adversary. This, with her customary bold courage, she now tried to push from her mind. After all, he couldn't kill her, and that was about the only other way he could get rid of her. Even Bill Cannon would hardly dare, in the present day in San Francisco, cold-bloodedly to murder a woman. The thought caused a slight, sarcastic smile to touch her lips. Fortunately for her, the lawless days of California were passed.

With the curtain caught between her finger-tips, her figure bent forward and motionless, she looked out into the street as if she saw something there of absorbing interest. But she saw nothing. All her mental activity was bent on the problem of Dominick's telephone message. She did not believe it. She was in that state where trifles light as air all point one way, and to have Dominick stay out to dinner with a sudden and unexpected "friend from New York" was more than a trifle. She assured herself with slow, cold reiteration that he was dining with Rose Cannon in the big house on California Street. If they walked together on Sunday mornings, why shouldn't they dine together on week-day nights? They were careful of appearances and they would never let themselves be seen together in any public place till they were formally engaged. The man from New York was a fiction. She—that immaculate, perfect girl—had invented him. Dominick could not invent anything. He was not that kind of man. But Berny knew that all women can lie when the occasion demands, and Rose Cannon could thus supply her lover's deficiencies.

With her blankly-staring eyes fixed on the white outside world, her mental vision conjured up a picture of them at dinner that night, sitting opposite each other at a table glistening with the richest of glass and silver, while soft-footed menials waited obsequiously upon them. Bill Cannon was not in the picture. Berny's imagination had excluded him, pushing him out of the romance into some unseen, uninteresting region where people who were not lovers dined dully by themselves. She could not imagine Rose and Dominick otherwise than alone, exchanging tender glances over the newest form of champagne glasses filled with the choicest brand of champagne.

A sound escaped her, a sound of pain, as if forced from her by the grinding of jealous passions within. She dropped the curtain and rose to her feet. If they married it would be always that way with them. They would have everything in the world, everything that to Berny made life worth while. Even Paris, with her three hundred thousand dollars to open all its doors, would be a savorless place to her if Rose and Dominick were to be left to the enjoyment of all the pleasures and luxuries of life back in California.

Unable to rest, fretted by jealousy, tormented by her longing for the offered money, oppressed by uneasiness as to Cannon's next move, the thought of the long afternoon in the house was unendurable to her. She could not remain unemployed and passive while her mind was in this state of

disturbance. Though the day was bad and there was nothing to do down town, she determined to go out. She might find some distraction in watching the passers-by and looking at the shop windows.

By the time she was dressed, it was four o'clock. The fog was thicker than ever, hanging over the city in an even, motionless pall of vapor. Its breath had a keen, penetrating chill, like that exhaled by the mouth of a cavern. Coming down the steps into it she seemed to be entering a white, still sea, off which an air came that was pleasant on the heated dryness of her face. She had no place to go to, no engagement to keep, but instinctively turned her steps in the down-town direction. Walking would pass more time than going on the car, and she started down the street which slanted to a level and then climbed a long, dim reach of hill beyond. Its emptiness—a characteristic feature of San Francisco streets—struck upon her observation with a sense of griping, bleak dreariness. She could look along the two lines of sidewalk till they were lost in the gradual milky thickening of the fog, and at intervals see a figure, faint and dreamlike, either emerging from space in slow approach, or melting into it in phantasmal withdrawal.

It was a melancholy, depressing vista. She had not reached the top of the long hill before she decided that she would walk no farther. Walking was only bearable when there was something to see. But she did not know what else to do or where to go. Indecision was not usually a feature of her character. To-day, however, the unaccustomed strain of temptation and worry seemed to have weakened her resourcefulness and resolution. The one point on which she felt determined was that she would not go home.

The advancing front of a car, looming suddenly through the mist, decided her. She hailed it, climbed on board, and sank into a seat on the inside. There was no one else there. It smelt of dampness, of wet woollens and rubber overshoes, and its closed windows, filmed with fog, showed semicircular streaks across them where passengers had rubbed them clean to look out. The conductor, an unkempt man, with an unshaven chin and dirty collar, slouched in for her fare, extending a grimy paw toward her. As he took the money and punched the tag, he hummed a tune to himself, seeming to convey in that harmless act a slighting opinion of his passenger. Berny looked at him severely, which made him hum still louder, and lounge indifferently out to the back platform where he leaned on the brake and spat scornfully into the street.

Berny felt that sitting there was worse than walking. There was no one to look at, there was nothing to be seen from the windows. The car dipped over the edge of an incline, slid with an even, skimming swiftness down the face of the hill, and then, with a series of small jouncings, crossed the rails of another line. Not knowing or caring where she was, she signaled the conductor to stop, and alighted. She looked round her for an uncertain moment, and then recognized the locality. She was close to the old Union Street plaza on which the Greek Church fronted. Here in the days before her marriage, when she and Hazel had been known as "the pretty Iverson girls," she had been wont to come on sunny Sunday mornings and sit on the benches with such beaux as brightened the monotony of that unaspiring period.

She felt tired now and thought it would not be a bad idea to cross to the plaza and rest there for a space. She was warmly dressed and her clothes would not be hurt by the damp. Threading her way down the street, she came out on the opening where the little park lies like an unrolled green cloth round which the shabby, gray city crowds.

She sank down on the first empty bench, and looking round she saw other dark shapes, having a vague, huddled appearance, lounging in bunched-up attitudes on the adjacent seats. They seemed preoccupied. It struck her that they, like herself, were plunged in meditation on matters which they had sought this damp seclusion silently to ponder. The only region of activity in the dim, still scene was where some boys were playing under the faintly-defined outline of a large willow tree. They were bending close to the ground in the performance of a game over which periods of quietness fell to be broken by sudden disrupting cries. As Berny took her seat their imp-like shapes, dark and without detail, danced about under the tree in what appeared a fantastic ecstasy, while their cries broke through the woolly thickness of the air with an intimate clearness, strangely at variance with the remote effect of their figures.

The fact that no one noticed her, or could clearly see her, affected her as it seemed to have done the other occupants of the benches. She relaxed from her alert sprightliness of pose, and sank against the back of the seat in the limpness of unobserved indifference. Sitting thus, her eyes on the ground, she heard, at first unheeding, then with a growing sense of attention, footsteps approaching on the gravel walk. They were the short, quick

footsteps of a woman. Berny looked up and saw the woman, a little darker than the atmosphere, emerging from the surrounding grayness, as if she were slowly rising to the surface through water.

Her form detached itself gradually from the fog, the effect of deliberation being due to the fact that she was dressed in gray, a long, loose coat and a round hat with a film of veil about it. She would have been a study in monochrome but for the color in the cheek turned to Berny, a glowing, rose-tinted cheek into which the damp had called a pink brighter than any rouge. Berny looked at it with reluctant admiration, and the woman turned and presented her full face, blooming as a flower, to the watcher's eye. It was Rose Cannon.

If in these wan and dripping surroundings the young girl had not looked so freshly fair and comely, Berny might have let her pass unchecked. But upon the elder woman's sore and bitter mood the vision of this rosy youthfulness, triumphant where all the rest of the world sank unprotesting under the weight of a common ugliness, came with a sense of unbearable wrong and grievance. As Rose passed, Berny, with a sudden blinding up-rush of excitement, leaned forward and rose.

"Miss Cannon," she said loudly. "Oh, Miss Cannon,—just a moment."

Rose turned quickly, looking inquiringly at the owner of the voice. She had had a vague impression of a figure on the bench but had not looked at it. Now, though the face she saw was unfamiliar, she smiled and said,

"Did you want to speak to me?"

The ingratiating amiability of her expression added to Berny's swelling sense of injury and injustice. Thus did this siren smile upon Dominick, and it was a smile that was very sweet. The excitement that had seized upon the older woman made her tremble, but she was glad, fiercely, burningly glad, that she had stopped Miss Cannon.

"Yes," she said, "just for a moment, if you don't mind."

Rose had never seen the woman before, and at the first glance supposed her to be some form of peddler or a person selling tickets. The daughter of Bill Cannon was eagerly sought by members of her own sex who had wares for sale, and it did not strike her as odd that she should be stopped in the plaza on a foggy afternoon. But a second glance showed her that the woman

before her was better dressed, more assured in manner than the female vender, and she felt puzzled and interested.

“You had something to say to me?” she queried again, the questioning inflection a little more marked.

“Yes, but not much. I won’t keep you more than a few moments. Won’t you sit down?”

Berny designated the bench and they sat on it, a space between them. Rose sat forward on the edge of the seat, looking at the strange woman whose business with her she could not guess.

“You’ve never seen me before, have you, Miss Cannon?” said Berny. “You don’t know who I am?”

The young girl shook her head with an air of embarrassed admission.

“I’m afraid I don’t,” she said. “If I’ve ever met you before, it must have been a long time ago.”

“You’ve never met me,” said Berny, “but I guess you’ve heard of me. I am the wife of Dominick Ryan.”

She said the words easily, but her eyes were lit with devouring fires as they fastened on the young woman’s face. Upon this, signs of perturbation immediately displayed themselves. For a moment Rose was shaken beyond speech. She flushed to her hair, and her eyes dropped. To a jealous observation, she looked confused, trapped, guilty.

“Really,” she said after the first moment of shock, “I—I—I really don’t think I ever did meet you.” With her face crimson she raised her eyes and looked at her companion. “If I have, I must have forgotten it.”

“You haven’t,” said Berny, “but you’ve met my husband.”

Rose’s color did not fade, but this time she did not avert her eyes. Pride and social training had come to her aid. She answered quietly and with something of dignity.

“Yes, I met Mr. Ryan at Antelope when we were snowed up there. I suppose he’s told you all about it?”

“No,” said Berny, her voice beginning to vibrate, “he hasn’t told me *all* about it. He’s told me just as much as he thought I ought to know.”

Her glance, riveted on Rose’s face, contained a fierce antagonism that was like an illumination of hatred shining through her speech. “He didn’t think it was necessary to tell me *everything* that happened up there, Miss Cannon.”

Rose turned half from her without answering. The action was like that of a child which shrinks from the angry face of punishment. Berny leaned forward that she might still see her and went on.

“He couldn’t tell me *all* that happened up at Antelope. There are some things that it wouldn’t have done for him to tell me. A man doesn’t tell his wife about his affairs with other women. But sometimes, Miss Cannon, she finds them out.”

Rose turned suddenly upon her.

“Mrs. Ryan,” she said in a cold, authoritative voice, “what do you want to say to me? You stopped me just now to say something. Whatever it is, say it and say it out.”

Berny’s rages invariably worked themselves out on the same lines. With battle boiling within her, she could preserve up to a certain point a specious, outward calm. Then suddenly, at some slight, harmless word, some touch as light as the pressure on the electric button that sets off the dynamite explosion, the bonds of her wrath were broken and it burst into expression. Now her enforced restraint was torn into shreds, and she cried, her voice quavering with passion, shaken with breathlessness:

“What do you suppose I want to say? I want to ask you what right you’ve got to try and steal my husband?”

“I have *no* right,” said Rose.

Berny was, for the moment, so taken aback, that she said nothing but stared with her whole face set in a rigidity of fierce attention. After a moment’s quivering amaze she burst out,

“Then what are you doing it for?”

“I am not doing it.”

“You’re a liar,” she cried furiously. “You’re worse than a liar. You’re a thief. You’re trying to get him every way you know how. You sit there looking at me with a face like a little innocent, and you know there’s not a thing you can do to get him away from me you’re not doing. If a common chippy, a gutter girl, acted that way they’d call her some pretty dirty names, names that would make you sit up if you thought any one would use them to you. But I don’t see where there’s any difference. You think because you’re rich and on top of the heap that you can do anything. Just let me tell you, Miss Rose Cannon, you can’t steal Dominick Ryan from me. You may be Bill Cannon’s daughter, with all the mines of the Comstock behind you, but you can’t buy my husband.”

Rose was aghast. The words of Berny’s outburst were nothing to her, sound and fury, the madness of a jealous woman. That this was a loving wife fighting for the husband whose heart she had lost was all she understood and heard. That was the tragic, the appalling thought. The weight of her own guilty conscience seemed dragging her down into sickened silence. The only thing it seemed to her she could honestly say was to refute the woman’s accusations that Dominick was being stolen from her.

“Mrs. Ryan,” she implored, “whatever else you may think, do *please* understand that I am not trying to take your husband away from you. You’re making a mistake. I don’t know what you’ve heard or guessed, but you’re distracting yourself without any necessity. How could I ever do that? I never meet him. I never see him.”

She leaned forward in her eagerness. Berny cast a biting, sidelong look at her.

“How about Sunday morning on Telegraph Hill?” she said.

“I did meet him there, that’s true,”—a memory of the conversation augmented the young girl’s sense of guilt. If half this woman said was madness, half was fact. Dominick loved Rose Cannon, not his wife, and to Rose that was the whole tragedy. Meetings, words, renouncements were nothing. She stammered in her misery.

“Yes,—but—but—you must believe me when I tell you that that time and once before—one evening in the moonlight on the steps of our house—

were the only times I've seen your husband since I came back from Antelope."

"Well, I don't," said Berny, "I don't for a moment believe you. You must take me for the easiest fruit that ever grew on the tree if you think I'll swallow a fairy tale like that. If you met once on Telegraph Hill, and once in the moonlight, what's to prevent your meeting at other times, and other places? You haven't mentioned the visits up at your house and the dinner to-night."

Rose drew back, frowning, uncomprehending.

"What dinner to-night?" she said.

"The one you're going to take with my husband."

For the first time in the interview, the young girl was lifted from the sense of dishonesty that crushed her by a rising flood of angry pride.

"I take dinner with my father to-night in our house on California Street," she said coldly.

"Bosh!" said Berny, giving her head a furious jerk. "You needn't bother wasting time on lies like that to me. I'm not a complete fool."

"Mrs. Ryan," said Rose, "I think we'd better end this talk. We can't have any rational conversation when you keep telling me what I say is a lie. I am sorry you feel so badly, and I wish I could say something to you that you'd believe. All I can do to ease your mind is to assure you that I never, except on those two occasions, have seen your husband since his return from the country and I certainly never intend to see him again."

She rose from the bench and, as she did so, Berny cried,

"Then how do you account for the money that was offered me yesterday?"

"Money?" said the young girl, pausing as she stood. "What money?"

"The three hundred thousand dollars that your father offered me yesterday afternoon to leave my husband and let him get a divorce from me."

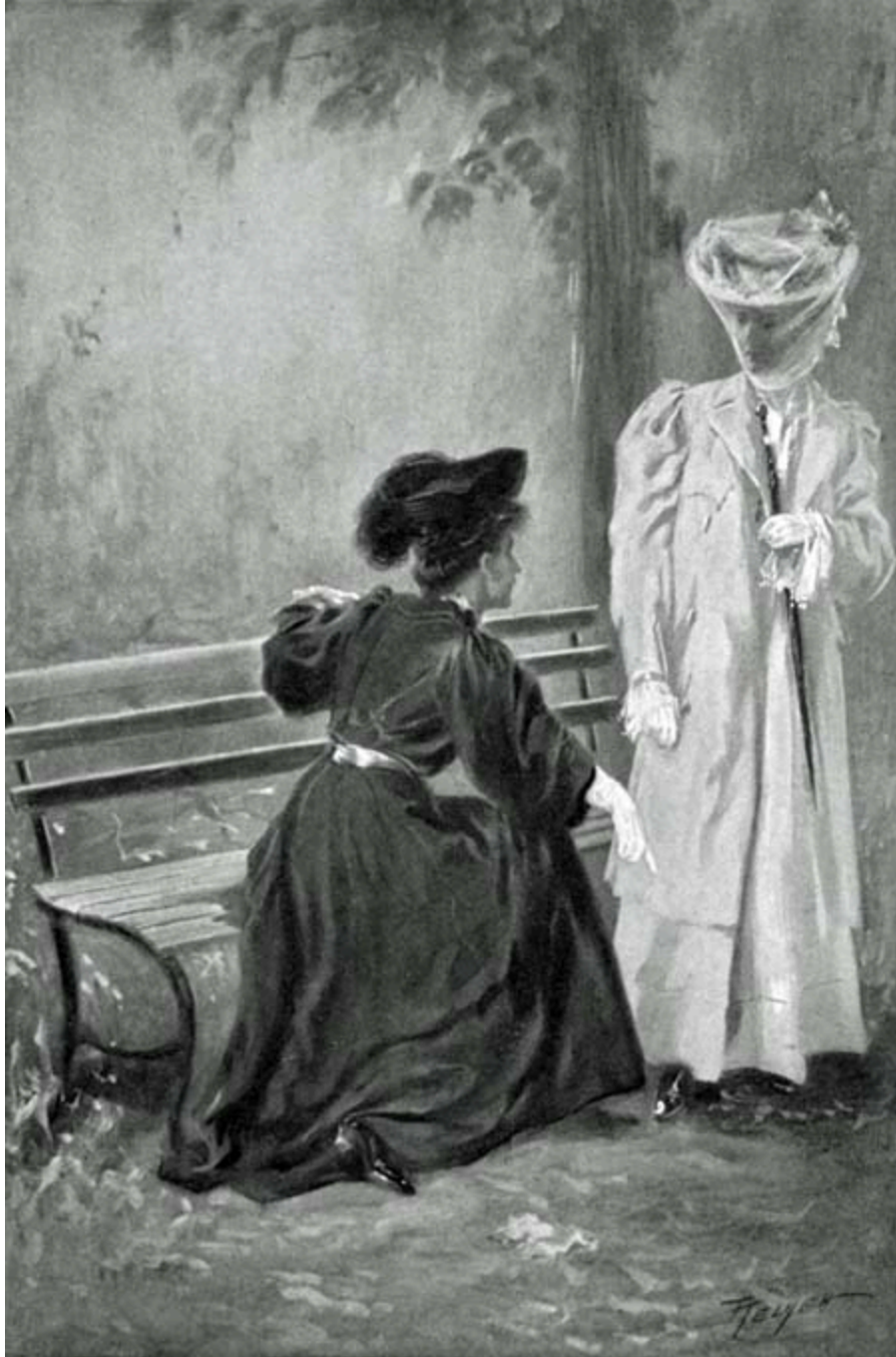
Rose sat down on the bench and turned a startled face on the speaker.

"Tell me that again," she said. "I don't quite understand it."

Berny gave a little, dry laugh.

“Oh, as many times as you like,” she said with her most ironical air of politeness, “only, I should think it would be rather stale news to you by this time. Yesterday afternoon your father made me his third offer to desert my husband and force him to divorce me at the end of a year. The offers have gone up from fifty thousand dollars—that was the first one, and, all things considered, I thought it was pretty mean—to the three hundred thousand they tried me with yesterday. Mrs. Ryan was supposed to have made the first offer, but your father did the offering. This last time he had to come out and show his hand and admit that one-third of the money was from him.” She turned and looked at Rose with a cool, imperturbable impudence. “It’s good to have rich parents, isn’t it?”

Rose stared back without answering. She had become very pale.



**“Then how do you account for the money that was
offered me yesterday?”**

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“That,” said Berny, giving her head a judicial nod, and delivering her words with a sort of impersonal suaveness, “is the way it was managed; you were kept carefully out. I wasn’t supposed to know there was a lady in the case, but of course I did. You can’t negotiate the sale of a husband as you do that

of a piece of real estate, especially when his wife objects. That, Miss Cannon, was the difficulty. While all you people were so anxious to buy, *I* was not willing to sell. It takes two to make a bargain.”

Rose, pale now to her lips, said in a low voice,

“I don’t believe it. It’s not true.”

Berny laughed again.

“Well, that’s only fair,” she said with an air of debonair large-mindedness. “I’ve been telling you what you say is lies and now you tell me what *I* say is lies. It’s not, and you know it’s not. How would I have found out about all this? Do you think Dominick told me? Men don’t tell their wives when they want to get rid of them. They’re stupid, but they’re not *that* stupid.”

Rose gave a low exclamation and turned her head away. Berny was waiting for a second denial of her statements, when the young girl rose to her feet, saying in a horrified murmur,

“How awful! How perfectly awful!”

“Of course,” Berny continued, addressing her back, “I was to understand *you* didn’t know anything about it. I had my own opinions on that. Fathers don’t go round buying husbands for their daughters unless they know their daughters are dead set on having the husbands. Bill Cannon was not trying to get Dominick away from me just because he wanted to be philanthropic. Neither was Mrs. Ryan. You’re the kind of wife she wanted for her boy, just as Dominick’s the husband your father’d like for you. So you stood back and let the old people do the dirty work. You——”

Rose turned quickly, sat down on the edge of the bench, and leaned toward the speaker. Her face was full of a quivering intensity of concern.

“You poor, unfortunate woman!” she said in a shaken voice, and laid her hand on Berny’s knee.

Berny was so astonished that for the moment she had no words, but stared uncomprehending, still alertly suspicious.

“You poor soul!” Rose went on. “If I’d known or guessed for a moment I’d have spoken differently. I can’t say anything. I didn’t know. I couldn’t have guessed. It’s the most horrible thing I ever heard of. It’s—too—too——”

She stopped, biting her lip. Berny saw that she was unable to command her voice, though she had no appearance of tears. Her face looked quite different from what it had at the beginning of the interview. All its amiable, rosy softness was gone. The elder woman was too astounded to say anything. She had a feeling that, just for that moment, nothing could be said. She was silenced by something that she did not understand. Like an amazed child she stared at Rose, baffled, confused, a little awed. After a minute of silence, the young girl went on.

“I can’t talk about it. I don’t altogether understand. Other people—they must explain. I’ve been—no, not deceived—but kept in the dark. But be sure of one thing, yesterday was the end of it. They’ll never—no one that I have any power over—will ever make you such offers again. I’ll promise you that. I don’t know how it could have happened. There’s been a mistake, a horrible, unforgivable mistake. You’ve been wronged and insulted, and I’m sorry, sorry and humiliated and ashamed. There are no words——”

She stopped again with a gesture of helpless indignation and disgust, and rose to her feet. Berny, through the darkness of her stunned astonishment, realized that she was shaken by feelings she could not express.

“You didn’t know anything about it then?” the wife said sullenly, wanting still to be defiant and finding all her defiance overwhelmed by an invading sensation of feeling small, mean and contemptible.

“Know it?” said the girl, letting a glance of scorn touch the questioner. “Know it and let it go on? But I suppose you’ve a right to ask me such a question.”

“I guess I have,” said Berny, but her voice did not have any assurance of her conviction on the subject. It sounded flat and spiritless.

“You have. You seem to me to have a right to say anything savage and angry and insulting. And I can only say to you I’m sorry, I’m sorry, and I ask your pardon—for me and for the others. And that doesn’t make it any easier for you to bear, or do you any good.”

Berny swallowed dryly and said,

“No, it doesn’t.”

“All I can do now is to promise you that it stops to-day and for ever. You’ll never be bothered again by anything of the kind. You can go back to your home and feel that never again will any one belonging to me try to come between you and your husband. I can’t say any more. I can’t talk about it. Good-by.”

She turned away as she spoke and without a backward look walked rapidly down the gravel walk to the street. With an immovable, unwinking gaze, Berny followed her figure as it melted into the fog. It seemed only a moment before it was gone, appearing to dissolve into the curd-like currents that surrounded it.

Berny sat without moving on the bench, staring in the direction in which it had disappeared. Her hands lay limp in her lap, the fog beaded in a crystal hoar on her clothes. She did not notice its growing chill nor the rapid downcoming of the dark. Her body was as motionless as a statue, but her mind was like a still, rankly-overgrown lake, suddenly churned into activity by unexpected gales of wind.

CHAPTER XXIII

THE WALL ACROSS THE WAY

It was dark when Rose reached home. She had walked rapidly, mechanically taking familiar turns, cresting the long slope of the hill at a panting speed, rounding corners where gushes of light revealed her as a dark, flitting figure hurrying by almost at a run.

She was as oblivious to her surroundings as Berny, left motionless on the park bench. Never before in her life had anything like this touched her. Such few troubles as she had known had been those of a sheltered domestic life—the life of a cherished child whose dainty self-respect had never been blurred by a coarse breath. Now had come this horrible revelation. It shook the pretty world she had lived in like an earthquake. Idols lay broken in the dust. She had often seen her father rough and brutal as he was to Gene, but that was a different thing to her father's buying that wretched woman's husband, buying him for her. Berny's face rose upon the darkness with its pitiful assumption of jaunty bravado, its mean shrewishness under the coating of powder and rouge.

"How could they do it?" the girl panted to herself. "How could they ever do such a thing?"

She did not suspect Dominick. She could not have believed he was party to such an action unless he had told her so with his own lips. As she hurried on the thought that this was the woman he had bound himself to for the rest of his life mingled with the other more poignantly-hateful thoughts, with a last sickening sense of wretchedness. The sudden, aghast consciousness of chaos, of an abrupt demolishing of the pleasant, familiar settings of a life that never comes to some, came to Rose that evening as she ran home through the fog.

She entered the house noiselessly and sped up to her room. It was time to dress for dinner, and an old woman-servant who had once been her nurse was waiting to help her. The mistress and maid were on terms of affectionate intimacy and the progress of the toilet was generally enlivened

by gossip and laughter. To-night the girl was singularly silent, responding with monosyllables and sometimes not at all to the remarks of her assistant. As the woman drew the fastenings of the dress together, she could feel that the body the gown clipped so closely quivered, like the casing of machinery, vibrating to powerful concussions within.

The silence that continued to hold her throughout dinner passed unnoticed, as Gene was there and enlivened the passage of the meal by contributing an almost unbroken stream of talk. The night before he had been to a play, the plot of which, and its development in four acts, he now related with a fullness of detail which testified to the closeness of his attention and the accuracy of his memory. As each course was removed from the table, and the young man could once more give his undivided attention to the matter of discourse, he leaned back in his chair and took up the dropped thread with a fresh zest and some such remarks as:

“In the beginning of the next act, the hero comes in with his hat on, and first he says”—and so on.

With each of these renewals of the narrative the Bonanza King subsided against his chair-back in a limp attitude, staring with gloomy fixity at his boy, and expelling his breath in a long audible rush of air, which was sometimes a sigh and sometimes approached the proportions of a groan.

At the end of dinner, when Gene announced his intention of leaving as he was to attend a vaudeville performance, the old man began to show signs of reviving animation, going so far as politely to ask his son where he was going and with whom. His manner was marked by a warm, hearty encouragement, as he said,

“Get the whole vaudeville program down by heart, Gene, and you can tell it to us to-morrow night. There’ll be about twelve parts to it, and Rose can order two extra courses for dinner, and we might hire some men with stringed instruments for an accompaniment.”

Gene, with innocent good-humor, responded gaily.

“All right, father, I’ll give it my best attention, and if there’s anything especially good, I’ll report to you. You and Rose might like to go some night.”

His father, disappointed that his shaft had made no impression upon the young man's invulnerable amiability, emitted a scornful snort, and made no further response to Gene's cheery "Good night."

"There," he said, in tones expressing his relief, as the portière dropped behind his son's departing figure, "he's gone! Now, Rosey, you and I can have a talk."

"Yes," said his daughter, looking at her coffee-cup, "that's what I wanted. I want to have a long talk with you to-night, papa."

"Fire away," said the old man. "I've had to listen to that fool for an hour, and it's broken my spirit. You can say anything you like."

"Not here," said his daughter; "in the sitting-room. I'll go in there and wait for you."

"Why not here? What's the matter with here? I like it better than the sitting-room. I'm more comfortable."

"No, the servants will want to clear the things away, and I don't want them to hear what I say."

"Tell the servants to go to hell," said the old man, who, relieved by Gene's departure, was becoming more cheerful.

"No, this is something—something serious. I'll go into the sitting-room and wait for you. When you've finished your coffee, come in."

She rose from her chair and walked to the door. He noticed that she was unusually unsmiling and it occurred to him that she had been so all through dinner.

"What is it, honey," he said, extending his hand toward her, "short on your allowance?"

"Oh, no, it's just—just something," she said, lifting the portière. "Come when you're ready, I'll be there."

She walked up the hall to the sitting-room and there sat down in a low chair before the chimneypiece. The chill of the fog had penetrated the house and a fire had been kindled in the grate. On its quivering fluctuation of flame she fixed her eyes. With her hands pressed between her knees she sat immovable, thinking of what she was going to say, and so nervous that the

blood sang in her ears and the palms of her hands, clasped tight together, were damp. She had never in her life shrunk so before an allotted task. It sickened her and she was determined to do it, to thresh it out to the end. When she heard her father's step in the passage her heart began to beat like a woman's waiting for her lover. She straightened herself and drew an inspiration from the bottom of her lungs to try to give herself breath wherewith to speak.

The old man flung himself into an arm-chair at one side of the fireplace, jerked a small table to his elbow, reached creakingly for an ash tray, and, having made himself comfortable, took his cigar from his mouth and said,

"Well, let's hear about this serious matter that's making you look like a tragedy queen."

"It is serious," she said slowly. "It's something that you won't like to hear about."

"Hit me with it," he said, wondering a little what it could be. "Gene's gone and a child could eat out of my hand now."

Looking into the fire, Rose said,

"I was out walking this afternoon and down in the Union Street plaza a woman stopped me. I'd never seen her before. She was Mrs. Dominick Ryan."

The old man's face became a study. A certain whimsical tenderness that was generally in it when he spoke to his daughter vanished as if by magic. It was as if a light had gone out. He continued to look at her with something of blankness in his countenance, as if, for the first moment of shock, every faculty was held in suspense, waiting for the next words. He held his cigar, nipped between a pair of stumpy fingers, out away from him over the arm of the chair.

"Well," he said quietly, "and what had she to say to you?"

"The most disagreeable things I think any one ever said to me in my life. If they're true, they're just too dreadful——" she stopped, balking from the final disclosure.

"Suppose you tell me what they were?" he said with the same almost hushed quietness.

“She said that you and Mrs. Ryan were offering her money—a good deal of money, three hundred thousand dollars was the amount, I think—to leave her husband so that he could get a divorce from her, and then—” she swallowed as if to swallow down this last unbearable indignity,—“and then be free to marry me.”

So Berny had told all. If deep, unspoken curses could have killed her, she would have died that moment.

“Is it true?” Rose asked.

“Well, yes,” said the old man in a perfectly natural tone of dubious consideration, “it’s a fairly accurate statement.”

“Oh, papa,” cried his daughter, “how could you have done it? How could you have done such a thing? Such a hateful, horrible thing.”

“Horrible thing?” he repeated with an air of almost naïve astonishment. “What’s horrible about it?”

“You know. I don’t have to tell you; you know. Don’t say to me that you don’t think it’s horrible. Don’t make me feel as if we were suddenly thousands of miles apart.”

The Bonanza King knew that in many matters, in most matters involving questions of ethics, they were more thousands of miles apart than she even now suspected. That was one of the reasons why he would have liked to kill Berny, who, for the first time, had brought this dissimilarity in their points of view to his daughter’s unwilling consideration. He spoke slowly and vaguely to gain time. He knew it was a critical moment in the relations between himself and the one creature in the world he loved.

“I don’t want you to feel that way, dearie,” he said easily. “Maybe there are things in this matter you don’t know about or understand. And, anyway, what’s there so horrible in trying to separate a man and woman who are unhappily married and can’t bear the sight of each other?”

“You were separating them for me,” she said in a low voice.

“Well, now,” he answered with a slight rocking movement of his shoulders and a manner of almost bluff deprecation, “I can say that I wasn’t, but suppose I was?”

She paid no attention to the last part of the sentence, and replied,

“The woman said you were.”

He did not answer for a minute, the truth being that he did not know what it was best to say, and wanted to wait and let her make statements that he could either contradict or seek to justify.

“What made you think I wanted to marry Dominick Ryan?” she said slowly, her eyes on the fire.

This was a question that went to the core of the subject. He knew now that he could not put her off, or slip from the responsibilities of the occasion. Drawing himself to the edge of his chair, he leaned forward and spoke with a sincerity and feeling that made his words very impressive.

“One evening when I was at Antelope, I came into the sitting-room and saw my daughter in the arms of Dominick Ryan. I knew that my girl wasn’t the woman to let a man do that unless she loved him. That was how I came to know.”

“Oh,” said Rose in a faint tone.

“Afterward I heard from Dominick of what his marriage was. I heard from his mother, too. Then I saw his wife and I got a better idea from her what it was than I did from either of the others. That fellow, the man my daughter cared for, was tied up in a marriage that was hell. He was bound to a woman who could only be managed with a club, and Dominick was not the kind that uses a club to a woman. What liking he’d had for her was gone. She stuck to him like a barnacle because she wanted to get money, was ready to hang on, feet and hands, till Delia Ryan was dead and then put up a claim for a share of the estate. Do you think a man’s doing such a horrible thing to break up a marriage like that?”

“Yes,” said Rose, “I do. It was a marriage. They’d taken each other for better or for worse. They’d made the most solemn promises to each other. Neither you nor any one else had a right to interfere.”

She spoke with a hard determination, with something of an inflexible, unrelenting positiveness, that was very unusual in her, which surprised and, for the moment, silenced her father. It rose from a source of conviction deeper than the surface emotions of likes and dislikes, of loves and hates, of

personal satisfactions and disappointments. At the core of her being, with roots extending through all the ramifications of her mental and moral nature, was a belief in the inviolability of the marriage tie. It was a conviction founded on neither tradition, nor reason, nor expediency, a thing of impulse, of sex, an hereditary instinct inherited from generations of virtuous women, who, in the days of their defenselessness, as in the days of their supremacy, knew that the most sacred possessions of their lives—their husbands, their children, their homes—rested on its stability. All the small, individual preoccupations of her love for Dominick, her pity for his sufferings, were swept aside by this greater feeling that she did not understand or reason about. She obeyed an instinct, elemental as the instinct of motherhood, when she refused to admit his right to break the bond he had contracted.

Her father stared at her for the moment, chilled by a sense of unfamiliarity in her sudden assumption of an attitude of challenge and authority. He had often heard her inveigh against the divorces so lightly obtained in the world about them. He had thought it one of those pretty ornamental prejudices of hers, that so gracefully adorned her youth and that he liked her to have when they did not interfere with anything of importance. Now, set up like a barrier in the path, he stopped before this one particular prejudice, perplexed at its sudden intrusion, unwilling to believe that it was not a frail, temporary obstruction to be put gently aside.

“Now listen, honey,” said he persuasively, “that’s all very well. I’ve got no right to interfere, and neither, we’ll admit, has anybody. But sometimes you have to push away these little rights and polite customs. They’re very nice for every-day use, but they’re not for big occasions. I suppose the Good Samaritan didn’t really have any right to stop and bind up the wounds of the man he found by the wayside. But I guess the feller he bound up was almighty glad that the Samaritan didn’t have such a respect for etiquette and wait till he’d found somebody to introduce them.”

“Oh, papa, that was different. Don’t confuse me and make me seem a fool. I can’t talk like you. I can’t express it all clearly and shortly. I only know it’s wrong; it’s a sin. I wouldn’t marry Dominick Ryan if he was divorced that way if it killed me to give him up.”

“So if the woman voluntarily took the money and went away and got Dominick to grant her the divorce, Dominick being, as we know, a man of good record and spotless honor, you’d refuse to marry him?”

“I would, certainly I would. It would be perfectly impossible for me to marry him under those circumstances. I should consider I was committing a sin, a particularly horrible and unforgivable sin.”

“See here now, Rosey, just listen to me for a minute. Do you know what Dominick Ryan’s marriage is? I don’t suppose you do. But you do know that he married his mistress, a woman who lived with him eight months before he made her his wife. She wasn’t an innocent young girl by any means. She knew all right where she was going. She established that relation with him with the intention of marrying him. She’s a darned smart woman, and a darned unscrupulous one. That’s not the kind of woman a man feels any particular respect for, or that a girl like you’d give a lot of sympathy to, is it?”

“I don’t see that that would make any difference,” she said. “I’m not thinking of her character, I’m thinking of her rights.”

“And don’t her character and her rights sort of dovetail into each other?”

“No, I don’t see that they do. The law’s above the character or the person. It’s the law, without any question of the man or the woman.”

“Oh Rosey, dear, you’re talking like a book, not like a girl who’s got to live in a world with ordinary people in modern times. This woman, that you’re arguing about as if she was the mother of the Gracchi, hasn’t got any more morality or principle than you could put on the point of a pin.”

“She’s been quite good and proper since her marriage.”

“Well, now, let’s leave her and look at Dominick’s side. He marries her honorably and lives with her for nearly three years. Every semblance of affection that he had for her gets rubbed off in those three years, every illusion goes. He’s tied to a woman that he can’t stand. He went up to Antelope that time because they’d had some sort of a scrap and he felt he couldn’t breathe in the same house with her. He told me himself that they’d not lived as man and wife for nearly a year. Now, I don’t know what you’re going to say, but *I* think to keep on living in *that* state is all wrong. I’ll borrow your expression, I think it’s a sin.”

She answered doggedly:

“It’s awful, but she’s his wife. Oh, if you’d seen her face when she talked to me, her thin, mean, common face, all painted and powdered and so miserable!”

He thought she was wavering, that he saw in this unreasonable, illogical dodging of the point at issue a sign of defeat, and he pushed his advantage.

“And you—a girl of heart and feeling like you—would condemn that man and woman to go on living that lie, that useless, purposeless lie? I can’t understand it. What good comes of it? What’s the necessity for it? Do you realize what a man Dominick might be if he was married to the right woman, and had a decent home where he could live like a Christian? Why, he’d be a different creature. He’d have a future. He’d make his place in the community. All the world would be before him, and he’d mount up to where he belongs. And what is he now? Nothing. All the best in him’s paralyzed by this hell of a box he’s got himself into. The man’s just withering up with despair.”

It was almost too much. For a moment she did not answer, then said in a small voice like a child’s,

“You’re making this very hard for me, papa.”

“My God, Rosey!” he cried, exasperated, “you’re making it hard for yourself. It’s you with your cast-iron prejudices, and your obstinacy, who are making it hard.”

“Well, I’ve got them,” she said, rising to her feet. “I’ve got them, and they’ll stay with me till I die. Nothing’s going to change me in this. I can’t argue and reason about them. They’re part of me.”

She approached the mantelpiece, and, leaning a hand on it, looked down at the fire. The light gilded the front of her dress and played on her face, down-drooped and full of stern decision.

“It’s quite true,” she said slowly, “that I love Dominick. I love him with the best I’ve got. It’s true that I would like to be his wife. It would be a wonderful happiness. But I can’t have it, and so there’s no good thinking about it, or trying to bring it about. It can’t be, and we—you too, papa—must give it up.”

He pressed himself back in his chair, looking at her with lowering, somber disapprobation—a look he had seldom had cause to level at his daughter.

“So you’re going to condemn this poor devil, who loves you and whom you say you love, to a future that’s going to kill any hope in him? You’re going to say to him, ‘You can be free, and make something of your life, and have the woman you want for your wife, but *I* forbid all that, and I’m going to send you back to prison.’ I can’t seem to believe that it’s my Rosey who’s saying that, and who’s so hard and inhuman.”

Rose turned from the fire. He noted an expression almost of austerity on her face that was as new to him as the revelation of obstinacy and indifference to his will she had shown to-night.

“Papa, you don’t understand what I feel. It’s not what you want, or what I want, or what Dominick wants. It’s not what’s going to please us and make us comfortable and happy. It’s something that’s much more important than that. I can’t make Dominick happy and let him make his life a success at the expense of that woman. I can’t take him out of prison, as you call it, because he’s got a responsibility in the prison, that he voluntarily took on himself, and that he’s got to stand by. A man can’t stay by his marriage only as long as it’s pleasant. He can’t throw down the woman he’s made his wife just because he finds he doesn’t like her. If she’s been disagreeable that’s a misfortune, but it doesn’t liberate him from the promises he’s made.”

“Then you think when a man like Dominick Ryan, hardly more than a boy, makes a mistake that ruins his life, he’s got to stay by it?”

“Yes, he must. He’s given a solemn promise. He must keep it. Mistake or sin doesn’t matter.”

The old man was silent. He had presented his case as strongly and persuasively as he knew how, and he had lost it. There was no longer any use in arguing with that unshakable feminine obstinacy, rooted, not in reason but in something rock-like, off which the arguments of reason harmlessly glanced. He had a dim, realizing sense that at the bottom of the woman’s illogical, whim-driven nature, there was that indestructible foundation of blind, governing instincts, and that in them lay her power.

“I guess that lets me out,” he said, turning to knock off the long ash on his cigar. “I guess there’s no use, Rosey, for you and me to try to come to an

agreement on this matter.”

“No, there isn’t. And don’t let’s talk about it any more.” She turned from the fire and came toward him. “But you must promise me one thing—that that woman is to be let alone, that no one—you or any one you have any control over—makes any more offers of money to her.”

She came to a stand beside his chair. He wanted to hold out his hand to her as was his custom when she stood near him, but he was afraid that she might not take it.

“Yes, I can promise that,” he said. “I’ll not offer her any more money. I don’t want to see her again, God knows.”

It was an easier promise to make than Rose guessed. The old man, under an air of mild concurrence in her demands, experienced a sensation of cynical amusement at the thought that the first move for a reopening of negotiations must come from Berny.

“Oh, yes, I’ll promise that,” he said amicably. “You needn’t be afraid that I’m going to go on offering her a fortune. The thing’s been done, the woman’s refused it, and there it stands. I’ve no desire to open it again.”

She leaned down to take his hand. He relinquished it to her with an immense lightening of his heart, and peace fell on him as he felt her rub her cheek against his knuckles.

“So you’re not mad at the old man, after all?” he said almost shyly.

“No,” she murmured, “not at *him*. I was angry at what he was doing.”

It was a subtly feminine way of getting round the delicate points of the situation—that inconsistently feminine way which separates judgment of the individual from judgment of his acts. But it relieved the Bonanza King of the heaviest weight that had lain upon him for many years, and, for once, he gave thanks for the irrationalness of women.

“Well, good-night, honey,” he said, “no matter what crazy notions you’ve got you’re the old man’s girl all right.”

She kissed him.

“And you won’t forget your promise?” she murmured.

“Of course not,” he said stoutly, not sure just what she was alluding to. “Any promise I make to you stands put till the Day of Judgment. Good night.”

When she left him, he lit another cigar, sank lower in his chair and stared at the fire.

It was a deadlock. In his helplessness, the enraged helplessness of the man who had ridden triumphantly over all obstacles that fate had set in his path, his prevailing thought was how much he would like to kill Berny. She had done all this. This viper of a woman, the kind to tread on if she raised her head, had baffled and beaten them all. He could not murder her, but he thought with grim lips of how he could crush and grind her down and let her feel how heavy Bill Cannon’s hand could be.

It seemed for the moment as if everything were over. They had reached a place where a blank wall stretched across the road. Berny’s refusing the money had been a serious obstacle, but not an unconquerable one. Rose tonight had given the whole plot its death blow. With lowering brows he puffed at his cigar, groping in his mind for some way that might yet be tried. He could not brook the thought of defeat. And yet the more he meditated the more impregnable and unscalable appeared the wall that stretched across the way.

CHAPTER XXIV

FRIEND OR FOE

For some time after Rose had left her, Berny remained on the bench, not moving, her glance resting on that part of the path whence the young girl's figure had faded from view.

The night slowly deepened, impregnating the gray atmosphere with a velvety depth of shadow that oozed through it like an infusion of a darker, denser element. Lights came out. First sporadically, here and there blooming through the opaque dusk, not suddenly, but with an effect of gradualness, as though the air was so thick it took some time to break through it. Then came more. Rows of windows appeared in long, magnified sputters. All round the plaza there was a suggestion of effaced brightness, as of a painting which had once been sharply outlined and brilliant but was now rubbed into a formless, impressionist study of shadows and undefined, yellow blurs. The golden halos of lamps blotted the dark at intervals, and now and then the figures, which had occupied the benches, passed into the circles of vaporous illumination, and passed out of them, as if they had been crossing the stage of a theater.

Berny did not move and did not notice the increasing chill of the hour or the moisture beading on her clothes like wintry rime. She was sunk in an abyss of thought, a suspended trance of contemplation, of receptivity to new ideas. In one hour her basic estimate of human nature, her accepted measurement of motives and standards, had been suddenly upset. Her point of view was like a kaleidoscope, which is unexpectedly turned. Sitting motionless on the bench she saw the familiar aspect of life fallen into new shapes, taking on alien forms.

She realized that Dominick had never been happy with her, and, for the first time, she understood the gulf between them. She saw what the life was that he had wanted to lead, and that he could have led with the other woman. It would have been that very form of existence which Berny had always derided, and thought an outward expression of the inward dullness of people who had children, looked shabby, and did not care for money. Now

she felt unsure as to whether her scorn of it was not foolish and unenlightened. As in a sudden forward shoot of a search-light, she saw them—Dominick and Rose—happy in a way she had never dreamed of being happy, in a world so far from hers that she had never before had a clear look at it, a man and woman concentrated upon the piece of life that belonged to them, living passionately for each other, indifferent to all that seemed to her of value.

She brought her mental vision back from this upon herself and felt shaken and slightly sick. Seeing beyond the circle of her own experience and sensation for the first time, she would have said to any companion who might have shared her thoughts, “No wonder Dominick didn’t get on with me!” For a dispassionately-contemplative moment she saw herself in Dominick’s eyes; she saw their married life as it had been to him. She felt sorry for both of them—for him in his forced acquiescence with the conditions around him, for herself because of her ignorance of all he had wanted and expected.

“I couldn’t be any different,” she whispered to herself, “that’s the way I am.”

She never could be any different. She was one kind of woman and Rose Cannon was another, and Dominick belonged to Rose Cannon’s kind. She did not know that it was so much better than her kind but it was different. They made her feel like an outsider in a distant world, and the feeling gave her a sensation of deadly depression. The burning heat of resentment that had made her speak to Rose was gone. All the burning heats and angers of the last two months seemed to belong to the past. An icy, nostalgic ache of loneliness had hold of her. The accustomed sense of intimacy and warm, enjoying interest in the world—what we mean when we talk of “living”—had been completely drawn out of her.

The cold, biting in to her marrow, at last woke her to a realization of her surroundings, and she sat upright, looking blinkingly to the right and left. The half-lit plaza lay like a lake of shadow surrounded by a circlet of light and girdled by noise. It was like the brightness and animation of the world flowing round her but not touching her, as she sat alone in the darkness.

She rose suddenly, determined to escape from her gloomy thoughts, and walked toward the upper end of the square, directing her steps to the

Spanish and Italian section of the city which is called the Latin Quarter. She walked slowly, not knowing where to go, only determined that she would not go home. She thought for a moment of her sisters', where she could have dinner and find the cheer of congenial society. But on consideration she felt that this, too, was more than she could just now bear. They would torment her with questions and she felt in no mood to put them off or to be confidential. Finally she remembered a Mexican restaurant, to visit which had at one time been a fashion. She had been there with Hazel and Josh, and once in a party with some of the bank people. She knew where the place was and felt that she could dine there with no fear of encountering any one she knew.

With an objective point in view, her step gained decision, and she moved forward briskly, leaving the plaza and plunging into the congeries of picturesque streets which harbor a swarming foreign population. The lights of shops and open stalls fell out into the fog, transforming it into thick, churning currents of smoky pallor. Wet walls and sidewalks showed a gold veneer, and lingering drops, trembling on cornices, hung like tiny globes of thin yellow glass.

People and things looked magnified and sometimes horrible seen through this mysterious, obscuring medium. Once behind a pane of glass she saw lines of detached, staring eyes, fastened glaringly on her as she advanced. It was the display in an optician's show-window, where glass eyes were disposed in fanciful lines, like a decoration. She looked at them askance, feeling that there was something sinister in their wide, unwinking scrutiny. She hurried by the market stalls, where the shawled figures of women stood huddled round the butcher's block. They looked as if they might be grouped round a point of interest, bending to stare at something lying there, something dreadful, like a corpse, Berny thought.

When she saw the Mexican restaurant she felt relieved. The strange atmospheric conditions seemed to have played upon her nerves and she was glad to get somewhere where she could find warmth and light and people. The place, a little shabby house dating from the era of the projecting shingle roof and encircling balcony, stood on a corner with windows on two streets. It was built upon a slope so sharp that the balcony, which in front skirted the second story, in the back was on a level with the sidewalk. The bright light of gas-jets, under shades of fluted white china, fell over the contents of

the show-window. They were not attractive. A dish of old and shriveled oranges stood between a plate of tamales and another of red and green peppers. There were many flies in the window, and, chilled by the cold, they stood along the inside of the glass in a state of torpor.

Berny pushed open the door and entered. The front part of the place was used as a grocery store and had a short counter at one side, behind which stood shelves piled high with the wares demanded by the Mexican and Spanish population. Back of this were the tables of the restaurant. The powerful, aromatic odors of the groceries blended with the even more powerful ones of the Mexican menu. The room was close and hot. In a corner, his back braced against the wall, a Spaniard, with inky hair and a large expanse of white shirt bosom, was languidly picking at a guitar.

Berny knew that there was an inner sanctum for the guests that preferred more secluded quarters, and walked past the counter and between the tables. An arched opening connected with this room. Coarse, dirty, lace curtains hung in the archway and, looped back against gilt hooks, left a space through which a glimpse of the interior was vouchsafed to the diners without. It was smaller than the restaurant proper, and was fitted up with an attempt at elegance. Lace curtains—also coarse and dirty—veiled the windows, and two large mirrors, with tarnished and fly-spotted gilt frames, hung on the wall opposite the entrance.

Just now it was sparsely patronized. In one corner two women in mourning and a child were sitting. They glanced at Berny with languid curiosity and then resumed a loud and voluble conversation in Spanish. A party of three Jews, an over-dressed woman and two young men—evidently visitors from another part of town—sat near them. On the opposite side there was no one. Berny slipped noiselessly into a chair at the corner table, her back against the partition that shut off the rest of the dining-room. She felt sheltered in this unoccupied angle, despite the fact that the mirror hanging opposite gave a reflection of her to any one standing in the archway.

The cloth was dirty and here and there showed a hole. Her ineradicable fastidiousness was strong in her even at this hour, when everything that was a manifestation of her own personality seemed weak and devitalized. She was disgustedly clearing away the crumbs of the last occupant with daintily-brushing movements of her finger-tips, when the waiter drew up

beside her and demanded her order. It was part of this weird evening, when natural surroundings seemed to combine with her own overwrought condition to create an effect of strangeness and terror, that the waiter should have been an old, shriveled man of shabby and dejected mien, with a defect in one eye, which rendered it abnormally large and prominent under a drooping, reddened lid. In order to see well it was necessary for him to hold his head at a certain angle and bring the eye, staring with alarming wildness, upon the object of his attention. His aspect added still further to Berny's dissatisfaction. She resolved to eat little and leave the place as soon as possible.

When her soup came, a thin yellow liquid in which dark bits of leaves and herbs floated, she tasted it hesitatingly, and, after a mouthful or two, put down her spoon and leaned back against the wall. She felt very tired and incapable of any more concentration of mind. Her thoughts seemed to float, disconnectedly and indifferently, this way and that, like a cobweb stirred by air currents and half held by a restraining thread. To her dulled sense of observation the laughter of the Jewish party came mingled with the tinkling of the guitar outside, and the loud, continuous talk from the Spanish women in the corner.

The waiter brought fish—a fried smelt—and she roused herself and picked up her fork. She did not notice that a man was standing near her in the archway, the edge of the lace curtain in his hand, looking about the room. He threw a side glance at her which swept her shoulders, her hat, and her down-bent profile, and looked away. Then, as if something in this glimpse had suddenly touched a spring of curiosity, he looked back again. His second survey was longer. The glance he bent upon her was sharp and grew in intensity. He made no attempt to enter or to move nearer her, but any one watching him would have seen that his interest increased with the prolongation of his scrutiny.

As if afraid of being observed he cast a quick surreptitious look over the room, which in its circuit crossed the mirror. Here, reflected from a different point of view, Berny was shown in full face, her eyes lowered, her hands moving over her plate. The man scanned the reflection with immovable intentness. Berny laid down her fork and pushed the fish away with a petulant movement, and the watcher drew back behind the lace

curtain. Through its meshes he continued to stare at the mirror, his lips tightly shut, his face becoming rigid in the fixity of his observation.

The waiter entered, his arms piled with dishes, and she made a beckoning gesture to him. He answered with a jerk of his head, and, going to the table where the Spanish women sat, unloaded his cargo there, as he set it out exchanging remarks with the women in their own language and showing no haste to answer Berny's summons. She moved in her chair and muttered angrily. The man behind the lace curtain advanced his head and through the interstices of the drapery tried to look directly at her. In this position he could only catch a glimpse of her, but he saw her hand stretched forward to take one of the red beans from the glass saucer in the middle of the table. It was an elegant hand, the skin smooth and white, the fingers covered with rings. She again beckoned, this time peremptorily, and the waiter came. The listener could hear her voice distinctly as he watched her reflection in the glass.

"Why didn't you come when I beckoned?" she said sharply.

"Because I had other people to wait on," said the waiter with equal asperity. "They was here before you."

"What's the matter with the dinner to-night? It's all bad."

"I ain't cooked it," retorted the man, growing red with indignation, his swollen eye glaring fiercely at her. "And no one else's complained. I guess it's what's the matter with you?"

Berny made an angry movement—sometimes alluded to as "flouncing"—and turned her head away from him.

"Get me an enchilada," she said peremptorily, "and after that some frijoles. I don't want anything else."

The waiter moved away and the man behind the curtain, as if satisfied by his long survey, also turned back into the general room. Close to the opening there was an unoccupied table, and at this he sat down, laid his hat on the chair beside him, and unfastened his coat. To the servant who came for his order, he asked for a cup of black coffee and a liqueur glass of brandy. He also requested an evening paper. With the sheet open before him he sat sipping the coffee, the slightest noise from the inner room causing him to start and lift the paper before his face.

He sat thus for some fifteen minutes. The Spanish women and the child emerged from the archway and left the restaurant, and a few moments later he heard the scraping of chair legs and Berny's voice as she asked for her bill. He lifted the paper and appeared buried in its contents, not moving as Berny brushed back the lace curtain and passed him. Her eyes absently fell on him and she had a vague impression of the dark dome of a head emerging from above the opened sheets of the journal. As she rustled by he lowered the paper and followed her with a keen watchful glance. He did not move till the street door closed behind her, when he threw the paper aside, snatched up his hat and flicked a silver dollar on to the cloth.

"No change," he said to the waiter, who came forward.

The surprised servant, unaccustomed to such tips, stared astonished after him as he hurried down the passage between the tables, quickly opened the door and disappeared into the darkness of the street.

Berny was only a few rods away, moving forward with a slow, loitering step. It was an easy night to follow without being observed. Walking at a prudent distance behind her, he kept her in sight as she passed from the smaller streets of the Latin Quarter into the glare and discord of the more populous highways, along Kearney Street, past the lower boundary of Portsmouth Square. He noticed that she walked without haste, now and then glancing at a window or a passer-by. She was like a person who has no objective point in view, or at least is in no hurry to reach it.

But this did not seem to be the case, for when she reached the square she took her stand on the corner where the Sacramento Street cars stop. The man drew back into a doorway opposite. They were the only passengers who boarded the car at that corner, Berny entering the closed interior, the man taking a seat on the outside. He had it to himself here, and chose the end seat by the window. Muttering imprecations at the cold, he turned up his overcoat collar and drew his soft felt hat down over his ears. By turning his head he could see between the bars that cross the end windows, the interior of the car shining with light, its polished yellow woodwork throwing back the white glare of the electricity. There were only three passengers, two depressed-looking women in dingy black, and Berny on a line with himself in the corner by the door. He could see her even better here than in the restaurant. She sat, a small dark figure, pressed into the

angle of the seat, her hands clasped in her lap, her eyes down. Her hat cast a shadow over the upper part of her face, and below this the end of her nose, her mouth and chin were revealed as pale and sharply-cut as an ivory carving. She seemed to be sunk in thought and sat motionless; the half of her face he could see, looking very white against her black fur collar.

He was furtively surveying her, when she started, glanced out of the window and signed to the conductor to stop. The man on the front dropped to the ground and stole lightly round the car, so that its moving body hid him from her. Emptiness and silence held the street, and he could easily follow her as she walked upward along the damp and deserted sidewalk. Halfway up the block a building larger than those surrounding it rose into the night. A mounting file of bay-windows broke its façade, and, a few steps above the level of the pavement, a line of doors with numbers showing black on illuminated transoms revealed it to the man opposite as a flat building. Here Berny stopped and without hesitation, evidently as one who was familiar with the place, mounted the steps and walked to the last of the doors.

The man, with soft and careful footsteps, crossed the street. As he drew nearer he saw that she was not using a latch-key, but was waiting to be admitted, leaning as if tired against the wall. He had reached the sidewalk when the door opened, vouchsafing him a bright, unimpeded view of a long flight of stairs carpeted in green. Berny entered and for a moment, before the door closed, he saw her mounting the stairs. She had not asked for any one, or indeed made a sound of greeting or inquiry. She was therefore either expected or an habitué of the place. When the door was shut he, too, mounted the porch steps and read the number on the transom. He whispered it over several times, the light falling out on his thin, aquiline face with a sweep of dark hair drooping downward toward his collar.

Satisfied with his investigation, he left the porch and walked rapidly down the street to the corner. Here there was a lamp, and halting under its light he drew from his pocket a leather wallet and took therefrom Dominick Ryan's card with an address written on it. The penciled numbers were the same as those on the door he had just left, and he stood looking fixedly at the card, an expression of excitement and exultation growing on his face.

CHAPTER XXV

THE ACTOR'S STORY

The afternoon of the next day Dominick came home earlier than usual. His New York friend, who was en route to Japan, had but a couple of days in San Francisco, and again claimed his company for dinner. The theater was to follow and Dominick had come home to change his clothes, and incidentally either to see Berny and explain his absence or to leave a message for her with the Chinaman.

He felt rather guilty where she was concerned. He had seen nothing of her for two days. The only time they met was in the evening after business hours, the only meal they took together was dinner. With every spark of affection dead between them, their married life the hollowest sham, she had so long and so sternly trained him to be considerate of her and keep her on his mind, that he still instinctively followed the acquired habit of thinking of her comfort and arranging for it. He knew she would be annoyed at the two lonely dinners, and hoped to see her before he left and suggest to her that she telephone for one of her sisters to join her.

The flat was very quiet when he entered, and after looking into one or two rooms for her he called the Chinaman, who said Mrs. Ryan had gone out early in the afternoon, leaving no message except that she would be home to dinner. Dominick nodded a dismissal and walked into the den. He carried the evening papers in his hand, and looking at the clock he saw that he had an hour before it would be necessary for him to dress and leave the house. Berny would undoubtedly be home before then; she was rarely out after six. Meantime, the thought that she was not in and that he could read the papers in unmolested, uninterrupted silence caused a slight sense of relief to lighten the weight that was now always with him.

He had hardly opened the first sheet when a ring at the bell dispelled his hopes. It was one of his wife's habits never to carry a latch-key, which she looked upon as a symbol of that bourgeois, middle-class helpfulness that she had shaken off with her other working-girl manners and customs. Dominick dropped the paper, waiting for her entrance, and framing the

words with which he would acquaint her with the fact that he was to be absent again. Instead, however, of the rustle of feminine skirts, he heard the Chinaman's padding steps, and the servant entered and presented him with a card. Traced on it in a sprawling handwriting was the name "James Defay Buford." Dominick remembered his invitation to the man to call, and realized that this probably was the only time that the actor could conveniently do so. There was an hour yet before dinner would be served, and turning to the servant Dominick told him to show the gentleman up.

A moment later, Buford entered, smiling, almost patronizingly urbane and benign. He was dressed with a rich and careful elegance which gave him a somewhat dandified air. After bestowing upon Dominick greetings that sounded as unctuous as a benediction, he took his seat at the end of the cozy corner facing the door which led into the hall. From here he looked at the young man with a close, attentive scrutiny, very friendly and yet holding, under its enfolding blandness, something of absence, of inattention, as though his mind were not in the intimate customary connection with the words that issued from his lips. This suggestion of absence deepened, showed more plainly in an eye that wandered to the door, or, as Dominick spoke, fell to the carpet and remained there, hidden by a down-drawn bush of eyebrow. Dominick was in the middle of a query as to the continued success of the "Klondike Monologue" when the actor raised his head and said politely, but with a politeness that contained a note of haste and eagerness beneath it,

"Is Madame at home?"

"No, she's not at home," said Madame's husband. "But she may be in any moment now. She generally goes out for the afternoon and gets back about this time."

"Perhaps you can tell me," said Buford, looking sidewise at his gloves and cane as they lay on the end of the divan, "who—you'll pardon my seeming curiosity, but I'll explain it presently—who was the lady that came in here last night at about half-past seven?"

He looked up and Dominick was suddenly aware that his face was charged with the tensest, the most vital interest. Thrust forward, it showed a hungriness of anticipation that was almost passionate. The young man was not only surprised at the expression but at the question.

“I haven’t an idea,” he said. “I wasn’t home to dinner last night, and didn’t get in till late. Why do you want to know?”

“For many reasons, or for one, perhaps—for one exceedingly important reason.”

He paused, his eyes again turned slantingly on the stick and gloves, his lips tight-pressed, one against the other.

“How did you know any woman came in here last night at that hour? Did you come up to call?” asked Dominick.

“No—no—” the other spoke with quick impatience evidently from the surface of his mind, “no, it was—at first, anyway—purely accidental. I saw the woman—and—and—afterward I saw her enter here. Mr. Ryan,” he said suddenly, looking at his vis-à-vis with piercing directness and speaking with an intensity of urgency that was almost a command, “can you give me half an hour of your time and your full attention? I want to speak to you of a matter, that to me, at least, is of great—the greatest—importance. You can help me; at least you can, I hope, throw some light on what is a dark subject. Have I your permission to talk freely to you, freely and at length?”

Dominick, who was beginning to feel as if he were in a play, and was exceedingly surprised and intrigued, nodded, remarking,

“Why, certainly, go on. If I can be of any help to you or explain anything for you, nothing would give me greater pleasure. Let me hear what it is.”

The actor dropped his glance to the floor for what seemed an anxiously-considering moment, then he raised his head and, looking directly at his host, said,

“You may remember that, while at Antelope, I once spoke to you of having been married—of having, in fact, been unfortunate enough to lose my wife.”

Dominick remembered, but it seemed imperfectly, for he said in a doubtful tone, which had more than a suggestion of questioning,

“She—er—she died?”

“No,” said the other, “she did not die. I lost her in a way that I think was more painful than death. She left me, voluntarily, of her own free will.”

“Oh, of course,” said the young man hastily. “I remember perfectly, one day by the sitting-room fire. I remember it all as clearly as possible now.”

“That was the time—the only time I mentioned the subject to you. On another occasion I spoke to that lovely and agreeable young lady, Miss Cannon, on the matter, and told her more fully of my domestic sorrows. But to you I made but that one allusion. May I now, more at length, tell you of the misfortunes—I may say tragedy—of my married life?”

Dominick, mystified, nodded his head. He could not imagine why Buford should come to him at this particular moment and in this particularly theatrical manner with the history of his domestic troubles. But he was undeniably interested, and feeling himself more than ever like a character in a play, said,

“Go on. Tell me anything you like. And if in any way I can be of use to you, I’ll be only too happy to do it.”

Looking at the carpet, a heat of inward excitement showing through the professional pomposity of his manner, Buford began slowly and solemnly:

“I’ll go back to seven years ago, when I was in Chicago. Previous to that, Mr. Ryan, I will tell you in confidence I had been a preacher, a Methodist, of good reputation, though, I am fain to confess, of small standing in the church. I left that esteemed body as I felt there were certain tenets of the faith I could not hold to. I am nothing if not honest, and I was too honest to preach doctrines with all of which I could not agree. I left the church as a pastor though I have never deserted it as a disciple, and have striven to live up to its standards.”

He paused, and Dominick, feeling that he spoke sincerely, said,

“That was the only thing to do.”

“So it seemed to me. I left the town where I was living and moved to Chicago where, through the influences of a friend, I obtained a position in a school of acting and elocution. I instructed the pupils in voice production. You may have noticed that I have an unusually deep and resonant voice. Through that, I obtained this work and received the stipend of thirty-five dollars a week. It was fairly good pay, the hours were not too long, there was no demand made of a sacrifice of conscience, and I confess that I felt much freer and more contented than I had in the church.

“It was at this stage of my career that I met the lady who became my wife. We lived at the same boarding-house—Mrs. Heeney’s, a most elegant, well-kept place, and Mrs. Heeney a lovely woman of one of the best southern families. It was at her table that I met the girl who was destined to have such a fatal influence on my life. She was a stenographer and typewriter in one of the largest firms in the city, earning her twenty dollars a week, as she was an expert and not to be beaten in the state. She was very pretty, the brunette type of beauty, black-eyed, and as smart as a steel trap. She was as dainty as a pink, always well-dressed and up-to-date, never anything sloppy or slouchy about her. Ask her to go to the theater and there wouldn’t be a woman in the house who could beat her for looks and style. Besides that, she was a fine conversationalist, could talk as easily as a book on any subject. If I brought her a novel, she’d read it and have the whole plot at her finger-ends, and be able to talk it all over, have her own opinions about every character. Oh, she was an accomplished, fascinating woman, if I say it myself! Any man might have taken to her. She was for ever telling me about California, and how she wanted to get back there—”

“California?” interrupted Dominick. “Did she come from California?”

“From here—from San Francisco. She was a native daughter of the state and the town. I was interested in California myself at that time, though I’d never seen it, and we’d talk of that and other things till, bit by bit, we drifted nearer and nearer together and the day came when we were engaged. I thought that was the happiest day of my life, and it would have been if she’d stayed true to her promises.”

The clock struck the single silvery note of the half-hour and Dominick heard it. He was interested in the story, but he had only another half-hour to give, and said as Buford paused,

“Go on. It’s very interesting. Don’t stop.”

“The first step in our married life that seemed to me strange, that cast, not what you’d call a cloud, but a shadow, over my happiness, was that she insisted on keeping the marriage secret. She had several reasons, all of which seemed good and sufficient to her. She said her people would not like her marrying a stranger away from home, and that they’d cut up very ugly when they heard it. Her principal reason, and the only one that seemed to me to have any force, was that she feared she’d lose her job. She had it on

good authority that the firm where she worked wouldn't employ married women, and if they knew she'd got a husband who was making a fair salary, they'd give her the sack. Whether it was for all the reasons together, or for just this one I don't know, but she'd only marry me if I'd solemnly promise to keep the matter secret. I'd have promised her anything. She'd out and out bewitched me.

"So we were married and went to housekeeping in a little flat in a suburb. We had our mail sent to our old address at Mrs. Heeney's. She was in our secret, the only person who was. We had to let her know because of the letters, and inquiries that might have been made for us from time to time. We were married in the winter, and that winter was the happiest time of my life. I'll never forget it. That little flat, and that little black-eyed woman,—they were just Paradise and the angel in it for me. Not but what she had her faults; she was hot-tempered, quick to flare up, and sharp with her tongue. But *I* never cared—just let her sputter and fizz till she'd worked it all off and then I'd take things up where they were before the eruption began. It was a happy time—a man in love and a woman that keeps him loving—you can't beat it this side of Heaven."

Dominick made no answer. The actor for a moment was silent and then with a sigh went on.

"I suppose it was too good to last. Anyway, it ended. We'd lived that way for six months when in the beginning of June the Dramatic School failed and I lost my job. It came on us with almost no warning, and it sort of knocked us out for a bit. *I* wasn't as upset by it as Mrs. Carter was, but she —"

"Who's Mrs. Carter?" said Dominick.

"My wife. That's my name, Junius Carter. Of course the name I use on the stage is not my own. I took that in the Klondike, made it up from my mother's and the name of a pard I had who died. Well, as I was saying, Mrs. Carter took it hard. She couldn't seem to get reconciled to it. I tried to brace her up and told her it would only be temporary, and I'd get another place soon, but she was terribly upset. We'd lived well, not saved a cent, furnished the flat nicely and kept a servant. There was nothing for it but to live on what she made. It was hard on her, but I've often thought she might have been easier on me. I didn't *want* to be idle or eat the bread she paid

for, the Lord knows! I tried hard enough to get work. I tramped those streets in sun and rain till the shoes were falling off my feet. But the times were hard, money was tight, and good jobs were not to be had for the asking. One of the worst features of the case was that I hadn't any regular line of work or profession. The kind of thing I'd been doing don't fit a man for any kind of job. If I couldn't do my own kind of stunt I'd have to be just a general handy-man or stevedore, and I'm not what you'd call rugged.

"It was an awful summer! The heat was fierce. Our little flat was like an oven and, after my long day's tramp after work, I used to go home just dead beat and lie on the lounge and not say a word. My wife was worn out. She wasn't accustomed to warm weather, and that and the worry and the hard work sort of wore on her, and there were evenings when she'd slash round so with her tongue that I'd get up, half-dead as I was, and go out and sit on the door-step till she'd gone to bed. I'm not blaming her. She had enough to try her. Working at her machine all day in that weather would wear anybody's temper to a frazzle. But she said some things to me that bit pretty deep. It seemed impossible it could be the same woman I'd got to know so well at Mrs. Heeney's. We were both just about used up, thin as fiddle-strings, and like fiddle-strings ready to snap at a touch. Seems queer to think that thirty-five dollars a week could make such a difference! With it we were in Paradise; without it we were as near the other place as people can get, I guess.

"Well, it was too much for her. She was one of those women who can't stand hardships and she couldn't make out in the position she was in. Love wasn't enough for her, there had to be luxury and comfort, too. One day I came home and she was gone. No," in answer to a look of inquiry on Dominick's face, "there was no other man. She wasn't that kind, always as straight as a string. No, she just couldn't stand the grind any longer. She left a letter in which she said some pretty hard things to me, but I've tried to forget and not bear malice. It was a woman half crazy with heat and nerves and overwork that wrote them. The gist of it was that she'd gone back to California, to her sisters who lived there, and she was not coming back. She didn't like it,—marriage, or me, or Chicago. She was just going to throw the whole business overboard. She told me if I followed her, or tried to hold her, she'd disappear, hinted that she'd kill herself. That was enough for me. God knows if she didn't want me I wasn't going to force myself upon her.

And, anyway, she knew fast enough I couldn't follow her. I hadn't money to have my shoes patched, much less buy a ticket to California.

"After that there were some dark days for me. Deserted, with no money, with no work, and no prospects—I tell you that's the time the iron goes down into a man's soul. I didn't know what was going to become of me, and I didn't care. One day on the street I met an old chum of mine, a fellow called Defay, that I hadn't seen for years. He was going to the Klondike, and when he heard my hard-luck story, he proposed to me to join forces and go along with him. I jumped at it, anything to get away from that town and state that was haunted with memories of her.

"It was just the beginning of the gold rush and we went up there and stayed for two years. Defay was one of the finest men I ever knew. Life's all extremes and contrasts; there's a sort of balance to it if you come to look close into it. I'd had an experience with the kind of woman that breaks a man's heart as you might a pipe-stem, then I ran up against the kind of man that gives you back your belief in human nature. He died of typhoid a year and a half after we got there. I had it first and nearly died; in fact, the rumor went out that it was I that was dead and not Defay. As I changed my name and went on the stage soon afterward, it was natural enough for people to say Junius Carter was dead.

"I was pretty near starving when I drifted on the stage. I had learned some conjuring tricks, and that and my voice took me there. I just about made a living for a year, and then I floated back down here. I never played in San Francisco till now. I acted on the western circuits, used to go as far East as Denver and Kansas City, and then swing round the circle through the northwestern cities and Salt Lake. I managed to make a living and no more. I was cast in parts that didn't suit me. The 'Klondike Monologue' was the first thing I did that was in my line."

"Did you never see or hear of your wife?"

"Not a word. I didn't know whether she was dead or living till last night."

Buford raised his eyes and looked piercingly into the young man's face. Dominick forgot the time, his engagement, Berny's anticipated entrance. He drew himself up in his chair and said in a loud, astonished voice,

"Last night? Then the woman you saw here last night was your *wife*?"

The actor gravely inclined his head.

“I saw my wife,” he said solemnly, “last night at Deledda’s restaurant. It was entirely by accident. I liked the Mexican cooking and had been more than once to that place. Last night I was about to enter the back part of the restaurant when I saw her sitting there alone in the corner. For a moment I could not believe my eyes. I got behind a lace curtain and watched her. She was changed but it was she. I heard her speak to the waiter and if I’d never seen her face I’d have known the voice among a thousand. She’d grown stouter and I think even prettier, and she looked as if she were prosperous. She was well-dressed and her hands were covered with rings. When she went out I followed her and she came straight here from the restaurant and rang the bell and came in.”

“Are you sure she didn’t go into one of the other flats? There are four in the building.”

“No, she came in here. I compared the number on the transom with the address you’d given me on the card.”

“What an extraordinary thing!” said Dominick. “It’s evidently some one my wife knows who came to see her that evening, probably to keep her company while I was out. But I can’t think who it could be.”

He tried to run over in his mind which one of Berny’s acquaintances the description might fit and could think of no one. Probably it was some friend of her working-girl days, who had dropped out of her life and now, guided by Fate had unexpectedly reappeared.

“It’s certainly a remarkable coincidence,” he went on, “that she should have come to this flat, one of the few places in the city where you know the people. If she’d gone to any of the others——”

A ring at the bell stopped him.

“There!” he said, “that’s Mrs. Ryan. Now we’ll hear who it was.”

For a moment they both sat silent, listening, the actor with his face looking sharp and pale in the suspense of the moment, the muscles of his lean cheeks working. The rustle of Berny’s dress sounded from the stairway and grew in volume as she slowly ascended. The two men rose to their feet.

“Come in the den for a moment, Berny,” Dominick called. “There’s a gentleman here who wants to see you.”

The rustle advanced up the hall, and the portière was drawn back. Bernice, brilliantly dressed, a mauve orchid pinned on her bosom, stood in the aperture, smiling.

Buford’s back was against the light, and, for the first moment she only saw him as a tall masculine outline and her smile was frank and natural. But he saw her plain as a picture and before Dominick could frame the words of introduction, started forward, crying,

“Bernice Iverson!”

She drew back as if struck and made a movement to drag the portière over her. Her face went white to the lips, the patches of rouge standing out on her cheeks like rose-leaves pasted on the sickly skin.

“Who—who’s that?” she stammered, turning a wild eye on Dominick.

“Mr. Ryan,” the actor cried, beside himself with excitement, “*this* is my wife! This is the woman I’ve been talking of! Bernice, don’t you know me? Junius Carter?”

“He’s crazy,” she faltered, her lips so loose and tremulous they could hardly form the words. “I never saw him before. I don’t know what he’s talking about. Who’s Junius Carter?”

“This is my wife, Mr. Buford,” said Dominick, who had been staring from one to the other in blank astonishment. “We’ve been married nearly three years. I don’t understand——”

“It’s Bernice Iverson, the girl I married in Chicago, that I’ve just been telling you about, that I saw last night at the Mexican restaurant. Why, she can’t deny it. She can’t look at me and say she doesn’t know me—Junius Carter, the man she married in the Methodist chapel, seven years ago, in Chicago. Bernice——”

He approached her and she shrank back.

“Keep away from me,” she cried hoarsely, stretching out a trembling hand. “I don’t know what you’re talking about. You’re crazy. Junius Carter’s dead

—” then suddenly turning on Dominick with a blazing look of fury—“It’s you that have done this! It’s you, you snake! I’ll be even with you yet!”

She tore herself out of the folds of the portière which she had clutched to her and rushed into the hall and into her own room. The banging of the door behind her shook the house.

The two men stood as she had left them, staring at each other, not knowing what to say, speechless and aghast.



“Mr. Ryan,” the actor cried, “*this* is my wife”

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CHAPTER XXVI

THE LAST INTERVIEW

The night was falling when Buford left. He and Dominick had sat on in the den, talking together in low voices, going over past events in the concatenation of circumstances that had led up to the extraordinary situation in which they now found themselves. Both listened with strained ears for the opening of Bernice's door, but not a sound came from her room. Each silently, without expressing his thoughts to the other, wondered what she would do, what sensational move might now be expected of her. While they talked, it was evident she intended to make no sign of life.

After Buford had left, Dominick called up his friend on the telephone telling him that he would be unable to meet him at dinner. He knew that Berny could hear every word he uttered, and with indescribable dread he expected that she would open her door and accost him. But again she preserved an inviolate invisibility, though beneath her portal he could see a crack of light and could hear her moving about in the room.

He went into his own room, lit the gas, and began packing his trunks. He was dazed and stupefied by what had occurred, and almost the only clearly-defined idea he had was to leave the house and get far from the presence of the woman who had so ruthlessly poisoned his life. He was in the midst of his packing when the Chinaman summoned him to dinner, but he told the man he cared for nothing and would want no breakfast on the following morning. The servant, who by this time was well aware that the household was a strange one, shrugged his shoulders without comment and passed on to the door of his mistress' room, upon which he knocked with the low, deferential rap of the Chinese domestic. Berny's voice sounded shrilly, through the silence of the flat:

"Go away! Let me alone! If that's dinner I don't want any."

The sound of her voice pierced Dominick with a sense of loathing and horror. He stopped in his packing, suddenly deciding to leave everything and go, go from the house and from her as soon as he could get away. He

thrust into a valise such articles as he would want for the night and set the bag by the stair-head while he went into the parlor to find some bills and letters of his that he remembered to have left in the desk. As he passed Berny's door, it flew open and she appeared in the aperture. The room behind her was a blaze of light, every gas-jet lit and pouring a flood of radiance over the clothes outspread on the bed, the chairs, and the floor. She, herself, in a lace-trimmed petticoat and loose silk dressing-sack, stood in the doorway staring at Dominick, her face pinched, white, and fierce.

"What are you doing?" she said abruptly. "Going away?"

"Yes," he answered, stopping at the sight of the dreaded apparition. "That's my intention."

"Where are you going?" she demanded.

He gave her a cold look and made no answer.

"Are you going to your mother's?" she cried.

He moved forward toward the parlor door and she came out into the passage, looking after him and repeating with a tremulous, hoarse persistence, "Dominick, answer me. Are you going to your mother's?"

"Yes, I am," he said over his shoulder.

He had an unutterable dread that she would begin to speak of the situation, of Buford, of her past life; that she would try to explain and exonerate herself and they would be plunged into a long and profitless discussion of all the sickening, irremediable wretchedness of the past. He could not bear the thought of it; he would have done anything to avoid it. He wanted to escape from her, from the house where she had tortured him, where he seemed to have laid down his manhood, his honor, his faith, and seen her trample on them. The natural supposition that he would want to confront her with her deception and hear her explanation was the last thing he desired doing.

"Don't go to your mother's," she cried, following him up the hall, "for to-night, Dominick, please. And don't tell her. I beg, I pray of you, don't tell her till to-morrow."

Her manner was so pleadingly, so imploringly insistent, that he turned and looked somberly at her. She was evidently deeply in earnest, her face lined

with anxiety.

“This is the last thing I’ll ever ask of you. I know I’ve got no right to ask anything, but you’re generous, you’ve been kind to me in the past, and it’ll not cost you much to be kind just once again. Go to a hotel, or the club, or anywhere you like, but not to your mother’s and don’t tell her till to-morrow afternoon.”

He stared at her without speaking, wishing she would be silent and leave him.

“I’ll not trouble you after to-morrow. I’ll go, I’ll get out. You’ll never be bothered by me any more.”

“All right,” he said, “I’ll go to the club. Let me alone, that’s all, and let me go.”

“And—and,” she persisted, “you won’t tell her till to-morrow, to-morrow afternoon?”

He had entered the parlor in which the Chinaman had lit the lamps, and opening the desk began hunting for his papers. To her last words he returned no answer, and she crept in after him and stood in the doorway, leaning against the woodwork of the door-frame.

“You won’t tell her till to-morrow—to-morrow, say, after three?”

He found the letters and drew them out of their pigeonhole.

“All right,” he almost shouted. “I won’t tell her. But, for God’s sake, leave me alone and let me go. If you keep on following me round this way I won’t answer for what I’ll do.”

“You promise then,” she said, ignoring his heat. “You promise you’ll not tell her till after three?”

He turned from the desk, gave her a look of restrained passion, and said, “I promise,” then passed by her as she stood in the doorway and walked to the stair-head. Here his valise stood, and snatching it up he ran down the stairs and out of the house.

Bernice, hearing the door shut, returned to her room and went on with the work of sorting her wardrobe and packing her trunks. She did it deliberately and carefully, looking over each garment, and folding the choicer articles

between sheets of tissue paper. At midnight she had not yet finished, and under the blaze of the gases, looking very tired, she went on smoothing skirts and pinching up the lace on bodices as she laid them tenderly on the trays that stood on the bed, the table, and the sofa. The night was far spent before everything was arranged to her satisfaction and she went to bed.

She was up betimes in the morning. Eight o'clock had not struck when she was making a last tour of the parlor, picking up small articles of silver and glass that she crowded down into cracks in the tightly-packed trunks. At breakfast the Chinaman, an oblique, observant eye on her, asked her what he should prepare for lunch. Conscious that if she told him she would not be back he might become alarmed at the general desertion and demand his wages, she ordered an even more elaborate menu than usual, telling him she would bring home a friend.

She breakfasted in her wrapper and after the meal finished her toilet with the extremest solicitude. Never had she taken more pains with herself. Though anxiety and strain had thinned and sharpened her, the fever of excitement which burnt in her temporarily repaired these ravages. Her eyes were brilliant without artificial aid; her cheeks a hot dry crimson that needed no rouge. The innate practicality of her character asserted itself even in this harassed hour. Last night she had put the purple orchid in a glass of water on the bureau. Now, as she pinned it on her breast, she congratulated herself for her foresight, the pale lavender petals of the rare blossom toning altogether harmoniously with her dress of dark purple cloth.

Before she left the room she locked the trunks and left beside them a dress suit-case packed for a journey. Standing in the doorway she took a hurried look about the apartment—a last, farewell survey, not of sentiment but of investigation, to see if she had forgotten anything. A silver photograph frame set in rhinestones caught her eye and she went back and took it up, weighing it uncertainly in her hand. Some of the rhinestones had fallen out, and she finally decided it was not worth while opening the trunks to put in such a damaged article.

It was only a quarter past nine when she emerged from the flat. She took the down-town car and twenty minutes later was mounting the steps to Bill Cannon's office. She had been motionless and rigidly preoccupied on the car, but, as she approached the office, a change was visible in her gait and

mien. She moved with a light, perky assurance, a motion as of a delicate, triumphant buoyancy seeming to impart itself to her whole body from her shoulders to her feet. A slight, mild smile settled on her lips, suggesting gaiety tempered with good humor. Her eye was charged with the same expression rendered more piquant by a gleam—the merest suggestion—of coquettish challenge.

The Bonanza King was already in his office. The same obsequious clerk who had shown her in on a former occasion took her card in to the inner sanctum where the great man, even at this early hour, was shut away with the business which occupied his crowded days. In a moment the young man returned smiling and quite as murmurously polite as he had been on her former visit, and Berny was once again ushered into the presence of the enemy.

The old man had read the name on the card with a lowering glance. His command to admit the visitor had been hardly more than an inarticulate growl which the well-trained clerk understood, as those about deaf mutes can read their half-made signs. Cannon was not entirely surprised at her reappearance, and mingled feelings stirred in him as he turned his swivel chair away from the table, and sat hunched in it, his elbows on its arms, his hands clasped over his stomach.

She came in with an effect of dash, confidence, and brilliancy that astonished him. He had expected her almost to sidle in in obvious, guilty fear of him, her resistance broken, humbly coming to sue for the money. Instead, a rustling, scented apparition appeared in the doorway, more gracious, handsome, and smiling than he had ever thought she could be. She stood for a moment, as if waiting for his invitation to enter, the whole effect of her rich costume, her feverishly high coloring, and her debonair and self-confident demeanor, surprising him into silence. A long white feather on her hat made a background for her darkly-flushed face and auburn hair. There were some amethysts round her neck, their purple lights harmonizing richly with the superb flower pinned on her breast. Her eyes looked very black, laughing, and provocative through her spotted veil.

“Well,” she said in a gay voice, “here I am again! Is it a surprise?”

She advanced into the room, and the old man, almost unconsciously, rose from his chair.

“Yes, sort of,” he said dryly.

She stopped by the desk, looked at him sidewise, and said,

“Do we shake hands?”

His glance on her was hard and cold. Berny met it and could not restrain a sinking of the courage that was her most admirable characteristic and that she had screwed far past its ordinary sticking-point that morning. She sank down into the same arm-chair that she had occupied on her former visit and said, with a little languid effect of indifference,

“Oh, well, never mind. We don’t have to waste time being polite. That’s one of the most convenient things about our interviews. We just say what we really think and there’s no need bothering about humbug.”

“So glad to hear it,” said the old man with his most ironical air. “Suppose then you let me know what you’ve come down to say.”

“Can’t you guess?” she answered, with an expression that was almost one of flirtatious interrogation.

“Nup,” he answered, looking steadily at her. “I have to have it said in that plain style with no politeness that you say is the way we always talk.”

“All right,” she answered briskly. “Here it is as plain as A B C. I’ve decided to accept your offer and take the money.”

She looked up at him, smiling gallantly. But as her eye caught his her smile, try as she would to keep it, died. He suddenly realized that she was extremely nervous, that her lips were dry, and the hand she put up to adjust her veil, and thus hide her intractable mouth, was shaking. The admiration he had of late felt for her insolent fearlessness increased, also he began to feel that now, at last, he was rising to the position of master of the situation. He leaned back in the swivel chair and glowered at her.

“You know,” he said slowly, “you’ve a gall that beats anything I’ve ever seen. Two days ago you busted this business higher than a kite by stopping my daughter on the public street and telling her the whole story. You did the one thing you knew I’d never forgive; and you ended the affair, hammered the nails in its coffin and buried it. Now you come flourishing into my office as if nothing had happened and say you’ll take the money. It beats me how you’ve got the nerve to dare to show your face in here.”

Berny listened with the hand holding the veil pressed against her mouth and her eyes staring over it.

“It’s all straight enough,” she burst out, “what you say about telling your daughter. I did it and I was crazy. I’ll admit that. But you’ll have to admit on your side that it was pretty rough the way I was treated here, ordered out like a peddler. I was sore, and it was you that made me so. And I’ll not deny that I wanted to hit you back. But you brought it on yourself. And, anyway, what does it matter if I go? Maybe your daughter’s mad and disgusted now, but women don’t stay that way for ever. If I get out, drop out of sight, the way I intend to do, give Dominick his freedom, isn’t she going to forget all about what I said? Wouldn’t any woman?”

The Bonanza King made no answer. He had no intention of talking with this objectionable woman about his daughter. But in his heart hope sprang at the words. They were an echo of his own desires and opinions. If this woman took the money and went, would not Rose, in the course of time, relent in her attitude of iron disapproval, and smile on the man she loved? Could any woman hold out for ever in such a position?

“See here,” Berny went on, “I’ll leave a statement. I’ll put it in your hands that I changed my mind and voluntarily left. I’ll draw it up before a notary if you want. And it’s true. She needn’t think that I’m being forced out to make a place for her. I’m glad to go.”

She had leaned nearer to him from the chair, one finger tapping the corner of the desk to emphasize her words. Scrutinizing her as she spoke, he became more than ever impressed with the conviction that she was held in a tremor of febrile excitement. Her voice had an under note of vibration in it, like the voice of one who breathes quickly. The orchid on her breast trembled with the trembling of her frame.

“Look here,” he said quietly, “I want to understand this thing. What’s made you change your mind so suddenly? A few days ago you were all up on fiddle-strings at the suggestion of taking that money. Here, this morning, in you pop, and you’re all of a tremble to get it. What’s the meaning of it?”

“I can’t stand it any more,” she said. “When you said I couldn’t the other day, that I’d break down, you were right. I can’t stand it. Nobody could. It’s

broken me to pieces. I want to get away from it all. I want to go somewhere where I'm at peace, where the people don't hate me and hound me——”

Her voice suddenly grew hoarse and she stopped. He looked at her in surprise. She bent her face down, biting her under lip, and picked tremulously at the leaves of the purple orchid as if arranging them.

“You’ve beaten me,” she said in a suddenly strangled voice, “you’ve beaten me. I can’t fight any longer. Give me some money and let me go. I’m beaten.”

She lowered her head still farther and burst into tears. So unexpected were they that she had no preparations for them. Her handkerchief was in the bead purse that hung on her wrist, and, blinded by tears, she could not find the clasp. Her fumbling hand tried for a possible reserve supply in her belt, and then in despair went up to her face and lifted her veil trying to brush away the falling drops. The Bonanza King stared at her amazed, as much surprised as if he had seen a man weep. Finally he felt in his own pocket, produced a crisply-laundered square of white linen and handed it to her, observing soothingly,

“Here, take mine. You’re all broke up, aren’t you?”

She seized his offering and mopped her cheeks with it, sniffing and gasping, while he watched her in genuine solicitude.

“What’s wore you down to this state?” he said. “You’re the nerviest woman I ever saw.”

“It’s—it’s—all this thing,” she answered in a stifled voice. “I’m just worn out. I haven’t slept for nights,”—a memory of those miserable nights of perturbation and uncertainty swept over her and submerged her in a wave of self-pity. The tears gushed out again, and she held the old man’s large handkerchief against her eyes, uttering small, sobbing noises, sunk in abandoned despondence in the hollow of the chair.

The Bonanza King was moved. The facile tears of women did not affect him, but the tears of this bold, hard, unbreakable creature, whom he had regarded only as an antagonist to be vanquished, stirred him to a sort of abashed sympathy. There was something singularly pathetic about the completeness of her breakdown. She, who had been so audacious an

adversary, now in all her crumpled finery weeping into his handkerchief, was so entirely and utterly a feeble, crushable thing.

“Come, brace up,” he said cheerfully. “We can’t do any talking while you’re acting this way. What’s the proposition again?”

“I want some money and I want to go.” She raised her head and lowered the handkerchief, speaking with a strained, throaty insistence like a child. “I can’t live here any more. I can’t bear it. It would give a prize fighter nervous prostration. I can’t bear it.” Her voice grew small and high. “Really I can’t,” she managed to articulate, and then dissolved into another flood.

The old man, high in his swivel chair, sat with his hands in his pockets, his lips pursed and his eyes on the floor. Once or twice he whirled the chair slightly from one side to the other. After a pause of some minutes he said,

“Are you prepared to agree to everything Mrs. Ryan and I demanded?”

After the last outbreak she had completely abandoned herself to the hysterical condition that was beyond her control. Now she made an effort to recover herself, sat up, swallowing and gasping, while she wiped her eyes.

“I’m ready to do it all,” she sniffed, “only—only—” she paused on the verge of another collapse, suppressed it, and said with some show of returning animation, “only I must have some money now—a guarantee.”

“Oh,” he said with the descending note of comprehension. “As I remember, we agreed to pay you seven thousand dollars for the first year, the year of desertion.”

She lowered the handkerchief entirely, presenting to him a disfigured face, all its good looks gone, but showing distinct signs of attention.

“I don’t want the seven thousand. I’ll waive it. I want a sum down, a guarantee, an advance. You offered me at first fifty thousand dollars. Give me that down and I’ll go this afternoon.”

“That wasn’t our original arrangement,” he said to gain time.

“Deduct it from the rest. I must have it. I can’t go without it. If you give me the check now I’ll leave for New York to-night.”

Her reviving interest and force seemed to have quenched the sources of her tears as suddenly as her exhausted nerves had made them flow. But her

disfigured face, her figure which seemed to have shrunk in its fine clothes, were extremely pathetic.

“If you don’t trust me send one of your clerks with me to buy my ticket, send one to see me off. I’ve left my husband for good, for ever. I can’t live here any longer. Give me the money and let me go.”

“I don’t see that I’m going to have any security that you’re going to carry out the whole plan. How do I know that you’re not going to New York to have a good time and then, when you’ve spent the money, come back here?”

She sat up and sent a despairing look about the room as if in a wild search for something that would convince him of her sincerity.

“I *swear*, I *promise*,” she cried with almost frantic emphasis, “that I’ll never come back. I’m going for good and I’m going to set Dominick free. Oh, *do* believe me. *Please*. I’m telling the truth.”

He was impressed by her manner, as he had been by her tears. Something undoubtedly had happened which had suddenly caused her to change her mind and decide to leave her husband. He did not think that it was what she had told him. Her excitement, her overwrought condition suggested a cause less gradual, more like a shock. He ran over in his mind the advantages of giving her the money. Nothing would be jeopardized by it. It would simply be an advance made on the sum they had agreed upon.

“Fifty thousand’s too much,” he said slowly. “But I’ll be square to you and I’ll split the difference and give you twenty-five. I’ll give you the check now and you can take it and go to-night.”

She shook her head obstinately.

“It won’t do,” she said. “What difference does it make to you whether you give it to me now or next year? I’ll give you a receipt for it. There won’t be any trouble about it. It’s as broad as it’s long. It’s simply an advance on the main sum.”

He looked moodily at her and then down. Her demand seemed reasonable enough, but he distrusted her.

“If you don’t believe me,” she insisted, “send out that clerk of yours to buy my ticket to New York. Tell him to go up to the flat and he’ll see my trunks

all packed and ready. I tell you you've beaten me. You and Mrs. Ryan are one too many for me."

He again looked at her, his lips pressed together, his eye coldly considering.

"I'll give you thirty thousand dollars and it's understood that you're to leave the city to-night."

She demurred, but with less show of vigor, and, for a space, they haggled over the sum till they finally agreed upon thirty-five thousand dollars.

As the old man drew the check she watched him with avid eagerness, restraining by force the hand that trembled in its anxiety to become possessed of the slip of paper. He noticed, as she bent over the desk to sign the receipt, that her fingers shook so they could hardly direct the pen. She remarked it herself, setting it down to her upset nerves, and laughing at the sprawling signature.

With the check in her hand she rose, something of the airy buoyancy of demeanor that had marked her on her entrance returning to her.

"Well," she said, opening her purse, "this is the real beginning of our business relations. I feel as if we were partners."

The old man gave a short, dry laugh. He could not rid his mind of suspicions of her and the whole proceeding, though he did not see just how she could be deceiving him.

"Wait till next year," he said. "When I see the divorce papers I'll feel a lot surer of the partnership."

She snapped the clasp of her purse, laughing and moving to the door. She was wild to get away, to escape from the dark room that held such unpleasant memories, and the old man, whose steely penetrating eye, fastened on her, was full of unsatisfied query.

"Well, so long!" she cried, opening the door. "Next time we meet it will be more sociable, I hope. We really ought to be old friends by this time."

She hardly knew what she was saying, but she laughed with a natural gaiety, and in the doorway turned and bowed her jaunty good-bys to him. He stood back and nodded good-humoredly at her, his face showing puzzlement under its slight, ironic smile.

Once in the street her demeanor again changed. Her step became sharp and quick, her expression keenly absorbed and concentrated. A clock showed her that it was nearly half-past ten, and she walked, with a speed that was as rapid a mode of progression as it could be without attracting attention, to the great bank on which the check was drawn. On the way down on the car she had thought out all her movements, just what she would do, and where she would go. Her mind was as clear, her movements as systematic as though she were moved by mechanism.

She ran up the steps to the bank and presented the check at the paying teller's window.

"In one-thousand dollar bills, if you please," she said, trying not to speak breathlessly, "all but five hundred, and you can give me that in one-hundreds."

The man knew her, made some vaguely-polite remark, and took the slip of paper back into unseen regions. Berny stood waiting, throbbing from head to foot with excitement. She was not afraid they would refuse to cash the check. Her sole fear was that Cannon, as soon as she was gone, might have regretted his action and telephoned from his office to stop the payment on it. She knew that once the money was hers he would not make any attempt to get it back. His own reputation and that of his daughter were too inextricably bound up with the transaction for him to dare to apprehend or punish Berny for her deception.

Her heart gave a wild leap as she saw the teller returning, and then pause behind the netting of his golden cage while he counted out the bills. She tried to speak lightly to him as he laid them one by one on the glass slab. She was hardly conscious of what she said; all she realized was that the crisp roll of paper in her fingers was her possession, if not of great fortune, at least of something to stand between her and the world.

When she left the bank she walked forward slowly, the excitement which had carried her on to this point having suddenly left her feeling weak and tired. She entered the railway office and bought her ticket for New York for that evening's train. Then once more emerging into the sunshine she directed her steps to the car which would take her to her sisters. She had decided to spend her last day in San Francisco with them. As the car whisked her up the hills she carefully pondered on how much she would tell

them, where truth was advisable and where fiction would serve a better purpose.

CHAPTER XXVII

THE STORM CENTER MOVES

As soon as Berny had left his office Bill Cannon wrote a note to Mrs. Ryan, telling her of the interview he had just had with her daughter-in-law. He did not mention the check, simply stating Berny's decision to accept their proposal and leave her husband. The matter was of too intimate a nature to trust to the telephone and he sent the note by one of his own clerks, who had instructions to wait for an answer, as the old man did not know what Mrs. Ryan might already have heard from Dominick.

It threw its recipient into a state of agitated, quivering exultation. Mrs. Ryan had heard nothing from her son, and her hopes of the separation had sunk to the lowest ebb. Not so prudent as Cannon, she called up Dominick at the bank, asking him if it were true that his wife had left him, and beseeching him simply to tell her "yes" or "no." The young man, hampered by the publicity of his surroundings and his promise to Berny, answered her with the utmost brevity, telling her that there had been a change in his domestic life but that he could not enter into details now. He begged her to ask him no further questions as he would be at home at three o'clock that afternoon, when he would explain the whole matter to her.

She wrote this to the Bonanza King and sent it by his waiting messenger. The old man felt relieved when he read the letter. He was confident now that Berny had not deceived him. She had told the truth, and was leaving the town and her husband, for what reason he could not yet be sure, but there seemed no doubt that she was going. They would ignore the subject before Rose, and, in the course of time, Dominick would break down the unflinching resistance she had threatened to make to his suit. The old man felt buoyant and exhilarated. It looked as if things were at last going their way.

He sent a message to Mrs. Ryan, asking her to let him know as soon as possible what Dominick said, and waited in his office in a state of tension very foreign to his usual iron stolidity. It was four o'clock before word came from her in the form of a telephone message, demanding his presence

at her house at the earliest possible moment. He responded to it at once, and in the sitting-room of the Ryan mansion heard from Dominick's own lips the story of his false and tragic marriage.

The old man listened, unwinking, speechless, immovable. It was the one thing he had never thought of, a solution of the situation that was as completely unexpected to him as death would have been. He said nothing to Dominick about the money he had given Berny, did not mention having seen her. A sharp observer might have noticed that he looked a little blank, that, the first shock of surprise over, there was a slight expression of wandering attention in his eye, a suggestion of mental faculties inwardly focusing on an unseen point, about his manner.

He walked home, deeply thinking, abashed a little by the ease with which Fate unties the knots that man's clumsy fingers work over in vain. And it was untied. They were free—the boy and girl he loved—to realize his and their own dreams. It would need no years of wooing to melt Rose from stony resistance. Nobody had been sacrificed.

He felt a sense of gratitude toward Berny. Down in his heart he was conscious of a stirring of something that was kindly, almost affectionate, toward her. It did not require a great stretch of imagination to see himself and her as two knowing, world-battered rogues who had combined to let youth and innocence have their happiness. He could almost feel the partnership with her she had spoken of, a sort of bond of Masonic understanding, a kindred attitude in matters of ethics. They had a mutually low estimate of human nature, a bold, cool unscrupulousness, a daring courage that never faltered. In fact, he was sorry he had not given Berny the whole fifty thousand dollars.

"She could have got it out of me," he said to himself, pondering pensively. "If she'd stuck out for it I'd have given it to her. And she might just as well have had it."

That evening for the first time in nearly three years Dominick Ryan dined with his mother in the great dining-room of the Ryan mansion. Cornelia was out with Jack Duffy, so Mrs. Ryan had her boy all to herself and she beamed and glowed and gloated on him as he sat opposite her, the reddened light of the candles falling on his beloved, familiar face.

After dinner they went into the sitting-room, the sanctum with the ebonized cherry furniture where the family always retired when important matters were afoot. Here, side by side, they sat before the fireplace with the portrait of the late Cornelius Ryan looking benignly down on them. They did not talk much. The subject of the young man's marriage had been thoroughly gone over in the afternoon. Later on, his mother would extract from him further particulars, till she would be as conversant with that miserable chapter of his life as if she had lived it herself.

To-night they were both in the quiescent state that follows turmoil and strife. They sat close together, staring into space, now and then dropping one of the short disconnected sentences that indicate a fused, understanding intimacy. The young man's body was limp in his chair, his mind lulled in the restorative lethargy, the suspension of activities, that follows a struggle. His thoughts shrank shudderingly from the past, and did not seek to penetrate the future. He rested in a torpor of relief through which a dreamy sense of happiness came dimly, as if in the faintest, most delicate whispers.

His mother's musings were definite and practical. She could now make that settlement, share and share alike, on both children that she had long desired—Cornelia's would be a dowry on her wedding day and Dominick's—well, Dominick had had hard times enough. She would go down to-morrow morning and see her lawyer about it.

At the same hour, in the house of the other rich man, the Bonanza King, having driven the servants from the room with violent words that did not indicate bad humor so much as high spirits, told his daughter the story. He told it shortly, hardly more than the main facts, and when it was concluded, forbore to make comments or, in fact, to look at her. It was a great deliverance, but he was not quite sure that his darling would experience the frank, unadulterated joy that had possessed both himself and Mrs. Ryan without restraining qualms. He did not know what to say to Rose. There were mysterious complexities in her character that made him decide to confine his statement to a recital of facts, eliminating those candid expressions of feeling which he could permit himself when talking to Mrs. Ryan or Berny.

As soon as he had told it all he rose from his chair as if ending the interview. His daughter rose too, pale and silent, and he put his arm round

her shoulders and pressed her against his chest in a good-night hug. She kissed him and went up stairs to her own rooms, and he returned to his arm-chair at the end of the dining-table. Here, as was his wont, he sat smoking and pondering, turning over in his head the various aspects of the curious story and its unexpected outcome. Once, as the memory of Berny weeping into his handkerchief recurred to him, he stirred uneasily and muttered to himself,

“Why didn’t the damned fool stick out for the whole fifty thousand? I’d have given it to her as soon as not.”

Meantime the storm center, the focus round which the hopes and angers and fears of this little group had circled, was speeding eastward in the darkness of the early night. Berny sat in the corner of her section with her luggage piled high on the seat before her, a pillow behind her head. In the brightly clear light, intensified by reflections from glazed woodwork and the surfaces of mirrors, she looked less haggard, calmer and steadier, than she had looked for many weeks. Relief was at her heart. Now that she had turned her back on it she realized how she had hated it all—the flat, the isolation, the unsuccessful struggle, Dominick and his superior ways.

The excitement of change, the desire of the new, the unfamiliar, the untried, which had taken her far afield once before, sang in her blood and whispered its siren song in her ear. She had missed a fortune, but still she had something. She was not plunging penniless into the great outside world, and she pressed her hand against her chest where the thirty-five thousand dollars was sewed into the lining of her bodice. Thirty-five thousand dollars! It was a good deal if it wasn’t three hundred thousand.

As the train thundered on through the darkness she saw before her the lights of great cities, and heard the call of liberty, the call of the nomad and the social vagabond, the call of the noisy thoroughfare, of the bright places, of the tumult and the crowd. The roving passion of the wanderer, to whom the spell of home is faint as a whisper in the night, passed into her veins like the invigorating heat of wine. She exulted in the sense of her freedom, in the magic of adventure, in the wild independence of the unknown.

TRANSCRIBER'S NOTES:

Obvious typographical errors have been corrected.

Inconsistencies in hyphenation have been standardized.

Archaic or alternate spelling has been retained from the original.

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